

AIR FORCE DOCTRINE PUBLICATION 1

THE AIR FORCE



U.S. AIR FORCE

10 March 2021

CSAF PERSPECTIVE ON DOCTRINE

Our Nation needs an Air Force that can *fly*, *fight*, and *win* as part of the joint team. Commanders must articulate intent and prepare to take the initiative in dynamic, contested environments. Doctrine offers an agreed upon, operationally relevant body of best practices and principles that articulates how we fight, captures our airpower experience, and guides how we operate within a joint force. It provides a starting point, so we don't reinvent the wheel with every operation and allows us to continue to be the world's most capable Air Force.

In today's complex global security environment, victory goes to the rapid integrator of ideas. These ideas are driven by training and the distilled knowledge all Airmen bring to the fight. I'm relying on every Airman to innovate and incorporate concepts and technologies that will develop new best practices to shape future doctrine. We must prioritize and make difficult choices as we field a lethal, resilient, and rapidly adapting joint force. Leaders must push decisions to the lowest competent, capable level using doctrine as a foundation for sound choices.

Doctrine is an opportunity to educate, empower, and prepare for the future fight. It guides us, but does not bind us. I'm relying on every Airman to understand the lessons of doctrine, and then draw on them to innovate and incorporate concepts and technologies that will develop new best practices to shape future doctrine. This is how we solve difficult problems, make necessary changes, and how we accelerate change in our Air Force.

The tools in doctrine provide an excellent opportunity to build our foundation for future Airmen and forge unbeatable airpower for our Nation. Airmen should read, understand, contemplate, and prepare for the full spectrum of operations, from competition to armed conflict. Never forget General LeMay's words: "At the very heart of warfare lies doctrine."

CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR.
General, USAF
Chief of Staff, United States Air Force

PREFACE

Air Force doctrine is the extant and emerging best practices in the application of airpower. Doctrine describes the operations and activities that create convergence of effects across the [competition continuum](#). Doctrine is organized as basic, operational, and tactical level doctrine. Basic doctrine states the most fundamental and enduring beliefs describing airpower and the Airman's perspective. [Operational doctrine](#) describes more detailed organization of forces and applies the principles of basic doctrine to military actions. Tactical doctrine is contained in Air Force and Multi-Service Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures publications.

Blue underlined text denotes a hyperlink to another source document, normally Air Force or joint operational doctrine, for additional discussion.

Air Force Doctrine Publication (AFDP) 1, *The Air Force*, forms the basis of our Service culture. It defines airpower, as **the ability to project military power through control and exploitation in, from and through the air**. Airpower is employed to achieve [joint force commander](#) (JFC) objectives in support of the [National Defense Strategy](#) (NDS).

AFDP 1 addresses four fundamental topics:

- ★ **Why We Fight - War**: our foundational purpose as a Service.
- ★ **Who We Are - Airmen**: our values.
- ★ **What We Do - Airpower**: airpower fundamentals and perspective.
- ★ **How We Do It - Tenets of Airpower**: airpower employment considerations.

Ideas presented here enable Airmen to describe what the Air Force provides to [joint all-domain operations \(JADO\)](#).

Air Force Doctrine Publication 1, *The Air Force*

Table of Contents

Chapter 1 – WHY WE FIGHT: WAR	1
NATURE OF WAR	1
LEVELS OF WARFARE	1
AIRPOWER IN THE COMPETITION CONTINUUM	2
NATIONAL DEFENSE STRATEGY & OBJECTIVES	2
Chapter 2 – WHO WE ARE: AIRMEN	4
Chapter 3 – WHAT WE DO: AIRPOWER	6
DESCRIPTION OF AIRPOWER	6
FOUNDATIONS OF AIRPOWER	7
AIRPOWER FROM AN AIRMAN’S PERSPECTIVE	8
Chapter 4 – HOW WE DO IT: TENETS OF AIRPOWER	11
MISSION COMMAND	12
SYNERGISTIC EFFECTS	14
PERSISTENCE	15
CONCENTRATION	15
PRIORITY	15
BALANCE	15
CONCLUSION	16

Chapter 1 – WHY WE FIGHT: WAR

In our victory over Japan, airpower was unquestionably decisive. That the planned invasion of the Japanese Home islands was unnecessary is clear evidence that airpower has evolved into a force in war co-equal with land and sea power, decisive in its own right and worthy of the faith of its prophets.

**General Carl A. Spaatz, 1st Chief of Staff,
United States Air Force**



NATURE OF WAR

[War](#) is one of the means used by nation-states, sub-national groups, or supranational groups to achieve their objectives. Conducting war from the air underpins the reason for the Air Force's existence. Airpower is an instrument of national power and can be employed in warfare. There are three basic truths that the Air Force believes are fundamental to warfare:

- ✦ **War is an extension of politics by other means.** War has been described as a [violent clash of interests](#) characterized by the use of force. The Air Force conducts warfare as an extension of our national policy.
- ✦ **War is a complex and chaotic human endeavor.** Uncertainty and unpredictability, sometimes called the “fog of war”, combine to create what Clausewitz called “friction” which makes simple operations unexpectedly, and sometimes even insurmountably, difficult. The tenets of airpower help Airmen apply airpower effectively within this environment.
- ✦ **War is a clash of opposing wills.** War is a collision of two or more forces, producing a dynamic interplay of action and reaction. The will of the people and the character of their leaders are critical components of warfare.

Sound doctrine, good leadership, effective organization, moral values, and realistic training can reduce the effects of uncertainty, unpredictability, and unreliability present in war.

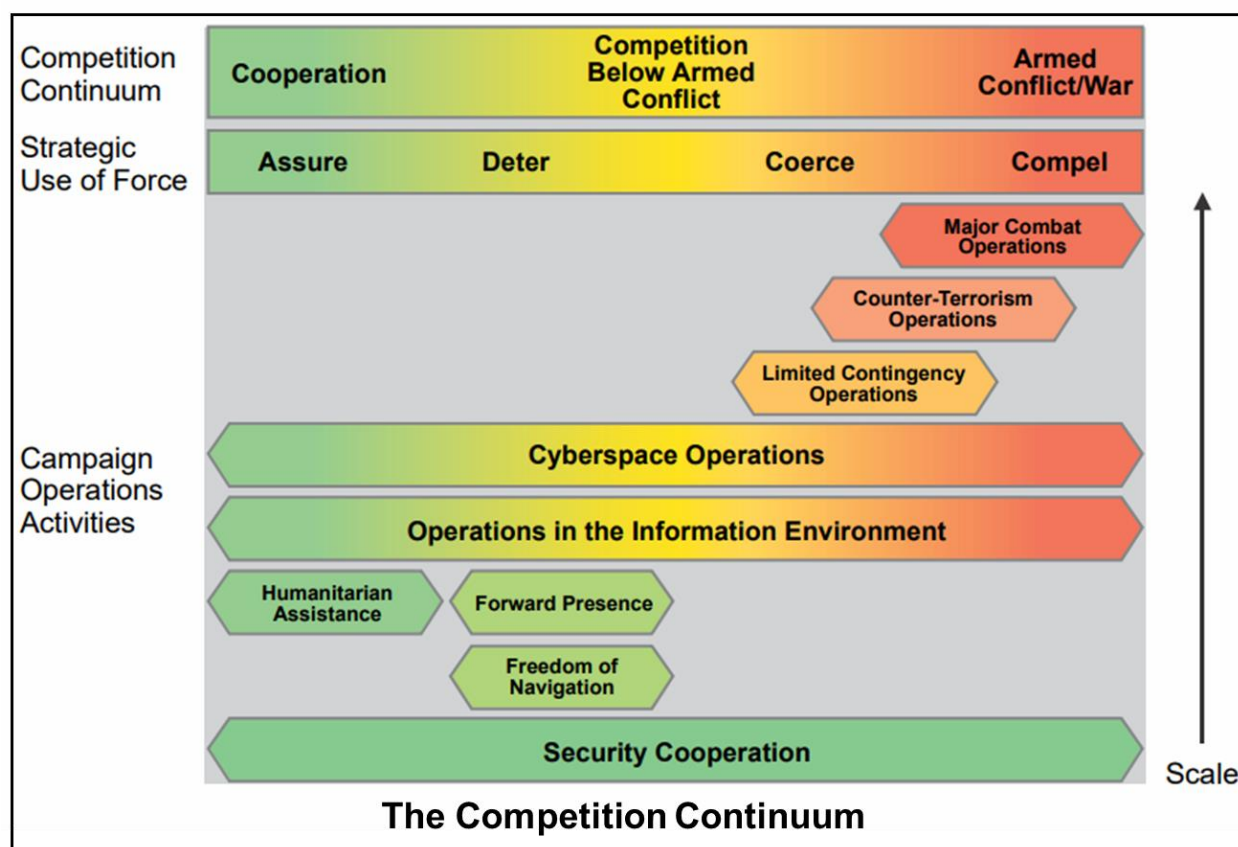
LEVELS OF WARFARE

Airpower creates effects across all three levels of warfare: [strategic, operational, and tactical](#). The strategic level of war defines *why* and *with what* the conflict occurs. The operational level of war determines *what* courses of action, in *what* order, and for *what*

duration forces are employed in the conflict. Finally, the tactical level of war defines *how* we create the operational effects. Actions in war occur at the tactical level, but an understanding of the operational and strategic implications of those actions is key to the employment of airpower in pursuit of our national objectives.

AIRPOWER IN THE COMPETITION CONTINUUM

The Air Force employs forces in pursuit of our national objectives across the [competition continuum](#). Rather than the traditional binary classifications of peace and war, the competition continuum describes a world of enduring competition conducted through a mixture of cooperation, competition below armed conflict, and armed conflict. The Air Force creates effects across the continuum through the conduct of operations, military engagement, security cooperation, deterrence, and other activities.



For detailed discussion on the competition continuum, see [Joint Doctrine Note 1-19, Competition Continuum, 3 June 2019](#).

NATIONAL DEFENSE STRATEGY & OBJECTIVES

The [National Defense Strategy](#) sets the context in which Airmen must anticipate and plan across the competition continuum. Long-term strategic competition and the expansion of our adversary's military capabilities threaten the United States' prosperity

and security. Joint force operations are increasingly interconnected, interdependent, and challenged. Our adversary's anti-access and area denial focus and proliferation of advanced technologies create contested environments that reduce airpower's ability to conduct global operations across the competition continuum, reduce freedom of maneuver, and challenge the Air Force's ability to operate. This operating environment requires examining how forces will sense, plan, decide, and act in concert across all domains.

The National Defense Strategy delivers the framework that defines the [Department of the Air Force's functions](#). The Air Force, as part of the Department of the Air Force, provides the Nation with global vigilance, global reach, and global power. Service doctrine describes how to fulfill that responsibility.

- ★ **Global Vigilance** is the ability to gain and maintain awareness anywhere; to provide warning and to determine intent, opportunity, capability, or vulnerability; then to fuse this information with data received from other Services or agencies and use and share relevant information with the [joint force commander](#) (JFC).
- ★ **Global Reach** is the ability to project military capability responsively—with unsurpassed velocity and precision—anywhere, and provide mobility to rapidly supply, position, or reposition joint forces.
- ★ **Global Power** is the ability to hold at risk or strike any target anywhere, assert national sovereignty, safeguard joint freedom of action, and create swift, decisive, precise effects.

The Air Force prepares and employs forces within this strategic environment to achieve our national objectives. These objectives include defend the homeland, remain the preeminent military power in the world, ensure the balances of power remain in our favor, and advance an international order that is most conducive to our security and prosperity. When the Air Force mobilizes in the pursuit of these objectives, they are integrated as a part of the joint force, led by a JFC.

The Air Force organizes, trains, and equips forces to be an air component to a JFC. As part of the joint force's air component, our forces must be prepared to accomplish JFC objectives. The air component commander's administrative authorities are derived from Title 10, U.S. Code and exercised as the commander, Air Force forces (COMAFFOR). The air component commander's operational authorities are delegated from the JFC and exercised as both the COMAFFOR, over Air Force Forces, and as the functional joint force air component commander (JFACC), over joint air forces made available for tasking. Thus, the air component commander leads Air Force forces as the COMAFFOR and the JFC's joint air operations as the JFACC. This duality of authorities is expressed in the axiom: Airmen work for Airmen and the senior Airman works for the JFC.

Chapter 2 – WHO WE ARE: AIRMEN

Our Airmen are the competitive edge we have over our adversaries and the reason we are the world's greatest Air Force.

JoAnne S. Bass, 19th Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force



All Airmen support and defend the Constitution of the United States and live by Air Force core values. Historically, the term Airman is associated with uniformed members of the US Air Force (officer or enlisted; regular, Reserve, or Guard) regardless of rank, component, or specialty.¹ Today, Air Force civilians and members of the Civil Air Patrol, when conducting missions as the official Air Force Auxiliary, are incorporated within the broader meaning of the term, Airman.

Airmen espouse Air Force core values:

- ★ **Integrity first.**
- ★ **Service before self.**
- ★ **Excellence in all we do.**

Success hinges on the incorporation of these values into the character of every Airman. Air Force core values are a commitment each Airman makes when joining the Air Force. They provide a foundation for leadership, decision-making, and success, no matter their rank, the difficulty of the assigned task, or the dangers presented by the mission.

Every Airman is a leader and positively influences others to accomplish the mission. Leadership is the art and science of motivating, influencing, and directing Airmen to understand and accomplish JFC objectives.² Two fundamental elements of leadership are the mission and the Airmen who accomplish it. Effective leadership transforms human potential into effective performance in the present and prepares capable leaders for the future. Airmen step forward to lead others in accomplishing the mission while simultaneously serving as followers. You can be a commander without being a leader,

¹ This broader meaning does not, however, mean or imply that anyone other than uniformed members of the US Air Force are members of the Armed Services in other contexts. For example, in the context of punitive Air Force instructions or law of war regulations, care must be taken to ensure the rights and obligations imposed under those regulations are not uniformly applied to both Service members and civilians.

² Air Force Manual 35-15, *Air Force Leadership* (1948): "Leadership is the art of influencing people to progress with cooperation and enthusiasm toward the accomplishment of a mission." Air Force Pamphlet 35-49, *Air Force Leadership* (1985): "Leadership is the art of influencing and directing people to accomplish the mission." The definition in the text is a distillation of these earlier efforts.

or you may be a fine leader without a command, but you must be a good leader to be an effective commander.³



I'm firmly convinced that leaders are not born; they're educated, trained, and made, as in every other profession. To ensure a strong, ready Air Force, we must always remain dedicated to this process.

General Curtis E. LeMay, 5th Chief of Staff, United States Air Force

Airmen understand the attributes of airpower and should apply airpower with an appreciation for the breadth, scope, and uniqueness it brings to joint all-domain operations. Airpower is fundamentally distinct from other forms of military power. Its inherent flexibility allows it to be applied independently or in concert with other forms of military power. Airmen have a distinct point of view forged from air operations throughout history and our unique operating domains.

³ Concept dates to AFM 35-15 pg 4 (1948).

Chapter 3 – WHAT WE DO: AIRPOWER

Regardless of our respective ranks and positions, we must execute to the best of our abilities and we must do it right the first time because the application of airpower is serious business where half-hearted efforts and playing for second place are not options.

**General Charles Q. Brown, Jr.,
22d Chief of Staff, United States Air Force**



DESCRIPTION OF AIRPOWER

Airpower is defined as the ability to project military power through control and exploitation in, from and through the air. Elevation above the earth's surface provides relative advantages and creates a mindset that sees competition from a broad perspective. The air domain allows Airmen to exploit airpower's attributes of speed, range, precision, tempo, lethality, and adaptability to create effects in all domains. These attributes of airpower change the dynamics of competition in ways that enhance the effectiveness of joint forces through greater mobility and responsiveness. Airmen have an appreciation for airpower's broad potential. Airmen do not view or study airpower as an auxiliary or complementary capability subordinate to another Service. Airmen view their expertise in the application of airpower as the main reason for the Service's existence. The Air Force employs airpower to achieve JFC objectives and to complement other components of the joint force.

The attributes of airpower create effects throughout the operational environment and competition continuum. Airmen apply airpower by bypassing geographical limitations or striking with precision at critical vulnerabilities within adversary [centers of gravity](#) (COGs) at long ranges, on short notice, and for sustained periods. Airpower can control the tempo of operations in our favor and leaders employ airpower in concert with all forms of military power. Airmen integrate capabilities across multiple domains to create effects in support of JFC objectives through [joint all-domain operations](#). While all Services rely heavily on such integration, joint all-domain integration is fundamental to how Airmen employ airpower as part of the joint force.

To enable convergence of effects in all domains, Airmen support JADO by conducting operations principally in, from, and through:

- ★ The [air domain](#), defined as “the atmosphere, beginning at the Earth's surface, extending to the altitude where its effects upon operations become negligible.”
- ★ The [Information Environment](#) (IE), which includes the [cyberspace domain](#). The IE is “the aggregate of individuals, organizations, and systems that collect, process,

disseminate, or act on information,” while cyberspace consists of “the interdependent networks of information technology infrastructures and resident data, including the Internet, telecommunications networks, computer systems, and embedded processors and controllers.” The effective use of information as an instrument for affecting perceptions and behaviors and to support human and automated decision-making is an increasingly important element of [joint operations](#).

- ★ The [electromagnetic spectrum](#) (EMS) is defined as “the entire range of electromagnetic radiation.” It is critical for connecting the joint force and as a medium for creating effects, freedom of action in the EMS at the time, place, and parameters of the joint force’s choosing, is a [required precursor](#) to the successful conduct of operations in all domains.

A comprehensive understanding of operations within the warfighting domains, the EMS, and IE are critical to achieving JFC objectives.

The other Services have air arms—magnificent air arms—but their air arms must fit within their Services, each with a fundamentally different focus. So those air arms, when in competition with the primary focus of their Services, will often end up on the short end, where the priorities for resources may lead to shortfalls or decisions that are suboptimum. It is therefore important to understand that the core competencies of [airpower] are optional for the other Services. They can elect to play or not play in that arena. But if the nation is to remain capable and competent in air and space [sic], someone must pay attention across the whole spectrum; that is why there is a US Air Force.



**General Ronald R. Fogleman, 15th Chief of Staff,
United States Air Force**

FOUNDATIONS OF AIRPOWER

The evolution of airpower stems from the Airman’s original vision of combat from a distance, bypassing the force-on-force clash of surface combat. Originally manifested in long-range aircraft delivering kinetic weapons, airpower has evolved to include other global capabilities, notably non-kinetic forces and capabilities that can produce lethal or non-lethal effects. Airpower evolution accelerated as technological advancements allowed Airmen to conduct a greater percentage of operations globally versus regionally.

Airpower has successfully influenced strategic political outcomes outside of armed conflict since the Berlin Airlift of 1948. Throughout the Cold War, and continuing under various international arms control agreements, Air Force assets have observed and verified compliance, leveraging our national ability to negotiate and influence diplomacy.

The Air Force provides JFCs options across the competition continuum, which may accomplish objectives without the application of lethal force. Airpower has the ability to respond rapidly to crises anywhere in the world with flexible options that contribute to global influence and stability, and communicate US capabilities and resolve to worldwide audiences. Examples include:

- ★ The deterrent role played by the Air Force's [nuclear-armed bombers and intercontinental ballistic missiles](#) against the existential threat posed by adversaries' strategic forces.
- ★ The role [mobility](#) forces play in humanitarian assistance and disaster response worldwide.
- ★ Aviation [foreign internal defense](#) by [Air Force Special Operations](#) combat aviation advisors, to build partner capacity and help them protect their societies from subversion, insurgency, or extremism.

Airmen apply the foundations of airpower across the competition continuum; translate the benefits of airpower into meaningful objectives and desired effects; and influence the overall joint planning and execution effort. As experts in the joint application of airpower, the Airman's perspective provides the ability to force multiple dilemmas on adversaries, decreasing their decision space for potential courses of action.

AIRPOWER FROM AN AIRMAN'S PERSPECTIVE

Effective airpower application requires an Airman's unique perspective. Airmen gained this perspective through a century of air operations experience. These distilled truths should be at the forefront of an Airman's perspective when operating with joint partners.

- ★ **Control of the air is a necessary precondition for control of the surface.** The first mission of an air force is to defeat or neutralize the enemy airpower so friendly operations in all domains can proceed.
- ★ **Airpower creates effects at the strategic level of warfare.** Airpower, through global reach and global power, can hold an enemy's strategic COGs and critical vulnerabilities at risk immediately and continuously through kinetic or non-kinetic means. Airpower also has capability for nonlethal strategic influence, as in humanitarian relief and building partnership activities.
- ★ **Airpower exploits the principles of mass and maneuver simultaneously.** There are no natural boundaries to prevent air capabilities from quickly concentrating

(physically or in terms of delivered effects) at any point. Airpower can dominate the fourth dimension—time—and compress events to produce physical and psychological shock.

- ★ **Airpower applies force against many facets of enemy power.** Global power enables airpower to be brought to bear against any lawful target in an enemy system simultaneously or separately. It enables rapid expression of our national will wherever and whenever necessary.
- ★ **Airpower is not bound by geographical operating areas and creates effects throughout a theater.** Airmen view the application of force more from a functional than geographic standpoint and classify targets by generated effects rather than physical location.
- ★ **Airpower's attributes combine to make it one of the most versatile components of military power.** Its versatility allows it to be rapidly employed against strategic, operational, and tactical objectives and in support of multiple theaters simultaneously.
- ★ **The choice of appropriate capabilities is a key aspect in the realization of airpower.** Achieving the full potential of airpower requires timely, actionable intelligence and sufficient command and control (C2) capabilities to permit commanders to exploit airpower attributes.
- ★ **Airpower is a critical component of operations in the information environment.** All Air Force actions, including written or spoken words and displayed or related images, have [informational](#) aspects that communicate some message or intent, which can be leveraged to support the achievement of JFC objectives. Shaping and leveraging those messages are integral to operations and planning.
- ★ **Airpower provides more than lethal effects.** Global vigilance enables airpower to alleviate crises and provide a visible symbol of international support and power projection. Assisting partner nations, building alliances and the perception of credible airpower, supports deterrence and assurance activities that lead to greater regional stability and security.
- ★ **Airpower requires protection and sustainment to enable air operations and requires effective integration of capabilities, people, weapons, bases, logistics, and supporting infrastructure.** No single aspect of airpower should be treated in isolation since all elements are essential and interdependent. The Air Force depends on Airmen who command, operate, and sustain forces in any environment including chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear. The Air Force's [combat support](#) capability and [agile combat employment](#) provide the ability to deploy globally, begin operations, and sustain the initiative. Counterair and force protection capabilities provide defense for forces. Airpower supports and is supported by

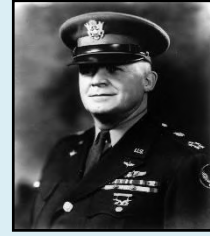
military power in other domains, from other components, and from other Services.

- ★ **Airpower's unique attributes necessitate it be centrally controlled by an Airman.** Experience has shown the Air Force to be the preferred choice of JFCs to exercise command and control (C2) over the joint air effort. Airmen tend to take a broad view of competition; their focus is on applying airpower to accomplish the JFC's objectives. Airmen apply airpower through the tenet of mission command.
-

Chapter 4 – HOW WE DO IT: TENETS OF AIRPOWER

Strategic air assault is wasted if it is dissipated piecemeal in sporadic attacks between which the enemy has an opportunity to readjust defenses or recuperate.

Henry H. Arnold, General of the Air Force



The application of airpower is refined by its tenets:

- ★ Mission Command.
- ★ Flexibility and versatility.
- ★ Synergistic effects.
- ★ Persistence.
- ★ Concentration.
- ★ Priority.
- ★ Balance.

These tenets reflect the unique aspects of airpower and complement [principles of joint operations](#). The Air Force recognizes unity of effort as the 13th principle to highlight its importance.⁴ **While the principles provide general guidance on the application of military force, the tenets provide specific considerations for the employment of airpower. Like principles of joint operations, airpower tenets**

Principles of Joint Operations (JP 3-0)

Unity of command – purpose is to ensure unity of effort under one responsible commander for every objective.

Objective - purpose is to direct every military operation toward a clearly defined, decisive, and achievable goal.

Offensive – purpose of action is to seize, retain, and exploit the initiative.

Mass - purpose is to concentrate the effects of combat power at the most advantageous place and time to produce decisive results.

Maneuver - purpose is to place the enemy in a position of disadvantage through the flexible application of combat power.

Economy of force - purpose is to expend minimum essential combat power on secondary efforts to allocate maximum combat power on primary efforts.

Security - purpose is to prevent the enemy from acquiring unexpected advantage.

Surprise - purpose is to strike at a time or place or in a manner for which the enemy is not prepared.

Simplicity - purpose is to increase the probability that plans and operations will be executed as intended by preparing clear, uncomplicated plans, and concise orders.

Restraint - purpose is to prevent the unnecessary use of force.

Perseverance - purpose is to ensure the commitment necessary to achieve national objectives.

Legitimacy - purpose is to maintain legal and moral authority in the conduct of operations.

Unity of Effort (additional Air Force principle) - purpose is to ensure that a wide range of agencies operating during a contingency coordinate their resources and focus on the same goal.

⁴ Joint doctrine recognizes Unity of Effort as a “common operating precept.” See Joint Publication 3-0, [Joint Operations](#).

require informed judgment in application. Airmen tailor the application of tenets to the operational environment. The competing demands of the principles and tenets (for example mass versus economy of force, concentration versus balance, and priority versus objective) require an Airman's nuanced understanding to strike the required balance. Competition is interactively complex, and no two operations are identical. Airmen apply professional judgment and experience as they employ airpower.

MISSION COMMAND

The Airman's philosophy for the C2 of airpower is [mission command](#). **Mission command** is an approach to C2 that empowers subordinate decision-making for flexibility, initiative, and responsiveness in the accomplishment of commander's intent. **Mission command** provides Airmen operating in environments of increasing uncertainty, complexity, and rapid change with the freedom of action needed to exploit emergent opportunities and succeed. Given the global reach and strategic effects of airpower, the Air Force's approach to mission command balances the need for tactical flexibility with the management of global risks. Core principles of mission command are:

- ★ **Build teams through mutual trust.** Built over time through shared experiences, mutual trust is shared confidence between commanders, subordinates, and partners that they can be relied on and are competent to carry out the mission.
- ★ **Create shared understanding.** A common understanding of the environment that includes an operation's purpose, challenges, and ways of solving them equips decision-makers at all levels with the insight and foresight needed to make effective decisions and manage associated risks.
- ★ **Provide clear commander's intent.** A clear and concise expression of the purpose of an operation, the desired outcome, and acceptable risks provides focus and helps subordinate and supporting commanders succeed, even when events do not unfold as planned. Commander's intent succinctly describes what constitutes success.
- ★ **Use mission-type orders (MTOs) when appropriate.** An MTO is an order that contributes to the accomplishment of the total mission assigned to the higher headquarters; it does not necessarily specify how tasks are to be accomplished. [Mission type orders](#) focus on the purpose of an operation rather than the details of how to accomplish it. They empower subordinates with the greatest possible freedom of action within the guidelines of commander's intent. MTOs are most applicable and effective when there is a reasonable expectation that the assumptions captured in commander's intent will remain valid during execution. MTOs should be based on higher-level headquarters priorities and intent, nested within the five-paragraph order format, which can be adapted and applied to peer and lower echelons. The planning orders (PLANORDs), operation orders

**USAF Modified
Five-Paragraph Order
Format (JP 5-0)**

1. Situation
2. Mission
3. Execution
4. Force Sustainment
5. Command, Signal and Communications

(OPORDs), [joint air operation plan](#) (JAOP), and the [air operations directive](#) (AOD), should serve as foundational documents for issuing MTOs.

- ★ **Exercise disciplined initiative.** Disciplined initiative is the proactive application of inventiveness and creativity when existing orders no longer fit the situation or when unforeseen threats or opportunities arise. It is informed by a clear understanding of mission objectives, desired effects, overall commander's intent, and broader strategic context.
- ★ **Accept prudent risk.** All military operations contain uncertain, complex, and ambiguous elements. Commanders must analyze risks in collaboration with their subordinates to balance the tension between protecting the force and accepting and managing risks that must be taken to accomplish the mission.

Airmen execute **mission command** through **centralized command**, **distributed control**, and **decentralized execution**. Centralized command is the organizing standard for the effective and efficient means of employing airpower; it enables the principle of mass while maintaining the principle of economy of force. Because of airpower's potential to directly affect the strategic and operational levels of warfare, it should be commanded by a single Airman, the air component commander. Distributed control exploits airpower's flexibility and versatility to ensure that it remains responsive, survivable, and sustainable. Decentralized execution is the delegation of authority to achieve effective span of control, foster disciplined initiative, and empower subordinates to exploit fleeting opportunities.

Centralized command gives the commander the responsibility and authority for planning, directing and coordinating a military operation using the C2 philosophy of mission command. Centralized command is best accomplished by an Airman at the functional component commander level who maintains a broad focus on the JFC's objectives to direct, integrate, prioritize, plan, coordinate and assess the use of airpower across the competition continuum. Centralized command empowers the air component commander to respond to changes in the environment and enables priority and balance while still allowing subordinate echelons to exercise initiative. Centralized command promotes effectiveness and preserves flexibility and versatility at the operational level.

Distributed control enables commanders to delegate planning and coordination activities to dispersed locations or subordinate echelons in order to achieve an effective span of control. The benefits inherent in distributed control and decentralized execution are maximized when clearly communicated commander's intent guides subordinate actions. Distributed control allows subordinate commanders to respond to changes in the operational environment and take advantage of fleeting opportunities. Contested environments may require a greater degree of distributed control than uncontested environments. Commanders should empower subordinates at the lowest capable level through MTOs, and with command by negation rather than micromanagement.

Decentralized execution is the delegation of authority to achieve effective span of control and foster disciplined initiative at the tactical level. It allows subordinates to exploit fleeting opportunities in dynamic situations. To achieve decentralized execution, the air component commander and subordinate echelons use MTOs with clearly communicated commander's intent to empower front-line decision makers (e.g., strike package leaders, air battle managers, forward air controllers) to make effective on-scene decisions during complex, rapidly unfolding operations. Decentralized execution promotes effectiveness and resilience at the tactical level.

The balance among centralization, distribution, and decentralization is situationally dependent. Some situations (e.g., high-value targets, time-sensitive targets, political sensitivities, covert/ clandestine operations, offensive cyberspace operations, nuclear employment) may require a level of centralized execution of specific operations, most notably when the JFC wants to control strategic effects and manage risks at the sacrifice of tactical efficiency. In all cases, commanders balance overall execution against the need for tactical resilience and effectiveness.

The effectiveness of airpower depends on Airmen ensuring assets are employed efficiently and effectively to achieve commander's intent. Operations in denied, degraded, and disrupted environments require flexible and adaptive Airmen who maintain unity of effort by exercising the philosophy of mission command, based on trust, shared awareness, and shared intent.

FLEXIBILITY AND VERSATILITY

Although often used interchangeably, flexibility and versatility are different.

Flexibility is the ability for airpower to seamlessly transition between mission sets while simultaneously exploit the principles of mass and maneuver. Flexibility allows airpower to shift from one JFC objective to another, quickly and decisively; to re-role assets quickly from a preplanned mission to support an unanticipated need.

Versatility is the ability to employ airpower effectively at the strategic, operational, and tactical levels of warfare and provide a wide variety of tasks in concert with other joint force elements. Airpower has the potential to achieve synergy through asymmetric and parallel operations.

SYNERGISTIC EFFECTS

The proper application of a coordinated force across multiple domains can produce effects that exceed the contributions of forces employed individually. An objective of modern warfare is the precise, coordinated application of the various elements of military power to bring disproportionate pressure on adversaries. This synergistic effect forces adversaries to comply with our national will (affecting their intent) or to cause functional defeat of their forces (affecting their capability). Airpower allows commanders

to observe adversaries which enables JFCs to counter enemy movements with unprecedented speed and agility.

PERSISTENCE

Airpower operations are often conducted continuously against a broad spectrum of objectives. Its attributes allow forces to visit and revisit multiple targets without occupying terrain or remaining in proximity to areas of operation to bring force upon targets. Persistence denies an adversary an opportunity to seize the initiative or to directly accomplish assigned tasks.

CONCENTRATION

Focusing overwhelming power at a decisive time and place is a warfighting imperative, supported by the principles of mass and economy of force. The flexibility and versatility of airpower with its attributes and persistence makes it an attractive option for concentration. The demand for airpower often exceeds the available forces and Airmen should guard against the inadvertent dilution of airpower effects resulting from this high demand.

PRIORITY

Commanders should prioritize the use of airpower. Limited resources require that airpower be applied where it can make the greatest contribution to the most critical JFC objectives. The air component commander should assess the possible use of forces, analyze their strengths and capabilities to support the overall joint campaign, and have an informed dialogue with the JFC regarding effective prioritization of airpower. The application of airpower is balanced against its ability to conduct simultaneous operations at all levels of warfare.

BALANCE

Much of the skill of the air component commander is reflected in the dynamic and correct balancing of the principles of joint operations and the tenets of airpower to bring Air Force capabilities together to produce synergistic effects. An air component commander should weigh combat opportunity, necessity, effectiveness, efficiency, and the impact on accomplishing assigned objectives against the associated risk to friendly forces. An Airman is uniquely suited to determine the proper theater-wide balance between offensive and defensive air operations, and among strategic, operational, and tactical applications to best accomplish the JFC's objectives.

CONCLUSION

At the very heart of warfare lies doctrine. It represents the central beliefs for waging war in order to achieve victory. Doctrine is of the mind, a network of faith and knowledge reinforced by experience which lays the pattern for the utilization of [Airmen], equipment, and tactics. It is the building material for strategy. It is fundamental to sound judgment.

General Curtis E. LeMay, 5th Chief of Staff, United States Air Force



Airmen understand airpower and how to employ it to accelerate change in, from, and through the air. Airmen exemplify the core values of integrity, service and excellence, and are the foundation of the Air Force. The Air Force and Airmen exist to provide expert application of airpower to a JFC across the competition continuum in support of the *National Defense Strategy*. The doctrine presented in this publication and its subordinate operational and tactical documents underscore the reason for our existence and provide Airmen the basis for success.

**BY ORDER OF THE
SECRETARY OF THE AIR FORCE**



AIR FORCE INSTRUCTION 1-1

18 AUGUST 2023

Air Force Culture

AIR FORCE STANDARDS

COMPLIANCE WITH THIS PUBLICATION IS MANDATORY

ACCESSIBILITY: Publications and forms are available for downloading or ordering on the e-Publishing website at www.e-publishing.af.mil.

RELEASABILITY: There are no releasability restrictions on this publication.

OPR: AF/DS

Certified by: AF/DS
(Lt Gen Kevin B. Schneider)

Supersedes: AFI1-1, 7 August 2012

Pages: 38

This Air Force Instruction (AFI) implements Air Force Policy Directive (AFPD) 1, *Air Force Culture*, and provides specific guidance on required standards of conduct, performance, and discipline. This instruction applies to uniformed members of the Regular Air Force, Air Force Reserve, and Air National Guard. This publication does not apply to the United States Space Force or to civilian employees. Civilian employee professional and personal standards are governed by AFI 36-703, *Civilian Conduct and Responsibility*. Ensure all records generated as a result of processes prescribed in this publication adhere to Air Force Instruction (AFI) 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, and are disposed in accordance with the Air Force Records Disposition Schedule, which is located in the Air Force Records Information Management System. Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Offices of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using Department of the Air Force (DAF) Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*; route DAF Forms 847 from the field through the appropriate chain of command. This instruction may not be supplemented at any level and contains a collection of compliance requirements from other directive publications. More detailed standards may be found in these other directive publications. Refer to the originating publication(s) for the respective tier authorities to waive wing/delta/unit level requirements for DAF compliance items. See Department of the Air Force Instruction (DAFI) 90-160, *Publication and Forms Management*, and Department of the Air Force Manual (DAFMAN) 90-161, *Publishing Processes and Procedures*, for a description of the authorities associated with the tier numbers waiver request procedures. The use of the name or mark of any specific manufacturer, commercial product, commodity, or service in this publication does not imply endorsement by the Air Force.

SUMMARY OF CHANGES

This publication has been substantially revised to update guidance and references throughout and must be completely reviewed.

Chapter 1—THE AIR FORCE ENVIRONMENT	4
1.1. Overview.	4
1.2. Mission, Vision, and Core Functions.....	4
1.3. Air Force Core Values.	4
1.4. Major Performance Areas (MPAs) and Airmen Leadership Qualities (ALQs).....	7
1.5. Oath.....	8
1.6. The Airman’s Creed.....	9
1.7. Code of Conduct.	9
1.8. Customs and Courtesies.....	10
Figure 1.1. Air Force Enlisted Terms of Address.	12
1.9. Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility.....	12
Chapter 2—CONDUCT	14
2.1. Overview.....	14
2.2. Professional Relationships.	14
2.3. Standards of Ethical Conduct.....	15
2.4. Duty Performance.	18
2.5. Mission Command.	18
2.6. Wingmen.....	19
2.7. Unlawful Discrimination.	19
2.8. Harassment.....	19
2.9. Sexual Assault.....	21
2.10. Drug Abuse.	21
2.11. Alcohol Abuse.	21
2.12. Financial Responsibility.	21
2.13. Dependent Care.....	22
2.14. Self-Reporting Criminal Conviction.....	22
2.15. Free Exercise of Religion and Religious Accommodation.	22
2.16. Balance of Free Exercise of Religion and Establishment Clause.	23
2.17. Political Activities.....	23

2.18. Protest and Extremist Activities.....	24
2.19. Public Statements.....	24
2.20. Personal Use of Social Media.	25
Chapter 3—APPEARANCE	26
3.1. Overview.....	26
3.2. Dress and Personal Appearance.....	26
3.3. Personal Grooming.	26
3.4. Uniforms.	26
3.5. Physical Fitness.....	27
Attachment 1—GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION	29
Attachment 2—ROLES, RESPONSIBILITIES, AND STRUCTURE	34

Chapter 1

THE AIR FORCE ENVIRONMENT

1.1. Overview. The importance of the Air Force's mission and inherent responsibility to the Nation requires its Airmen to adhere to higher standards than those expected outside of Military Service. Airmen are proud of our high standards. Through self-discipline, Airmen adhere to them and hold our fellow Airmen accountable to follow our standards. The Air Force environment, whether at home station or forward deployed, encompasses the actions, values and standards Airmen live by each and every day, whether on or off duty.

1.2. Mission, Vision, and Core Functions.

1.2.1. United States Air Force Mission. The mission of the United States Air Force is to Fly, Fight, and Win... Airpower anytime, anywhere.

1.2.2. Air Force Vision. To achieve the Air Force mission, the Air Force vision is: The United States Air Force will be a trusted and reliable joint partner with our sister services known for integrity in all of our activities, including supporting the joint mission first and foremost. We will provide compelling airpower capabilities for employment by the combatant commanders. We will excel as stewards of all Air Force resources in service to the American people, while providing precise and reliable Global Vigilance, Reach, and Power for the Nation.

1.2.3. Air Force Core Functions. The Air Force Core Functions articulate, to internal and external audiences, how the Air Force fulfills its statutory Title 10 role to organize, train and equip forces for combatant commanders to execute their assigned missions. The Core Functions are Air Superiority; Global Strike; Rapid Global Mobility; Intelligence; Surveillance, and Reconnaissance; and Command and Control.

1.3. Air Force Core Values. The Air Force Core Values are Integrity First, Service Before Self, and Excellence In All We Do. The Air Force individual Core Values represent the enduring and guiding principles for which we as individuals and as an organization stand. Our Core Values are so fundamental they define our identity, and for those of us who join this proud community of Airmen, being a part of the Air Force family requires that we commit to living these values, on and off duty.

1.3.1. The Air Force Core Values exist for all members of the Air Force family - officer, enlisted, and civilian; Active, Guard, Reserve, and retired. We must internalize these Core Values and model the behaviors that demonstrate them. We must inspire others, set an example through personal conduct, and promote leadership and accountability across the force.

1.3.2. The Air Force Core Values are much more than minimum standards. They remind us of what is required to get the mission done. They inspire us to do our very best at all times. They are the fundamental common bond among all Airmen of the United States Air Force. They are the values that strengthen and sustain the Total Force and tie us to the great warriors and public servants of the past.

1.3.3. For those who join this proud community of Airmen- whether officer, enlisted, civilian, Active, Guard, or Reserve - being a part of the Air Force family requires commitment to living these values, on and off duty. This is the expectation of our profession and is the standard against which our fellow Service members and the American public hold us. The Air Force

Professional is a trusted servant of our Nation who adheres to the highest standards of character, courage, and competence. How Airmen act represents to others the collective identity of the Air Force.

1.3.4. Living the Air Force Core Values.

1.3.4.1. Understanding the Air Force Core Values is easy. The true challenge is to live them. It is a commitment that never ends, and one that always matters.

1.3.4.2. Each of our Core Values are further defined by virtues (desired behaviors and characteristics) Airmen must practice and demonstrate in their daily lives, showing they truly value Integrity, Service, and Excellence. Consistently practicing these virtues results in habits of honorable thought and action, producing an Air Force Professional. Air Force Professionalism is a shared belief in, and a commitment to, honorable service based on our Air Force Core Values.

1.3.5. Integrity First. Simply doing the right thing, all the time, whether everyone is watching, or no one is watching. This Air Force core value is the compass that keeps us on the right path when confronted with ethical challenges and personal temptations, and it is the foundation upon which trust, and respect are built. An individual realizes integrity when thoughts and actions align with what he or she knows to be right. The virtues that demonstrate one truly values integrity include:

1.3.5.1. Honesty. The hallmark of integrity is honesty. As public servants, Airmen are trusted agents. Honesty requires us to evaluate our performance against standards, and to conscientiously and accurately report findings. It drives us to advance our skills and credentials through our own effort. Our word must be unquestionable. This is the only way to preserve the trust and respect that we hold so dear for one another and the population we serve.

1.3.5.2. Courage. Not the absence of fear but doing the right thing despite fear. Courage empowers us to take necessary personal or professional risks, make decisions that may be unpopular, and admit to our mistakes; having the courage to take these actions is crucial for the mission, the Air Force, and the Nation. A person of integrity does what is right even if the personal cost is high.

1.3.5.3. Accountability. Accountability is the responsibility to an audience. That audience may be the American people, our units, our supervisors, our fellow Airmen, our families, our loved ones, and even ourselves. Accountable individuals maintain transparency, seek honest and constructive feedback, lead and live with respect for themselves and others, and take ownership of the outcomes of their actions and decisions. They are responsible to themselves and others and refrain from actions which discredit themselves or our Service.

1.3.5.4. Humility. A person of integrity grasps and is sobered by the extraordinary task of defending the Constitution of the United States. We practice humility by putting others before ourselves. We seek to add value through community and humanitarian support. We serve with gratitude and without arrogance.

1.3.6. Service Before Self. The choice to serve is a decision to hold ourselves to a higher standard; it is a calling, a daily commitment that takes energy, dedication, and sacrifice. Selfless services places demands upon us which are not levied upon the American public or

those who choose other professions. Selfless service begins when our Airmen take the Oath of Office or Enlistment, but it does not mean that we let go of all that we hold dear – our family, loved ones, and sincerely held beliefs. We embrace a disciplined approach to self-control, respect for authority, and respect for the beliefs and worth of others. Additionally, Airmen must practice self-care first to be able to serve others. The virtues that demonstrate one truly values service include:

1.3.6.1. Duty. The obligation to perform what is required for the mission. While our responsibilities are determined by the law, the DoD, and DAF instructions, directives, and guidance, our sense of duty is a personal one and bound by the oath of service we took as individuals. Duty sometimes calls for sacrifice unlike any other profession. Airmen who truly embody Service Before Self consistently choose to make necessary sacrifices to accomplish the mission, and in doing so, they honor those who made such sacrifices before us.

1.3.6.2. Loyalty. An internal commitment to the success and preservation of something bigger than ourselves. An Airman's loyalty is to the Nation first, the values and commitments of the Air Force second, and finally to those with whom they serve. Loyalty to leaders requires Airmen to trust, follow, and execute leader's decisions, even when they disagree. We offer alternative solutions and innovative ideas most effectively through the chain of command. Leaders demonstrate loyalty by respecting those who serve and treating them with dignity, compassion, and true concern for their wellbeing. Ultimately, loyalty is demonstrated by helping each other act with respect and honor.

1.3.6.3. Respect. Encompasses self-respect, mutual respect, and organizational respect. This three-dimensional view requires us to embrace the unique value of all individuals and treat everyone with dignity. We must always act in the certain knowledge that all Airmen must be treated with respect and Boldly speak up, even when it is uncomfortable, to assert this truth. Further, respecting others requires a commitment to recognize and root out prejudices, biases, and stereotypes. Airmen must engage genuinely, honestly, and with an empathetic and open mind. We must honor the Air Force and others by following our words with actions. Respect must be embraced mutually by military and civilian personnel in all grades or positions and demonstrated in the everyday actions of all Airmen. Without it, we simply cannot stand strong in the defense of our Nation. Mutual respect strengthens teamwork, supports increased communication, reduces stress, and diminishes conflict. Put simply, respect means treating others the way you would want to be treated and creating an environment, through your words and actions, where every Airman can serve to their full potential.

1.3.7. Excellence In All We Do. This Air Force core value does not mean that the Air Force demands perfection in everything from everyone. Instead, it directs Airmen to continuously advance their craft and increase their knowledge as Airmen. Airmen must have a passion for continuous improvement and innovation that propels America's Air Force in quantum leaps towards accomplishment and performance. The virtues that demonstrate one truly values excellence include:

1.3.7.1. Mission. The mission focus must encompass operations and excellence in stewardship. The complex undertaking of the Air Force mission requires us to harness the ingenuity, expertise, and elbow grease of all Airmen. Airmen approach it with the mindset

of respect, pride, innovation, and a continued commitment to anticipate and embrace change. Our work areas, our processes, and our interpersonal interactions must be undeniably professional and positive. Our people are the platform for delivering innovative ideas, strategies, and technologies to the fight.

1.3.7.2. Discipline. An individual commitment to uphold the highest personal and professional standards. Airmen commit to a life of discipline and self-control. They demonstrate it in attitude, work ethic, and effort directed at continuous improvement, whether it be pursuing professional military education or nurturing ourselves physically, intellectually, emotionally, or spiritually. Each Airman represents the entire Air Force. Our appearance, actions, and words shape the culture of the Air Force and the reputation of the entire military profession.

1.3.7.3. Teamwork. Essential to triumph at every level. Airmen recognize the interdependency of every Airman's contributions towards the mission and strive for organizational excellence. They not only give their personal best, but also challenge and motivate each other to perform their best. They gain respect through their actions and strong work ethic to build team trust, and they give respect to others for their contributions. Airmen carry their own weight and do whatever is necessary to help our wingmen carry theirs. They embrace the idea that their part of the Air Force meets the Air Force's world-class standard.

1.4. Major Performance Areas (MPAs) and Airmen Leadership Qualities (ALQs). How well a member does their job and the qualities the individual brings to the job are of paramount importance to the Air Force. It is also important for development of skills and leadership abilities and in determining who will be selected for advancement through assignments, promotions, and other personnel actions. The Officer and Enlisted Evaluation Systems, DAFI 36-2406, emphasizes the importance of performance using periodic performance feedback as the basis for formal evaluations and through the use of Airman Leadership Qualities (ALQs). ALQs are used as a competency-based assessment of the qualities we value in all Airmen. DAFI 36-2406 groups ten ALQs under four Major Performance Areas (MPAs)—Executing the Mission, Leading People, Managing Resources, and Improving the Unit—derived from AFI 1-2, *Air Force Culture: Commander's Responsibilities*. MPAs represent key processes, procedures and requirements based on public law, executive orders, directives, and instructions. DAFI 36-2406 outlines the feedback and evaluation methods for assessing Airmen under the framework of MPAs and ALQs.

1.4.1. Executing the Mission. Effectively uses knowledge, initiative, and adaptability to produce timely, high quality/quantity results to positively impact the mission. The ALQs are Job Proficiency; Initiative; and Adaptability.

1.4.1.1. Job Proficiency. Demonstrates knowledge and professional skill in assigned duties, achieving positive results and impact in support of the mission.

1.4.1.2. Initiative. Independently assesses and takes action to complete a task or mission that produces meaningful results.

1.4.1.3. Adaptability. Adjusts to changing conditions, to include plans, information, processes, requirements, and obstacles in accomplishing the mission.

1.4.2. **Leading People.** Fosters cohesive teams, effectively communicates, and uses emotional intelligence to take care of people and accomplish the mission. The ALQs are: Inclusion & Teamwork; Emotional Intelligence; and Communication.

1.4.2.1. **Inclusion & Teamwork.** Collaborates effectively with others to achieve an inclusive climate in pursuit of a common goal or to complete a task or mission.

1.4.2.2. **Emotional Intelligence.** Exercises self-awareness, manages their own emotions effectively; demonstrates an understanding of others' emotions, and appropriately manages relationships.

1.4.2.3. **Communication.** Articulates information in a clear and timely manner, both verbally and non-verbally, through active listening and messaging tailored to the appropriate audience.

1.4.3. **Managing Resources.** Manages assigned resources effectively and takes responsibility for actions/behaviors to maximize organizational performance. The ALQs are: Stewardship; and Accountability.

1.4.3.1. **Stewardship.** Demonstrates responsible management of assigned resources, which may include time, equipment, people, funds and/or facilities.

1.4.3.2. **Accountability.** Takes responsibility for the actions and behaviors of self and/or team; demonstrates reliability and transparency.

1.4.4. **Improving the Unit.** Demonstrates critical thinking and fosters innovation to find creative solutions and improve mission execution. The ALQs are: Decision Making; and Innovation.

1.4.4.1. **Decision Making.** Makes well-informed, effective, and timely decisions under one's control that weigh constraints, risks, and benefits.

1.4.4.2. **Innovation.** Thinks creatively about different ways to solve problems, implements improvements and demonstrates calculated risk-taking.

1.5. Oath. Upon entering the Air Force, all Airmen voluntarily took an oath. Each time we accept continued service or reenlist, we reaffirm our belief in and commitment to that oath. We promise to protect and defend our American freedoms and agree to live by a set of military rules and standards. The oath is consistent with and encompasses the Air Force Core Values of Integrity, Service, and Excellence. An Airman's actions must always be consistent with this oath. See 10 U.S.C. § 502; 5 U.S.C. § 3331; DAFI 36-2606, *Reenlistment in the United States Air Force*; DAFI 36-2501, *Officer Promotions and Selective Continuation*.

1.5.1. **Oath of Enlistment.**

"I, _____, do solemnly swear (or affirm) that I will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; and that I will obey the orders of the President of the United States and the orders of the officers appointed over me, according to regulations and the Uniform Code of Military Justice. So help me God." (**Note:** Members may omit the words "So help me God," if desired.)

1.5.2. **Oath of Office (Commissioning Oath).**

“I,___, having been appointed a (grade in which appointed) in the United States Air Force, do solemnly swear (or affirm) that I will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; that I take this obligation freely, without any mental reservation or purpose of evasion; and that I will well and faithfully discharge the duties of the office upon which I am about to enter. So help me God.” (**Note:** Members may omit the words “So help me God,” if desired.)

1.6. The Airman’s Creed. The Airman’s Creed reminds all Airmen that we are far more than a conglomeration of diverse specialties, skill sets, or jobs. Airmen are in the profession of arms made up entirely of volunteers sworn to defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies. Those “arms” may be classical weapons of physical warfare or the vastly complex structures and activities that enable the Air Force to project sophisticated power on behalf of America. The Creed allows Airmen to think and act with one mind, and with a commitment to victory in any armed conflict. Airmen are warriors, and are dedicated to flying, fighting, and winning in every domain of operations.

I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
I AM A WARRIOR.
I HAVE ANSWERED MY NATION’S CALL.

I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
MY MISSION IS TO FLY, FIGHT, AND WIN.
I AM FAITHFUL TO A PROUD HERITAGE,
A TRADITION OF HONOR,
AND A LEGACY OF VALOR.

I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN,
GUARDIAN OF FREEDOM AND JUSTICE,
MY NATION’S SWORD AND SHIELD,
ITS SENTRY AND AVENGER.
I DEFEND MY COUNTRY WITH MY LIFE.

I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN:
WINGMAN, LEADER, WARRIOR.
I WILL NEVER LEAVE AN AIRMAN BEHIND,
I WILL NEVER FALTER,
AND I WILL NOT FAIL.

1.7. Code of Conduct. The Code of Conduct, established by President Eisenhower through Executive Order 10631 17 Aug 1955, outlines basic responsibilities and obligations of members of the U.S. Armed Forces. The Air Force expects all Airmen to measure up to the standards described in the Code of Conduct. Originally developed to guide Service members who became prisoners of war, the spirit and intent remain equally applicable to Service members subject to hostile detention. Such Service members should consistently conduct themselves in a manner that brings credit to themselves and our country. The six articles of the Code of Conduct address situations and decision areas that any Service member could encounter to some degree. The Code of Conduct includes basic information useful to prisoners of war to help them survive honorably

while resisting captors' efforts to exploit them. Such survival and resistance require knowledge, understanding and a commitment to the articles:

1.7.1. ARTICLE 1. I am an American, fighting in the forces which guard my country and our way of life. I am prepared to give my life in their defense.

1.7.2. ARTICLE 2. I will never surrender of my own free will. If in command, I will never surrender the members of my command while they still have the means to resist.

1.7.3. ARTICLE 3. If I am captured, I will continue to resist by all means available. I will make every effort to escape and to aid others to escape. I will accept neither parole nor special favors from the enemy.

1.7.4. ARTICLE 4. If I become a prisoner of war, I will keep faith with my fellow prisoners. I will give no information or take part in any action which might be harmful to my comrades. If I am senior, I will take command. If not, I will obey the lawful orders of those appointed over me and will back them up in every way.

1.7.5. ARTICLE 5. When questioned, should I become a prisoner of war, I am required to give name, rank, Service number, and date of birth. I will evade answering further questions to the utmost of my ability. I will make no oral or written statements disloyal to my country and its allies or harmful to their cause.

1.7.6. ARTICLE 6. I will never forget that I am an American, fighting for freedom, responsible for my actions, and dedicated to the principles which made my country free. I will trust in my God and in the United States of America.

1.8. Customs and Courtesies. Our customs and courtesies reflect the unique nature of our profession and guide significant aspects of our behavior. We emphasize our strong bond with other military members, as well as our mutual respect for one another and our civilian leadership. See AFI 34-1201, *Protocol*; Air Force Pamphlet (AFPAM) 34-1202, *Guide to Protocol*.

1.8.1. Saluting. Saluting is a courtesy exchanged between members of the uniformed Services as both a greeting and a symbol of mutual respect. The basic rules regarding saluting are:

1.8.1.1. Airmen salute the President, Vice President, Secretary of Defense, Department Secretaries, all superior commissioned and warrant officers, all Medal of Honor recipients, and superior officers of friendly foreign nations.

1.8.1.2. Airmen salute the President, the Vice President, Secretary of Defense, Department Secretaries, and senior officers in vehicles when distinguished by vehicle plates and/or flags.

1.8.1.3. Airmen do not, typically, salute indoors. However, it is appropriate to salute when formally reporting to a superior officer and during ceremonial events.

1.8.1.4. Airmen salute outdoors when in uniform, both on and off base, unless:

1.8.1.4.1. Precluded by duties, safety, injury, carrying objects which cannot be transferred to the left hand, or other legitimate reason. In this case, a respectful oral greeting is appropriate. If the senior member's right arm is incapacitated, Airmen will still salute.

1.8.1.4.2. In a designated no-salute area.

1.8.1.4.3. In military formation or work detail, in which case, only the senior member of the formation or detail salutes.

1.8.1.5. Saluting while in physical training gear is authorized, but not required.

1.8.1.6. Salutes between individuals are not required in public gatherings, such as sporting events, meetings, or when a salute would be inappropriate or impractical.

1.8.2. Respect for the United States Flag. Guidance on proper United States Flag protocols is addressed in AFI 34-1201. Airmen should be familiar the guidance and requirements concerning proper respect to the United States Flag.

1.8.2.1. When in uniform, Airmen salute the flag as it passes in front of them in a procession or parade. Airmen salute six paces before the flag passes before them and hold the salute until the flag has passed six paces beyond their position.

1.8.2.2. National Anthem. Airmen must show respect for the flag during the playing of the National Anthem, both indoors and outdoors, in uniform and while in civilian clothing.

1.8.2.2.1. Indoor Ceremonies. When in uniform, face the flag (if visible) or music. Stand at attention at the first note and maintain that position until the last note without rendering a salute. If in civilian clothing, Airmen stand at attention and place their right hand over their heart.

1.8.2.2.2. Outdoor Ceremonies. When in uniform, face the flag (if visible) or music. Stand at attention and salute at the first note of the National Anthem and hold until completion of the last note. If in civilian clothing, Airmen should either stand at attention and place their right hand over their heart or render a salute. Civilian hats will be removed.

1.8.2.3. During the playing of the national anthems of recognized nations, render the same customs and courtesies as those given during the playing of the United States National Anthem.

1.8.2.4. Reveille and Retreat. Flags on stationary flag staffs are only saluted during reveille, retreat, or special ceremonies. In these cases, when outside and in uniform, consistent with safety and mission requirements, Airmen stop what they are doing, face the direction of the flag (if visible) or the music. Stand at parade rest during the sounding of retreat (which precedes the lowering of the flag), then come to attention and salute during the playing of the National Anthem or “To the Colors.” If driving a vehicle, stop if consistent with safety and mission requirements. Airmen and their passengers should sit quietly until the music ends.

1.8.2.5. Taps. Many installations play “Taps” to signify lights out at the end of the day. For these purposes, there are no formal protocol procedures required. However, upon hearing “Taps” at a military ceremony (military funeral/memorial ceremony), proper protocol dictates Airmen in uniform render appropriate honors consistent with protocol for the National Anthem (see [paragraph 1.8.2.2](#)), indoor and outdoor, until the music is complete.

1.8.2.6. Pledge of Allegiance. When in uniform and outdoors, stand at attention, face the flag, remain silent, and salute. If indoors, stand at attention, face the flag, and remain silent (where the participants are primarily civilians or in civilian attire, reciting the Pledge of

Allegiance is optional for those in uniform). When not in uniform, Airmen stand at attention, face the flag, place their right hand over their heart, and recite the Pledge of Allegiance. Civilian hats will be removed.

1.8.3. Respect for Retirees. Retirees are entitled to the same respect and courtesies as active military personnel. They will be addressed by their retired grade on all official records and official correspondence, except for correspondence and other matters relating to a retiree's civilian employment. See AFI 36-3106, *Retiree Activities Program*.

1.8.4. Respect for Authority. Junior personnel shall employ a courteous and respectful bearing and mode of speech toward senior personnel. When addressed by an officer senior to them, junior personnel shall stand (unless seated at mess or unless circumstances make such action impracticable or inappropriate). Junior personnel shall walk or ride to the left of senior personnel whom they are accompanying. Senior personnel enter an aircraft or automobile last and leave first.

1.8.5. Titles of Address. Military personnel are addressed by their grade or title. Pay grade terms (e.g., E-9, O-6) are not to be used to address or identify military personnel. Officers are addressed by their grade name (e.g., Captain, Major, General) or "sir" or "ma'am." Physicians and dental officers may be addressed as "Doctor." Chaplains may be addressed as "Chaplain" or by their ecclesiastical title. Enlisted personnel are addressed in **Figure 1.1**.

Figure 1.1. Air Force Enlisted Terms of Address.

TITLE	TERM OF ADDRESS
Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force	Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force or Chief
Chief Master Sergeant	Chief Master Sergeant or Chief
Senior Master Sergeant	Senior Master Sergeant or Senior or Sergeant
Master Sergeant	Master Sergeant or Sergeant
Technical Sergeant	Technical Sergeant or Tech Sergeant or Sergeant
Staff Sergeant	Staff Sergeant or Sergeant
Senior Airman	Senior Airman or Airman
Airman First Class	Airman First Class or Airman
Airman	Airman
Airman Basic	Airman Basic or Airman

1.9. Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility. Diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility are key to Air Force standards and missions. Diversity of thought, experience, and perspectives is critical to innovation and maintaining the Air Force's competitive advantage. At their core, diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility provide our Total Force an aggregation of strengths, perspectives, and capabilities that transcends individual contributions. Our ability to attract a larger, highly talented, diverse pool of applicants for service with the Air Force, both military and civilian, and develop and retain our current personnel will impact our future Total

Force. Diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility are about strengthening our force and ensuring our long-term viability to support Air Force missions with dignity and respect. See AAFP 36-70, *Diversity & Inclusion*; AFI 36-7001, *Diversity and Inclusion*.

Chapter 2

CONDUCT

2.1. Overview. The high standards of the Air Force mandate that personnel conduct themselves consistent with those standards. This includes treating others with genuine dignity, fairness, and respect at all times. Each Airman is entitled to fair, just, and unbiased treatment. Each Airman has the obligation to care for, teach, and lead others. Behavior that departs from those standards not only degrades public trust in the Air Force, but also puts mission accomplishment at risk. This chapter provides details of conduct that is either expected of all Airmen or prohibited and the basis for possible discipline.

2.2. Professional Relationships. While personal relationships between military members are normally matters of individual choice and judgment, they can in certain circumstances become matters of official concern. They become such matters when the relationships adversely affect, or have the reasonable potential to adversely affect, the Air Force by eroding morale, good order, discipline, respect for authority, unit cohesion, or mission accomplishment. *See AFI 36-2909, Air Force Professional Relationships and Conduct.*

2.2.1. Professional relationships are those interpersonal relationships that reflect Air Force standards of conduct and the Air Force Core Values. Effective professional relationships enhance morale, unit cohesion, good order and discipline and improve the operational environment while, at the same time, preserving proper respect for authority and focus on the mission.

2.2.2. With respect to relationships between superiors and subordinates, whether they are other military members or civilian employees, there is a balance that recognizes the appropriateness of a relationship. Social interaction that contributes appropriately to unit cohesiveness and effectiveness is encouraged. Relationships are unprofessional when they detract from the supervisor-to-subordinate authority or reasonably create the appearance of favoritism, misuse of office or position, or the abandonment of organizational goals for personal interests. This is true whether pursued and conducted on or off duty.

2.2.3. Unprofessional relationships can develop between officers, between enlisted members, between officers and enlisted members, between officers or enlisted members and cadets, and between military personnel and civilian employees or contractor personnel when standards are not maintained. Unprofessional relationships conducted via electronic means (e.g., by phone, text messaging, social media) are no less corrosive to good order and discipline, and abuse by members in these forums shall result in the same degree of accountability. This includes avoiding inappropriate electronic friendships that compromise and degrade the officer/enlisted command and supervisory relationships.

2.2.4. The rank of cadet is a unique military rank reserved for cadets at the United States Air Force Academy and the Reserve Officers' Training Corps. A cadet is neither enlisted, nor an officer. Dating, close friendships, or sexual relationships between cadets and officers or cadets and enlisted personnel are prohibited. More specific guidance concerning relationships among different classes of cadets is provided through the leadership of the United States Air Force Academy and Reserve Officers' Training Corps programs.

2.2.5. There is a long-standing and well-recognized custom in military service, as well as set forth in the UCMJ and DAF issuances, that officers and enlisted personnel shall not fraternize. Fraternization exists when a relationship between an officer and an enlisted member puts the enlisted member on terms of military equality with the officer in such a way that prejudices good order and discipline in the armed forces or is of a nature to bring discredit upon the armed forces. Excessive socialization and undue familiarity, real or perceived, degrades leadership and interferes with command authority and mission effectiveness. With the proliferation of social media and online video conferencing, the task of maintaining professionalism requires a heightened awareness to ensure full compliance regardless of the medium of interaction used.

2.2.6. Relationships in which one member exercises supervisory or command authority over another can become unprofessional. Similarly, differences in grade increase the risk that a relationship will be, or will be perceived to be, unprofessional because senior members in military organizations exercise authority, or have some direct or indirect organizational influence, over the duties and careers of junior members. The danger for abuse of authority, or the perception of such abuse, is always present. The ability of the senior member to influence assignments directly or indirectly, promotion recommendations, duties, awards, and other privileges and benefits, places both the senior member and the junior member in vulnerable positions. Once established, unprofessional relationships, such as inappropriate personal relationships and favoritism, do not go unnoticed by other members of a unit and call into question the superior's impartiality toward the subordinate and his or her peers. Failure to maintain relationships between members in a strictly professional manner undermines morale, good order, and discipline, and corrodes the indispensable respect for the chain of command and unit cohesion.

2.2.7. Unprofessional relationships can develop between members of different Military Services when the relationships adversely affect or have the reasonable potential to adversely affect the Air Force by eroding morale, good order, discipline, respect for authority, unit cohesion, or mission accomplishment.

2.2.8. Civilian employees and contractor personnel are an integral part of the Air Force. These fellow Airmen and teammates contribute directly to readiness and mission accomplishment. Consequently, military members of all grades must maintain professional relationships with civilian employees and government contractor personnel they work with, supervise or direct, and must avoid relationships that adversely affect or are perceived to adversely affect morale, discipline, respect for authority, and unit cohesion, or that violate law or regulation.

2.3. Standards of Ethical Conduct. As Air Force members, Airmen must practice the highest standards of conduct and integrity, not only in our jobs, but also in our relationships with other people, in our personal financial dealings, and in our interaction with the civilian community; and must not engage in any conduct that is illegal or otherwise brings discredit to the Air Force. An Airman's code of ethics must be such that our behavior and motives do not create even the appearance of impropriety. Each Airman's commitment to integrity will lead the way for others to follow.

2.3.1. Title 5 Code of Federal Regulations (CFR), Section 2635.101 establishes the basic ethical principles that must be followed by federal employees:

2.3.1.1. Public service is a public trust, requiring employees to place loyalty to the Constitution, the laws, and ethical principles above private gain.

2.3.1.2. Employees shall not hold financial interests that conflict with the conscientious performance of duty.

2.3.1.3. Employees shall not engage in financial transactions using nonpublic government information or allow the improper use of such information to further any private interest.

2.3.1.4. An employee shall not solicit or accept any gift or other item of monetary value from any person or entity seeking official action from, doing business with, or conducting activities regulated by the employee's agency, or whose interests may be substantially affected by the performance or nonperformance of the employee's duties.

2.3.1.5. Employees shall put forth honest effort in the performance of their duties.

2.3.1.6. Employees shall not knowingly make unauthorized commitments or promises of any kind purporting to bind the government.

2.3.1.7. Employees shall not use public office for private gain.

2.3.1.8. Employees shall act impartially and not give preferential treatment to any private organization or individual.

2.3.1.9. Employees shall protect and conserve Federal property and shall not use it for other than authorized activities.

2.3.1.10. Employees shall not engage in outside employment or activities, including seeking or negotiating for employment, that conflict with official government duties and responsibilities.

2.3.1.11. Employees shall disclose fraud, waste, abuse, and corruption to appropriate authorities.

2.3.1.12. Employees shall satisfy, in good faith, their obligations as citizens, including all just financial obligations, especially those—such as federal, state, or local taxes—that are imposed by law.

2.3.1.13. Employees shall adhere to all laws and regulations that provide equal opportunity for all persons regardless of protected class.

2.3.1.14. Employees shall endeavor to avoid any actions creating the appearance that they are violating the law or ethical standards. Whether circumstances create an appearance that the law or ethical standards have been violated shall be determined from the perspective of a reasonable person with knowledge of the relevant facts.

2.3.2. Conflicts of Interest. A conflict of interest is a personal interest or relationship that conflicts with the faithful performance of official duty. Under 18 U.S.C. § 208, a Federal employee is prohibited from participating personally and substantially in an official capacity in any matter in which, to his knowledge, he, or any person whose interests are imputed to him under this statute has a financial interest, if the particular matter will have a direct and predictable effect on that interest.

2.3.2.1. One method of identifying potential conflicts of interest and preventing them is by the timely filing of financial disclosure reports if the individual is a required filer.

2.3.2.2. Ethics counselors help required filers by reviewing financial reports, educating on the law and regulatory guidance, and assisting with remedies.

2.3.3. Gifts from outside sources. Federal Regulation 5 CFR 2635.202, *et seq* provides guidance for gifts from outside sources:

2.3.3.1. As a general rule, employees may not solicit or accept gifts given to them from a prohibited source or given to them because of their official position. A prohibited source is an entity or company that: 1) is seeking official action by DoD; 2) does business or seeks to do business with DoD; 3) conducts activities regulated by DoD; or 4) has interests that may be substantially affected by the performance or nonperformance of a DoD employee's official duties.

2.3.3.2. There are limited exemptions and exceptions to the general rule including, but not limited to: 1) modest food and refreshments (non-alcoholic) not offered as part of a meal; 2) items intended primarily for presentation that have little intrinsic value (such as plaques, certificates, and trophies); 3) discounts and favorable rates offered to all government or all military personnel; 4) non-cash items with a value of \$20 or less (not to exceed \$50 per calendar year from a single source); and 5) gifts based on outside personal/family or business relationships (of the Airman or their spouse).

2.3.4. Gifts Between Employees. Federal Regulations (5 CFR 2635.301, *et seq.*) provides guidance on gifts between employees:

2.3.4.1. Employees may generally not accept gifts from subordinates or employees that make less pay than themselves.

2.3.4.2. Employees may not: 1) solicit a donation or a contribution from other personnel for a gift to a superior; 2) make a donation for a gift to a superior official, or 3) accept a gift from subordinate personnel, except under these circumstances: (a) voluntary gifts or contributions of nominal value (the solicitation of which should not exceed \$10); (b) on occasions of special personal significance (e.g., marriage, birth of a child, bereavement); however, the gift must be appropriate to the occasion; (c) or on occasions that terminate the superior-subordinate relationship (e.g., retirement, permanent change of station or assignment); however, there is a \$300 limit for a gift from any group that includes a subordinate.

2.3.5. Use of Government Resources, Time, and Title.

2.3.5.1. In accordance with 5 CFR 2635.704, federal employees have a duty to protect and conserve Government property as well as refrain from using or allowing its use for purposes other than those for which it is made available to the public or those authorized in accordance with law or regulation.

2.3.5.2. Federal Employees shall use official time in an honest effort to perform official duties, unless authorized under law or regulation to use official time for other purposes. See 5 CFR 2635.705[a].

2.3.5.3. Per 5 CFR 2635.705(b), an employee shall not encourage, direct, coerce, or request a subordinate to use official time to perform activities other than those required in the performance of official duties or authorized in accordance with law or regulation.

2.3.5.4. Employees may not use or permit the use of their government positions, titles, or authority in a manner that could be reasonably construed to imply official endorsement or sanction of personal activities or non-Federal entities, 5 CFR 2635.702. However, per the

Joint Ethics Regulation (JER) 5500.07-R, 3-300(a)(1), use of grade and branch of Service are usually considered customary terms of address and do not imply official endorsement.

2.3.6. The *Joint Ethics Regulation* (JER), DoD 5500.07-R, provides additional guidance concerning acceptable ethical conduct by DoD personnel:

2.3.6.1. Employees may not engage in any personal commercial solicitation or sale to any military personnel junior in grade at any time—on or off-duty, in or out of uniform. This does not apply to the one-time sale of personal property, such as a home, boat, or car, where the junior buyer approaches the senior seller to engage in the transaction and the junior buyer receives fair market value for any purchase made. It also does not apply to off-duty DoD personnel employed—with appropriate supervisor permission—in retail stores or other situations that do not include solicited sales. *See* JER, paragraph 2-205.

2.3.6.2. Employees may not gamble or bet while on government-owned or leased property or while in a duty status, unless specifically authorized. *See* JER, paragraph 2-302.

2.3.6.3. Employees may not endorse, or appear to endorse, fundraising for any charitable purpose. However, there are limited exceptions to this prohibition including endorsement or the appearance of endorsement of fundraising for the Combined Federal Campaign (CFC), the Air Force Assistance Fund (AFAF), and other organizations composed primarily of DoD employees or their dependents when fundraising among their own members for the benefit of welfare funds for their own members or their dependents. Supervisors may encourage subordinate participation in the AFAF Campaign and in the CFC generally (but may not endorse individual component charities). *See* JER, paragraph 3-210.

2.3.6.4. As members of private nonprofit and professional organizations, employees must avoid using, or appearing to use, their title, position, or DAF organization in a way that might suggest DAF or DoD endorsement of the private organization. Employees may participate in the management of such an organization so long as those duties do not interfere with their official DAF duties and the position of responsibility was not offered to them because of their official DAF position. *See* JER, paragraph 3-300.

2.4. Duty Performance. Our primary responsibility as Airmen is to do our part to accomplish the mission; however, accomplishing the mission requires more than just technical proficiency. Airman must be team members. We must be responsive and accomplish our duties in a timely and efficient manner. We must be dependable and responsible for our own actions and avoid the need for supervisors and commanders to constantly monitor or follow up on our activities. Quality and quantity of work are both important since they are our primary measures of efficiency and productivity. Our conduct and performance must be guided by the Air Force Core Values and the principles of mission command.

2.5. Mission Command. Mission command is a philosophy of leadership that empowers Airmen to operate in uncertain, complex, and rapidly changing environments through trust, shared awareness, and understanding commander's intent. The key attribute of mission command is decentralized execution through the delegation of authority to empower subordinate decision making and enable flexibility, initiative, and responsiveness in the accomplishment of commander's intent. Airmen at all levels should be comfortable making decisions and operating

based on commander's intent and the principles of mission command. See Air Force Doctrine Publication, AFDP 1, *The Air Force*

2.6. Wingmen. Airmen at all levels of command and supervision, have a role as wingmen. The Air Force culture is centered on the idea that a wingman will always safeguard their lead, and it adheres to the belief that a lead never lets his or her wingman stray into danger. All Airmen are encouraged to be good wingmen. Being a good wingman means taking care of fellow Airmen and taking action when signs of trouble or distress are observed, especially in situations where Airmen appear as if they are about to make a poor decision, are in despair, or show signs of hurting themselves or others. Commanders also need to recognize when their people need help and know where to send them to get it. Supervisors are the first line of defense for the well-being of the people they supervise. And as leaders, supervisors are often in a position to spot the first signs of trouble and are in the best position to listen and provide, or arrange for, needed assistance.

2.7. Unlawful Discrimination. The DAF does not tolerate unlawful discrimination and harassment (including bullying, hazing, and sexual harassment) against military members on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex (including pregnancy), gender identity, sexual orientation, and religion. The DAF does not tolerate unlawful discrimination and harassment against civilian employees on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex (including pregnancy, gender identity, and sexual orientation), religion, age (40 or older), disability, genetic information, and retaliation that contributes to a hostile work environment. The right to non-discrimination on the basis of religion includes the right to reasonable accommodation of one's religious beliefs and practices. See DAFI 36-2710, *Equal Opportunity Program*.

2.7.1. Unlawful harassment includes creating an intimidating, hostile working environment for another person on the basis of a protected class. The use of disparaging terms with respect to a person's protected class contributes to a hostile work environment and must not be tolerated. It is the obligation of each Airman (military and civilian) in the chain of command or supervision to identify and prevent such conduct. Commanders and supervisors are responsible for establishing a work climate free from unlawful discrimination and harassment and are responsible for fostering a work climate that can readily identify and appropriately address these behaviors.

2.8. Harassment. The DAF will not tolerate harassment that is unwelcome or offensive to a reasonable person, whether oral, written, or physical, that creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive environment. Harassment can occur through electronic communications, including social media, other forms of communication, and in person. Harassment may include offensive jokes, epithets, ridicule or mockery, insults, or put-downs, displays of offensive objects or imagery, stereotyping, intimidating acts, veiled threats of violence, threatening or provoking remarks, racial or other slurs, derogatory remarks about a person's accent, or displays of racially offensive symbols. Activities or actions undertaken for a proper military or governmental purpose, such as combat survival training, are not considered harassment. Types of harassment include, but are not limited to, sexual harassment, bullying, and hazing. See DoDI 1020.03, *Harassment Prevention and Response in the Armed Forces*; DAFI 36-2710, *Equal Opportunity Program*.

2.8.1. Bullying includes acts of aggression by military members or civilian employees, with a nexus to military service, with the intent of harming a Service member either physically or psychologically, without a proper military or other governmental purpose. Bullying may involve the singling out of an individual from his or her coworkers, or unit, for ridicule because

he or she is considered different or weak. It often involves an imbalance of power between the aggressor and the victim.

2.8.2. Hazing includes conduct which physically or psychologically injures or creates a risk of injury without a proper military or governmental purpose for the initiation into, admission into, affiliation with, change in status or position within, or a condition for continued membership in any military or DoD civilian organization.

2.8.3. Sexual Harassment.

2.8.3.1. Sexual harassment under Article 134, UCMJ, involves knowingly making unwelcome sexual advances, demands or requests for sexual favors, or knowingly engaging in other conduct of a sexual nature. Under the circumstances, the conduct would cause a reasonable person to believe that submitting (or refusing to submit) to such conduct would be made (either explicitly or implicitly) a term or condition or be used as a basis for a decision affecting, the person's job, career, pay, benefits, or entitlements. The conduct may also constitute the offense if it is so severe, repetitive, or pervasive that a reasonable person would perceive it as creating an intimidating, hostile, or offensive working environment and under the circumstances, the conduct affects good order and discipline in the armed forces, or of a nature to bring discredit upon the armed forces.

2.8.3.2. Sexual harassment under DAFI 36-2710 involves unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and deliberate or repeated offensive comments or gestures of a sexual nature when: (1) submission to such conduct is made either explicitly or implicitly a term or condition of a person's job, pay, or career; (2) submission to or rejection of such conduct by a person is used as a basis for career or employment decisions affecting that person; or (3) such conduct has the purpose or effect of unreasonably interfering with an individual's work performance or creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive environment; and is so severe or pervasive that a reasonable person would perceive, and the victim does perceive, the environment as hostile or offensive. Use or condonation, by any person in a supervisory or command position, of any form of sexual behavior to control, influence, or affect the career, pay, or job of a member of the armed forces is prohibited. Any deliberate or repeated unwelcome verbal comments or gestures of a sexual nature by any member of the armed forces or civilian employee of the Department of Defense is prohibited. There is no requirement for concrete psychological harm for behavior to constitute sexual harassment. Behavior is sufficient to constitute sexual harassment if it is so severe or pervasive that a reasonable person would perceive, and the complainant does perceive, the environment as hostile or offensive. Sexual harassment can occur through electronic communications, including social media, other forms of communication, and in person.

2.8.4. Retaliation. Airmen shall not retaliate against any person for reporting or planning to report a criminal offense, or making or planning to make a protected communication, or with the intent to discourage any person from reporting a criminal offense or making or planning to make a protected communication. Retaliation is taking or threatening to take an adverse personnel action, or withholding or threatening to withhold a favorable personnel action, with respect to a military member because the member reported a criminal offense. See DAFI 36-2710, *Equal Opportunity Program*.

2.9. Sexual Assault. The DAF will not tolerate sexual assault. Sexual assault undermines our mission readiness, directly contradicts the Air Force Core Values, and erodes the trust and confidence upon which our institution is built. All Airmen have the enduring responsibility to foster a climate of dignity and respect and to promote and ensure a culture that will not tolerate sexual assault or behaviors that support it. See Article 120 UCMJ and DAFI 90-6001, *Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) Program*.

2.10. Drug Abuse. The illegal use of drugs, or improper use of legal drugs, is not just against federal law, but is also completely inconsistent with Air Force Core Values and DAF standards of behavior, performance, and discipline necessary to accomplish the Air Force missions. Drug abuse can seriously damage an Airman's physical and mental health, jeopardize their safety and the safety of others, and adversely affect the success of Air Force missions and national security. It can result in criminal prosecution or nonjudicial punishment under Article 112a, UCMJ, as well as administrative discharge. It can also subject members to prosecution under federal, state, and local criminal law. See AFI 44-121, *Alcohol and Drug Abuse Prevention and Treatment (ADAPT) Program*.

2.10.1. The knowing use or attempted use of any intoxicating substance (other than the lawful use of alcohol, tobacco products, or prescription drugs), which is inhaled, injected, consumed, or introduced into the body in any manner to alter mood or function is prohibited and will not be tolerated. These substances include, but are not limited to designer drugs, such as inhalants, propellants, solvents, household chemicals, and other substances used for "huffing"; prescription or over-the-counter medications when used in a manner contrary to their intended medical purpose or in excess of the prescribed dosage; and naturally occurring intoxicating substances. The possession of any intoxicating substance, with the intent to use the substance in a manner that would alter mood or function without legal authorization, or distribution of any intoxicating substance is also prohibited and will not be tolerated.

2.10.2. Airmen with substance abuse problems are encouraged to seek assistance from the unit commander, First Sergeant, substance abuse counselor, or a medical professional through the Alcohol and Drug Abuse Prevention and Treatment Program.

2.11. Alcohol Abuse. DAF standards call on all members to prevent alcohol abuse and alcoholism. Air Force leaders will assist Airmen in resolving alcohol-related problems. DAF standards ensure humane management and administrative disposition of those who are unable or unwilling to be restored to full, effective functioning. Alcohol abuse, such as driving while intoxicated, can also lead to disciplinary action, including criminal prosecution under the UCMJ or state and local law. Airmen are responsible for exercising good judgment in the use of alcohol. This includes ensuring alcohol use does not adversely affect an Airman's ability to be recalled, if specifically required (e.g., when serving in an on-call status), to the duty station during scheduled off-duty time. Further, State, and foreign nation drinking age laws, including those in a deployed environment, must be obeyed both on- and off-duty. Airmen may be enrolled in the Alcohol and Drug Abuse Prevention and Treatment (ADAPT) Program by Self-Identification, Command Referral, Medical Referral, or Addictive Behavior Referral if their misuse of alcohol negatively affects individual behavior, duty performance, and/or physical and mental health. See AFI 44-121, *Alcohol and Drug Abuse Prevention and Treatment (ADAPT) Program*.

2.12. Financial Responsibility. Just like physical fitness is important for an Airman's health, "fiscal fitness" is equally important to their overall well-being as an Air Force member. Failure to

satisfy just financial obligations is not consistent with the standards of conduct expected of Airmen. Two of the key tools to individual financial responsibility are the development and maintenance of a personal budget and effective management of one's debt. Airmen are expected to review leave and earnings statements on a regular basis to ensure the accuracy of pay and allowances, file travel vouchers in a timely manner, and use the government travel card for authorized purchases only. Additionally, Airmen are expected to provide regular and adequate support for dependents, including payments required by court order. To assist with financial affairs, the Air Force provides financial management information and personal counseling, as well as legal assistance. See DAFI 36-2906, *Personal Financial Responsibility*.

2.13. Dependent Care. The Air Force must have people in the right place at the right time, unencumbered and ready to perform the jobs for which they have been trained. Unless specifically deferred or exempted, all military personnel must be available at all times to perform a full range of military duties and assignments, including but not limited to, permanent change of station or assignment, unaccompanied tours, temporary duty (including short- or no- notice deployments), alerts, recalls, extended hours, or shift work. See DoDI 1342.19, *Family Care Plans*; AFI 36-2908, *Family Care Plans*.

2.13.1. Each Airman must make and maintain dependent care arrangements that will allow the member to be worldwide deployable at all times.

2.13.2. Dependent care plans must cover all possible situations in both the short- and long-term and must be sufficiently detailed and systematic to provide for a smooth, rapid transfer of responsibilities to another individual during the absence of the military sponsor.

2.13.3. Single parents and military couples with dependents face additional challenges. Nevertheless, these parents must be worldwide deployable on short notice. Suitable arrangements must be planned in advance for a nonmilitary member to assume custody of dependent(s) in the event the Service member(s) is/are unavailable to provide dependent care due to military obligations.

2.14. Self-Reporting Criminal Conviction. All Air Force commissioned officers, enlisted members above the grade of E-6, and any member serving in a Designated Special Duty assignment who are in the Regular Air Force or in an active duty status in the Reserve Component will report, in writing to their commander, any conviction for a violation of a criminal law of the United States or while serving overseas. The member must report a conviction whether or not the member was on active duty or inactive duty at the time of the conduct that provides the basis for the conviction. See AFI 36-2909, *Air Force Relationships and Conduct*.

2.15. Free Exercise of Religion and Religious Accommodation. Airmen should confidently practice their own beliefs while respecting others whose viewpoints differ from their own. Every Airman is free to practice the religion of their choice or subscribe to no religious belief at all. Every Airman also has the right to individual expressions of sincerely held beliefs, to include conscience, moral principles, or religious beliefs, unless those expressions would have an adverse impact on military readiness, unit cohesion, good order, discipline, health and safety, or mission accomplishment.

2.15.1. Airmen's right to practice their religious beliefs does not excuse them from complying with directives, instructions, and lawful orders; however, they may request religious accommodation in the form of deviations from directives, instructions, or lawful orders. With

the exception of medical practice or immunization accommodation requests, Airmen will continue to comply with directives, instructions, and lawful orders for which the member seeks accommodation until their religious accommodation request has been approved. See DoDI 1300.17, *Religious Liberty in the Military Services*; AFD 52-2, *Accommodation of Religious Practices in the Air Force*; DAFI 52-201, *Religious Freedom in the Department of the Air Force*.

2.16. Balance of Free Exercise of Religion and Establishment Clause. Leaders at all levels must balance constitutional protections for free exercise of religion and the constitutional prohibition against governmental establishment of religion. They must ensure their words and actions do not discriminate against any individual or group because of their faith, belief, or absence of belief, or extend preferential treatment for the same. Leaders must ensure that their personal expression is not reasonably associated with their government role, but may engage in such expression per DAFI 52-201, *Religious Freedom in the Department of the Air Force*.

2.17. Political Activities. Generally, as individuals, Airmen enjoy the same rights and have the same responsibilities as other citizens. However, because they are Airmen in the United States Air Force, the manner in which they exercise their rights is limited in some cases. Under our democratic system, the military, as a group, must remain politically neutral and divorced from partisan politics per AFI 51-508, *Political Activities, Free Speech, and Freedom of Assembly of Air Force Personnel*. There are some general rules that Airmen should remember:

2.17.1. Airmen have the right as American citizens to vote and to voice their opinions concerning political matters; however, they must be careful that their personal opinions and activities are not directly, or by implication, represented as those of the Air Force. Airmen must take care not to appear to represent the Air Force when they express their personal opinions and engage in activities associated with voting and political matters. Airmen must also refrain from contemptuous words against certain federal and state officials; the details of such rules are included in Articles 88 and 134 of the UCMJ.

2.17.2. Airmen may attend partisan political rallies or speeches when not in uniform, not on duty, and when solely acting as a spectator. Airmen, including Air Force Reserve and Air National Guard when in an active status, may not speak before a partisan political event, ride, or participate in a partisan political parade, or engage in partisan political fundraising activities, regardless of whether they are in uniform.

2.17.3. Airmen may make a monetary contribution to a political organization, party, or committee favoring a political candidate or slate of candidates, subject to the limitations of 52 USC § 30116.

2.17.4. Airmen may support or endorse a particular political candidate, party, cause, or issue through displaying a single standard-sized bumper sticker on personally owned vehicles. No larger vehicle signs are permitted. Airmen may not display any type of political sign, banner, poster, or similar device in their office or work area or at their on-base residence, even if that residence is part of a privatized housing development.

2.17.5. Federal installations and workplaces are not traditional public forums for free speech and political discussions are generally not appropriate. Airmen may not attempt to influence the view, position, or vote of any subordinate except to generally encourage participation in the voting process.

2.18. Protest and Extremist Activities. Airmen have a constitutional right of freedom of assembly. However, our ability to exercise that right is largely dependent on the setting. Demonstrations or other activities within military installations, which could result in interference with or prevention of the orderly accomplishment of a mission of the installation or which present a clear danger to loyalty, discipline, or morale of members of the Armed Forces, are prohibited. Military members are also prohibited from participating in demonstrations when they are on duty, when they are in a foreign country, when they are in uniform, when their activities constitute a breach of law and order, or when violence is likely to result. See DAFI 51-508, *Political Activities, Free Speech, and Freedom of Assembly*.

2.18.1. Airmen are prohibited from actively participating in extremist activities. Extremist activities are inconsistent with the responsibilities and obligations of military service, as well as the oaths of office and enlistment, and can be prohibited even in some circumstances in which such activities would be constitutionally protected in a civilian setting. Extremist activities as defined below is prohibited and, as appropriate, may be punishable under Article 92 of the UCMJ.

2.18.1.1. Extremist activities include, but are not limited to: (a) advocating or engaging in unlawful force, unlawful violence or other illegal means to deprive individuals of their constitutional rights; (b) advocating or engaging in unlawful force or violence to achieve goals that are political, religious, discriminatory or ideological in nature; (c) advocating or engaging in or supporting terrorism within the United States or abroad; (d) advocating or engaging in or supporting the overthrow of the U.S. Government (or a political subdivision thereof), by force or violence, or seeking to alter the form of these governments by unconstitutional or unlawful means; or (e) advocating or encouraging military, civilian, or contractor personnel within the DoD or United States Coast Guard to violate the laws of the United States, or any political subdivision thereof; (f) advocating widespread discrimination based on race, color, national origin, religion, sex (including pregnancy), gender identity, or sexual orientation. DAF regulations broadly define prohibited active participation to include a large range of organizing, recruiting for, fundraising on behalf of, and execution of extremist activities. See AFI 51-508, *Political Activities, Free Speech, and Freedom of Assembly*.

2.19. Public Statements. Only DAF military and civilian employees may be authorized to act in the capacity of an official DAF or Air Force spokesperson. Although military and civilian employees (including 10 U.S.C. § 1588 volunteers) may be asked to author or review proposed information releases such as statements press, releases, articles, imagery, or other content, only authorized DAF, and Public Affairs representatives, as appropriate, are permitted to publicly release such information on behalf of their DAF organization and its leaders, or to express an official position. Ensuring that official statements are properly worded and approved avoids statements that do not reflect official DAF policy or that, if taken out of context, could be misleading to the public. Public statements should be fully coordinated with the appropriate Public Affairs office, for security and policy review, before release. See AFI 35-101, *Public Affairs Operations*; AFMAN 35-101, *Public Affairs Procedures*.

2.19.1. The Air Force is committed to making its operations as transparent as possible to the American public. To that end, requests for information should be forwarded to the Public Affairs office or other appropriate Air Force offices. Those offices include the Freedom of Information Act office, legal office (for litigation matters), Air Force Office of Special

Investigations or Security Forces (for law enforcement information), etc. Air Force policy provides for clearance by the Public Affairs officer at the lowest level where competent authority exists to judge the security and policy aspects of the information submitted for review.

2.19.2. All personnel are responsible for safeguarding classified and controlled unclassified information, personally identifiable information and the identities of deployed Service members and their families. Failure to do so may result in disciplinary action.

2.20. Personal Use of Social Media. Airmen are personally responsible for what they say and do, including through any electronic medium and on any social media or similar platform. Regardless of the method or style of communication used, DAF standards must be observed by Airmen at all times, on and off duty. For further guidance regarding personal use of social media, see Air Force Handbook (AFH) 33-337, *Tongue and Quill*; AFI 35-101, *Public Affairs Operations*, DoDI 5400.17, *Official Use of Social Media for Public Affairs Purposes*, for *DoD Social Media*.

2.20.1. Operations security is vital to the accomplishment of the Air Force mission. The use of social media and other forms of communication that allow Airmen to communicate with a large number of people brings with it the increased risk of magnifying potential vulnerabilities to a DAF activity. Classified, controlled unclassified information, and other official DoD information and documents are prohibited from being released to unauthorized recipients, including posting on social media or transmitted via non-DoD e-mail accounts without proper authorization. See DoDM 5200.01, Volume 1_DAFMAN 16-1404, Volume 1, *Overview, Classification and Declassification*; DoDM 5200.01, Volume 2_AFMAN 16-1404, Volume 2, *Information Security Program: Marking of Information*; DoDM 5200.01, Volume 3_DAFMAN 16-1404, Volume 3, *Information Security Program: Protection of Classified Information*.

2.20.2. Airmen are obliged to communicate and conduct themselves appropriately with officer and enlisted personnel, peers, superiors, and subordinates (to include civilian superiors and subordinates). This obligation is applicable whether they communicate via social media or other forms of communication, such as e-mail, instant messaging, or texting. Do not add slogans, quotes, or other personalization to a signature block in official correspondence.

2.20.3. Airmen should strive to avoid offensive and/or inappropriate language or behavior on social media and through other forms of communication that could bring discredit upon on the Air Force or themselves as a member of the Air Force, or that would otherwise be harmful to good order and discipline. Bullying or harassment of other Airmen, via social media platforms, is likewise corrosive to good order and discipline, and strictly prohibited. See paragraph 2.6.

2.20.4. When Airmen express personal opinions on social media sites and can be identified as a member of the Air Force, they should make clear that they are speaking for themselves and not on behalf of the Air Force. While Service members may generally use their grade and Service even when acting in their personal capacity, they should not do so in situations where the context may imply official sanction or endorsement of their personal opinions (e.g., through the use of images in uniform).

2.20.5. Airmen should recognize that social network “friends” and “followers” may potentially constitute relationships that could affect determinations in background investigations and periodic reinvestigations associated with security clearances.

Chapter 3

APPEARANCE

3.1. Overview. First impressions are often drawn based upon appearance. Projecting a good military image reflects not only on the members personally, but also on the Air Force. Appearance matters both on and off duty and involves more than just the clothes Airmen wear. Projecting a professional image is paramount. See DAFI 36-2903, *Dress and Personal Appearance of Air Force and Space Force Personnel*.

3.2. Dress and Personal Appearance. Pride in one's personal appearance and wearing of the uniform correctly enhances the *esprit de corps* and the professional image essential to an effective military force. All Airmen must maintain a high standard of dress and personal appearance and comply with DAFI 36-2903. This standard consists of five elements: neatness, cleanliness, safety, uniformity, and military image. The first four elements are absolute, objective criteria needed for the efficiency and well-being of the Air Force. Although the fifth element—military image—is subjective, it is critical. Individuals, both military and civilian, draw certain conclusions about the individual members and the Air Force based on what they see. When in uniform or civilian clothes, in an official capacity, Airmen must present a professional image.

3.3. Personal Grooming. While every Airman may, within limits, express individuality, and their racial and cultural identity, through their appearance, the Air Force has defined what is and is not an acceptable professional military image in terms of personal grooming. All uniformed Air Force personnel must comply with the grooming standards found in DAFI 36-2903. Commanders have the responsibility to determine whether an Airman's personal grooming is within standards. Supervisors also have the responsibility to determine compliance and to correct violations of DAFI 36-2903, *Dress and Personal Appearance of Air Force and Space Force Personnel*.

3.4. Uniforms. Wearing Air Force uniforms means carrying on a tradition—one that identifies you as an Airman in the profession of arms. While in uniform, Airmen must adhere to standards of neatness, cleanliness, safety, uniformity, and military image. Airmen will procure and maintain all mandatory uniform items; follow local supplements and procedures regarding wear of the uniform; and keep their uniforms neat, clean, buttoned, and properly maintained. Airmen are responsible for knowing the authorized uniform combinations and the correct placement of ribbons, insignia, and other uniform items.

3.4.1. Authorized Wear of the Uniform:

3.4.1.1. Military Duties. Airmen wear the appropriate uniform while performing military duties unless authorized to wear civilian clothes. Airmen assigned to non-Air Force organizations wear the Air Force-equivalent uniform to the dress observed in the assigned organization. If authorized to wear civilian clothes on duty, Airmen must still comply with Air Force appearance and grooming standards unless the member has obtained a proper waiver for operational necessity.

3.4.1.2. Travel. If departing from or arriving at commercial airports in the continental United States, any authorized combination of uniform, except the flight duty uniform, may be worn. If departing from and arriving at a military airfield via United States government aircraft or contracted United States government commercial flights, any authorized combination of the uniform is appropriate. When traveling in an official capacity on

commercial air overseas, members should consult the DoD Foreign Clearance Guide for authorized and expected uniform wear. Airmen who wear civilian clothes during official travel must ensure that their clothing is neat, clean, and appropriate for the mode of travel and destination.

3.4.1.3. Social Functions. Airmen attending a military event must wear the appropriate uniform or civilian attire as requested by the host or hostess or directed by the commander. If the uniform is worn to civilian social functions, Airmen should wear a uniform commensurate with the attire worn by civilian attendees typically, service dress uniform, mess dress uniform, or semiformal uniform.

3.4.2. Prohibitions on Wear of Uniform. Airmen will not wear any uniform combination or any uniform items in the following situations:

3.4.2.1. When attending a meeting of, or sponsored by, an organization, association, movement, or group that: the Attorney General of the United States has named as totalitarian, fascist, communist, or subversive; advocates or approves acts of force or violence to deny others their rights under the United States Constitution; or seeks to change the United States government by unconstitutional means.

3.4.2.2. When participating in or attending public political speeches, interviews, picket lines, marches, or rallies, or in any public demonstration when participation might imply Air Force sanction of the cause or if the purpose may be to advocate, express, or approve opposition to the armed forces.

3.4.2.3. When it would discredit the armed forces.

3.4.2.4. When furthering political activities, private employment, or commercial interests.

3.4.2.5. When engaged in off-duty, civilian employment.

3.4.2.6. When participating as a defendant in civilian court proceedings if a conviction would bring discredit to the Air Force.

3.4.2.7. When using frequent flyer miles to upgrade to business or first class. Thus, even when an upgrade to business or first-class accommodations is legitimate, military personnel should not wear the uniform to avoid the public perception of misuse of government travel resources.

3.4.2.8. When distinctive uniform items are mixed with civilian clothes. Distinctive uniform items are those items that are unique to the uniform, such as grade insignia, ribbons, cap devices, badges, uniform jackets and other United States or Air Force insignia. **Note:** items of physical training gear are not considered distinctive uniform items.

3.4.2.9. When eating at off-base restaurants where most diners wear business attire, or at establishments that operate primarily to serve alcohol, members will not wear the operational camouflage pattern uniform, or flight duty uniform.

3.5. Physical Fitness. Airmen must be physically fit to support the Air Force mission. An active lifestyle increases productivity, optimizes health, and decreases absenteeism, which helps maintain a higher level of readiness. Also, by maintaining a fit appearance, we project the proper military image. The Physical Fitness Assessment (PFA) and the Body Composition Assessment (BCA) provides commanders with a tool to assist them in determining the overall fitness of their military

personnel. The fitness assessment uses a composite score based on various scientifically established physical fitness components. Age- and gender-specific fitness assessment score charts are provided in DAFMAN 36-2905, *Air Force Physical Fitness Program*. The body composition assessment uses the Waist-to-Height Ratio (WHtR) to calculate body composition to determine an associated health risk. Commanders and supervisors should incorporate fitness into their organizational culture to encourage members to maintain physical fitness and good health to meet expeditionary mission requirements. However, each Airman is ultimately responsible for keeping themselves in good physical condition. See DAFMAN 36-2905, *Air Force Physical Fitness*.

CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR. General, USAF
Chief of Staff

Attachment 1**GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION*****References***

5 USC § 3331, *Oath of Office*

10 USC § 502, *Enlistment Oath: Who May Administer*

10 USC § 892, *Failure to obey order or regulation*

10 USC § 893, *Cruelty and maltreatment*

10 USC § 893a, *Prohibited activities with military recruit or trainee by person in position of special trust*

10 USC § 912a, *Wrongful use, possession, etc., of controlled substance substances*

10 USC § 917a, *Wrongful broadcast or distribution of intimate visual images*

Title 18 USC

52 USC § 30116, *Limitations on Contributions and Expenditures*

5 CFR § 2635.101, *Basic Obligation of Public Service*

5 CFR § 2635.202, *General Prohibition on Solicitation or Acceptance of Gifts*

5 CFR § 2635.302, *General Standards*

5 CFR § 2635.702, *Use of Public Office for Private Gain*

5 CFR § 2635.704, *Use of Government Property*

5 CFR § 2635.705, *Use of Official Time*

DoD 5500.07-R, *Joint Ethics Regulation (JER)*, August 1993

DoDI 1020.03, *Harassment Prevention and Response in the Armed Forces*, Change 2, 20 December 2022

DoDI 1300.17, *Religious Liberty in the Military Services*, 1 September 2020

DoDI 1342.19_ *Family Care Plans*, Change 2, 30 November 2017

DoDI 5400.17, *Official Use of Social Media for Public Affairs Purposes*, Change 1, 24 January 2023

DoDM 5200.01, Volume 1_DAFMAN 16-1404, Volume 1, Overview, Classification and Declassification, 11 January 2021

DoDM 5200.01, Volume 2_AFMAN 16-1404, Volume 2, Marking of Classified Information, 7 January 2021

DoDM 5200.01, Volume 3_DAFMAN 16-1404, Volume 3, Protection of Classified Information, 23 December 2020

AFDP 1, The Air Force, 10 March 2021

AFPD 1, Air Force Culture, 16 October 2019

AFPD 36-70, *Diversity & Inclusion*, 16 October 2018

AFPD 52-2, *Accommodation of Religious Practices in the Air Force*, 28 July 2020

DAFPD 36-29, *Military Standards*, 24 January 2023

AFI 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, 23 March 2020

DAFI 90-160, *Publications and Forms Management*, Change 1, 21 Jun 2023

DAFMAN 90-161, *Publishing Processes and Procedures*, 15 April 2022

AFI 34-1201, *Protocol*, 18 August 2020

DAFI 35-101, *Public Affairs Operations*, 20 November 2020

AFI 36-703, *Civilian Conduct and Responsibility*, 30 August 2018

AFI 36-7001, *Diversity and Inclusion*, 19 February 2019

AFI 36-2109, *Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force, Senior Enlisted Leadership Management and Air Force Enlisted Council*, 5 January 2021

AFI 36-2113, *The First Sergeant*, 11 June 2020

AFI 36-2501, *Officer Promotions and Selective Continuation*, 16 July 2004

AFI 36-2606, *Reenlistment and Extension of Enlistment in the United States Air Force*, Change 2, 1 February 2023

DAFI 36-2710, *Equal Opportunity Program*, 18 June 2020

DAFI 36-2903, *Dress and Personal Appearance of Air Force and United States Space Force Personnel*, Change 4, 12 Apr 2022

DAFI 36-2906, *Personal Financial Responsibility*, 13 May 2021

AFI 36-2909, *Air Force Professional Relationships and Conduct*, Change 1, 28 September 2022

AFI 36-3106, *Retiree Activities Program*, 2 Apr 2020

AFI 44-121, *Alcohol and Drug Abuse Prevention and Treatment (ADAPT) Program*, 18 July 2018

DAFI 51-101, *The Air Force Judge Advocate General's Corps (AFJAG) Operations, Accessions, and Professional Development*, 30 Jun 2023

DAFI 51-201, *Administration of Military Justice*, 14 April 2022

DAFI 51-202, *Nonjudicial Punishment*, 4 January 2022

AFI 51-304, *Legal Assistance, Notary, Preventive Law, and Tax Programs*, 22 August 2018

DAFI 51-508, *Political Activities, Free Speech, and Freedom of Assembly*, 24 March 2023

AFI 52-101, *Planning and Organizing*, 15 July 2019

DAFI 52-201, *Religious Freedom in the Department of the Air Force*, 23 June 2021.

DAFI 90-201, *The Inspection System of the Department of the Air Force*, 15 March 2023

AFI 90-301, *Inspector General Complaints Resolution*, Change 1, 30 September 2021

DAFI 90-6001, *Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) Program*, Change 1, 26 March 2021

DAFI 91-202, *The US Air Force Mishap Prevention Program*, 12 March 2020

AFI 33-332, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, Change 1, 28 Jul 2021

DAFMAN 36-2905, *Air Force Physical Fitness Program*, 21 April 2022

AFH 33-337, *Tongue and Quill*, 27 May 2015

AFPAM 34-1202, *Guide to Protocol*, 8 May 2019

DoD Foreign Clearance Guide

The Manual for Courts-Martial, United States (2019 edition)

A Profession of Arms: Our Core Values (May 2022)

Adopted Forms

DAF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*

Abbreviations and Acronyms

AFDP—Air Force Doctrine Publication

AFH—Air Force Handbook

AFI—Air Force Instruction

AFMAN—Air Force Manual

AFPAM—Air Force Pamphlet

AFPD—Air Force Policy Directive

CFR—Code of Federal Regulations

DAFI—Department of the Air Force Instruction

DAFMAN—Department of the Air Force Manual

DoD—Department of Defense

DoDI—Department of Defense Instruction

DoDM—Department of Defense Manual

JER—Joint Ethics Regulation

POW—Prisoner of War

USC—United States Code

Terms

Airmen—All members of the Air Force family - officer, enlisted and civilian representing the Regular Air Force, Air Force Reserve and Air National Guard.

Air Force Core Values—Integrity First, Service Before Self and Excellence In All We Do. The Air Force Core Values are more than minimum standards. They inspire us; remind us what it takes to get the mission done. They are the common bond among all professional Airmen, past and present.

Air Force Professional—An Airman (Regular, Reserve, Guard) is a trusted servant to our Nation who demonstrates unquestionable competence, adheres to the highest ethical standards and is a steward of the future of the Air Force profession. Air Force professionals are distinguished from other Airmen by a willing commitment and loyalty to their Service's Core Values.

Air Force Professionalism—A personal commitment and loyalty to Air Force standards and expectations framed within an environment of shared trust, guided by each Service's Core Values.

Airmen Leadership Qualities—Ten qualities grouped into four major performance areas (MPAs) that are valued in our Airmen; used to develop and evaluate Airmen; and which are indicative of potential for greater responsibility. In the MPA, Executing the Mission, the ALQs are: Job Proficiency; Initiative; and Adaptability. In the MPA, Leading People, the ALQs are: Inclusion & Teamwork; Emotional Intelligence; and Communication. In the MPA, Managing Resources, the ALQs are: Stewardship; and Accountability. In the MPA, Improving the Unit, the ALQs are: Decision Making; and Innovation. ALQs are evaluated via a proficiency-level scale. See DAFI 36-2406, *Officer and Enlisted Evaluations Systems*.

Bullying—A form of harassment that includes acts of aggression by Service members or DoD civilian employees, with a nexus to Military Service, with the intent of harming a Service member either physically or psychologically, without a proper military or other governmental purpose. Bullying may involve the singling out of an individual from their coworkers, or unit, for ridicule because they are considered different or weak. It often involves an imbalance of power between the aggressor and the victim. Bullying can be conducted through the use of electronic devices or communications, and by other means including social media, as well as in person.

Goal—An expression of the desired future state of the Air Force in a particular area or theme. Goals define and prioritize broad direction and are inherently long-term in nature.

Hazing—Includes conduct which physically or psychologically injures or creates a risk of injury without a proper military or governmental purpose for the initiation into, admission into, affiliation with, change in status or position within, or a condition for continued membership in any military or DoD civilian organization.

Mission—Fundamental reason for being purpose of the organization/effort, and why it exists beyond present day operations.

Mission Command—A philosophy of leadership that empowers Airmen to operate in uncertain, complex, and rapidly changing environments through trust, shared awareness, and understanding of commander's intent.

Objective—A major milestone or action required to achieve a goal. Objectives are specific action statements establishing what, not how.

Profession of Arms—A vocation comprised of experts in the design, generation, support and application of global vigilance, global reach and global power serving under civilian authority, entrusted to defend the Constitution and accountable to the American people.

Reprisal—Taking or threatening to take an unfavorable personnel action or withholding or threatening to withhold a favorable personnel action on a military member for making or preparing or being perceived as making or preparing to make a protected communication.

Restriction—Preventing or attempting to prevent members of the Armed Forces from making or preparing to make lawful communications to Members of Congress and/or an IG.

Retaliation—Retaliation is taking or threatening to take an adverse personnel action, or withholding or threatening to withhold a favorable personnel action, with respect to a military member because the member reported a criminal offense, or reported a potential violation of the law, DAF Policy, or guidance to the authorities, chain of command/supervision and/or the Inspector General.

Vision—Mental image of the future, the preferred end state, including how to approach those who are served and to satisfy the mission, how services are delivered, how to organize and manage people and other resources.

Attachment 2

ROLES, RESPONSIBILITIES, AND STRUCTURE

A2.1. Roles, Responsibilities, and Structure. To perform effectively in the Air Force, Airmen must understand the structure and some of the systems that govern its operation.

A2.2. Chain of Command and Supervision. The chain of command and supervision is critical to the establishment and maintenance of high standards of conduct and performance throughout the DAF. It provides the command, control, and communication necessary to accomplish the mission. Each link in the chain is a level of responsibility and authority extending from the Secretary of the Air Force through each commander at every level. Different levels within the chain have different responsibilities and authority; however, all levels have some things in common. Each level in the chain is responsible for all lower levels and accountable to all higher levels. The chain cannot work without loyalty to every level. Loyalty up and down the chain makes a system efficient and effective. It is most effective when issues are resolved at the lowest possible level. If practicable, one should request assistance at each level before going to the higher level and ensure each level is kept informed.

A2.3. Command Chief Master Sergeant and Senior Enlisted Leader. The Command Chief Master Sergeant is the senior enlisted leader of the command at wing or higher levels and is a key member of the command's key enlisted advocates and advisors. Command Chief Master Sergeants are the commander's key enlisted advocate and advisor on operational effectiveness and the organization, training and equipping of enlisted Airmen. Command Chief Master Sergeants ensure the commander's directions and policies are carried out and the Airmen understand and are dedicated to the mission of the command. Command Chief Master Sergeants are responsible for the professional development and proper utilization of the command's enlisted force. Command Chief Master Sergeants work in concert with other enlisted leaders such as Group Senior Enlisted Leaders and First Sergeants to oversee the readiness, training, health, morale, welfare, and quality of life of assigned personnel. *See AFI 36-2109, Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force, Senior Enlisted Leadership Management and Air Force Enlisted Council.*

A2.4. First Sergeant. This senior noncommissioned officer is especially important to command as a role model and member of the enlisted corps who not only exemplifies, but also holds others to DAF standards of conduct and appearance. A First Sergeant is an enlisted leader serving in a time-honored special duty position, rich in custom and tradition. The position is critical to the execution of the unit mission. Although the First Sergeant does not typically have a specific operational or technical expertise requirement, he or she must thoroughly understand how decisions affect unit performance. The First Sergeant primarily supports the mission through interaction, support, and management of Airmen and families. The First Sergeant works directly for and derives authority from the unit commander and serves as the commander's critical link within the unit for all matters concerning assigned personnel. The First Sergeant must ensure that the force understands the commander's policies, goals, and objectives, and must also ensure support agencies, i.e., security forces, civil engineering, medical facilities, force support, etc., are responsive to the needs of unit personnel and their families. *See AFI 36-2113, The First Sergeant.*

A2.5. Staff Agencies. Other agencies support and strengthen the chain of command. These include the different staff functions (such as, the Chaplain Corps, Staff Judge Advocate, Equal Opportunity, Sexual Assault Prevention and Response Program, Safety, Public Affairs and

Inspector General). These agencies are sources of professional advice or assistance in particular areas. These agencies are not a substitute for the chain of command, but instead, support the chain and make it more efficient and effective.

A2.5.1. Chaplain Corps. The Air Force Chaplain Corps provides religious accommodation, spiritual fitness, and leadership advisement.

A2.5.1.1. The Chaplain Corps directly or indirectly provides for the free exercise of religion for all Airmen from all faith groups. This support takes a variety of forms such as religious rites, pastoral care, religious education, additional faith-group-appropriate religious practices and programs, and roles in the formal religious accommodation process.

A2.5.1.2. Spiritual fitness is the ability to adhere to beliefs, virtues, or values needed to develop a fulfilling life with quality of service. Spirituality is the means to find ultimate meaning and life.

A2.5.1.3. Chaplains and Religious Affairs Airmen advise DAF leaders at all echelons on all matters pertaining to religion, spiritual fitness, morale, morals, and ethics. See AFI 52-101, *Planning and Organizing*, for additional information.

A2.5.2. Judge Advocate. Judge advocates, with the support of paralegals and civilian attorneys, advise commanders on a broad spectrum of legal and policy issues. This includes advice on military justice and disciplinary matters; prosecution of courts-martial; representation of the government in administrative separation hearings; advice to military investigative agencies; representation of DAF interests in environmental, civilian labor and utility matters; advice on contract law and related civil law issues; advice on military operations, and review of actions for legal sufficiency in a wide variety of areas. Judge advocates also provide personal legal assistance to eligible DAF Airmen and their dependents. See DAFI 51-101, *The Air Force Judge Advocate General's Corps (AFJAGC) Operations, Accessions, and Professional Development*.

A2.5.2.1. Uniform Code of Military Justice. A special system of laws and courts is required to maintain good order and discipline because military discipline enhances combat capability, the military environment and duties are unique, and military personnel serve throughout the world. The Uniform Code of Military Justice (UCMJ) is the system of criminal justice that helps protect Airmen's constitutional rights while in the armed forces, and it safeguards the armed forces' state of military discipline and, thus, combat effectiveness, by holding offenders accountable. It is federal law enacted by Congress and contains specific punitive articles that help enforce good order and discipline in the military. The UCMJ and the rules and regulations used to administer it not only contain criminal laws Airmen must obey, but also provide procedures for court-martial and nonjudicial punishment. The fact that Airmen are required to obey military laws does not excuse them from their duty to comply with the laws of the community where they live or work. See Manual for Courts-Martial, United States; DAFI 51-201, *Administration of Military Justice*; DAFI 51-202, *Nonjudicial Punishment*.

A2.5.2.2. Personal Legal Assistance. Legal offices provide confidential legal assistance in connection with personal civil legal matters, which in turn support and sustain command effectiveness and readiness. Assistance is provided in several areas, such as wills and estate planning, consumer and financial affairs, family law, the Servicemembers' Civil

Relief Act, veterans' reemployment rights, and taxes. Assistance is subject to the availability of legal staff resources and expertise and gives priority to mobilization and deployment-related issues. See AFI 51-304, *Legal Assistance, Notary, Preventive Law, and Tax Programs*.

A2.5.2.3. Area Defense Counsel. The Office of the Area Defense Counsel's primary responsibility is to advocate for uniformed military personnel who are suspected of violating the Uniform Code of Military Justice or who are facing other adverse administrative actions. Constrained only by ethical limits, the Area Defense Counsel and Defense Paralegal are authorized by law to enter attorney-client relationships, promote the individual interests of their clients, and safeguard those rights throughout criminal and adverse administrative proceedings. Defense personnel are assigned to the Office of the Judge Advocate General and operate independently from the local chain of command.

A2.5.2.4. Victims' Counsel. Victims' Counsel deliver victim-centered advice and advocacy to victims of qualifying sex-related offenses, domestic violence offense, and other offenses that contain elements of interpersonal violence. Victims' Counsel assist victims with obtaining support and recovery resources and promotes greater confidence in both the military justice process and the DAF. Victims' Counsel represent victims at every step of the military justice process to enforce their rights. Victims' Counsel engage with base leaders and other decision makers to ensure that a victim's voice and choices are heard; represent victims at law enforcement, trial, and defense counsel interviews; and attend pre-trial hearings and courts-martial. Victims' Counsel are supported by the Victims' Paralegals. Victims' Counsel/Victims' Paralegals' chain of command is independent from a base chain of command. In addition to the duties mentioned herein, Victims' Counsel and Victims' Paralegals provide a broad range of legal assistance support, represent victims in administrative proceedings (for example, discharge boards and other separation actions) and coordinate with local authorities in situations involving civilian prosecutions.

A2.5.2.5. Office of Special Trial Counsel (OSTC). The OSTC provides expert, specialized, independent, and ethical representation of the United States in the investigation and trial-level litigation of specific covered offenses. A select group of judge advocates are certified to serve as Special Trial Counsel by virtue of their education, training, experience, and judicial temperament. They partner with military criminal investigative organizations and installation legal offices from the initiation of an investigation through the completion of trial proceedings. OSTC personnel operate under the direction of the Lead Special Trial Counsel, reporting directly to the Secretary of the Air Force.

A2.5.3. Public Affairs. The purpose of Public Affairs operations is to communicate timely, accurate, and relevant information about DAF activities to Department of Defense, DAF, and domestic and international audiences. The Public Affairs representative is the commander's principal spokesperson, advisor, and member of the wing staff and is a principal capability of DAF information power. Public Affairs advises the commander and senior leaders on the implications of decisions, operations, activities, and investments on internal and external public perceptions, and researches, plans, executes, and assesses Public Affairs activities and events to support overall operational success. Through strategic and deliberate release of accurate and relevant information and musical products, PA puts military actions into context, facilitates the development of informed perceptions about Air Force activities, and helps undermine adversarial propaganda efforts. In addition, Public Affairs exercises its core

competency of “global influence and deterrence” by communicating U.S. capabilities and resolve to adversaries, competitors, partner nations and non-Federal entities. Public Affairs should be involved in planning, decision making, training, equipping, and executing activities, as well as integrating Public Affairs activities into all levels of command. See DAFI 35-101, *Public Affairs Operations*.

A2.5.4. Equal Opportunity. The Equal Opportunity office provides prompt, fair, and impartial services to Airmen (military and civilian) to include civilian equal employment opportunity (EEO) and military equal opportunity (MEO) complaint processing, outreach, training, human relations education, and assistance through negotiation and dispute resolution, equal opportunity subject matter expertise, and other related services and initiatives. This includes assisting military members with issues related to unlawful discrimination and harassment (including sexual harassment), on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex (including pregnancy), gender identity, sexual orientation, and religion as well as other forms of harassment (e.g., bullying, hazing) contributing to a hostile work environment. The Equal Opportunity office also assists civilian personnel with issues related to unlawful discrimination and harassment (including sexual harassment) on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex (including pregnancy, gender identity, and sexual orientation), religion, age (40 or older), disability, genetic information, and retaliation. See DAFI 36-2710, *Equal Opportunity Program*.

A2.5.5. Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) Program. The SAPR program reinforces the DAF’s commitment to the development, implementation, and assessment of policies and programs to effectively prevent and respond to sexual assault. Trained and certified SAPR teams with immediate sexual assault response capability are made available at all times to military and civilian Airmen at all locations. The SAPR office offers restricted and unrestricted reporting of sexual assault and provides person-centered, trauma-informed victim support. A victim’s unrestricted report of sexual assault is reported to law enforcement and may be used to initiate the official investigation process. The SAPR office also provides restricted and unrestricted reporting options and SAPR victim advocacy to DAF military members who experience sexual harassment. Sexual harassment reporting and victim advocacy via the SAPR program do not replace the MEO complaint processes available to military members. Unrestricted reports of sexual harassment will be reported to MEO. SAPR prevention initiatives and response services reinforce DAF standards and are designed to empower Airmen to serve as catalysts for attitude and behavior changes, fostering an environment that cultivates a culture of dignity, mutual respect, and trust. See DAFI 90-6001, *Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) Program*.

A2.5.6. The Inspector General (IG). The IG acts as an extension of the commander by serving as the eyes and ears to be alert to issues affecting the organization. The IG’s responsibilities are categorized into two distinct and separate systems: The Air and Space Force Inspection System (referred to as the Inspection System) and the DAF Complaints Resolution Program. All IGs must maintain a clear distinction between being an extension of the commander and their duty to serve as fair, impartial, and objective factfinders, and problem solvers.

A2.5.6.1. The Air and Space Force Inspection System. The purpose of the Inspection System is to assess unit efficiency, effectiveness, operational readiness, compliance with applicable guidance and nuclear surety (as applicable). It extends to all aspects of the Air

Force environment, including all organizations and all levels of command and supervision. See AFI 90-201, *The Air Force Inspection System*.

A2.5.6.2. The DAF Complaints Resolution Program. Under the DAF Complaints Resolution Program, any complainant has the right to present a complaint without fear of reprisal. It is illegal to restrict a military member from making a lawful communication to an IG or member of Congress. These rights are ensured in federal law and codified in DoD and DAF guidance, directives, and issuances. Complaints may be submitted in person, by phone, through electronic means, or in writing. Complaints may be made to supervisors, First Sergeants, commanders, members of any level of the IG system, someone higher in the chain of command, or members of Congress. While complainants should attempt to resolve complaints at the lowest level, when possible, use of the DAF Complaints Resolution Program remains open and available at all times. In addition to having the right to present personal complaints, Air Force military and civilian employees have the duty to promptly report fraud, waste, abuse, or gross mismanagement. Airmen also have a duty to report a violation of law, policy, procedures, instructions, regulations, or an injustice. Airmen also have a duty to report any abuse of authority, inappropriate conduct, or misconduct through appropriate supervisory channels or the IG. See AFI 90-301, *Inspector General Complaints Resolution*.

A2.5.7. The Installation/Wing Safety Office. The Installation/Wing Safety Office is responsible for the commander's mishap prevention program. It provides expertise in flight safety, weapons safety, and occupational safety. It conducts mishap investigations and is a direct line to the Commander regarding safety culture within the installation/wing. It manages proactive on and off-duty safety programs and initiatives to protect the warfighter and maximize combat readiness. See AFI 91-202, *The US Air Force Mishap Prevention Program*.

A PROFESSION OF ARMS: OUR CORE VALUES



U.S. AIR FORCE

16 MAY 2022

CSAF PERSPECTIVE

Wingmen, Leaders, Warriors,

We are members of a unique society. No other profession holds its members to the standards that we hold ourselves and each other to. Our Nation holds Airmen to this high standard because it is our job to defend the homeland, project airpower globally, and operate as a joint, allied, and partnered force...and they count on us to fly, fight, and win.

As Airmen, we are all on a journey as members of the *Profession of Arms*. As with all journeys, we need a compass, a north star...a way to navigate the path as we go. These Core Values are our north star, they provide us the basic understanding of what is expected and required of Airmen—all Airmen—every day. These Core Values serve as a reminder that we all start our journey with an oath to something bigger than ourselves. We owe it to ourselves and to each other to uphold these values without wavering.

These are not new values; they have been woven into our fabric by generations of Airmen. We must all internalize these Core Values and model the behaviors that demonstrate them. We must inspire others, set an example through personal conduct, and promote leadership and accountability across the force.

I am proud to be an Airman, and I know that you are as well. Together we will continue to support and defend the Constitution of the United States and defend it against all enemies, united in *The Profession of Arms*.



Charles Q. Brown, Jr.
General, USAF
Chief of Staff

PURPOSE

The first thing you must understand is that our chosen profession is that of a higher calling, in which we hold ourselves to higher standards. To serve proudly and capably, our commitment to our cause must be unbreakable; it must be bonded in our mutual respect for each other. Throughout our service, we are guided and reminded of this remarkable responsibility to our Nation. The oaths we take remind us that we serve freely in support and defense of the Constitution of the United States.

Whoever you are and wherever you fit on the Air Force team, this is your basic guide to our Air Force Core Values. The Core Values exist for all members of the Air Force family - officer, enlisted, and civilian; active, guard, reserve, and retired.

The Core Values are much more than minimum standards. They remind us what it takes to get the mission accomplished. They inspire us to do our very best at all times. They are the common bond among all comrades in arms, and they are the glue that unifies the force and ties us to the great warriors and public servants of the past, and guides us into the future.

Integrity First, Service Before Self, and Excellence In All We Do. These are the Air Force Core Values. Study them...understand them...follow them...encompass them...and encourage others to do the same.

We abide by a Code of Conduct that captures our resolve, while our Airman's Creed highlights the strength of our diverse Airmen who fly, fight, and win as one Air Force. Wherever you are in your Air Force career, it is a reminder to the meaning of service in our profession - *The Profession of Arms*.

A PROFESSION OF ARMS: OUR CORE VALUES

Table of Contents

Chapter 1 – INTRODUCTION

A PROFESSION OF ARMS	5
----------------------------	---

Chapter 2 – OUR OATHS

OATH OF ENLISTMENT	7
OATH OF OFFICE, OFFICER.....	7
OATH OF OFFICE, CIVIL SERVANT	7

Chapter 3 – AIR FORCE CORE VALUES

LIVING THE CORE VALUES.....	8
INTEGRITY FIRST	9
SERVICE BEFORE SELF.....	10
EXCELLENCE IN ALL WE DO.....	11
CORE VALUES – THE WHY.....	12

Chapter 4 – THE CODE OF CONDUCT

ARTICLES 1 THROUGH 6	13
----------------------------	----

Chapter 5 – THE AIRMAN’S CREED.....	14
-------------------------------------	----

Chapter 1- INTRODUCTION

A PROFESSION OF ARMS

No profession asks more of its members than the *Profession of Arms*. As we state in our Airman's Creed, we have answered our Nation's call. It is a higher calling, and it comes with a higher standard.

General Ronald Fogleman, our 15th Chief of Staff once said, "We are not engaged in just another job; we are practitioners of the *Profession of Arms*. We are trusted with the security of our Nation, the protection of our citizens, and the preservation of its way of life. In this capacity, we serve as guardians of America's future. By its very nature, this responsibility requires us to place the needs of our service and our country before personal concerns."

That responsibility was given to each and every one of us when we raised our right hand and swore to support and defend the Constitution of the United States. When we joined our Air Force with a sacred oath, we accepted a sacred trust from the American people, one that goes beyond anything else in society. As members of a joint team, our profession is distinguished from others because of our expertise in the justified application of lethal military force and the willingness of those who serve to pay the ultimate sacrifice for our Nation. No other profession expects its members to lay down their lives for their friends, families or freedoms...but it is what our profession readily expects.

We are professionals. As volunteers, our sworn obligation is to the Constitution. Fighting America's wars is an ugly business; there is nothing pretty or glorious about warfighting, but it must be done. Our status as the world's greatest Air Force was earned by those who have served before us and is carried on by every Airman who wears the uniform today and by the civil servants who bring continuity to the mission of the Air Force at home and abroad. Every Airman is a leader of character. This identity calls on us to live honorably, lift others to their best possible selves, and elevate the performance of the team. We do this by owning the pursuit of our identity, engaging in purposeful experiences, and practicing habits of thought and action consistent with our Core Values.

"Every member of our team – whether enlisted, officer or civil servant – is responsible for embodying and upholding the high standards that come with serving the United States in the Profession of Arms. Our commitment to those standards, and to our shared core values, shapes us as a professional military force and guides how we execute our mission to protect the Constitution and the Nation. One Team, One Fight."

Honorable Frank Kendall
26th Secretary of the Air Force



All Airmen belong to the *Profession of Arms*...every officer, enlisted, and civil servant are members of this selfless profession. We are all accountable for meeting ethical and performance standards in our actions and similarly accountable for our failure to take action when appropriate. The distinction between pay grades lies solely in our level of responsibility and the degree of accountability, not in our level of commitment to the *Profession of Arms*. We share the common attributes of character, courage, and competence. We qualify as professionals through intensive training, education, and practical experience.

As professionals, we are defined by our strength of character, respect for others, and a lifelong commitment to Core Values. We all have a responsibility not to engage in—nor tolerate—behaviors that harm members of our formation. Actions like harassment, sexual assault, sexual harassment, stalking, bullying, extremism, and discrimination erode our foundation and weaken us from within. These actions violate our Core Values. We must guard against those at all times. We must be dedicated to maintaining our professional abilities through continuous individual and institutional improvements.

We must remember, above all else, we are patriots first. As the Total Force, we more than anyone else, understand the price of freedom. We understand the sacrifices that come from willingly serving our country. We understand what it means to serve in the *Profession of Arms*.



Chapter 2 - OUR OATHS

Every Airman began their service in our Air Force by reciting the Oath of Enlistment or the Oath of Office for officers and civil servants. The oath is a humbling reminder of the seriousness of the *Profession of Arms*. Throughout our careers, we must continually reflect on the meaning of the words and the gravity of our commitment.

★ OATH OF ENLISTMENT

“I, _____, do solemnly swear (*or affirm*) that I will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; and that I will obey the orders of the President of the United States and the orders of the officers appointed over me, according to regulations and the Uniform Code of Military Justice. So help me God (*optional*).”

★ OATH OF OFFICE, OFFICER

“I, _____, having been appointed a (rank) in the United States Air Force, do solemnly swear (*or affirm*) that I will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; that I take this obligation freely, without any mental reservation or purpose of evasion; and that I will well and faithfully discharge the duties of the office on which I am about to enter. So help me God (*optional*).”

★ OATH OF OFFICE, CIVIL SERVANT

“I, _____, do solemnly swear (*or affirm*) that I will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; that I take this obligation freely, without any mental reservation or purpose of evasion; and that I will well and faithfully discharge the duties of the office on which I am about to enter. So help me God (*optional*).”

“Before you can lead others, you have to lead yourself. We must develop leaders of character that are ready to create and foster environments of respect, inclusivity, and trust. When Airmen know they are valued, have high quality of service and quality of life, and are empowered to reach their full potential—there are no limits to what we can accomplish.”

General Charles Q. Brown, Jr.
22nd Chief of Staff of the Air Force



Chapter 3 - AIR FORCE CORE VALUES

Values represent enduring and guiding principles for which we as individuals or organizations stand. “Core” values are so fundamental that they define our identity. The United States Air Force has clearly defined its identity by these three simple values: *Integrity First, Service Before Self, and Excellence In All We Do.*

For those of us who join this proud community of Airmen, whether officer, enlisted, civilian, active, guard, or reserve, being a part of the Air Force family requires that we commit to living these values, on- and off-duty. This is the expectation of our profession and is the standard against which our fellow service members and the American public hold us. This commitment to our values demonstrates respect for the Air Force, for others, and for the mission at hand. The Air Force professional is a trusted servant of our Nation who adheres to the highest standards of character, courage, and competence. How we act represents to countless others the collective identity of the United States Air Force.

LIVING THE CORE VALUES

Understanding the Core Values is relatively easy. The true challenge is to live them. It is a commitment that never ends and one that always matters.

We all have the ability to display integrity, both professionally and personally. We have all placed ourselves in a position to serve a greater purpose and we all have the innate desire to achieve excellence. Yet there will be moments where living and acting by the Core Values will be challenging.

These moments are also opportunities to prove, through our actions, that we genuinely embody these Core Values. In doing so, we honor the heritage and continue the legacy of those who served before us and sacrificed so much. It is through this alignment of our actions with these values that we, as an Air Force, earn the public’s trust, strengthen our service, and accomplish our mission.

Each of these Core Values is further defined by virtues (desired behaviors and characteristics) we must practice and demonstrate in our daily lives, showing we truly do value *Integrity, Service, and Excellence*. Consistently practicing these virtues results in habits of honorable thought and action, producing an Air Force professional. Air Force professionalism is a shared belief in and a commitment to honorable service based on our Air Force Core Values.

INTEGRITY FIRST

Integrity is doing the right thing all the time, whether everyone is watching or no one is watching. It is the compass that keeps us on the right path when we are confronted with ethical challenges and personal temptations, and it is the foundation upon which trust and respect are built. An individual realizes integrity when thoughts and actions align with what he or she knows to be right. The virtues that demonstrate one truly values *Integrity* include:

★ HONESTY:

Honesty is the hallmark of integrity. As public servants, we are trusted agents. Honesty requires us to evaluate our performance against standards, and to conscientiously and accurately report findings. It drives us to advance our skills and credentials through our own effort. Our word must be unquestionable. This is the only way to preserve the trust and respect that we hold so dear for one another and the population we serve.

★ COURAGE:

Courage is not the absence of fear but doing the right thing despite fear. Courage empowers us to take necessary personal or professional risks, make decisions that may be unpopular, and admit our mistakes; having the courage to take these actions is crucial for the mission, the Air Force, and the Nation. A person of integrity does what is right even if the personal cost is high.

★ ACCOUNTABILITY:

Accountability is the responsibility to an audience. That audience maybe the American people, our units, our supervisors, our fellow Airmen, our families, our loved ones, and even ourselves. Accountable individuals maintain transparency, seek honest and constructive feedback, lead and live with respect for themselves and others, and take ownership of the outcomes of their actions and decisions. They are responsible to themselves and others and refrain from actions that discredit themselves or our service.

★ HUMILITY:

A person of integrity grasps and is sobered by the extraordinary task of defending the Constitution of the United States. We practice humility by putting others before ourselves. We seek to add value through community and humanitarian support. We serve with gratitude and without arrogance.

SERVICE BEFORE SELF

The choice to serve is a decision to hold ourselves to a higher standard; it is a calling, a daily commitment that takes energy, dedication, and sacrifice. Selfless service places demands upon us which are not levied upon the American public or those who choose other professions. Selfless service begins when our Airmen take the Oath of Office or Enlistment, but it does not mean we let go of all that we hold dear - our family, loved ones, and sincerely held beliefs. We embrace a disciplined approach to rule-following, self-control, respect for authority, and respect for the beliefs and worth of others. **NOTE:** *Airmen must practice self-care first to be able to serve others.* The virtues that demonstrate *Service Before Self* include:

★ DUTY:

Duty is the obligation to perform what is required for the mission. While our responsibilities are determined by the law, the Department of Defense, and Air Force instructions, directives, and guidance, our sense of duty is a personal one and bound by the oath of service we take as individuals. Duty sometimes calls for sacrifice in ways no other profession has or will have. Airmen who truly embody *service before self* consistently choose to make necessary sacrifices to accomplish the mission, and in doing so, we honor those who made such sacrifices before us.

★ LOYALTY:

Loyalty is an internal commitment to the success and preservation of something bigger than ourselves. Our loyalty is to the Nation first, the values and commitments of our Air Force second, and finally, to those with whom we serve. Loyalty to our leaders requires us to trust, follow, and execute their decisions, even when we disagree. We offer alternative solutions and innovative ideas most effectively through the chain of command. Leaders demonstrate loyalty by respecting those who serve and treating them with dignity, compassion, and true concern for their wellbeing. Ultimately, loyalty is demonstrated by helping each other act with respect and honor.

★ RESPECT:

Respect encompasses self-respect, mutual respect, and organizational respect. This three-dimensional view requires us to embrace the unique value of all individuals and treat everyone with dignity. We must always act in the certain knowledge that all Airmen must be treated with respect and boldly speak up, even when it is uncomfortable, to assert this truth. Further, respecting others requires a commitment to recognize and root out prejudices, biases, and stereotypes. We must engage genuinely, honestly, and with an empathetic and open mind. We must honor the Air Force and others by following our words with actions.

Respect must be embraced mutually by military and civilian personnel in all grades or positions and demonstrated in the everyday actions of all Airmen. Without it, we simply cannot stand strong in the defense of our Nation. Mutual respect strengthens teamwork, supports increased communication, reduces stress, and diminishes conflict. Put simply; it means treating others the way you would want to be treated and creating an environment, through your words and actions, where every Airman can serve to their full potential.

EXCELLENCE IN ALL WE DO

Excellence In All We Do does not mean that we demand perfection in everything from everyone. Instead, this value directs us to continuously advance our craft and increase our knowledge as Airmen. We must have a passion for continuous improvement and innovation that propels America's Air Force in quantum leaps toward accomplishment and performance. The virtues that demonstrate *Excellence In All We Do* include:

★ MISSION:

Mission encompasses operations and excellence in stewardship. The complex undertaking of the Air Force mission requires us to harness the ingenuity, expertise, and elbow grease of all Airmen. We approach it with the mindset of respect, pride, innovation, and a continued commitment to anticipate and embrace change. Our work areas, our processes, and our interpersonal interactions must be undeniably professional and positive. Our people are the platform for delivering innovative ideas, strategies, and technologies to the fight.

★ DISCIPLINE:

Discipline is an individual commitment to upholding the highest of personal and professional standards. Airmen commit to a life of discipline and self-control. We demonstrate it in attitude, work ethic, and effort directed at continuous improvement, whether pursuing professional military education or developing ourselves physically, intellectually, emotionally, and spiritually. Each Airman represents the entire Air Force. Our appearance, actions, and professional and respectful presence shape the culture of the Air Force and the reputation of the entire military profession.

★ TEAMWORK:

Teamwork is essential to triumph at every level. Airmen recognize the interdependency of every member's contributions toward the mission and strive for organizational excellence. We not only give our personal best but also challenge and motivate each other to perform their best. We gain respect through our actions and strong work ethic to build team trust, and we give respect to others for their contributions. We carry our own weight and whenever necessary, help our Wingmen carry theirs. We serve in the greatest Air Force in the world, and we embrace the idea that our part of the Air Force meets the world-class standard.



CORE VALUES – THE WHY

The first reason is that *the Core Values tell us the price of admission to the Air Force itself*. All of us must accept accountability and practice justice, which means that all Airmen must possess *Integrity First*. Our selfless commitment to duty, our loyalty to our mission, and our respect for other drives *Service Before Self*. In addition, it is imperative that we all seek *Excellence In All We Do* - whether it be product or service excellence, resources excellence, community excellence, personal excellence or operations excellence.

The second reason for recognizing the Core Values is that *they point to what is universal and unchanging in the Profession of Arms*. The values are navigation points inviting us to consider key features of the requirements of professional service, but they cannot hope to point to or pick out everything. By examining *Integrity, Service, and Excellence*, we also eventually discover the importance of duty, honor, country, dedication, fidelity, competence, and a host of other professional requirements and attributes. The important thing is not the three values our leaders demand. The important thing is that our leaders selected these values, and it is our obligation to understand and be advocates of the ethical demands these values require.

The third reason for recognizing the Core Values is that *they help us get a fix on the ethical climate of an organization*. How successful are we in trying to live by the Core Values? Our answer to this question may not be the one we would like to give. When fellow Airman in our formation believe our operating procedures or the requirements levied upon us from above are absurd or enforced, we face the tendency to “make our own rules” or be “selective about the rules we are going to follow.” As time goes by, these actions become habitual. Eventually, you can no longer distinguish between the “important” tasks/rules and the “stupid” ones you chose not to follow. To combat this activity, every Airman must take ownership in the culture in the places they serve.

The fourth reason for recognizing the Core Values is that in addition to helping us to evaluate the climate of our organization, *they also serve as beacons vectoring us back to the path of professional conduct*; the Core Values allow us to transform a climate of corrosion into a climate of ethical commitment.

“The foundation of our Profession of Arms is, and has always been, respect. That is a non-negotiable principle that supports the Integrity, Service and Excellence of our great Air Force. It is the cornerstone of the culture we need in our Air Force.”

JoAnne S. Bass
19th Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force



Chapter 4 – THE CODE OF CONDUCT

The Code of Conduct outlines the basic responsibilities and obligations of members of the U.S. Armed Forces. All members are expected to measure up to the standards described in the Code of Conduct. Although developed for Prisoners of War (POW), the spirit and intent are applicable to service members subject to other hostile detention. Such service members should consistently conduct themselves in a manner that brings credit to themselves and their country. The six articles of the Code of Conduct address situations and decision areas that any member could encounter to some degree. The Code of Conduct includes basic information useful to POWs to help them survive honorably while resisting captors' efforts to exploit them. Such survival and resistance requires knowledge, understanding, and a commitment to the articles.



ARTICLE 1

"I am an American, fighting in the forces, which guard my country and our way of life. I am prepared to give my life in their defense."

ARTICLE 2

"I will never surrender of my own free will. If in command, I will never surrender the members of my command while they still have the means to resist."

ARTICLE 3

"If I am captured, I will continue to resist by all means available. I will make every effort to escape and to aid others to escape. I will accept neither parole nor special favors from the enemy."

ARTICLE 4

"If I become a prisoner of war, I will keep faith with my fellow prisoners. I will give no information or take part in any action, which might be harmful to my comrades. If I am senior, I will take command. If not, I will obey the lawful orders of those appointed over me and will back them up in every way."

ARTICLE 5

"When questioned, should I become a prisoner of war, I am required to give name, rank, service number, and date of birth. I will evade answering further questions to the utmost of my ability. I will make no oral or written statements disloyal to my country and its allies or harmful to their cause."

ARTICLE 6

"I will never forget that I am an American, fighting for freedom, responsible for my actions, and dedicated to the principles which made my country free. I will trust in my God and in the United States of America."

THE AIRMAN'S CREED

The Airman's Creed is intended to remind all Airmen that we are not just a conglomeration of diverse specialties, skill sets, or jobs, but we are brothers and sisters in the *Profession of Arms*. It allows Airmen to think and act with one mind and with a commitment to fundamental warfighting beliefs. Airmen are warriors and are dedicated to flying, fighting, and winning.

*I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
I AM A WARRIOR.
I HAVE ANSWERED MY NATION'S CALL.*

*I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
MY MISSION IS TO FLY, FIGHT, AND WIN.
I AM FAITHFUL TO A PROUD HERITAGE,
A TRADITION OF HONOR,
AND A LEGACY OF VALOR.*

*I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
GUARDIAN OF FREEDOM AND JUSTICE,
MY NATION'S SWORD AND SHIELD,
ITS SENTRY AND AVENGER.
I DEFEND MY COUNTRY WITH MY LIFE.*

*I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
WINGMAN, LEADER, WARRIOR.
I WILL NEVER LEAVE AN AIRMAN BEHIND,
I WILL NEVER FALTER,
AND I WILL NOT FAIL.*

"They knew not the day or hour nor the manner of their passing when far from home they were called to join that great band of heroic Airmen that went before."

**Inscription on the Air Force Memorial
in Washington, D.C.**



THIS PAGE INTENTIONALLY LEFT BLANK

**OUR MISSION:
FLY, FIGHT, & WIN...
AIRPOWER ANYTIME, ANYWHERE**



THE ENLISTED FORCE STRUCTURE



U.S. AIR FORCE

16 MAY 2022

CMSAF PERSPECTIVE

Fellow Wingmen,

Our role in the United States Air Force is more than just a job; it is a calling to serve our country, the Air Force mission, and our fellow Airmen.

The foundation of our enlisted force is deeply rooted in a rich heritage, commitment to duty, and dedication to upholding and living a high set of standards. As Airmen, our Core Values directly align with our steadfast ability to serve in a demanding profession and embody the trust our Nation places in us.

The framework, development levels, responsibilities, and standards of our enlisted force are the subject of this guide. They apply to all of us. My expectation is for each one of us, together, to know, learn, and embody the contents of this handbook as we continue the storied history of those who have come before us. This is how we will deliver Airpower.



JoAnne S. Bass
19th Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force

PURPOSE

We are the world's greatest Air Force...powered by Airmen and fueled by innovation. This guide defines our enlisted force structure and serves to identify established standards and expectations. It provides the foundation for the enlisted force to meet mission requirements and individual Airman proficiency and competency development, both foundationally and for their specific occupations. The "Brown Book" describes what makes us enlisted Airmen, not merely functional specialists.

Our force is comprised of a diverse group of Airmen in the *Profession of Arms*. Despite the differences across functional and operational lines, there is a compelling need for a deliberate and standardized approach to force development and career progression as well as the assumption of increased supervisory and leadership responsibilities.

Force development synchronizes the pillars of education, training, and experience. Each is complemented by the *Air Force Foundational Competencies*, career field specific *Occupational Competencies*, and the *Airman Leadership Qualities (ALQs)*. These provide individuals with a common framework, set of priorities, and expectations based on rank, experience and/or position.

Information presented within this guide helps Airmen understand the structure, values, principles, and standards of our enlisted force. It supersedes Air Force Handbook 36-2618, *The Enlisted Force Structure*, dated July 5, 2018.

THE ENLISTED FORCE STRUCTURE

Table of Contents

Chapter 1 – WHY WE SERVE: DEFEND AMERICA

A CALLING	5
A PROFESSION OF ARMS: OUR CORE VALUES	5
THE AIRMAN’S CREED	6

Chapter 2 – WHO WE ARE: AIRMANSHIP

A CULTURE OF RESPECT, TRUST, AND INCLUSION	7
WINGMAN, LEADER, WARRIOR	7
FOLLOWERSHIP, LEADERSHIP, AND TEAMWORK	8

Chapter 3 – OUR MISSION: AIRPOWER

CORE MISSIONS	9
AIR FORCE SPECIALTIES	9
MULTI-CAPABLE AIRMEN	10

Chapter 4 – WHAT WE DO: ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

COMMAND TEAMS	11
TEAMING AND PARTNERSHIPS	12
EXPECTATIONS AND DUTIES	13

Chapter 5 – HOW WE DO IT: COMPETENCIES AND ALQs

FEEDBACK AND DEVELOPMENT	22
MENTORING AND COACHING	23
PERFORMANCE AND EVALUATION	24

CONCLUSION	25
TERMS OF ADDRESS AND BASIC REQUIREMENTS BY RANK	26
REFERENCES	27

Chapter 1 – WHY WE SERVE: DEFEND AMERICA

A CALLING

The choice to serve is always a personal one. Together, we as Americans accept and carry the torch of the generations who came before us and fought for our freedoms. We stand watch to defend the homeland and our way of life – from north to south, east to west, and sea to shining sea. Strengthened and enriched by diversity across our lands, the United States remains a global symbol of freedom, democracy, human rights, and opportunity.

America expects us to be exemplary role models, competent experts, thoughtful counselors, committed advisors, approachable mentors, and leaders of character. To meet these expectations, we continually invest in our people and, by doing so, develop them as professionals and citizens. These actions directly fuel the Department of Defense's mission to provide combat-credible military forces needed to deter war and protect the security of our Nation.

We willingly take the *Oath of Enlistment*, which demonstrates a public commitment to the country and the Air Force. In this oath, we are accepting responsibility to support and defend The Constitution of the United States, as well as the orders given to us by officers appointed over us. We take the oath at the start of our career and with each reenlistment to signify this commitment.

THE OATH OF ENLISTMENT

"I [*state your full name*], Do solemnly swear (*or affirm*) that I will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; and that I will obey the orders of the President of the United States and the orders of the officers appointed over me, according to regulations and the Uniform Code of Military Justice. So help me God (*optional*)."

A PROFESSION OF ARMS

A Profession of Arms defines our service as a higher calling, in which we hold ourselves to higher standards. We abide by a code of conduct that demonstrates our Air Force Core Values, serves as our compass, and provides the fortified foundation of our service. The Airman's Creed highlights the strength of our Airmen who fly, fight, and win as one Air Force.

Inherent in the *Profession of Arms* is warrior ethos. It forms the foundation of what it means to be an Airman. Warrior ethos is the hardiness of spirit as well as moral and physical courage. It instills a combat mindset and emphasizes that every Airman is part of the fight regardless of their career field or what capacity they serve.

OUR CORE VALUES

The expectation for all Airmen is to embrace and actively demonstrate their commitment to the Air Force Core Values – Integrity First, Service Before Self, and Excellence in All We Do. These foundational, enduring, and guiding principles aid in creating a culture of respect and trust while ensuring we continue to meet the standard against which our fellow service members and the American public hold us. In every position we serve, it will always be our responsibility to uphold and enforce our Core Values.

AIRMAN'S CREED

In order to be effective as a service, we must all share the same understanding of how we contribute to the mission. The Airman's Creed describes our commitment to our fundamental warfighting beliefs. It also defines us as American Airmen, reminds us that we are warriors, and instills our dedication to serve our Nation. Each line of the Airman's Creed defines the essential fundamental and foundational responsibilities we abide by. [Video: The Airman's Creed.](#)

The Airman's Creed also sets the tone of our personal and professional lives while serving in the Air Force. This is where we embrace our Air Force family with our brothers and sisters in arms by connecting to the past, serving in the present, and preparing for future generations.

***I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
I AM A WARRIOR.
I HAVE ANSWERED MY NATION'S CALL.***

***I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
MY MISSION IS TO FLY, FIGHT, AND WIN.
I AM FAITHFUL TO A PROUD HERITAGE,
A TRADITION OF HONOR,
AND A LEGACY OF VALOR.***

***I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
GUARDIAN OF FREEDOM AND JUSTICE,
MY NATION'S SWORD AND SHIELD,
ITS SENTRY AND AVENGER.
I DEFEND MY COUNTRY WITH MY LIFE.***

***I AM AN AMERICAN AIRMAN.
WINGMAN, LEADER, WARRIOR.
I WILL NEVER LEAVE AN AIRMAN BEHIND,
I WILL NEVER FALTER,
AND I WILL NOT FAIL.***

"I have been recognized as a hero for my 10 minutes of action over Vietnam, but I am no more a hero than anyone else who has served this country."

**Sgt. John L. Levitow
Medal of Honor Recipient**



Chapter 2 – WHO WE ARE: AIRMANSHIP

A CULTURE OF RESPECT, TRUST, AND INCLUSION

Respect in the *Profession of Arms* goes beyond professional courtesy or deference to those in a position of authority. Respect is a positive way of treating or thinking about others. It is the foundation for accepting others for who they are, including their previous experiences. Exhibiting respect in our organizations builds a culture of trust. Airmen in high-trust organizations are more productive, collaborate better with their teams, and have an increased commitment to the mission. Every Airman's responsibility is to utilize these tools toward a healthy environment where everyone is welcome to be the best version of themselves while supporting each other and contributing to a common cause.

Airmen can build a culture of respect and trust in their organizations by practicing these behaviors:

★ **Value Diversity and Uphold Equality.** Embrace differences allowing us to solve problems in collaborative ways. Actively learn from others with different worldviews and life experiences. Seek multiple perspectives and opportunities before making decisions that affect the group. Ensure every Airman feels free to offer their skills, abilities, and ideas while rejecting prejudice and injustice in all forms.

★ **Intentionally Build Relationships.** Express interest in and concern for team members' success and well-being. Seek out and build connections with others, especially those who may see the world differently. Remember that connection is a basic human need (regardless of being an introvert/extrovert) and trust is built in small moments, not grand gestures.

★ **Actively Share Information.** Open communication is key in inclusive cultures. Strive to reduce uncertainty and create a shared understanding of opportunities and decisions.

★ **Give Airmen Discretion When Able.** Empower Airmen to practice what they have been trained and to execute tasks and projects in a way that they will own and feel valued. Actively train replacements for the future responsibilities and provide opportunities across the entire team to foster inclusion.

★ **Facilitate Whole-Person Growth.** Develop personally as well as professionally. Acquiring new skills is not enough if you are not growing at a personal level. To understand others, you first must understand yourself. A growth mindset and self-development are key to better communication and teamwork. Foster opportunities for teammates to maximize their potential.

★ **Professional Communication.** As an Airman, you must be a professional 24 hours a day, 365 days a year. Your actions on- and off-duty are a representation of yourself, the Air Force, and our Nation. The Air Force respects Airmen's rights to self-expression, and at the same time, you must recognize that in the *Profession of Arms* there are certain limitations placed on freedoms of speech. Each one of you, as an Airman, are personally responsible for the messages conveyed across all communication mediums, both online and off. In both official and unofficial capacities, your actions can shape public opinion. Therefore, everyone should strive to demonstrate the highest standards of conduct and professionalism to convey the Air Force's Core Values. See [*DAFI 35-101, Public Affairs Operations*](#) for more information.

WINGMAN, LEADER, WARRIOR

What it means to be an Airman — on Duty and in Life.

Wingman. Everything we do is about teamwork. This means looking out for and always being willing to help each other. Wingmen bear an inherent responsibility to understand this and assist others in meeting this expectation. Wingmen are there for each other in good and bad times. Wingmen are dependable and act whenever the moment calls. Regardless of rank, we must never forget what it means to be a teammate first and to be a Wingman.

The Enlisted Force Structure

Leader. Leadership starts with serving others. We should all continuously set the example, be approachable, show humility, actively listen, and strive for excellence. Leaders own their culture, set a vision, share, and translate decisions. Leaders elevate teams with impacts that echo throughout organizations.

Warrior. Being a warrior is not easy, but is vital for our Nation to sustain its way of life and the values and principles we hold dear. Being a warrior means we have taken an oath to protect those who count on us. This requires courage, grit, honor, pride, resilience, self-discipline, and determination.

FOLLOWERSHIP, LEADERSHIP, AND TEAMWORK

Followership. Followership is reaching a specific goal; while exercising respect for authority, taking the initiative, having humility, a positive attitude, integrity, and self-discipline. When joining the Air Force, we agree to be professional, act morally and responsibly, complete tasks to the best of our ability, and have a willingness to serve our community. Effective followership is an essential element of the development of all Air Force leaders.

Leadership. Leadership is the art and science of accomplishing the Air Force mission by motivating, influencing, and directing personnel. This highlights two central elements: the mission and the Airmen who will accomplish it. Leadership motivates and inspires people to interact and understand one another by encouraging a sense of achievement, self-esteem, recognition, and belonging. Qualities that help leaders gain respect are credibility, a positive influence on others' self-awareness, cultural awareness, and empathy. Leadership attributes are described in the Joint Staff's *Developing Enlisted Leaders for Tomorrow's Wars*.

Teamwork. Teamwork is essential at every level. We must recognize the interdependency of every Airman's contribution toward the mission and strive for organizational excellence. We not only give our personal best but also challenge and motivate each other. We gain respect through our actions and strong work ethic, thus increasing team trust. We carry our weight and, whenever necessary, help our Wingmen carry theirs.

★ **Self-Accountability.** Self-accountability is the courage to unbiasedly reflect on and take personal responsibility for your actions. Avoid blaming others and be open to constructive feedback as this exposes blind spots. Self-accountability enforces standards and strengthens mission effectiveness. One must take failures in stride, as failures lead to growth and development. Mistakes met with learning and transparency are essential to the foundational trust within an organization.

★ **Team-Accountability.** Team-accountability means the team works together to follow command standards, commitments, completion of projects on time, and always toward the goals. The inability to take ownership of one's faults can directly lead to team degradation and a toxic work environment. Every team shares a culture and each of us plays a part in setting the tone of what is acceptable.

"When I think of the enlisted force, I see dedication, determination, loyalty, and valor."

CMSAF Paul W. Airey,
1st Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force
*Prisoner of War in World War II



Chapter 3 – OUR MISSION: AIRPOWER

CORE MISSIONS

As members of the Department of Defense, we deliver airpower to the Nation. [*Air Force Doctrine Publication 1, The Air Force \(AFDP-1\)*](#) further describes why we fight, who we are, what we do, and how we do it. Our Total Force is comprised of three components: the Regular Air Force (RegAF), the Air National Guard (ANG), and the Air Force Reserve (AFR).

The service's focus is to develop, train, sustain, and integrate the elements of airpower to execute its functions across the spectrum of operations. Key capabilities are at the forefront of the Air Force's strategic perspective and, therefore, at the heart of the service's contribution to our Nation's total military capabilities and strategic vision. The key capabilities are not doctrine, but they are enablers of our doctrine. These capabilities begin to translate the central beliefs of doctrine into understandable concepts and thus contribute to a greater understanding.

To best contribute to the mission, we must understand our role within these critical capabilities and define our contributions so that all Airmen understand how they fit into the overall success of defending our Nation through airpower. No matter where our Airmen serve or what they do, they contribute to at least one of these five core missions:

★ **Air Superiority.** Our freedom from attack and our freedom to attack. We continually build distinctive capabilities that enable joint forces to dominate enemy operations in all dimensions: land, sea, air, space, cyber, and information.

★ **Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR).** The eyes and ears on our adversaries. ISR is about helping leaders make informed decisions to maintain deterrence, contain crises, and achieve success in battle.

★ **Rapid Global Mobility.** Delivery on demand. We maintain and improve our ability to respond quickly and decisively anywhere we are needed around the globe.

★ **Global Strike.** Any target at any time. Global strike missions include a wide range of crisis response and escalation control options, such as providing close air support to troops at risk, interdicting enemy forces, inserting special operations forces, and targeting an adversary's vital centers.

★ **Command and Control.** Pervasive and highly interconnected, command and control networks will be extremely contested. The capability to deliver airpower is intimately dependent on the ability to operate effectively in cyberspace, a domain in and through which we conduct all of our core missions and is critical to many of our command and control systems.

AIR FORCE SPECIALTIES

The military personnel classification system is designed to match personnel qualifications with job/career field requirements. [*AFMAN 36-2100, Military Utilization and Classification*](#), provides examples and notes regarding enlisted and officer Air Force Specialty Codes (AFSC.) AFSCs are structured with five (enlisted) and four (officer) digits/characters that indicate specific identifiers within the military classification structure.

Airmen + Core Missions = [*Global Vigilance, Global Reach, Global Power for America.*](#)

The Enlisted Force Structure

- ★ **1XXXX – Operations:** includes jobs such as aircrew operations and support, special warfare, cyber, intelligence, remotely piloted aircraft, and weather.
- ★ **2XXXX – Logistics and Maintenance:** includes logistics, aerospace maintenance, missile and space systems maintenance.
- ★ **3XXXX – Support:** includes force support, civil engineering, equal opportunity, and security forces.
- ★ **4XXXX – Medical and Dental:** includes all medical and dental positions.
- ★ **5XXXX – Legal and Chaplain:** includes paralegals and religious affairs.
- ★ **6XXXX – Acquisition and Finance:** includes contracting and financial management.
- ★ **7XXXX – Special Investigations:** used for special investigation careers.
- ★ **8XXXX – Special Duty Identifiers:** used for specialized roles outside of career fields.
- ★ **9XXXX – Reporting Identifiers:** is a designation for temporary use or for specialized positions.

MULTI-CAPABLE AIRMEN

Mindset and Approach. The speed and pace of threats have changed in today's world, and so must we. Our people possess capabilities that we often cannot see and do not keep track of formally. Mindset, flexibility, innovation, initiative, and a desire to contribute in any space and in any way that adds value will be critical in the coming years. Airmen must become force multipliers broadening their cross-functional competencies while building teamwork, communication skills, and resiliency. Airmen must adapt and overcome critical challenges in a dynamic environment to achieve mission results.

Presentation of Forces and Capabilities. *Multi-capable Airmen (MCA)* are members capable of accomplishing tasks outside of their core Air Force Specialty. Specifically, these personnel are trained as a cross-functional team to provide combat support and combat service support to Agile Combat Employment (ACE) force elements. MCA are enabled by cross-utilization training (CUT) and can operate independently in an expeditionary environment to accomplish mission objectives with acceptable levels of risk. MCA supports ACE operating concepts, which align with Adaptive Operations in Contested Environments (AOiCE.) ACE is an operational concept that supports joint all-domain operations, enable convergence across domains, and presents an adversary with dilemmas at an operational tempo that complicates or negates adversary responses and enables the joint force to operate inside the adversary's decision-making cycle.

"Regardless of our respective ranks and positions, we must execute to the best of our abilities and we must do right the first time because the application of Airpower is serious business where half-hearted efforts and playing for second place are not options."

General Charles Q. Brown, Jr.
22nd Chief of Staff, United States Air Force



Chapter 4 – WHAT WE DO: ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

COMMAND TEAMS

Our command teams play a vital role in the successes or failures of our units. A *commander (a civilian director or equivalent), the Senior Enlisted Leader, the First Sergeant, and where possible, a Key Spouse*, can set constructive conditions at all levels of command and be the catalyst for positive experiences for our people. There is no single checklist on how command teams should operate. In general, command teams should be *visible, accessible, and engaged*. Airmen, both above and below command teams, must stay in sync to support the chain of command and mission priorities. The personnel in these positions are all responsible for fostering a culture of dignity and respect within the unit by ensuring supervisors, wingmen, and enlisted Airmen do their part.

★ **Commander.** Special authorities and responsibilities are inherent with command. In addition to leading people to accomplish an assigned mission, commanders have the lawful authority and responsibility to promote and safeguard the morale, physical well-being, and general welfare of persons under their command. Commanders are responsible for executing the mission, leading people, managing resources, and improving the unit. [Air Force Instruction 1-2, Commander's Responsibilities](#).

All commanding officers and others in authority in the Air Force are required to:

- (1) Show themselves as a good example of virtue, honor, patriotism, and subordination;
- (2) Be vigilant in inspecting the conduct of all persons who are placed under their command;
- (3) Guard against and suppress all dissolute and immoral practices and correct, according to the laws and regulations of the Air Force, all persons who are guilty of them;
- (4) Take all necessary and proper measures, under the laws, regulations, and customs of the Air Force, to promote and safeguard the morale, the physical well-being, and the general welfare of the persons under their command or charge.

★ **Director.** A director may serve in conjunction with or in place of a commander, depending on the structure of an organization. They typically carry responsibility commensurate with that of a commander. A director may be in charge of an agency, activity, department, or other large organization types.

★ **Senior Enlisted Leader (SEL).** Senior Enlisted Leaders are a part of the leadership triad and are charged with readiness, training, health, morale, welfare, and quality of life for the unit or group of assigned personnel. Additional responsibilities include managing and directing resource activities, interpreting and enforcing policies and applicable directives, establishing control procedures to meet mission goals and standards, and actively supporting and maintaining robust recognition programs. **NOTE:** Regular Air Force Senior Enlisted Leaders may support and advise commanders on the Enlisted Force Distribution Panel (EFDP) process, as well as the nomination and selection of Airmen for career-broadening opportunities.

★ **First Sergeant.** The First Sergeant works directly for and derives authority from the unit commander. They are a dedicated focal point for all readiness, health, morale, welfare, and quality of life issues within their organizations. At home stations and in expeditionary environments, their primary responsibility is to build and maintain a mission-ready force. The First Sergeant ensures the organization understands the commander's intent, policies, and goals. They conduct quality force reviews on all performance reports, decoration recommendations, and other personnel actions. Working with their fellow senior noncommissioned officers and supervisors, First Sergeants ensure impartial and effective discipline and the highest levels of esprit de corps. They are the organization's experts for connections to base agencies and overall resources. [Air Force Instruction 36-2113, The First Sergeant](#).

★ **Key Spouse.** An extension of the command team is the Key Spouse, who connects our military families with their respective unit. They serve as a vital resource to support Air Force families. The purpose of the Key Spouse is to increase resilience and unit cohesion amongst military members and their families throughout the military life cycle. The Key Spouse is typically a spouse volunteer in the unit who is appointed by the commander and serves as a communication link between the chain of command and families for timely information and referral services supporting overall family readiness. Resources: [Key Spouse Program Link](#) and [Five And Thrive](#).

TEAMING AND PARTNERSHIPS

Teaming is the collaboration of unique specialties coming together to accomplish the overall mission and advance the commander's priorities. Teaming can occur within all units, at all levels, and amongst all ranks. Additionally, through the power of partnership, we can work with our local communities, sister services, joint and allied partners, inter-agency organizations, industry, and academia partners to accomplish mission and community tasks together. Some of these common tasks or goals are focused on academia, driving innovation, industry building, and problem-solving. We must work within our force (internal) and extend out (external) to increase the opportunities to succeed in airpower.

Teams solve problems and produce solutions more effectively when we are diverse. Creating teams by including mixed ranks, status, level of responsibility, and experience will drive better results and increase relationships in and outside of organizations. These partnerships strengthen our service and increase our ability to meet and exceed mission priorities.

★ **Officer Corps.** Enlisted Airmen should understand the officer structure, duty titles, and corresponding responsibilities within their organizations. The officer force structure is comprised of three distinct and separate tiers. The tiers are Company Grade Officer, which includes grades O-1 thru O-3, Field Grade Officer, comprising of grades O-4 thru O-6, and General Officer, including grades of O-7 through O-10. Progression through the tiers correlates to increased levels of leadership and managerial responsibilities, with each tier building on the responsibilities of the previous one. The focus of each tier is to develop the appropriate Airman Leadership Qualities and foundational competencies associated with their tier and position.

★ **Civilian Corps.** Civilians are fundamental to the strength of our Air Force. They provide corporate knowledge and stability across the Air Force and may deploy to various contingency areas. Like the enlisted and officer corps, civilians have a compelling need for a deliberate and common approach to force development, career progression, and the assumption of increased supervisory and leadership responsibilities. [AFMAN 36-606, Civilian Career Field Management and Development](#), outlines career field governance structure, centrally managed positions, career paths, and career progression models.

★ **Civic Partners.** We collaborate with many entities in the local community to accomplish our missions effectively. Establishing these relationships is key to base and mission sustainment. Different civic partners we may work with are local law enforcement, chamber of commerce, local contractors, honorary commanders, local government, healthcare partners, education institutions, industry partners, and many more.

EXPECTATIONS AND DUTIES

The enlisted force is comprised of three distinct and separate tiers: Junior Enlisted Airmen, Noncommissioned Officers, and Senior Noncommissioned Officers. Each tier correlates to increased levels of education, training, and experience, as well as leadership and managerial responsibilities. The primary goal in each tier is mission accomplishment. However, every tier and every Airman has a personal expectation to maintain personal wellness and readiness. **NOTE:** A full list of terms of address for each rank, including required education levels, can be found on [page 26](#).

★ **Air Force Leadership Levels.** The Air Force operates in a dynamic global context across multiple domains requiring leadership skills at three levels: tactical, operational, and strategic. These levels emphasize a different mix of qualities and experience. The leadership level at which an Airman operates determines the level of Airman Leadership Qualities and foundational competencies required to lead Airmen in mission accomplishment. As Airmen progress from the tactical to strategic leadership levels, emphasis on the use of Airman Leadership Qualities and foundational competencies shifts from a personal focus to an organizational focus. The nature and scope of leadership challenges and preferred leadership methods differ based on the level of leadership and duties. These levels apply across the entire spectrum of the enlisted force structure.

★ **Foundational Competency Levels.** A competency is a combination of knowledge, skills, and abilities, and other characteristics that manifest in an observable and measurable pattern of behavior. There are four levels which are basic, intermediate, advanced, and expert. Competence levels are used to describe observable and measurable behaviors. These levels are not dependent on the member's rank, they are based on their experience level demonstrated through specific behaviors on assigned tasks. **Example:** An A1C can demonstrate an advanced level of communication based on previous knowledge, skills, and abilities. Where a SMSgt can demonstrate a basic level based on their overall experience or need to develop these same skills and abilities. [*AFH 36-2647, Competency Modeling*](#)

★ **Airman Leadership Qualities (ALQs) Proficiency Levels.** The ALQs are the most important sub-elements of performance, derived from those same validated behaviors identified in the foundational competencies. ALQs are designed to guide the rater and facilitate discussion when providing constructive feedback. A rater should use their best judgment when determining the proficiency level of a ratee bearing in mind that each definition should be applied using a whole-person concept relative to the rank, AFSC, and assigned duties. There are four levels, which are *Developing, Proficient, Highly Proficient and Outstanding*. Proficiency levels should be described and evidenced in feedback utilizing examples of behavior rooted in the foundational competencies.

Practicing Personal Wellness and Readiness:

★ **Comprehensive Airman Fitness (CAF).** All Airmen must ensure self-care and wellness remain a priority. While facing personal and professional demands, it is essential to work to find a harmony between life at work and home. The CAF model provides a holistic approach for Airmen, including mental, physical, spiritual, and social health.

★ **Financial Readiness.** The Air Force's goal is to ensure all Airmen have access to financial literacy education to support choices that are best for their financial goals in and out of uniform. Airmen and their families are encouraged to take advantage of Air Force programs and plan for life after transitioning from military service. For more information visit: [*AFPC – Air Force Family Readiness Programs*](#)

Meeting Expectations through Deliberate Progression. All members are expected to understand and practice the Air Force leadership levels, Airman Leadership Qualities, and foundational competencies. Airmen must show increased development through career progression and will have expectations, duties, and responsibilities commensurate with their rank. Below you will find the expectations and responsibilities for each tier outlined through *Developing Self, Developing Others, Developing Ideas, and Developing Organizations*.

★ **Junior Enlisted Airmen:** The fuel to our daily missions. This tier's focus and priority is on learning and consists of Airman Basic (AB), Airman (Amn), Airman First Class (A1C), and Senior Airman (SrA). This tier should be developing their Airman Leadership Qualities and be familiar with foundational and occupational competencies to perform at the basic and intermediate levels. As Airmen progress, their focus will be on developing:

Airman Basic. Primary focus is to adapt from a civilian to a military lifestyle.

Airman. Are still learning and adapting to the military profession and are expected to understand and conform to military standards, customs and courtesies while beginning to show occupational proficiency.

Airman First Class. Apply their knowledge and skills to become highly efficient in their career field and focus on earning their 5-skill level.

Senior Airman. Encompass all the previous junior enlisted requirements to perform as skilled technicians and become well-versed trainers. They begin developing supervisory and leadership skills to advance their professional growth. Senior Airmen gain supervision experience of individuals and begin building skills in leading teams. Upon completion of Airman Leadership School, a Senior Airman may have an opportunity to become an official supervisor.

Responsibilities of all Junior Enlisted Airmen:

Developing Self:

- ★ Act as an Air Force ambassador both on- and off-duty.
- ★ Abide by all things that build a military professional; these principles are described in detail in previous chapters.
- ★ Accept and accomplish all duties, responsibilities, and lawful orders in an efficient manner. Work to find harmony between your personal desires and Air Force needs.
- ★ Address any issues that could detract from mental readiness. Seek assistance through support agencies. Be proactive in contacting a Wingman to seek help.
- ★ Work toward identifying, correcting, and reporting behaviors that may put yourself or others at risk. Provide clear guidance and follow-up as necessary through appropriate channels.
- ★ Contribute to a culture of dignity and respect by enforcing a zero-tolerance policy for sexual harassment, sexual assault, and discrimination.
- ★ Maintain spiritual and physical readiness to establish a sense of purpose or personal priorities to develop the skills required to persevere in times of distress.
- ★ Properly maintain financial responsibilities and make informed decisions on budgets, investments, and life-long goals.
- ★ Be knowledgeable and stay informed on current events affecting the Air Force.
- ★ Ensure no discredit to the Air Force or compromise to operational security occurs while using personal and government information systems, including but not limited to, social media.
- ★ Pursue development through voluntary education (school, certification, reading, etc.), base organizations, and community partnerships.

Developing Others:

- ★ Contribute to a professional climate and culture by supporting leaders' decisions, seeking clarification when needed, and aiding others in understanding.
- ★ Be alert for behavioral changes and/or signs of stress, depression, and self-harm.
- ★ Build relationships that promote well-being and optimal performance. Key components of social readiness are teamwork, communication, and social support.
- ★ Foster inclusion by actively learning from, listening to, and engaging with teammates from diverse backgrounds and perspectives.
- ★ Identify and communicate any barriers regarding equal opportunity, toxic leadership, or toxic followership for all Airmen.

Developing Ideas:

The Enlisted Force Structure

- ★ Use technology to identify data and information; explore, create and manage digital content; and appropriately interact in a virtual environment. Follow organizational protocols for the use of electronic devices. Get help for computer system problems as needed and participate in online training.
- ★ Apply learned concepts or methods to new situations and consider previous solutions to generate new ideas.
- ★ Gain buy-in through seeking input from others and use facts to support points of view when meeting with team members. Work to validate sources of information prior to seeking support.

★ **Noncommissioned Officers:** The “backbone” of the United States Air Force. This tier focuses on training, supervision, and task execution and consists of Staff Sergeant (SSgt) and Technical Sergeant (TSgt). NCOs lead by example as role models to all and ensure proper use of resources within their control. They become proficient and internalize the Airman Leadership Qualities and progress toward intermediate and advance foundational competency levels. Additionally, they continue their development through Enlisted Professional Military Education and career-broadening positions, as they begin building a strong network within and outside their organizations. As Noncommissioned Officers progress in this tier, the focus will be on establishing proficiency:

Staff Sergeant. Earn the 7-skill level and further develop as technicians, supervisors, and leaders. Responsible for their subordinate's development and effective accomplishment of all tasks.

Technical Sergeant. Further development by striving to be the technical expert while providing excellent attention to detail, establishing effective communication, and fostering a positive culture of trust within the organization.

Responsibilities of all Noncommissioned Officers: In addition to meeting all Junior Enlisted Airmen responsibilities, Noncommissioned Officer responsibilities include:

Developing Self:

- ★ Increase knowledge and understanding of the occupational and foundational competencies required to accomplish the mission. These competencies are gained through a combination of education, training, and experience.
- ★ Embrace and demonstrate personal and team resilience by embodying the social, physical, mental, and spiritual domains of Comprehensive Airman Fitness and encouraging others to do the same.
- ★ Uphold physical readiness. Lead the way by promoting, supporting, and participating in physical fitness programs. Incorporate physical training into the team's duty schedules as the mission allows to ensure a fit and ready force.

Developing Others:

- ★ Contribute to a professional climate and culture by supporting leaders' decisions, seeking clarification when needed, and defining expectations to their subordinates, as well as identifying, highlighting, and correcting behaviors that might detract from their teams.
- ★ When needed, exercise authority to issue lawful orders to complete assigned tasks in accordance with Article 92 of the Uniform Code of Military Justice.
- ★ Practice and promote mental readiness. Be actively aware of challenges that subordinates may be facing. Advocate seeking help for individuals and remain engaged to ensure continued mental readiness and effectiveness.
- ★ Allow and encourage team members to develop spiritual skills needed in times of stress, hardship, and tragedy. This may or may not include religious activities.

The Enlisted Force Structure

- ★ Stay professionally engaged with team members both on- and off-duty. Be familiar with a subordinate's environment/residence or living spaces and visit installation support facilities to understand off-duty opportunities and living conditions.
- ★ Recognize and reward individuals whose performance clearly exceeds standards. Ensure subordinates and peers are held accountable when deviating against standards.
- ★ Provide feedback and counseling to subordinates on development, performance, career opportunities, promotions, benefits, and entitlements. Use continuous informal and formal feedback to optimize a subordinate's potential and performance. On an annual basis, Noncommissioned Officers must discuss and provide the [Benefits Facts Sheets](#) to subordinates during feedback.

Developing Ideas:

- ★ Demonstrate and facilitate a healthy climate of effective followership by willingly owning, explaining, and promoting leaders' decisions. In some circumstances, Noncommissioned Officers who are lower ranking may be placed in charge of others of the same grade as determined by the unit commander.
- ★ Use multi-media to learn and expand partnerships to explore potential ideas. Protect sensitive personal and operational information on social networking sites or other online forums.
- ★ Develop insights into new situations; question conventional approaches by applying and modifying complex learned concepts or methods appropriately. Question existing methods or processes and identify novel alternatives.
- ★ Prototype and test potential solutions. Use experts and other influence tactics to build support for ideas. Appeal to ideals or values to overcome resistance and sway the opinions of others.
- ★ Use multiple digital resources at the same time to conduct research. Select communication mediums based on situational needs. Provide others with advice on new digital technology.

Developing Organizations:

- ★ Encourage retraining opportunities to balance the force and meet mission requirements.

★ **Senior Noncommissioned Officers:** This tier preserves our legacy and heritage by focusing on leading teams and shaping the future force. The ranks consist of Master Sergeant (MSgt), Senior Master Sergeant (SMSgt), and Chief Master Sergeant (CMSgt). As Senior Noncommissioned Officers progress in this tier, they actively integrate subordinates' talents, skills, and abilities with other teams to effectively accomplish the mission. Additionally, they seek joint and interagency professional development opportunities to build partnership capacity. Senior Noncommissioned Officers should be highly proficient at the Airman Leadership Qualities and have a comprehensive knowledge of the foundational competencies operating at the advanced and expert levels. All Senior Noncommissioned Officers mentor their subordinates and peers through continual education, training, and experience to develop ready and disciplined teams. They also play a unique and critical role in developing and advising officers to lead teams successfully. As Senior Noncommissioned Officers progress in this tier, they focus on:

Master Sergeant. Technical experts that begin transitioning from first-line supervisors and trainers to leaders of teams with operational competence and overall effectiveness.

Senior Master Sergeant. Experienced operational leaders that continue to develop their leadership and management skills. They strive to learn the art of strategic leadership and earn the 9-skill level.

Chief Master Sergeant. Serve in the highest enlisted grade and hold strategic leadership positions with tremendous influence at all levels of the Air Force.

Responsibilities of all Senior Noncommissioned Officers: In addition to meeting all Junior Enlisted Airmen and Noncommissioned Officers responsibilities, Senior Noncommissioned Officers responsibilities include:

Developing Self:

- ★ Dedicate time to develop a greater understanding of leadership, operational, and managerial concepts and advance communication skills to reach and connect with diverse audiences.
- ★ Leverage appropriate data collection techniques by identifying root causes, involving others, and gathering information, to rationally weigh all sources in the decision-making process.
- ★ Respond proactively to unexpected or ambiguous situations, opportunities, or risks. In static environments, find and implement constructive methods to exercise flexibility.
- ★ Show self-control by remaining visibly calm in stressful situations when others are not, control emotions or other stress, and take action to respond constructively to the source of the problems.

Developing Others:

- ★ Contribute to a professional climate and culture by ensuring their teams understand leadership orders by clarifying expectations as well as identifying, highlighting, and correcting behaviors that might detract from a professional climate and culture.
- ★ Empower Noncommissioned Officers and maintain harmony between caring for people and mission execution.
- ★ Support professional development by sharing knowledge and experience and enforcing standards to best meet the organization's mission requirements. Build and maintain professional relationships and strive to create effective leadership teams.
- ★ Continue to develop themselves and their subordinates through available education, leadership seminars, and content provided through senior leaders' respective official libraries.

Developing Ideas:

- ★ Reframe issues to evaluate them from different perspectives and identify useful relationships among complex data from unrelated sources.
- ★ Create a sense of urgency to overcome inaction and take steps to develop trust among the various parties. Teach and influence tactics and strategies to others.

Developing Organizations:

- ★ Be an active and visible leader to effectively cultivate a climate of inclusion and excellence.
- ★ Study leaders' decisions to understand their rationale and goals. Translate and communicate tasks and responsibilities up and down the chain of command in order to facilitate mission accomplishment. Foster unit cohesion, connectedness, and belonging as a team.
- ★ Leverage personal experience/knowledge to effectively accomplish and advance the mission.
- ★ Understand, manage, and explain manning health and capabilities based on unit requirements and manpower documents. Help commanders best balance risk to mission and risk to force.
- ★ Work to improve resource management (to include personnel, manpower, facilities, funding) in organizations, teach and encourage others to do the same.
- ★ Understand and be prepared to advocate for both current and future fiscal budget requirements.
- ★ Define how your organization/specialty coordinates with partners to execute the mission. Establish and expand relationships to advance priorities and connect teams to solve problems.
- ★ Understand and educate your team on how to respond, support events during deployments and emerging situations. Foster enduring team readiness for wartime actions and decisions.

The Enlisted Force Structure

General Duty Titles: When properly applied, duty titles facilitate a quick understanding of a person's role and level of responsibility. The following duty titles are common throughout the enlisted force but may vary based on organizational structure. When published, duty titles may be specified in career field governing directives. In each of these positions, Airmen are responsible for *Executing the Mission, Leading People, Improving the Unit and Managing Resources* at a level commensurate to their title.

★ **Supervisor.** Used for Junior Enlisted Airmen and Noncommissioned Officers who are first-line supervisors. Junior Enlisted Airmen will not have the duty title "Supervisor" unless they are at least a Senior Airman and supervise the work of others. Supervisors are responsible for prepping the line by ensuring those under their charge are meeting all responsibilities and continuing to develop.

★ **Noncommissioned Officer in Charge (NCOIC).** Used for Noncommissioned Officers responsible for a work center or element that typically have subordinate supervisors. Noncommissioned Officer in Charge is also used for those whose primary duty is a unit-wide program or function management, even if they do not directly rate on personnel.

★ **Manager.** Used for Noncommissioned Officers and Senior Noncommissioned Officers who are program, project, and policy managers at higher headquarters and staff levels. Managers may or may not have personnel working for them and may be the enlisted leader of the branch, division, or directorate.

★ **Flight Chief.** Used for Senior Noncommissioned Officers, and occasionally Noncommissioned Officers, who are the enlisted leaders of a flight.

★ **Section Chief.** Used for Senior Noncommissioned Officers and occasionally Noncommissioned Officers responsible for a section with at least two subordinate work centers or elements.

★ **Superintendent.** Used for Senior Noncommissioned Officers in Charge of functional responsibilities. Only Senior Noncommissioned Officers will hold the duty title of Superintendent.

★ **Chief.** Used for Chief Master Sergeants and civilians who are program, project or policy managers at Numbered Air Force, Major Command, Direct Reporting Unit, Field Operating Agency, Joint Staff, or Air Staff. Chiefs may or may not have personnel working for them and may be the enlisted leader of the branch, division, or directorate.

Specific Enlisted Positions: Enlisted Airmen may serve in a variety of special leadership or duty positions inside and outside of their functional specialty. **NOTE:** *Airmen may serve in joint leadership positions and ranks such as the Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff (SEAC), Combatant Command Senior Enlisted Advisors, and the Senior Enlisted Advisor of the National Guard.* Specific enlisted positions include, but are not limited to:

★ **Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force (CMSAF).** The Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force is both a distinctive rank and a duty position. It represents the highest enlisted level of leadership in the United States Air Force. The position provides direction for the enlisted force and represents their interests, as appropriate, to the American public and to those in all levels of government. The Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force serves as the personal adviser to the Chief of Staff and the Secretary of the Air Force on all issues regarding the welfare, readiness, morale, and proper utilization and progress of more than 600,000 Total Force Airmen. The CMSAF consults with the SEAC and sister service senior enlisted advisors on issues affecting all enlisted Airmen and families across the Department of Defense. The CMSAF engages with foreign military leadership regarding theater security cooperation and partner nation's development efforts and is the Air Force functional manager for command chief master sergeants and group senior enlisted leaders.

★ **Command Chief Master Sergeant (CCM).** The command chief is the Senior Enlisted Leader of the

The Enlisted Force Structure

command at wing or higher levels and is a key member of the command's leadership team. A CCM is the commander's key enlisted advocate and advisor on operational effectiveness and the organization. They are responsible for training and equipping the enlisted Airmen. CCMs ensure the commanders' directions and policies are carried out and the Airmen understand and are dedicated to the mission of the command. CCMs are responsible for the professional development and proper utilization of the command's enlisted force. CCMs work in concert with other senior enlisted leaders and first sergeants to oversee the readiness, training, health, morale, welfare, quality of life, and force development of assigned personnel.

★ **Career Field Manager (CFM).** Enlisted career field managers are typically Chief Master Sergeants, located at Headquarters Air Force, responsible for organizing one or more enlisted career fields. Their responsibilities include establishing career field entry requirements, developing/managing training plan requirements, evaluating training effectiveness, monitoring career field manning health, collaborating with other career field managers on issues affecting their Airmen, and providing input on programs and policies. Additionally, through Enlisted Development Teams, CFMs ensure the most qualified Noncommissioned and Senior Noncommissioned Officers are placed into key leadership or key development positions utilizing talent management practices.

★ **Major Command Functional Manager (MFM).** Enlisted Major Command Functional Managers are Senior Noncommissioned Officers who manage designated career fields across their command as well as serve as liaisons to their Air Force Career Field Manager. Responsibilities include visiting the organizations, monitoring the health, balancing manning, elevating concerns, evaluating command training, and disseminating programs and policies for their designated career fields. MFM's are responsible for coordinating with Air Force Personnel Center, through their major command, to distribute personnel. This ensures the prioritization of personnel, manpower, and resources by providing functional and subject matter expertise to Air Education and Training Command.

★ **Senior Enlisted Leader (SEL).** Senior Enlisted Leader is a duty title reserved for the commander-appointed senior enlisted member at a detachment, squadron, or group. Additionally, this title may be used for appointed Senior Noncommissioned Officers at higher headquarters who lead directorates and/or divisions. Senior Enlisted Leaders provide vital leadership and management experience regarding organizing, equipping, training, and mobilizing the unit or group to effectively meet home station and expeditionary mission requirements. SELs must be well versed and able to advocate for future resources and evolving mission requirements.

★ **First Sergeant.** The First Sergeant is a key leader serving in a time-honored career-broadening position rich in custom and tradition. They epitomize the highest qualities of Air Force Senior Noncommissioned Officers. These qualities require the First Sergeant to always remain perceptive and credible and to exemplify the core values of the United States Air Force. **NOTE:** *a description of the First Sergeant is covered on page 11.*

Career-Broadening Opportunities: *The Air Force Enlisted Classification Directory* contains official specialty descriptions for all military classification codes and identifiers used to identify each Air Force Job and describes the minimum mandatory qualifications for personnel to fill these jobs. *The Special Duty Category Guide* provides additional mandatory eligibility qualifications and requirements for a wide variety of career-broadening positions. Airmen should seek these opportunities throughout their careers to build experience and understanding of how each career field contributes to the overall mission.

Force Generators: As part of career-broadening, Force Generators comprise Airmen in key roles to

The Enlisted Force Structure

recruit, build, and develop the Airmen we need. These priority positions are integral in the development of our force and provide a robust experience in training, management, mentorship, and leadership skills that provide greater opportunities upon return to the career field. Airmen that serve in these roles are often the first impression and first line of impact on our newest recruits. Force Generators develop Airmen at every level and are catalysts to elevate character, competence, and commitment within our formations. For this reason, Force Generators must be strong examples of professionals, have a passion for developing others, and be screened for selection in these duties.

★ **Recruiter.** The Air Force recruiter is the first Airman potential enlistees will ever meet. They represent the Air Force in communities throughout the world and must exhibit the highest levels of integrity, professionalism, military bearing, respect for authority, and exceptional dress and personal appearance. Recruiters are responsible for interviewing, screening, testing, and evaluating applicants from civilian sources; assisting and participating in special events such as state and municipal ceremonies, exhibits, fairs, parades, centennials, and sporting events; and performing other duties as required to achieve recruiting goals.

★ **Military Training Instructor (MTI).** Military Training Instructors are responsible for shaping newly enlisted trainees into Airmen ready to serve in the United States Air Force. They must exhibit the highest levels of professional behavior, military bearing, respect for others, dress, and personal appearance. MTIs plan, organize, direct basic and initial military training, and determine requirements for training, facilities, space, equipment, visual aids, and supplies. They instruct trainees in dormitory setup, drill, and other training subjects using demonstration-performance and lecture methods and inspect and evaluate military training activities, personnel, and facilities. MTIs must be attuned to trainees' interpersonal interactions to identify and correct behaviors that are incompatible with military service and the *Profession of Arms*.

★ **Military Training Leader (MTL).** Military Training Leaders supervise all assigned non-prior service Airmen during technical training. They evaluate standards of conduct, performance, military bearing, discipline, and create a culture of dignity and respect. While scheduling and conducting military training functions. MTLs establish incoming, outgoing, and student entry briefings; conduct individual and group interviews; motivate personnel to develop military attitudes, effective human relations, and social skills for improving interpersonal and military relations; and assist students in their personal adjustment to military life.

★ **Academy Military Training (AMT) Noncommissioned Officer.** Academy Military Training Noncommissioned Officers lead, mentor, instruct, develop, and supervise the United States Air Force cadets. AMTs serve as the principal advisor to the Cadet Squadron Commander on all issues relating to cadets. These trainers provide military training, exercise general supervision/leadership, and prepare cadets to support mission requirements to ensure cadet and squadron success.

★ **Air Force Reserve Officer Training Corp (AFROTC) Training Instructor.** AFROTC Training Instructors serve as the detachment's key enlisted leader and as the primary enlisted advisor to the detachment commander/Professor of Aerospace (PAS) on cadet academics, professional development, military training, and discipline. They promote health, welfare, and morale for all assigned cadets and provide oversight of administrative tasks for Enlisted Commissioning Programs (ECP) students, supporting cadet life cycle management, and completing actions for contracting and commissioning.

★ **Technical Training Instructor.** Technical training instructors provide initial skills training and education for their Air Force specialty. They are technical experts in their career field and work closely with Air Force career field managers to develop training and education requirements necessary to award the 3-skill level; and plan, organize, and direct the training of all non-prior service Airmen and career Airmen cross-training into a new Air Force specialty.

The Enlisted Force Structure

★ **Professional Military Education (PME) Instructor and Curriculum Developer.** Professional Military Education Instructors use informal lectures, case studies, teaching interviews, guided discussions, and a variety of other teaching methods to provide instruction and education necessary to facilitate knowledge and understanding of *The Profession of Arms*. They plan, organize, and direct programs at Airman Leadership School, Noncommissioned Officer Academy, Senior Noncommissioned Officer Academy, and the Chief Leadership Academy. These instructors are responsible for delivering Professional Military Education courses that develop the foundational competencies for enlisted Airmen along their career continuum.

★ **Airmen Development Advisors (ADA).** Formerly known as Career Assistance Advisors, Airmen Development Advisors serve at the base level and advise commanders and supervisors on force development and force management programs. ADAs counsel Airmen on career progression and planning, monitor mandatory pay and benefits briefings, and conduct advertising and publicity programs. Airmen Development Advisors are critical in connecting the force development ecosystem across military installations to support tiered competency-based progression.

*"It's very hard for someone to find a job they truly love,
and I truly love serving my country."*

SMSgt Israel Del Toro,

*First 100% combat disabled Airman
allowed to continue serving



Chapter 5 – HOW WE DO IT: COMPETENCIES AND ALQs

As a warfighting force, the Air Force has a vast array of mission requirements. Therefore, we need a basic set of Air Force standards to build upon for all Airmen. From these, supervisors lay out a set of specific and relevant expectations for each member to execute their assigned missions and duties. We must also acknowledge that our Airmen all have different talents, goals, and aspirations. It is why we should not treat everyone the same. Leaders must keep these things in mind when developing objectives, providing feedback, and assessing performance.

FEEDBACK AND DEVELOPMENT

As an institution, *the Airman Leadership Qualities (ALQs) and Air Force Foundational Competencies* are driven directly from the four major graded areas of the Air Force Unit Effectiveness Inspection Program; *Executing the Mission, Leading People, Managing Resources, and Improving the Unit*. Additionally, each career field develops occupational competencies that are tailored to the requirements of their specialties. All of these development mechanisms are intertwined to deliver Airmen that are competent on their missions, remain adaptable problem-solvers, and have human skills to connect on a professional level.

★ **Airman Leadership Qualities (ALQs).** The ALQs are the most important behavior measures of specific enlisted performance. The ALQs are derived from how Airmen perform using the foundational competencies. The ALQs are the cornerstone to a more transparent and collaborative feedback system and the deliberate development of Airmen. The ALQs solidify how we perform. They are grouped under major performance areas that are aligned to the major graded areas critical to unit effectiveness. Through competency-based performance management founded on the ALQs, Airmen can be better informed about their performance to reach their full potential. Furthermore, they provide the foundation of how the Air Force develops leaders of character and competence by defining and rewarding the behaviors we value.

★ **Foundational Competencies.** The Air Force Foundational Competencies will assist Airmen in taking ownership in the development of themselves and their subordinates. Knowing is one thing, but “doing” is what turns thinking into action. Today’s competency-based approach to force development will allow us to capture what Airmen “know and can do.” A competency is a combination of knowledge, skills, and abilities and other characteristics that manifest in an observable and measurable pattern of behavior. These competencies, along with occupational competencies (specific for each career field), are part of the service’s systematic, competency-based approach to develop specific behaviors. This identifies what success looks like, to create a pathway that deliberately develops Airmen to become their most effective selves. The four primary categories of the foundational competencies are *Developing Self, Developing Others, Developing Ideas, and Developing Organizations* and include 24 sub-categories. The foundational competencies provide Total Force Airmen a pathway to success in their respective careers, lay the foundation for developing the Airmen we need, and are universally applicable to all Airmen. These levels are fluid based on the Airman’s experience and position. *Resource: Air Force Foundational Competencies – [AFH 36-2647, Competency Modeling](#)*



MENTORING AND COACHING

A mentor talks *to* you, and a coach talks *with* you. [Mentoring resources](#) provide additional support and information to assist Airmen in developing these skills. While the Department of the Air Force has programs to become a certified coach, supervisors and other leaders can use coaching skills or a coaching methodology to empower their Airmen. Some skills include active listening and asking open-ended and thought-provoking questions.

★ **Mentor.** A mentor is a wise, trusted, and experienced individual who shares knowledge, experience, skills, and advice with a less experienced person. Mentorship is a professional relationship in which a person with greater experience and wisdom guides another person to develop personally and professionally. This relationship helps achieve mission success and motivates individuals to achieve their goals. Mentoring promotes a climate of inclusion that can help foster and develop diverse strengths, perspectives, and capabilities of all Airmen. More guidance can be found in [AFH 36-2643, Air Force Mentorship Program](#)

★ **Coach.** A coach collaborates with individuals in a thought-provoking, empowering, and creative process that inspires them to maximize their personal and professional potential. Influential leaders often serve as coaches who must thoroughly understand the strengths, weaknesses, and professional goals of members of their teams. Coaches improve their teams by reinforcing goals, gaining a shared perspective on developing and implementing action plans, and providing oversight and motivation throughout the process. Successful leaders must accept the responsibility of being both a master student and a master teacher by embracing the role of both a follower and a leader.

Roles of a Mentor versus Roles of a Coach

Mentor	Coach
Talks more	Listens more
Shares their thinking	Challenges your thinking
Shares their ideas	Challenges you to find your own ideas
Pours their wisdom into you	Draws wisdom out of you
Solves your problems	Creates a problem solver
Expertise resides with the mentor	Expertise resides with the client

PERFORMANCE AND EVALUATION

Enlisted Evaluations. The focus within the Enlisted Evaluation System is to effectively capture how effectively Airmen are performing in their assigned duties as well as provide evidence of their readiness to assume increased responsibilities in the future.

Overall, a competency-based evaluation system enables increased transparency and more direct feedback between Airmen and their supervisors. It is the supervisor's responsibility to provide timely feedback on an Airman's performance and act as a mentor or coach to assist them in maximizing their potential. It remains every Airman's responsibility to take ownership of their individual actions and to actively work toward achieving specified goals and objectives both, personal and professional.

Supervisors should aim to capture evidence of their Airman's performance level during official feedback and denoting plans for improvement and goals along the way. Supervisors should explain and record any additional standards with the foundational competencies and ALQs so their subordinates are never surprised or unclear on the standards and expectations to which they are held. Transparency of standards, expectations, and evaluation of a member's performance is paramount in establishing trust in the work center and as a supervisor.

Performance assessment, along with input from supervisors at all levels, helps to identify and advance the right Airman at the right time. Recent duty performance and demonstrated potential to serve in the next grade remain the most important factors when considering Airmen for promotion. The ALQs provide a lens to evaluate these factors on promotion boards, endorsement panels, and stratification processes. The combination of all these approaches serves to best develop the Airmen we need to serve and defend America for today and tomorrow.

*"I wasn't educated to memorize and pretend;
I was educated to think and take action."*

**SEAC Ramon "CZ" Colón-López,
Senior Enlisted Advisor
to the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff**

**First Airman to serve in this position*



CONCLUSION

Our Airmen power the world's greatest Air Force, which is fueled by their innovation, leadership, followership, mentorship, training, and development. This guide provides the standards and foundation for the enlisted force to meet mission requirements.

The Air Force is comprised of a diverse group of functionally and operationally specialized Airmen in the *Profession of Arms*. To best leverage the strength of our force, we must have a consistent, well-defined set of expectations and opportunities for the growth of all Airmen, regardless of rank or specialty.

No matter where they are, no matter what they do - our enlisted force is essential to our Air Force mission: *Fly, Fight, and Win...Airpower Anytime, Anywhere.*

Terms of Address and Basic Requirements by Rank

Rank	Grade	Terms of Address	Abbreviation	Required Education & Skill
Airman Basic	E-1	Airman Basic Airman	AB	- BMT - Technical Training
Airman 	E-2	Airman	Amn	- Technical Training - OJT
Airman First Class 	E-3	Airman First Class Airman	A1C	- Technical Training - OJT
Senior Airman 	E-4	Senior Airman Airman	SrA	- Technical Training
Staff Sergeant 	E-5	Staff Sergeant Sergeant	SSgt	- ALS - 5 Level completed
Technical Sergeant 	E-6	Technical Sergeant Tech Sergeant Sergeant	TSgt	
Master Sergeant 	E-7	Master Sergeant Sergeant	MSgt	- NCOA - 7 Level completed - CCAF or equivalent f/eligibility to SMSgt
Senior Master Sergeant 	E-8	Senior Master Sergeant Senior Sergeant	SMSgt	- SNCOA
Chief Master Sergeant 	E-9	Chief Master Sergeant Chief	CMSgt	- 9 Level completed
Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force 	E-9	Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force Chief	CMSAF	

REFERENCES

- Department of the Air Force Instruction 36-2670, Total Force Development, 25 June 2020
- Department of the Air Force Manual 36-2905, Air Force Physical Fitness Program, 21 April 2022
- Air Force Doctrine Document 1-1, The Air Force, 10 March 2021
- Air Force Instruction 1-2, Commander's Responsibilities, 8 May 2014
- Air Force Instruction 35-101, Public Affairs Operations, 20 November 2020
- Air Force Instruction 36-2113, The First Sergeant, 11 Jun 2020
- Air Force Instruction 90-5001, Integrated Resilience, 21 October 2021
- Air Force Manual 36-2100, Military Utilization and Classification, 7 April 2021
- Air Force Policy Directive 36-26, Total Force Development and Management, 18 March 2019
- Air Force Handbook 36-2643, Air Force Mentorship Program, 17 May 2019
- Air Force Handbook 36-2647, Competency Modeling, 8 February 2022
- Air Force Manual 36-606, Civilian Career Field Management and Force Development, 14 November 2019
- Air Force Instruction 90-5001, Integrated Resilience 25 January 2019
- A Profession of Arms: Our Core Values, "The Blue Book" 20 May 2022
- The Blueprint for Enlisted Force Development 22 April 2022



Force Development Model

**OUR MISSION:
FLY, FIGHT, & WIN...
AIRPOWER ANYTIME, ANYWHERE**



THE JOINT TEAM



U.S. AIR FORCE



Airmen,

Today, we find ourselves in an era of strategic competition against adversaries who seek to outpace and eventually overtake us. They are building and refining their military capabilities while simultaneously seeking to disrupt the rules-based international order. The future challenging and uncertain environment requires an adaptive, innovative, and ready force that can effectively operate with any and all Services. The importance of having a capable and lethal Joint Force cannot be overstated.

To that end, every Airman needs to know what is at stake in strategic competition and to understand the critical importance of synchronizing our capabilities. Throughout our careers, we have seen the capabilities of our joint partners and how they amplify our own strength and power. As technology and information change at a rapid pace, the persistence of our Airmen, Guardians, Soldiers, Sailors, Marines, and Coast Guardsmen to innovate and solve complex problems is imperative to winning against those who challenge our way of life.

Each of us is part of a larger team, bringing our individual talents to add value to a cause much bigger than ourselves. We must all stay rooted in the conceptual knowledge of the Joint Force and what each service member brings to the fight. Likewise, we must recognize the operational importance of airpower and apply it across the full spectrum of warfare.

This guide provides us the knowledge of the Joint Force and outlines expectations for us all to know, articulate, and implement across the Air Force. Understanding the value each service brings to the fight is paramount when it comes to competing, deterring, and winning the high-end fight. Employing the concepts in this “Purple Book” is the first step toward a unity of effort that will allow us to develop the military our nation needs and to ensure the capabilities we bring to the fight – together – will always be unmatched!

Aim High!

JoAnne S. Bass
Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force

Charles Q. Brown, Jr.
General, USAF
Chief of Staff

PURPOSE

Since 1947, The United States Air Force has been a critical component of every conflict, humanitarian mission, and military presence around the globe. Every Airman contributes to the delivery of sovereignty and freedom through their specialized skillset, thereby generating airpower—anytime, anywhere. To continue to advance with the speed and agility required to keep pace in a dynamic and competitive environment, our Joint Force provides capabilities that validate the strength of the United States, its allies, and its partners. In order for our Soldiers, Marines, Sailors, Airmen, Guardians, and Coast Guardsmen to deter our adversaries and respond to threats in any environment, we must understand, articulate, and demonstrate jointness.

This guide explains our Joint Force. It is built upon the foundation of contextual knowledge of joint doctrine, the National Defense Strategy, and the National Military Strategy. It clarifies the fundamental questions all Airmen must be able to answer: “How do I fit into the Joint Force, and how can I ensure I hone and deliver my unique capabilities to assure its success?” This guide will help Airmen internalize what it means to fight jointly, understand the missions of the Joint Force, appreciate the joint organizations that are leading the fight, comprehend how to integrate in a joint warfighting environment, and identify how the Air Force fits into the joint construct.

Leaders within the Department of Defense continue to stress the importance of every service member building an understanding of the emerging dangers that face our Nation. All warfighters must acknowledge the threat that our adversaries pose as they attempt to close the gap that presently exists between their capabilities and our own. That can never happen. Our Joint Force is comprised of professional, agile, and, adaptable men and women who serve with the highest level of integrity and commitment to their service, the Joint Force, and our Nation.

Information presented within this guide is intended to help Airmen understand the Joint Force. It is also meant to inform joint partners of the capabilities and knowledge that Airmen bring to their Joint Force formations. There are no previous versions of this guide.

THE JOINT TEAM

Table of Contents

Chapter 1 - WHY WE FIGHT JOINTLY	5
JOINTNESS	5
HISTORICAL AND LEGAL CONTEXT	6
Chapter 2 - WHAT IS THE JOINT MISSION	8
INSTRUMENTS OF NATIONAL POWER	8
THE COMPETITION CONTINUUM	9
MILITARY ACTIVITIES	10
SERVICE MISSIONS AND IDENTITIES	11
Chapter 3 - WHAT ARE JOINT ORGANIZATIONS	13
JOINT STAFF	13
COMBATANT COMMANDS	15
JOINT COMPONENT COMMANDS AND JOINT TASK FORCES	18
DEFENSE AGENCIES AND DOD FIELD ACTIVITIES	20
ALLIANCES AND PARTNERSHIPS	22
Chapter 4 - WHAT IS JOINT WARFIGHTING	24
JOINT OPERATIONS OVERVIEW	24
PRINCIPLES OF JOINT OPERATIONS	25
JOINT FUNCTIONS	27
THE JOINT SERVICE MEMBER	28
CODE OF CONDUCT FOR MEMBERS OF THE U.S. ARMED FORCES	29
Chapter 5 - HOW THE AIR FORCE FITS INTO THE JOINT FIGHT	31
AIR FORCE FUNCTIONS	31
AIR FORCE CORE MISSIONS	32
JOINT OPERATIONS ACROSS ALL DOMAINS	34
CONCLUSION	35
UNITED STATES MILITARY RANKS	35
REFERENCES	35

Chapter 1 - WHY WE FIGHT JOINTLY

JOINTNESS

The term “jointness,” as defined in Joint Publication (JP) 1, Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States, implies the cross-service combination wherein the capability of the Joint Force is understood to be synergistic, with the sum greater than its parts (the capabilities of the individual components). The Joint Force is a values-based organization. The character, professionalism, and values of service members across the Joint Force are vital for operational success.

The nature of the challenges facing the United States and its interests demand that the Armed Forces operate as a closely integrated joint team. This joint construct leverages the unique capabilities and characteristics of the Army, Marine Corps, Navy, Air Force, Space Force, Coast Guard, and National Guard to enhance operational effectiveness. Each service possesses distinct capabilities and roles as well as rich culture and tradition, which, when blended appropriately, serve to achieve unique operational objectives across the range of military operations.

Jointness also requires effective coordination with interagency and multinational partners. Using a whole of government approach is essential to advancing our interests to strengthen security relationships and capacity by, with, and through military forces of partner nations, U.S. and foreign government agencies, state and local governments, and intergovernmental and nongovernmental organizations. To succeed, the Armed Forces must refine and proportionally integrate the military with all the tools of American power while working with partner nations to do the same.

Effective integration of joint forces is intended to address geographic and functional vulnerabilities. This does not mean that all forces are represented equally in all operations. Rather, Joint Force Commanders (JFC) choose the capabilities they need from the forces at their disposal. Each service contributes distinct capabilities to the Joint Force; however, overall joint effectiveness is dependent on each service’s purposeful reliance on the other services’ capabilities to maximize complementary and reinforcing effects. The degree of interdependence varies based on operational needs and objectives. Jointness has become the fundamental organizing construct across all echelons. When the United States military operates as a cohesive team, its capabilities exceed those of individual components. Jointness is a force multiplier that empowers the United States military to defeat adversaries and dominate all domains of warfare (air, land, maritime, space, cyberspace, and information warfare) during competition, crisis, and conflict.

For more information: [JP 1, Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States](#)

- https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp1_ch1.pdf

“We must never fight another war the way we fought the last two. I have a feeling that if the Army and Navy had fought our enemies as hard as they fought each other, the war would have ended much earlier.”

President Harry S. Truman
33rd President of the United States



HISTORICAL AND LEGAL CONTEXT

National Security Act of 1947. Prior to 1947, the United States military consisted of two distinct organizations in a fragmented structure – the Department of War and the Department of the Navy. On July 26, 1947, President Harry S. Truman executed a major restructuring of military forces by signing the National Security Act of 1947 into law. The National Security Act merged the Department of the Army (formerly the Department of War), the Department of the Navy, and the newly established Department of the Air Force into a single Department of Defense (DoD) under the Secretary of Defense (SecDef). The purpose of the reorganization was to integrate the policies and procedures of all military departments and to provide for their unified direction under civilian control of the SecDef, but not to merge the departments of the services. It also established Unified Combatant Commands to provide strategic direction of combatant forces and their integration into an efficient team of land, naval, and air forces. In addition to restructuring the U.S. military, the National Security Act of 1947 established the Central Intelligence Agency and the National Security Council (NSC). These organizations serve to assist Presidents in forming and implementing foreign policy.

For more information: [*National Security Act of 1947*](#)

- <https://history.state.gov/milestones/1945-1952/national-security-act>

Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1958. Just more than a decade after the enactment of the National Security Act of 1947 and the subsequent merging of the military departments into a single DoD, the services still made overlapping efforts, requiring further policy intervention to increase joint interoperability. Thus, the Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1958 was signed into law by President Dwight D. Eisenhower on August 6, 1958, building upon the efforts of the previous law. The Reorganization Act streamlined channels of authority, limiting service responsibilities and empowering the combatant commands in the employment of combat forces. Additionally, it authorized the President, acting through the SecDef, to establish unified or specified commands, assign missions, and determine their structure. It established a clear line of command from the President, through the SecDef, to combatant commanders. President Eisenhower's goal was "a complete unification of all military planning and combat forces and commands." The law requires that each service maintain a responsibility to organize, train, and equip forces under the direction of their respective service secretary. When a crisis requires a military response, authority is granted to combatant commanders to direct, deploy, or mobilize assigned forces provided by each service component.

For more information: [*Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1958*](#)

- <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/STATUTE-72/pdf/STATUTE-72-Pg514.pdf>

Goldwater Nichols Act of 1986. In April 1980, President Jimmy Carter authorized OPERATION EAGLE CLAW to rescue 53 American hostages in Tehran, Iran. The operation included assets from all military services—Army, Navy, Air Force, and Marines. According to the operations plan, Navy RH-53 helicopters were to launch from the aircraft carrier, USS Nimitz, headed for a remote site known as Desert One. Meanwhile, Air Force MC-130s and EC-130s would transport a 118-man assault force comprised of Army Rangers, Delta Operators, and Air Force Combat Controllers to Desert One where they would rendezvous and refuel the helicopters. From there, the assault force was to enter the U.S. Embassy compound in Tehran, rescue the hostages, and transport them to safety aboard Air Force C-141 aircraft. Despite the bravery and dedication of all involved, the operation was ultimately a failure and resulted in the loss of eight service members. As a result, retired Admiral James L. Holloway III led an official investigation into the operation's failure and recorded the findings in the "The Holloway Commission Report." The report highlighted 23 key findings; among them were deficiencies in command and control, joint training, and alterations to joint task force composition.

The lessons learned during OPERATION EAGLE CLAW prompted U.S. military and civilian leaders to pursue new legislation to codify joint organizing, training, and operating procedures. In October 1986, President Ronald W. Regan signed the Goldwater-Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act, sponsored by Senator Barry Goldwater and Representative Bill Nichols. The Goldwater-Nichols Act empowered the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff (CJCS) with greater influence, increased the authority of unified combatant commands, and enriched the Joint Staff by mandating that officers must have at least one joint tour for promotion eligibility to general or flag officer ranks (generals or admirals). Additionally, the Goldwater-Nichols Act established United States Special Operations Command to execute specialized, joint operations.

For more information: [H.R.3622 - Goldwater-Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1986](#)

- <https://www.congress.gov/bill/99th-congress/house-bill/3622>

OPERATION INHERENT RESOLVE. Since the passage of the Goldwater-Nichols Act, the military services have planned and executed successful joint operations across the globe. For example, in response to the attacks on American soil on September 11, 2001, the joint team has conducted operations to defend the sovereignty of the U.S., destroy terrorist networks in Iraq and Afghanistan, and stabilize governments during threats of insurgency. Fighting alongside and in support of joint service partners, Airmen have secured forward operating bases, cleared roadways of improvised explosive devices, conducted airstrikes, and provided countless other capabilities to bring American military might to bear on U.S. adversaries.

The successful campaign against Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) is one of many examples of the effectiveness of intentional Joint Force integration. This operation seamlessly integrated the capabilities of multiple services and allied nations. Combined Joint Task Force – Operation Inherent Resolve (CJTF-OIR) was established in 2014 to eliminate ISIS and ensure peace and stability for the people of Iraq and Syria. Throughout the nearly five years of operations, CJTF-OIR conducted over 34,000 airstrikes, 39,970 airlift sorties, and 331,454 aerial refueling missions. Remotely piloted aircraft provided support to partner forces and conducted Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance missions throughout the area of responsibility. The Command and Control capabilities Airmen provided increased situational awareness and aircraft deconfliction and helped fuse battlefield information for distribution to the Joint Force.

By March 2019, ISIS had suffered a crippling defeat, losing all the territory they once held. In addition to the territorial defeat, ISIS's leadership degraded, and its ideology became widely condemned. Following ISIS's defeat, CJTF-OIR continued operations with a revised mission to advise, assist, and enable partner forces until they can independently defeat Daesh in designated areas of Iraq and Syria in order to set conditions for long-term security cooperation frameworks. The heroic efforts of United States Airmen, their joint service counterparts, and partner nation allies led to the liberation of more than 42,000 square miles and almost eight million people who had been under ISIS's oppressive control.

Chapter 2 - WHAT IS THE JOINT MISSION

INSTRUMENTS OF NATIONAL POWER

The United States' vital national interests have endured since the founding of our Nation. Vital interests represent the matters and ideals for which the Nation is willing to sacrifice and are considered necessary for America's survival. America's core vital interests include security of the homeland, safety of Americans at home and abroad, economic prosperity, and preservation of the American way of life.

As the global security landscape evolves, U.S. Presidents emphasize broad objectives in the National Security Strategy (NSS) to address enduring and emerging threats that endanger these interests. Subsequently, U.S. government departments and agencies build their own strategies to translate and refine the NSS into more detailed guidance for their individual organizations. To advance national interests, appropriate government officials, often with National Security Council direction, employ the instruments of national power to achieve strategic objectives. These instruments include diplomatic, informational, military, economic, financial, intelligence, and law enforcement (DIME-FIL) activities. Each instrument of national power works most effectively when it is supported by and operates harmoniously with the other elements. Accordingly, all departments and agencies work within their unique lanes to support the President's foundational strategy via what is often referred to as a whole of government approach.

- ★ **Diplomatic.** Diplomacy is the principal instrument for engagement with other states and foreign groups to advance U.S. values, interests, and objectives and to solicit foreign support for U.S. military operations.
- ★ **Information.** Every DoD action that is planned or executed, every word that is written or spoken, and every image that is displayed or relayed communicates the intent of DoD and, by extension, the U.S. government, to achieve strategic effects.
- ★ **Military.** The U.S. employs the military at home and abroad in support of its national security goals. While the ultimate purpose of the U.S. Armed Forces is to fight and win the Nation's wars, military activities also include capacity and capability building of partner militaries and humanitarian aid and assistance operations.
- ★ **Economic.** A strong economy with free access to global markets and resources is fundamental to general welfare, the enabler of a strong national defense. The Department of Treasury works with other U.S. Government agencies, governments of other nations, and international finance institutions to encourage economic growth and prevent economic or financial crises.
- ★ **Financial.** The U.S. Government utilizes an array of resources to deny access to specified individuals or groups, including states and non-state actors, from formal or informal financial systems, networks, or sources of funding. Some of these resources include foreign aid, trade agreements, tariffs, embargos, and economic sanctions.
- ★ **Intelligence.** Intelligence consists of data collected by various organizations through a variety of mediums. Ambiguous data is translated into coherent information about the environment, future capabilities and intentions, and relevant actors to provide advantage to decision makers, including commanders and policy makers.
- ★ **Law Enforcement.** The U.S. Government enforces laws through government agencies, intergovernmental organizations, and host-nation partners. Law enforcement enables the U.S.

Government to secure the homeland, detain criminals, and assist mission partners with security needs.

The United States leverages DIME-FIL activities in both proactive and retaliatory forms to shape behaviors and outcomes of foreign nations and situations. Proactively applied, DIME-FIL instruments ensure U.S. investment in critical relationships with like-minded foreign allies and partners. Conversely, retaliatory application of the instruments of national power is crucial to preventing aggression of bad actors that threaten the United States and its partners. The first Gulf War is one example of the U.S. Government's employment of the instruments of national power to achieve strategic effects. When Saddam Hussein's forces invaded Kuwait, President George H. W. Bush utilized diplomacy to energize a coalition of nations to develop specific rules of engagement for the counter operation. Through diplomacy and measured military action, the coalition successfully removed Iraqi forces from Kuwait while minimizing casualties.

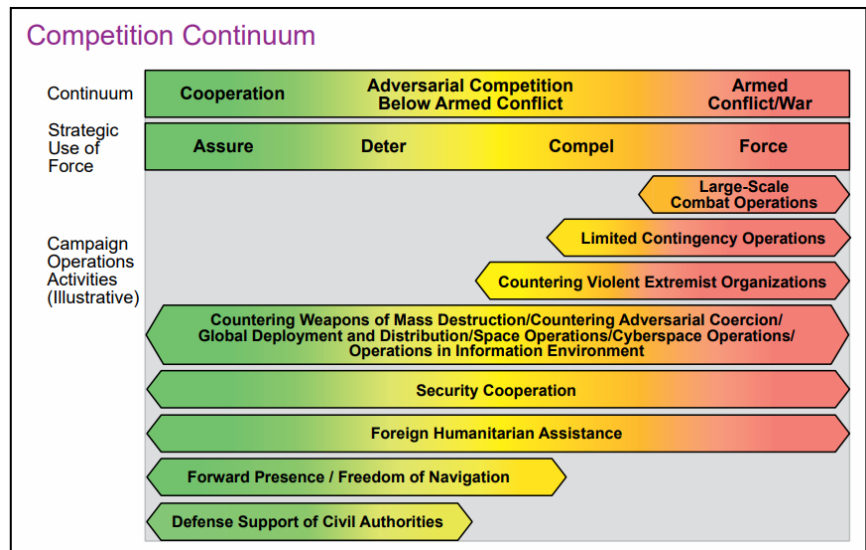
For more information: [*The First Gulf War; JP 1, Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States*](#)

- <https://history.state.gov/departmenthistory/short-history/firstgulf>
- https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp1_ch1.pdf

THE COMPETITION CONTINUUM

The U.S. military's mission extends beyond waging war on adversaries. The military plays an integral role in all aspects of DIME-FIL and provides a credible threat of force that empowers and enables our elected civilian leaders to leverage all instruments of national power to achieve objectives in accordance with national interests and policies.

Competition is a fundamental aspect of international relations. As state and non-state actors seek to protect and advance their interests, they continually compete over incompatible aims. The competition continuum describes a world of enduring competition conducted through a mixture of cooperation, competition, and armed conflict. These descriptors refer to the relationship between the United States and another strategic actor concerning a set of policy objectives. This description allows for simultaneous interaction with the same strategic actor at different



points along the competition continuum. For instance, the United States might be in a state of competition with a strategic competitor regarding some interests, such as freedom of navigation in disputed areas, and cooperation in others, such as counter-piracy. By providing a lexicon to describe this complexity, the competition continuum facilitates shared understanding, both within the DoD and with interagency partners who often have a leading role. The elements of the competition continuum include:

- ✧ **Cooperation:** Situations in which joint forces take actions with another strategic partner in pursuit of policy objectives. Cooperation does not preclude some element of competition or even armed conflict when their objectives are not in complete alignment.
- ✧ **Competition:** Competition is when joint forces or multinational forces take actions outside of

armed conflict against a state or non-state adversary in pursuit of policy objectives, but neither seeks armed conflict. These actions are typically nonviolent and conducted under greater legal or policy constraints than in armed conflict but can include lethal and nonlethal actions by the joint force or sponsorship of surrogates or partners. Competition does not preclude some cooperation in other areas.

- ★ **Armed Conflict/War:** Armed conflict/war occurs when military forces take actions against an enemy in hostilities or declared war. International law distinguishes armed conflict from disturbances, including riots and protests, by the intensity of the conflict and the organization of the parties.

For more information: [*JP 3-0, Joint Campaigns and Operations*](#)

- https://jdeis.js.mil/jdeis/new_pubs/jp3_0.pdf

MILITARY ACTIVITIES

The emerging strategic environment presents ever-increasing threats to the security and interest of our Nation across the range of the DIME-FIL domains. The character of war is not static, and the full spectrum of the instruments of national power are essential to deterrence and victory in future high-end fights with great power competitors. For its part, the Joint Force focuses on six primary activities in fulfilling its obligation to the Nation:

- ★ **Secure the Homeland.** Securing the U.S. homeland is the Nation's first priority. Defense of the homeland is the DoD's highest priority, aiming to identify and defeat threats as far away from the homeland as possible.
- ★ **Win the Nation's Wars.** Winning the Nation's wars remains the preeminent justification for maintaining capable and credible military forces in the event that deterrence should fail.
- ★ **Deter our Adversaries.** Deterring adversarial powers from making the decision to utilize armed force is one of the most vital tasks of national defense. Defending national interests requires the capability to prevail in conflict and deter potential adversaries that threaten the vital interests of the U.S. or its partners.
- ★ **Security Cooperation.** Security cooperation encompasses all DoD interactions with foreign defense establishments to build defense relationships that promote specific U.S. security interests, develop allied and friendly military capabilities for self-defense and multinational operations, and provide U.S. forces with peacetime and contingency access to host nations.
- ★ **Support to Civil Authorities.** The U.S. responds to a variety of civil crises to relieve human suffering and restore civil function. These crises may be foreign or domestic and may occur independently, as in a natural disaster disrupting an otherwise functioning society, or within the context of a conflict, such as widespread suffering in a nation embroiled in insurgency.
- ★ **Adapt to a Changing Environment.** The strategic security environment is constantly changing. Effectiveness in addressing an evolving environment and meeting unique security challenges requires appropriate employment of the instruments of national power and the capabilities of the joint team to conduct military operations worldwide. The Joint Force must be innovative and agile.

For more information: [*JP 1, Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States*](#)

- https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp1_ch1.pdf

SERVICE MISSIONS AND IDENTITIES

Each service maintains the responsibility to organize, train, and equip forces to conduct specific missions. Service members from each military branch are employed as a Joint Force to execute military operations under the direction of combatant commanders. Each service maintains its own organic mission, identity, culture, and values. When employed as a joint team, the services blend their unique elements to complement the strengths, capabilities, and values of the other services to achieve mission success.

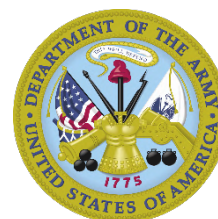
United States Air Force. The Air Force's mission is *"To Fly, Fight, and Win...Airpower Anytime, Anywhere."* The Air Force mission statement reflects a commitment to achieve and maintain superiority across all domains through the application of airpower to gain a distinct advantage over our adversaries. The Air Force's identity is grounded in independence and ingenuity, and its culture emphasizes the term *Airman*. This term refers to anyone who understands and appreciates the full range of air and space capabilities and can employ or support some aspect of airpower. The Air Force core values include integrity, service before self, and excellence in all we do.



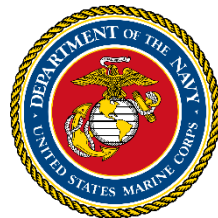
United States Space Force. The Space Force provides Guardians to conduct global space operations that enhance the way our joint and coalition forces fight, while also offering decision makers military options to achieve national objectives. Guardians comprise those forces that protect, defend, and project spacepower. They provide support, security, stability, and strategic effects by employing spacepower in, from, and to the space domain. The Space Force is a lean, mission-focused, digital service that relentlessly pursues new ideas, takes calculated risk, and rapidly learns from failure. Guardians value agility, innovation, and boldness.



United States Army. The Army's mission is to deploy, fight and win our Nation's wars by providing ready, prompt, and sustained land dominance by Army forces across the full spectrum of conflict as part of the Joint Force. The Army's mission is vital to the Nation as it propels the service capable of defeating enemy ground forces and indefinitely seizing and controlling adversary centers of gravity – its land, resources, and population. Army culture is founded on a fundamental belief in the human dimension of war and the centrality of land combat in its prosecution. Soldiers identify as warriors; accordingly, they value troop duty to the staff, training to education, and the practical to the theoretical. The Army core values include loyalty, duty, respect, selfless service, honor, integrity, and personal courage.



United States Marine Corps. The Marine Corps provides fleet marine forces of combined arms, together with supporting air components, for service with the fleet in the seizure or defense of advanced naval bases and for the conduct of such land operations as may be essential to the prosecution of a naval campaign. The culture of the Marine Corp is unique from that of the other services; Marines are proud to be "one of the few" and value being a Marine over any rank or occupational specialty. All Marines are riflemen first and selflessly take care of their own. The core values of the Marine Corps include honor, courage, and commitment.



United States Navy. The United States is a maritime Nation, and the Navy protects America at sea. The U.S. Navy defends freedom, preserves economic prosperity, and keeps the seas open and free. It remains prepared to execute its timeless role, as directed by Congress and the President, to defend American interests around the globe. Navy culture is a deployment culture, and Sailors pride themselves on the months and years they spend at sea. Accordingly, the Navy is the most independent of the services and prizes autonomy of command at sea and technical expertise. The Navy core values include honor, courage, and commitment.



United States National Guard. The National Guard has a unique dual mission that consists of both Federal and state roles. For state missions, the governor, through the state Adjutant General, commands Guard forces. The governor can call the National Guard into action during local or statewide emergencies, such as storms, fires, earthquakes, or civil disturbances. Additionally, the President of the United States can activate the National Guard for participation in federal missions. When federalized, Guard units are commanded by the combatant commander of the theater in which they are operating. The National Guard comprises the primary combat reserve of the Army and the Air Force, leveraging the civilian skillsets of its Soldiers and Airmen in a military capacity. Guardsmen prioritize readiness, people, and innovation.



United States Coast Guard. Organized under the U.S. Department of Homeland Security, the United States Coast Guard fulfills its mission to ensure our Nation's maritime safety, security, and stewardship. The Coast Guard saves those in peril and protects the Nation from all maritime threats. During times of war or conflict, the Coast Guard serves under the Department of the Navy. Its legal core is as a military service, vested with unique law enforcement authorities and leavened with a well-earned reputation for humanitarian service. These attributes enable Coast Guardsmen to satisfy a broad, multi-mission mandate to the Nation. The Coast Guard core values include honor, respect, and devotion to duty.



For more information: [*The Noncommissioned Officer and Petty Officer, Spacepower*](#)

- <https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/nco/NCO-Backbone.pdf>
- https://www.spaceforce.mil/Portals/1/Space%20Capstone%20Publication_10%20Aug%202020.pdf

Chapter 3 - WHAT ARE JOINT ORGANIZATIONS

Joint warfare is team warfare. The Armed Forces of the United States—all military organizations at all levels—are a team. The capacity of the Armed Forces to operate as a cohesive unit, in collaboration with governmental, non-governmental, civil, and public entities as well as international allies and partners, is a key advantage in any operational environment. The term “joint” connotes activities, operations, organizations, etc. in which elements of two or more military departments participate. The term “combined” identifies two or more forces or agencies of two or more allies operating together. Success depends on well-integrated command headquarters, supporting organizations, and forces that operate in concert with one another.

The Armed Forces of the United States are most effective when employed as a Joint Force. A Joint Force is defined as a force composed of elements, assigned or attached, of two or more military departments operating under a single Joint Force Commander (JFC). This comprehensive approach, involving all participating organizations, both military and nonmilitary, within an operational area requires the JFC to understand the capabilities, limitations, and mandates of those organizations involved and effectively communicate the mission of the Joint Force. The major components of the Joint Force include the Joint Staff, Combatant Commands (CCMD), Joint Task Forces (JTF), and Defense Agencies and DoD Field Activities (often referred to as 4th Estate Agencies). It is further bolstered by a powerful complement of international alliances and partnerships.

For more information: [*DoD Dictionary of Military and Associated Terms*](#)

- https://jdeis.js.mil/jdeis/new_pubs/dictionary.pdf

JOINT STAFF

The Joint Chiefs of Staff. The Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) consist of the Chairman, the Vice Chairman, the Chief of Staff of the Army, the Commandant of the Marine Corps, the Chief of Naval Operations, the Chief of Staff of the Air Force, the Chief of Space Operations, and the Chief of the National Guard Bureau. Headquartered at the Pentagon in Washington D.C., the Joint Staff is comprised of approximately 1,500 personnel from all six services and charged with assisting the Chairman in discharging their responsibility to the SecDef to provide unified strategic direction, operation, and integration of combatant land, naval, air, and space forces.



The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff (CJCS) is the principal military advisor to the President, the National Security Council, the Homeland Security Council, and the Secretary of Defense. Although the Chairman does not have command authority, in matters requiring global military strategic and operational integration, the Chairman, as global integrator, is responsible for providing advice to the SecDef on the arrangement of cohesive military actions in time, space, and purpose, executed as a whole to address trans-regional, all-domain, and multi-functional challenges.

The Vice Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. The DoD Reorganization Act of 1986 created the position of the Vice Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff (VCJCS), who performs such duties as the CJCS may prescribe. By law, he is the second ranking member of the Armed Forces and replaces the CJCS in his absence or disability. Though the Vice Chairman was not originally included as a member of the JCS, Section 911 of the National Defense Authorization Act of 1992 made him a full voting member of the JCS.

The Senior Enlisted Advisor to the CJCS. The Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman (SEAC) is a distinct military position and rank within the United States DoD and is designated the most senior enlisted service member, by position, in the United States Armed Forces. The SEAC serves as the principal advisor to the Chairman on all matters involving joint and combined total force integration, utilization, health of the force, and joint development for enlisted personnel. The SEAC represents the enlisted voice during engagements with leaders ranging from the Office of the Secretary of Defense to the civilian community to service leaders of foreign nations. Though not in the immediate chain of command, the SEAC serves as a vital conduit from the Chairman to the Service Senior Enlisted Advisors and the Command Senior Enlisted Leaders for the combatant commands to all enlisted members throughout the Joint Force.



"Today's operating environment is increasingly ambiguous, volatile, and complex. No longer is violent extremism the paramount threat. Rather, the 21st Century has witnessed the emergence of highly capable strategic competitors who are rapidly closing the gap in military capabilities and honing their capacity to disrupt rules-based order and reshape the international system. To deter adversarial aggression and win in a high-end fight, it is imperative that we build an innovative, adaptable, and lethal Joint Force. Our military services do not operate in a vacuum. Rather, they must synchronize unique capabilities to deliver the full complement of capabilities of the U.S. Armed Forces.

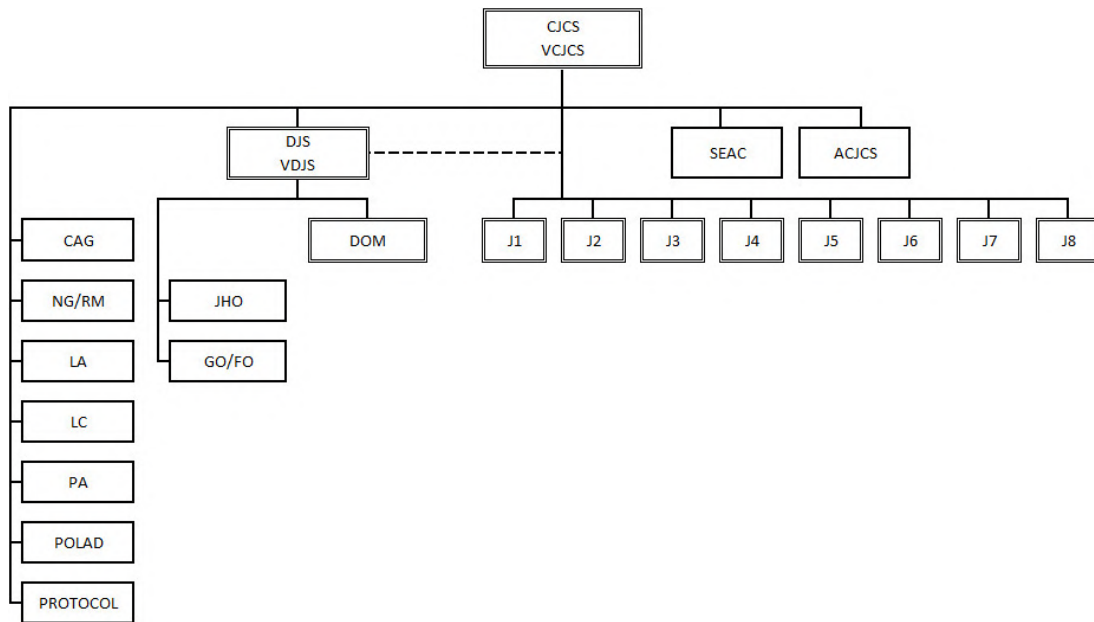


In 1947, Congress established an Air Force capable of preserving peace and security, providing defense, supporting national policies and objectives, and overcoming hostile enemies in conjunction with the other armed forces. Accordingly, our six services, in concert with international allies and partners, plan, train, and fight together as a team. Airmen are well equipped to support and execute all aspects of airpower, but it is only in tandem with our fellow Soldiers, Marines, Sailors, Guardians, and Coast Guardsmen that we advance and safeguard vital U.S. interests.

It is therefore imperative that today's Airmen understand why and how service members in the Profession of Arms fight jointly. We must educate and equip ourselves with knowledge of joint concepts and of the other services' unique capabilities. We must know the Air Force's core missions and appreciate airpower's contribution to the joint purpose and mission. We must recognize that each individual we stand and fight beside swore the same oath that we did, to support and defend the Constitution of the United States."

Ramon "CZ" Colon Lopez
Senior Enlisted Advisor to the CJCS

The Joint Staff. The Joint Staff is comprised of unique departments and directorates tasked with the execution of distinct functions. These include the Joint Staff Information Management Division, Directorate of Management, J1 – Personnel and Manpower, J2 – Intelligence, J3 – Operations, J4 – Logistics, J5 – Strategic Plans and Policy, J6 – Command, Control, Communications, and Computers/Cyber, J7 – Joint Force Development, and J8 – Joint Force Structure, Resources, and Assessment. These departments ensure planning, policies, intelligence, manpower, communications, and logistics function are translated into action. The Office of the Chairman also contains supporting elements that provide assistance to the CJCS, VCJCS, and the JCS on matters of advisement.



For more information: [The Joint Staff](https://www.jcs.mil/About/)

- <https://www.jcs.mil/About/>

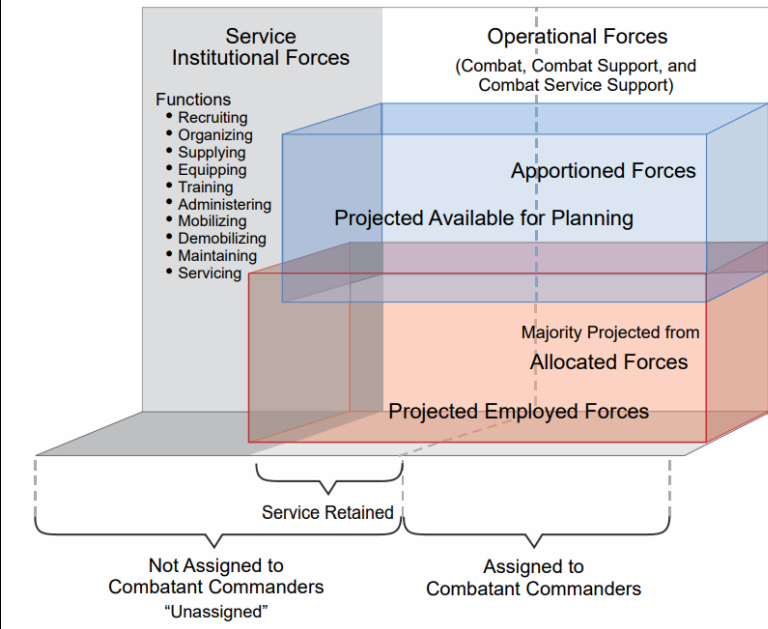
COMBATANT COMMANDS

The National Security Act of 1947 and Title 10, U.S. Code provide the basis for establishment of unified command of U.S. military forces. The Unified Command Plan (UCP) establishes the missions and responsibilities for CCMD Commanders (CCDR). The President, through the Secretary of Defense and with the advice and assistance of the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, establishes combatant commands for the performance of military missions and prescribes the force structure of such commands.

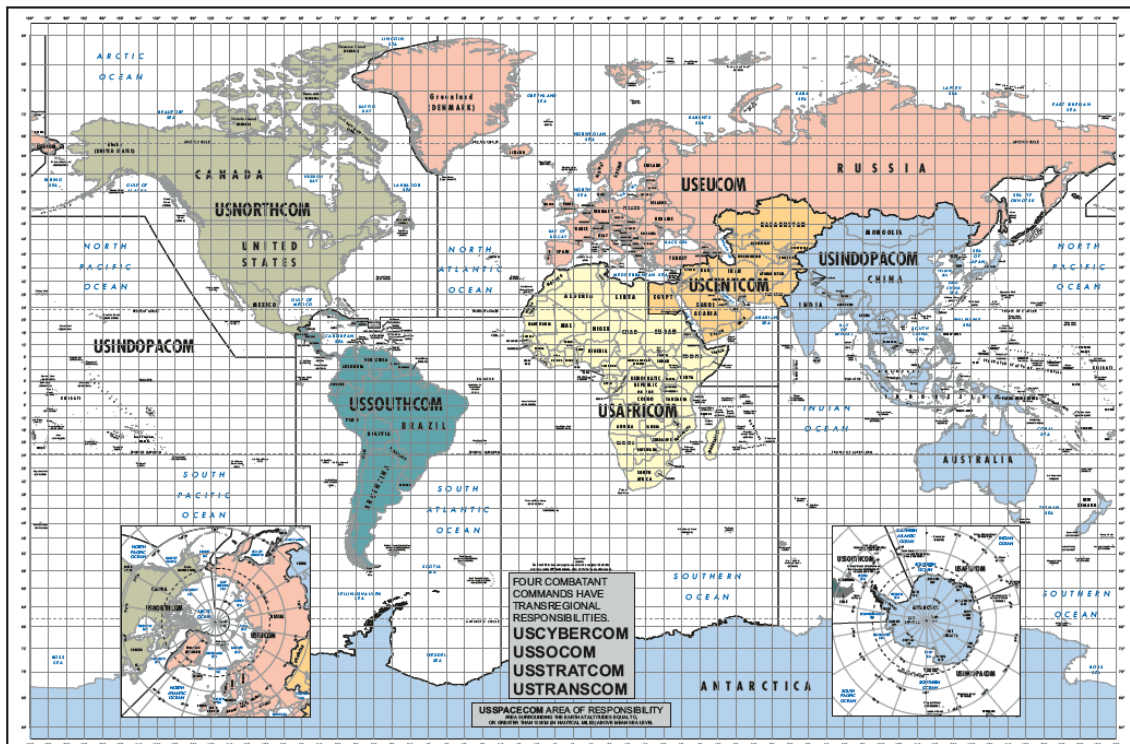
CCDRs exercise command authority (COCOM) of assigned forces. The CCDR may delegate operational control (OPCON), tactical control (TACON), or establish support command relationships of assigned forces. Airmen assigned to CCMDs perform their missions under the command authority of the CCDR to which they are assigned and support the mission and strategic objectives of that CCMD. Relative to their commands, CCDRs develop geographic or functional strategies which determine force employment. These strategies articulate the pursuit of global, regional, or functional objectives within the context of national strategy to achieve national policy objectives specific to designated region or function.

Assignment of forces is managed through Global Force Management (GFM). GFM is a series of processes that weigh the services' capacity to generate forces against CCDR requirements while building readiness and a credible deterrent force. Through the GFM process, Services provide sufficient, ready, and available forces to execute national strategy. GFM enables proper distribution of forces among the CCMDs through the assignment of forces, provides a mechanism to temporarily adjust force distribution to meet dynamic global challenges through the allocation process, and ensures the availability of apportioned forces, described as the services' estimate of the number of forces that can reasonably be made available over a general timeline should a surge of forces be required.

Department of Defense Force Structure and Global Force Management



In total, there are eleven CCMDs, seven of which are geographic and four of which are functional. The geographic commands include U.S. Africa Command, U.S. Central Command, U.S. European Command, U.S. Indo-Pacific Command, U.S. Northern Command, U.S. Southern Command, and U.S. Space Command. The functional commands include U.S. Cyber Command, U.S. Special Operations Command, U.S. Strategic Command, and U.S. Transportation Command.



U.S. Africa Command. USAFRICOM, with partners, counters trans-national threats and malign actors, strengthens security forces, and responds to humanitarian crises in order to advance U.S. national interests and promote regional security, stability, and prosperity.



U.S. Central Command. USCENTCOM directs and enables military operations and activities with allies and partners to increase regional security and stability in support of enduring U.S. interests.



U.S. Cyber Command. USCYBERCOM directs, synchronizes, and coordinates cyberspace planning and operations – to defend and advance national interests – in collaboration with domestic and international partners.



U.S. European Command. USEUCOM executes a full range of multi-domain operations in coordination with Allies and partners to support NATO, deter Russia, enable global operations, and counter trans-national threats in order to defend the Homeland forward and fortify Euro-Atlantic security. Should deterrence fail, USEUCOM is prepared to fight alongside allies and partners to prevail in any conflict.



U.S. Indo-Pacific Command. USINDOPACOM implements a combat credible deterrence strategy capable of denying our adversaries' sustained air and sea dominance by focusing on posturing the Joint Force to win before fighting while being ready to fight and win, if required.



U.S. Northern Command. USNORTHCOM defends our homeland – deters, detects, denies, and defeats threats to the United States, conducts security cooperation activities with allies and partners, and supports civil authorities.



The Joint Team

U.S. Southern Command. USSOUTHCOM deters aggression, defeats threats, rapidly responds to crises, and builds regional capacity, working with our allies, partner nations, and U.S. Government team members to enhance security and defend the U.S. homeland and our national interests.



U.S. Space Command. USSPACECOM conducts operations in, from, and to space to deter conflict and, if necessary, defeat aggression, deliver space combat power for the Joint/Combined Force, and defend U.S. vital interests with allies and partners.



U.S. Special Operations Command. USSOCOM develops and employs fully capable Special Operations Forces to conduct global special operations and activities as part of the Joint Force to support persistent, networked, and distributed combatant command operations and campaigns against state and non-state actors to protect and advance U.S. policies and objectives.



U.S. Strategic Command. USSTRATCOM employs nuclear, cyber, global strike, joint electronic warfare, missile defense, and intelligence capabilities to deter aggression, decisively and accurately respond if deterrence fails, assure allies, shape adversary behavior, defeat terror, and define the force of the future.



U.S. Transportation Command. USTRANSCOM conducts globally integrated mobility operations, leads the broader Joint Deployment and Distribution Enterprise, and provides enabling capabilities to project and sustain the Joint Force in support of national objectives.



For more information: [Title 10, U.S. Code, JP 5-0, Joint Planning](#)

- <https://uscode.house.gov/view.xhtml?path=/prelim@title10&edition=prelim>
- https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp5_0.pdf?ver=us_fQ_pGS_u65ateysmAng%3d%3d

JOINT COMPONENT COMMANDS AND JOINT TASK FORCES

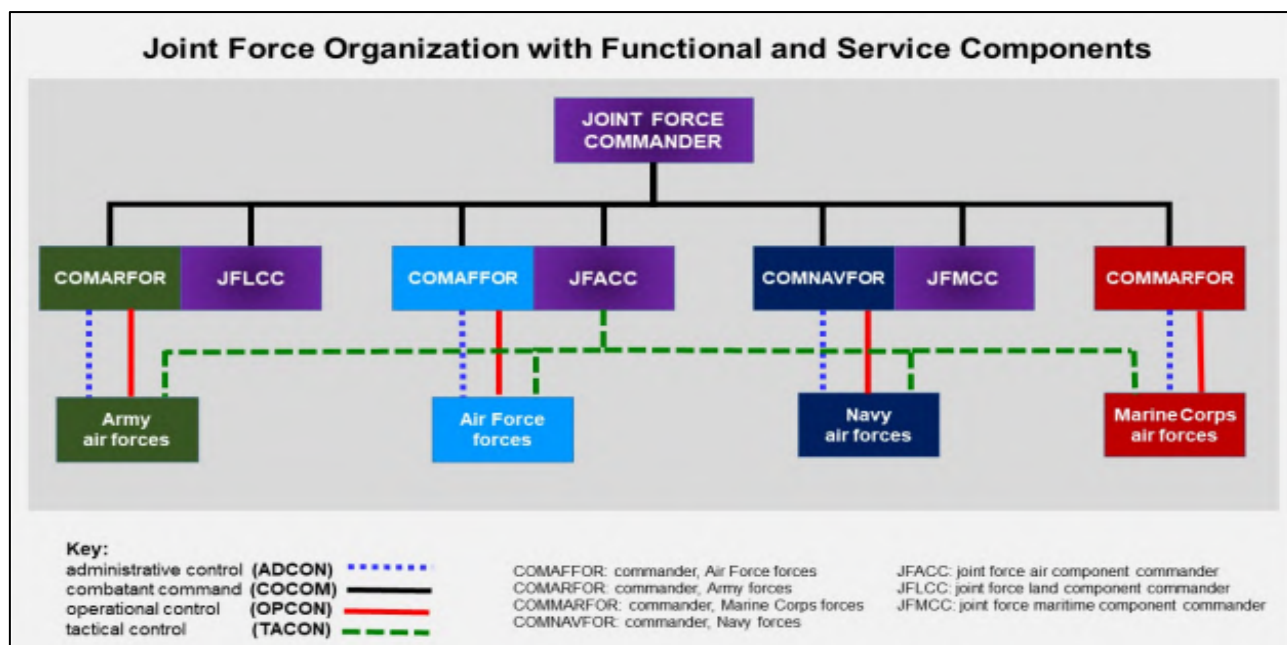
The JFC normally assigns broad missions to the component commanders. Each mission is assigned a specification of a supported commander for that mission. The designation of Joint Force air, land, maritime and special operations component commanders (Joint Force Air Component Commander [JFACC], Joint Force Land Component Commander [JFLCC], Joint Force Maritime Component Commander [JFMCC], and Joint Force Special Operations Component Commander [JFSOCC])

respectively) is at the discretion of the JFC. As an example, the JFC may designate the JFACC as the supported commander for counter air, strategic attack, air interdiction, and theater airborne intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance. As such, the JFACC is responsible to the JFC for planning, coordinating, executing, and assessing primary mission activities, while other component commanders support the JFACC. Because most services have forces that operate in the air domain, the designation of functional commanders allows greater synergy by integrating similar activities across service boundaries.

U.S. Forces are required by national command authorities to respond on short notice to spontaneous, unpredictable crises. When a crisis requires a military response, the Secretary of Defense, combatant commander, subordinate unified commander, or an existing JFC can form a Joint Task Force (JTF) tailored to address the crisis. The JTF is the primary construct for joint operations, and its organizational structure capitalizes on the unique capabilities of each service, providing flexibility to tailor the size and makeup of the force to accomplish specific tasks during peace, crisis, or war.

Some JTFs, known as Combined Joint Task Forces (CJTF) include partner nations. A CJTF is a deployable multinational, multiservice task force generated and tailored primarily but not exclusively for military operations not involving the defense of the alliance territory, such as humanitarian relief and peacekeeping. CJTFs provide a flexible and efficient means to enable partner nations to generate forces on short notice, providing rapidly deployable task forces with appropriate command and control.

Joint Task Forces do not normally have standing Air Force structures and require the Air Force establish an Air Expeditionary Task Force (AETF) as a temporary Air Force Service component command. The commander of the AETF would either be the commander, Air Force Forces (COMAFFOR) directly responsible to the JTF commander, or established in a supporting role to the JTF under the authority of the theater air component commander.



JTFs have a specific, limited objective, and once they have executed their missions, they are dissolved. Historically, JTFs have been constructed to execute disaster and humanitarian relief missions, combat operations, and counterdrug operations. Some examples of present-day JTFs and CJTFs include:

Combined Joint Task Force – Horn of Africa. CJTF-HOA is the USAFRICOM organization that conducts operations in the region to enhance partner nation capacity, promote regional security and stability, dissuade conflict, and protect U.S. and coalition interests. CJTF-HOA is comprised of multiple U.S. military service branches as well as allied and partner armed services personnel, working together against malign actors to strengthen collective security forces and respond to crises to promote regional security, stability, and prosperity.



Combined Joint Task Force – Operation Inherent Resolve. Established in 2014 at the request of Iraqi and Syrian governments to degrade and destroy the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (ISIL), CJTF-OIR is comprised of forces from over 77 nations and five international organizations. This combined JTF advises, assists, and enables partner forces until they can independently defeat Daesh in designated areas of Iraq and Syria in order to set conditions for long-term security cooperation frameworks.



Joint Task Force – Bravo. Stood up at the request of the Honduran government to increase the number and size of combined training exercises in the Republic of Honduras, JTF-Bravo was established in 1984, making it the longest standing JTF in the U.S. military. JTF-Bravo conducts and supports USSOUTHCOM operations, activities, and investments across all domains in support of U.S. Government agencies and partner nations in Central America, in order to enhance regional security and defend the U.S. homeland and national interests.



Joint Task Force – Civil Support. JTF-CS provides command and control for DoD forces deployed in support of the National Response Plan, specifically, managing the consequences of a domestic chemical, biological, radiological, nuclear, or high-yield explosive (CBRNE) incident. JTF-CS supports USNORTHCOM and is able to respond anywhere within North America within twenty-four hours to lead technical and non-technical search and rescue, security, hazard analysis, evidence collection, mission command, logistics support, aviation support, and medical support after an actual or threatened CBRNE incident.



Joint Task Force – National Capital Region. JTF-NCR was established in the aftermath of the September 11, 2001 attacks to address threats to the National Capital Region and provide DoD support to civil authorities. A joint command subordinate to USNORTHCOM, JTF-NCR conducts homeland defense and defense support of civil authorities. It is a collaborative, regional team focused on safeguarding the National Capital Region.



For more information: [*JP 3-30, Joint Air Operations*](#), [*The Combined Joint Task Forces Concept*](#)

- https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp3_30.pdf
- <https://www.nato.int/docu/comm/1999/9904-wsh/pres-eng/16cjtf.pdf>

DEFENSE AGENCIES AND DOD FIELD ACTIVITIES

The Department of Defense cannot operate without support from defense agencies and field activities outside the military services that perform functions critical to the joint mission. Pursuant to U.S. Code Title 10, Section 191, the Secretary of Defense, when they determine that it is more effective, economical, or efficient, may provide for the performance or supply of a service activity that is common to more than one military department by a single DoD agency. Such agencies are designated Defense Agencies or

DoD Field Activities and are commonly referred to as the 4th Estate.

There are more than two dozen defense agencies and field activities outside of the military branches which have been established for specific purposes in support of the DoD mission to provide the military forces needed to deter war and ensure the Nation's security. These organizations' missions range from combat support to research and development to security cooperation. Some examples of these agencies include:

Defense Contract Management Agency. The Defense Contract Management Agency (DCMA) is the independent eyes and ears of DoD and its partners, enhancing warfighter lethality by ensuring timely delivery of quality products, and providing relevant acquisition insight supporting affordability and readiness. The Defense Contract Management Agency is, first and foremost, a product delivery organization. Our Nation's warfighters expect our defense industry to produce and deliver the equipment they need to fight, survive, and win. DCMA's integrated team of acquisition and support professionals makes this happen.



Defense Health Agency. The Defense Health Agency (DHA) is a joint, integrated Combat Support Agency that enables the Army, Navy, and Air Force medical services to provide a medically ready force and ready medical force to combatant commands in both peacetime and wartime. The DHA uses the principles of Ready Reliable Care to advance high reliability practices across the Military Health System by improving our system operations, driving innovative solutions, and cultivating a culture of safety.



Defense Information Systems Agency. The Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) conducts Department of Defense Information Networks (DODIN) operations for the joint warfighter to enable lethality across all warfighting domains in defense of our Nation. DISA plans, engineers, acquires, tests, fields, operates, and assures information-sharing capabilities, command and control solutions, and a global enterprise infrastructure to support DoD and national-level leadership.



Defense Intelligence Agency. The Defense Intelligence Agency (DIA) provides intelligence on foreign militaries to prevent and decisively win wars. Additionally, DIA provides military intelligence to warfighters, defense policymakers, and force planners in the DoD and Intelligence Community, in support of U.S. military planning, operations, and weapons systems acquisition. DIA plans, manages, and executes intelligence operations during peacetime, crisis, and war.



Defense Logistics Agency. The Defense Logistics Agency (DLA) delivers readiness and lethality to the "Warfighter Always" and supports our Nation through quality, proactive global logistics. DLA is the Nation's combat logistics support agency that manages the end-to-end global defense supply chain – from raw materials to end user disposition – for the military services, combatant commands, other federal, state, and local agencies, and partner and allied nations.



Defense Security Cooperation Agency. The Defense Security Cooperation Agency (DSCA) advances U.S. defense and foreign policy interests by building the capacity of foreign partners in order to encourage and enable allies and partners to respond to shared challenges. DSCA's vision is to lead the Security Cooperation enterprise in delivering effective, enduring, and timely solutions, and serve as the source for security cooperation expertise and innovation for our defense and foreign policy stakeholders to ensure the United States remains the global partner of choice.



Defense Threat Reduction Agency. The Defense Threat Reduction Agency (DTRA) enables the DoD, the U.S. Government, and international partners to counter and deter Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD) and emerging threats. It enables the services and USSTRATCOM to ensure strategic deterrence is safe and credible and directly supports strategic response through nuclear readiness and modernization.



National Security Agency. The National Security Agency (NSA) provides intelligence support to military operations through signals intelligence activities, while cybersecurity personnel, products, and services ensure that military communications and data remain secure and out of the hands of our adversaries. NSA's cybersecurity mission also produces and packages the codes that secure our Nation's weapons systems. Additionally, it sets common protocols and standards so that our military can securely share information with our allies, NATO, and coalition forces around the world.



National Geospatial-Intelligence Agency. The National Geospatial-Intelligence Agency (NGA) provides geospatial intelligence for our Nation's security. NGA has a responsibility to provide the products and services that decision makers, military service members, and first responders need, when they need it most. As a member of the Intelligence Community and the Department of Defense, NGA supports a unique mission set. NGA is committed to acquiring, developing, and maintaining the proper technology, people, and processes that will enable overall mission success.



ALLIANCES AND PARTNERSHIPS

The Joint Force is significantly strengthened via a robust network of multinational alliances and partnerships. In terms of national security, alliances are formal agreements between two or more nations, formalized by means of a treaty, binding the signatories to support the other(s), particularly in time of war. Partnerships, often referred to as "strategic partnerships" are less formal than alliances and are not endorsed via treaty. Rather, partnerships are understandings between two or more nations that enable parties on both sides to learn from each other to enhance cooperation and build mutually beneficial relationships.

"Our world is at an inflection point. Global dynamics have shifted. New crises demand our attention. And in this moment of accelerating global challenges...one thing is certain: we will only succeed in advancing American interests and upholding our universal values by working in common cause with our closest allies and partners."

President Joseph R. Biden, Jr.
46th President of the United States



The United States has an unmatched network of alliances and partnerships that enables our Nation to disrupt threats before they can reach our shores and ensures peace, security, and prosperity for the American people. Some of these include:

Five Eyes. Five Eyes (FVEY) is a cooperative intelligence alliance comprised of the United States, United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand. Founded by the United Kingdom-United States of America Agreement (UKUSA) in 1946, FVEY is the world's oldest intelligence-sharing relationship, enabling partner nations to share collected multi-source intelligence to safeguard and advance common objectives and interests.

North American Aerospace Defense Command. The North American Aerospace Defense Command (NORAD) is a combined organization of the United States and Canada responsible for providing aerospace warning, air sovereignty, and protection for North America and the nations' critical infrastructure from any aerospace or maritime threat. NORAD maintains that a capable and persistent defense at home is a prerequisite to projecting power to a globally integrated forward fight. Accordingly, it engages in improving critical infrastructure resiliency, strengthening partnerships, and providing rapid, flexible options and decision space for national leaders to respond to threats against the homeland.

North Atlantic Treaty Organization. Founded in 1949 with the signing of the Washington Treaty, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) is a security alliance comprised of 30 member nations in North America and Europe. The foundational goal of this organization is to safeguard the allies' freedom and security by political and military means. At the core of the alliance is the concept that an attack against one ally is an attack against all. NATO ensures collaboration of member states to prevent and respond to global threats such as cyber-attacks, terrorism, piracy, and various forms of aggression that jeopardize the alliance and its global network of partners.

Quadrilateral Security Dialogue. Initiated in 2007 by Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe, the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, often referred to as the Quad, is a diplomatic and military arrangement between Australia, India, Japan, and the United States. Members of the Quad assert a shared vision for a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific" and a "rules-based maritime order in the East and South China seas," necessary to counter Chinese maritime claims.

Pacific Partnership. Established in 2006, the Pacific Partnership is an annual deployment of the U.S. Navy's Pacific Fleet, in coordination with regional governments, militaries, humanitarian, and other non-governmental organizations, to visit countries in the Indo-Pacific region to enhance relationships, interoperability, and security ties among the nations. The Pacific Partnership provides humanitarian, medical, dental, and civil engineering assistance to the nations of the Pacific.

State Partnership Program. The State Partnership Program (SPP), established in 1993, is a joint program of the United States DoD and individual states, territories, and the District of Columbia. The program is managed by the National Guard Bureau (NGB). The SPP matches NGB units of the various states, territories, and the District of Columbia with foreign nations around the world in support of security cooperation objectives, crisis relief, and humanitarian activities. The SPP has been successfully building relationships for over 25 years and now includes 85 partnerships with 93 nations around the globe.

Chapter 4 - WHAT IS JOINT WARFIGHTING

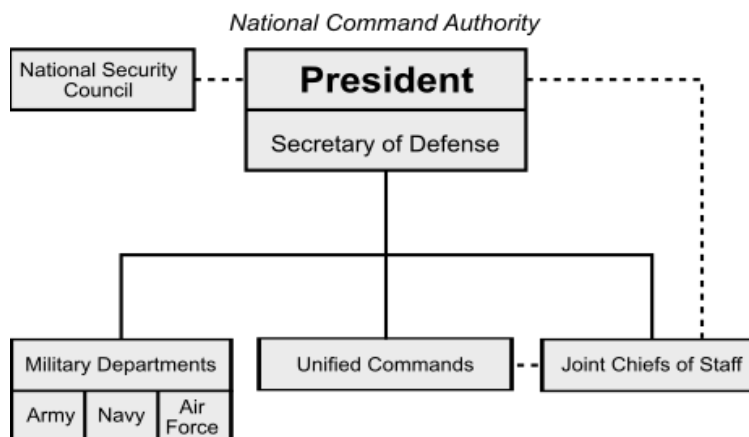
JOINT OPERATIONS OVERVIEW

A multitude of DIME-FIL factors affect national security in today's complex operating environment, requiring a whole of government approach and an atmosphere of inclusiveness to advance and safeguard vital U.S. national interests – protecting the American people, expanding America's prosperity, and realizing and defending our democratic values.

The success of joint operations requires unity of effort and unified action between military forces, governmental and nongovernmental entities, international partners, and the private sector. This necessitates that all stakeholders, regardless of service, organization, or other affiliation, coordinate activities and synchronize efforts toward common objectives.

Joint operations address regional and trans-regional threats across a dynamic geo-political landscape in which problems and mission partner interests, roles, and approaches evolve continually. In the past, militaries engaged in conflict primarily in the land, maritime, and air domains. Future conflict will likely be trans-regional, multi-domain, and multifunctional, spanning the full spectrum of the conflict and competition continuums. To defeat our adversaries and abate the advancement of our pacing threats, a coordinated and unified effort across the joint team is imperative.

Global Integration. As the global integrator, the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff considers and balances the demands and requirements of the geographic and functional commands in a complex and resource-constrained operational landscape to prepare best military advice for civil leader decisions and actions. Global integration requires a balanced, universally-oriented, and regionally-aware perspective to expand the Joint Force's competitive space both geographically and functionally across all domains. Thus, the Chairman, in collaboration with the Joint Staff and the services, "sets the globe" in force management, force readiness, and force movement by providing a global perspective on risk, assumptions, priorities, and options to inform Presidential and SecDef decision-making, setting the conditions for CCMDs at the speed of relevancy.



Mission Command and Operational Art. The primary way the Department of Defense employs two or more services, from at least two military departments, in a single operation is through joint operations. Joint operations are military actions conducted by joint forces and those service forces employed in specified command relationships with each other. A Joint Force is one composed of significant elements,

assigned or attached, of two or more military departments operating under a single Joint Force Commander (JFC) who exercises mission command.

Based on guidance from the President and SecDef, Geographic Combatant Commanders (GCCs) and Functional Combatant Commanders (FCCs) translate national security policy, strategy, and available military forces into theater and functional strategies to achieve national and regional strategic objectives. CCMD strategies are broad statements consisting of the CCCR's vision, guided by and prepared in the context of SecDef priorities outlined in the Guidance for Employment of the Force and the CJCS's objectives articulated in the National Military Strategy.

Service members at all echelons must understand mission command, defined as the conduct of military operations through decentralized execution based on mission-type orders. The three attributes of mission command – trust, understanding, and intent – ensure the disciplined initiative of subordinates to operate at the speed of the problem while providing senior leaders the decision space to better set conditions.

- ★ **Trust.** Trust is the reliance on the integrity, strength, and ability of a person or thing. In the Joint Force, trust fortifies relationships both up and down the chain of command and across services and organizations. Service members are assured that they can rely on each other based on their shared values of the Profession of Arms and joint core values.
- ★ **Understanding.** Understanding is built on continual dialogue, feedback, and investment in relationships. It entails exposure to and consideration of diverse perspectives, interests, authorities, capabilities, and policies of partners.
- ★ **Intent.** Commander's intent describes the desired end state and provides unified focus for subordinates at all levels. Service members that understand commander's intent are empowered to employ disciplined initiative in a complex, fast-paced, and unpredictable operational environment.

Mission command enables speed, agility, and decisiveness of the Joint Force. When effectively highlighted and employed, the three attributes of mission command assure empowerment of stakeholders as well as harmony and effectiveness of joint operations.

PRINCIPLES OF JOINT OPERATIONS

The Principles of Joint Operations are formed around the nine traditional Principles of War – Objective, Offensive, Mass, Maneuver, Economy of Force, Unity of Command, Security, Surprise, and Simplicity. Three additional principles – Restraint, Perseverance, and Legitimacy – are relevant to how the Armed Forces of the United States use combat power across the range of military operations. These principles are rules and guidelines that represent fundamental truths in the practice of war and military operations.

Objective. The purpose of specifying the objective is to direct every military operation toward a clearly defined, decisive, and achievable goal. The purpose of military operations is to achieve the military objectives that support attainment of the overall political goals of the conflict. This frequently involves the destruction of the enemy armed forces' capabilities and their will to fight. The objective of joint operations not involving this destruction might be more difficult to define; nonetheless, it too must be clear from the beginning. Objectives must directly, quickly, and economically contribute to the purpose of the operation. Each operation must contribute to strategic objectives. Additionally, changes to the military objectives may occur because political and military leaders gain a better understanding of the situation, or they may occur because the situation itself changes. The changes may be very subtle, but if not made, achievement of the military objectives may no longer support the political goals, legitimacy may be undermined, and force security may be compromised.

Offensive. The purpose of an offensive action is to seize, retain, and exploit the initiative. Offensive action is the most effective and decisive way to achieve a clearly defined objective. Offensive operations are the means by which a military force seizes and holds the initiative while maintaining freedom of action and achieving decisive results. The importance of offensive action is fundamentally true across all levels of war. Commanders adopt the defensive only as a temporary expedient and must seek every opportunity to seize or regain the initiative. An offensive spirit must be inherent in the conduct of all defensive operations.

Mass. The purpose of mass is to concentrate the effects of combat power at the most advantageous place and time to produce decisive results. To achieve mass, appropriate Joint Force capabilities are integrated and synchronized where they will have a decisive effect in a short period of time. Mass often must be sustained to have the desired effect. Massing effects of combat power, rather than concentrating forces, can enable even numerically inferior forces to produce decisive results and minimize human losses and waste of resources.

Maneuver. The purpose of maneuver is to place the enemy in a position of disadvantage through the flexible application of combat power. Maneuver is the movement of forces in relation to the enemy to secure or retain positional advantage, usually to deliver—or threaten delivery of—the direct and indirect fires of the maneuvering force. Effective maneuver keeps the enemy off balance, thus also protecting the friendly force. It contributes materially to exploiting successes, preserving freedom of action, and reducing vulnerability by continually posing new problems for the enemy.

Economy of Force. The purpose of economy of force is to expend minimum essential combat power on secondary efforts in order to allocate the maximum possible combat power on primary efforts. Economy of force is the judicious employment and distribution of forces. It is the measured allocation of available combat power to such tasks as limited attacks, defense, delays, deception, or even retrograde operations to achieve mass elsewhere at the decisive point and time.

Unity of Command. The purpose of unity of command is to ensure unity of effort under one responsible commander for every objective. Unity of command means that all forces operate under a single commander with the requisite authority to direct all forces employed in pursuit of a common purpose. During multinational operations and interagency coordination, unity of command may not be possible, but the requirement for unity of effort becomes paramount. Unity of effort—the coordination and cooperation toward common objectives, even if the participants are not necessarily part of the same command or organization—is the product of successful unified action.

Security. The purpose of security is to prevent the enemy from acquiring unexpected advantage. Security enhances freedom of action by reducing friendly vulnerability to hostile acts, influence, or surprise. Security results from the measures taken by commanders to protect their forces. Staff planning and an understanding of enemy strategy, tactics, and doctrine enhance security. Risk is inherent in military operations. Application of this principle includes prudent risk management, not undue caution.

Surprise. The purpose of surprise is to strike at a time or place or in a manner for which the enemy is unprepared. Surprise can help the commander shift the balance of combat power, thus achieving success well out of proportion to the effort expended. Factors contributing to surprise include speed in decision-making, information sharing and force movement, effective intelligence, deception, application of unexpected combat power, operations security, and variations in tactics and methods of operation.

Simplicity. The purpose of simplicity is to increase the probability that plans and operations will be executed as intended by preparing clear, uncomplicated plans and concise orders. Simplicity contributes to successful operations. Simple plans and clear, concise orders minimize misunderstanding and

confusion. When other factors are equal, the simplest plan is preferable. Simplicity in plans allows better understanding and execution planning at all echelons. Simplicity and clarity of expression greatly facilitate mission execution in the stress, fatigue, fog of war, and complexities of modern combat, and are especially critical to success in multinational operations.

Restraint. The purpose of restraint is to limit collateral damage and prevent the unnecessary use of force. A single act could cause significant military and political consequences; therefore, judicious use of force is necessary. Restraint requires the careful and disciplined balancing of the need for security, the conduct of military operations, and the national strategic end state. Failure to understand and comply with established Rules of Engagement (ROEs) can result in fratricide, mission failure, or national embarrassment. Restraint is best achieved when ROEs issued at the beginning of an operation address the most anticipated situations that may arise.

Perseverance. The purpose of perseverance is to ensure the commitment necessary to attain the national strategic end state. Perseverance involves preparation for measured, protracted military operations in pursuit of the national strategic end state. Some joint operations may require years to reach the termination criteria. The underlying causes of the crisis may be elusive, making it difficult to achieve decisive resolution. The patient, resolute, and persistent pursuit of national goals and objectives often is essential to success. This will frequently involve diplomatic, economic, and informational measures to supplement military efforts.

Legitimacy. The purpose of legitimacy is to maintain legal and moral authority in the conduct of operations. Legitimacy, which can be a decisive factor in operations, is based on the actual and perceived legality, morality, and rightness of the actions from the various perspectives of interested audiences. These audiences include national leadership, domestic populations, governments in the operational area, and nations and organizations around the world. Committed forces must sustain the legitimacy of the operation and the host government, where applicable. Security actions must be balanced with legitimacy concerns. All actions must be considered in the light of potentially competing strategic and tactical requirements, and must exhibit fairness in dealing with competing factions where appropriate.

For more information: [*JP 3-0, Joint Campaigns and Operations*](#)

- https://jdeis.js.mil/jdeis/new_pubs/jp3_0.pdf

JOINT FUNCTIONS

A joint function is a grouping of capabilities and activities that enable Joint Force Commanders to synchronize, integrate, and direct joint operations. There are seven joint functions common to joint operations: command and control (C2), information, intelligence, fires, movements and maneuver, protection, and sustainment. Commanders leverage the capabilities of multiple joint functions during operations. The joint functions apply to all joint operations across the competition continuum and enable both traditional and information warfare, but to different degrees, conditions, and standards, while employing different tactics, techniques, and procedures. The integration of activities across joint functions to accomplish tasks and missions occurs at all levels of command. Joint functions reinforce and complement one another, and integration across them is essential to mission accomplishment.

- ★ **Command and Control.** C2 encompasses the exercise of authority and direction by a commander over assigned and attached forces to accomplish the mission. The JFC provides operational vision, guidance, and direction to the joint force.
- ★ **Information.** The information function encompasses the management and application of information to support achievement of objectives. It is the deliberate integration with other joint functions to change or maintain perceptions, attitudes, and other elements that drive desired

relevant actor behaviors and to support human and automated decision making.

- ★ **Intelligence.** The intelligence function informs JFCs about adversary intentions, capabilities, centers of gravity, critical factors, vulnerabilities, and future courses of action and helps commanders and staffs understand friendly, neutral, and threat networks.
- ★ **Fires.** Fires is the use of weapon systems or other actions to create specific lethal or non-lethal effects on a target or objects of influence in accordance with U.S. and international law. Joint fires are delivered during the employment of forces from two or more components in coordinated action to produce desired results in support of a common objective.
- ★ **Movement and Maneuver.** The movement and maneuver function encompasses the disposition of joint forces to conduct operations by securing positional or informational advantages across the competition continuum and exploiting tactical success to achieve operational and strategic objectives.
- ★ **Protection.** Protection is all efforts to secure and defend the effectiveness and survivability of mission-related military and non-military personnel, equipment, facilities, information, and infrastructure deployed or located within or outside the boundaries of a given operational area to maintain mission effectiveness.
- ★ **Sustainment.** Sustainment is the provision of logistics and personnel services support to maintain operations through mission accomplishment and redeployment of the force. Sustainment gives the JFC the means for freedom of action, endurance, and extending operational reach.

For more information: [*JP 3-0, Joint Campaigns and Operations*](#)

- https://jdeis.js.mil/jdeis/new_pubs/jp3_0.pdf

THE JOINT SERVICE MEMBER

The success of joint operations hinges on the competence and professionalism of the individual members of the Joint Force. Accordingly, the greatest and most valuable competitive advantage the Joint Force maintains in a high-end fight is the individual service member that has dedicated their purpose and industry to the Profession of Arms. The service members that comprise the most distinguished and capable military force in the world adhere to the following Joint Core Values:

- ★ **Duty.** Duty is our foremost value. It binds us together and conveys our moral commitment or obligation as defenders of the Constitution and servants of the Nation. As members of the Profession of Arms, we fulfill our duty without consideration of self-interest, sacrificing our lives if needed. From duty comes responsibility.
- ★ **Honor.** Honor is the code of behavior that defines the ethical fulfillment of our duties. It is that quality that guides us to exemplify ethical and moral behavior; never to lie, cheat or steal; to abide by an uncompromising code of integrity, to respect human dignity; to have respect and concern for each other. It is the quality of maturity, dedication, trust, and dependability that commits members of the Profession of Arms to act responsibly, to be accountable for actions, to fulfill obligations, and to hold others accountable for their actions.
- ★ **Courage.** The United States of America is blessed with service members whose courage knows no boundaries. Even in warfare characterized by advanced technology, individual fighting spirit and courage remain essential. Courage has both physical and moral aspects, encompassing both bravery and fortitude.

- Physical Courage has, throughout history, defined warriors. It is the ability to confront

physical pain, hardship, death, or threat of death. Physical courage in a leader is most often expressed in a willingness to act, even alone if necessary, in situations of danger and uncertainty.

- Moral courage is the ability to act rightly in the face of popular opposition, or discouragement. This includes the willingness to stand up for what one believes to be right even if that stand is unpopular or contrary to conventional wisdom. This involves risk taking, tenacity, and accountability.
- ★ **Integrity.** Integrity is the quality of being honest and having strong moral principles. Integrity is the bedrock of our character and the cornerstone for building trust. Trust is an essential trait among service members—trust by seniors in the abilities of their subordinates and by juniors in the competence and support of their seniors. American service members must be able to rely on each other, regardless of the challenge at hand; they must individually and collectively say what they mean and do what they say.
- ★ **Selfless Service.** Selfless service epitomizes the quality of putting our Nation, our military mission(s), and others before ourselves. Members of the Profession of Arms do not serve to pursue fame, position, or money. They give of themselves for the greater good. Selfless service is the enabler of teamwork, the cooperative effort by the members of a group to achieve common goals.

Members of the Armed Forces of the United States must internalize and embody these values of the Profession of Arms. Their adherence to duty, honor, courage, integrity, and selfless service helps promulgate a joint warfighting mindset, producing a synergy that multiplies the effects of individual actions. They are the cornerstones of the freedom that we secure across the globe.

For more information: [*Guidance on Fostering Professionalism within the Department of Defense*](#)

- https://comptroller.defense.gov/Portals/45/documents/micp_docs/Topical/OSD001895-15_FOD_Final.pdf

CODE OF CONDUCT FOR MEMBERS OF THE U.S. ARMED FORCES

I. I am an American, fighting in the forces which guard my country and our way of life. I am prepared to give my life in their defense.

II. I will never surrender of my own free will. If in command, I will never surrender the members of my command while they still have the means to resist.

III. If I am captured I will continue to resist by all means available. I will make every effort to escape and aid others to escape. I will accept neither parole nor special favors from the enemy.

IV. If I become a prisoner of war, I will keep faith with my fellow prisoners. I will give no information or take part in any action which might be harmful to my comrades. If I am senior, I will take command. If not, I will obey the lawful orders of those appointed over me and will back them up in every way.

V. When questioned, should I become a prisoner of war, I am required to give name, rank, service number and date of birth. I will evade answering further questions to the utmost of my ability. I will make no oral or written statements disloyal to my country and its allies or harmful to their cause.

VI. I will never forget that I am an American, fighting for freedom, responsible for my actions, and dedicated to the principles which made my country free. I will trust in my God and in the United States of America.

For more information: [*Executive Orders | National Archives*](#)

- <https://www.archives.gov/federal-register/codification/executive-order/10631.html>

Chapter 5 - HOW THE AIR FORCE FITS INTO THE JOINT FIGHT

AIR FORCE FUNCTIONS

The Department of the Air Force (DAF) is composed of air, space, and cyber forces and is responsible to organize, train, and equip forces to project power for the conduct of prompt and sustained combat operations, military engagement, and security cooperation in defense of the Nation. In a variety of capacities, Total Force Airmen support the other military services and the Joint Force. The Air Force provides the Nation with global vigilance, global reach, and global power in the form of in-place, forward based, and expeditionary forces. These forces possess the capacity to deter aggression and violence by state, non-state, and individual actors to prevent conflict. Should deterrence fail, the Air Force stands ready to prosecute the full range of military operations in support of U.S. national interests.

In addition to service functions common to each military branch, the Air Force develops concepts, doctrine, tactics, techniques, and procedures to deliver forces to perform the following specific functions:

- ★ Conduct nuclear operations in support of strategic deterrence, to include providing and maintaining nuclear surety and capabilities.
- ★ Conduct offensive and defensive operations, to include appropriate air and missile defense, to gain and maintain air superiority and air supremacy as required, to enable the conduct of operations by U.S. and allied land, sea, air, space, and special operations forces.
- ★ Conduct global precision attack, to include strategic attack, interdiction, close air support, and prompt global strike.
- ★ Provide timely, globally integrated intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance capability and capacity from forward deployed locations and globally distributed centers to support world-wide operations.
- ★ Provide rapid global mobility to employ and sustain organic air and space forces and other military service and U. S. Special Operations Command forces, as directed, to include airlift forces for airborne operations, air logistical support, tanker forces for in-flight refueling, and assets for aeromedical evacuation.
- ★ Provide agile combat support to enhance the air and space campaign and the deployment, employment, sustainment, and redeployment of air and space forces and other forces operating within the air and space domains, to include joint air and space bases, and for the Armed Forces other than which is organic to the individual military services and U.S. Special Operations Command in coordination with the other military services, combatant commands, and U.S. Government departments and agencies.
- ★ Conduct global personnel recovery operations including theater-wide combat and civil search and rescue in coordination with the other military services, combatant commands, and DoD components.
- ★ Conduct globally integrated command and control for air and space operations.

"If we lose war in the air, we lose the war, and we lose it quickly."

Field Marshal Bernard Montgomery
1887-1976



For more information: [DoD Directive 5100.1, Reference a](#)

- <https://www.esd.whs.mil/Portals/54/Documents/DD/issuances/dodd/510001p.pdf>

AIR FORCE CORE MISSIONS

Since the birth of our service, we have trained, built, and employed the world's most skilled Airmen, who, in various roles, support or directly conduct combat operations. Operations that Airmen are involved in also incorporate the men and women of our sister services.

At its founding on September 18, 1947, the Air Force was assigned a set of five core functions and tasked with providing those distinct capabilities to complement the roles of our sister services in a joint endeavor. Though the core missions of the Air Force have been re-designated since that time, they have not changed fundamentally. These specific missions pinpoint the Air Force's unique role within the joint team and assure our brothers and sisters in arms that we can deliver. Joint organizations are comprised of a varied mix of service personnel, assets, and capabilities; thus, it is imperative that Airmen understand what they bring to the fight. Airmen must know that they can be counted on to deliver:

- ★ Air Superiority
- ★ Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR)
- ★ Rapid Global Mobility
- ★ Global Strike
- ★ Command & Control

There is no shortage of examples in our service's storied history of what Airmen have achieved through the execution of our core missions. It is essential that they understand how these missions have been employed in concert with those of the other services and how they have contributed to Joint Force objectives.

Air Superiority. Control of the air domain is crucial to the success of modern and emergent warfare. For decades, combatant commanders have come to rely on the mission-essential protection that Air Superiority ensures. The opening offensive of OPERATION DESERT STORM serves well to illustrate this point. In August 1990, coalition forces launched 812 combat sorties within a 24-hour period, effectively neutralizing Iraq's command and control capability. Within 25 days, the Iraqi Air Force halted flight operations entirely, freeing the coalition of concern over any credible enemy air attack. From the outset, Air Superiority effectively destroyed Iraq's warfighting capability, ensuring a protected military offensive on the ground. USAF Chief of Staff, General Merrill "Tony" McPeak, asserted, "The Iraqi Air Force never recovered from the opening attack. We took the initiative at the beginning, and we held it throughout the war."

Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance. Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) provides situational awareness of the battlespace, allowing decision space for command elements. ISR played a crucial role in providing a holistic picture and developing a common operational graphic during OPERATION UNIFIED RESPONSE in January 2010. The operation was launched after a 7.0 magnitude earthquake struck Haiti, killing more than 316,000 people and collapsing more than 100,000 structures. During this operation, a wide array of intelligence disciplines contributed to damage assessment, identification of ports of access and travel routes, and protection of relief workers. Imagery provided from unmanned aerial vehicles and satellites, as well as open source and human intelligence gathered on the ground, helped planners determine how to get relief workers and supplies where they were needed and to ensure their safety once in country. The employment of ISR enabled ground forces to execute the operation's objectives, providing relief rapidly and effectively to survivors and saving lives.

Rapid Global Mobility. American power can be projected quickly to anywhere on the face of the earth because of the Air Force's capability for rapid mobility. During OPERATION JUST CAUSE, a joint operation to oust the Panamanian leader Manuel Noriega, who was wanted in the U.S. for racketeering and drug trafficking, the Air Force's rapid global reach was on display. The Air Force launched critical Joint Force elements from bases such as Charleston Air Force Base, used for personnel and supply transport, and Pope Air Force Base, used to deploy Army Rangers from the 82d Airborne Division. Overall, the Air Force employed 80 C-141, 22 C-130, and 11 C-5 aircraft which played a crucial role in OPERATION JUST CAUSE ending in just over 40 days. Rapid Global Mobility's effects safeguarded the lives of 30,000 U.S. citizens residing in Panama, protected the integrity of the Panama Canal, helped the Panamanian opposition establish genuine democracy, and brought Noriega to justice.

Global Strike. The Air Force demonstrated its command of Global Strike during the North Atlantic Treaty Organization's (NATO) 1995 offensive, OPERATION DELIBERATE FORCE. This three-week campaign targeted military capabilities of the Army of the Serb Republic, which had, throughout the Bosnian War, persisted in indiscriminately attacking United Nations-designated "safe zones." Partnered with 15 nations as well as ground and naval forces, U.S. aircraft flew roughly two-thirds of the operation's 3,515 sorties, hitting 97 percent of intended targets and destroying or significantly damaging 80 percent of them. After just three weeks since the dropping of the first bomb, the war's aggressors were prepared for serious negotiations. Ambassador Richard Holbrook, special negotiator to the Balkans, stated of the campaign, "without the United States Air Force and Navy and precision bombing," diplomatic efforts would not have succeeded.

Command and Control. Airmen employ the Air Force's other four interdependent and enduring core missions through robust, adaptable, and survivable Command and Control systems. This vital core function was evident in OPERATION ODYSSEY DAWN which offered protection to the people of Libya from attacks by its dictator, Muammar Al-Qaddafi. A complement of unique service capabilities secured mission success. While the U.S. Navy played a critical role in command and control with the placement of the USS Mount Whitney in the Mediterranean, the Air Force's employment of E-3 Airborne Warning and Control System (AWACS) and the E-8 Joint Surveillance Target Attack Radar System (JSTARS) coupled with our service's innate use of Air Operations Centers eventually brought down Al-Qaddafi and his regime.

For more information: [*The Enlisted Force Structure*](#); [*Global Vigilance*](#), [*Global Reach*](#), [*Global Power for America*](#)

- https://www.doctrine.af.mil/Portals/61/documents/Airman_Development/BrownBook.pdf
- https://www.af.mil/Portals/1/documents/af%20events/2015/newGV_GR_GP_PRINT.pdf

JOINT OPERATIONS ACROSS ALL DOMAINS

Total Force Airmen are engaged both directly and indirectly in support of joint operations across all domains every minute of every day. Domains are those spheres of activity or influence that have common and distinct characteristics in which a force can conduct joint functions. To achieve strategic objectives, technicians in every field – air, space, cyber, security, logistics, information, administration, maintenance, etc. – play a critical role in reinforcing the Joint Force.

The Air Force's ability to operate is challenged by anti-access and area denial threats and the rapid proliferation of advanced technologies that restrict freedom of maneuver. Airmen do not fight alone, and Joint Force operations are increasingly interconnected, interdependent, and challenged. Success in this operating environment requires the convergence of effects globally and across all domains to consecutively or simultaneously present an adversary with multiple dilemmas, those situations in which one must make a difficult choice between two or more alternatives often equally undesirable.

Synergistic employment of capabilities in different domains enhances effectiveness and compensates for vulnerabilities, creating outcomes not readily attainable through single-domain action. Such dilemmas, when presented at an operational tempo that complicates or negates an adversary's response, enable the Joint Force to operate inside an adversary's decision cycle. Joint All Domain Operations (JADO) occur in air, land, maritime, cyberspace, space, and electromagnetic spectrum domains. When the Joint Force synchronizes action across multiple domains, integrated in planning and execution and at the speed needed to gain advantage, it achieves mission success.

For more information: [*AFDP 3-99, SDP 3-99 The Department of the Air Force Role in Joint All-Domain Operations; Joint Doctrine Home*](#)

- https://www.doctrine.af.mil/Portals/61/documents/AFDP_3-99/AFDP%203-99%20DAF%20role%20in%20JADO.pdf
- <https://www.jcs.mil/Doctrine/>

CONCLUSION

Airmen comprise an integral part of a larger team, made up of other military services, departments, and institutions of the federal government as well as allies and partners around the world. The Joint Force, through seamless integration of all components, advances national security against any and all threats to the American people and Nation's interests. Our "one fight" is our effort to deter, and if necessary, prevail in a conflict against strategic competitors. We must adapt our force design to address these and other pacing threats that challenge our Nation.

All service members must understand the importance of the Joint Force's contribution to advancing national objectives and recognize their role in fusing unique service capabilities when called upon. Jointness is not a concept; it is an agile, deliberate, and diverse integration of the strengths of all services that brings together the tools and resources needed to complement the other elements to advance our strategic objectives. Jointness is fused in military operations from the strategic to the tactical level, and each service member has a unique role within the joint mission.

The Joint Team, grounded in doctrine and aligned in purpose and values, assures mission success in all operations, from peacekeeping, to humanitarian need, to national security imperatives. All service members must do their part to educate and sharpen themselves, their fellow service members, and the joint partners they work alongside. The ability of the Joint Force to operate at its maximum effectiveness requires that all warfighters bring their best.

UNITED STATES MILITARY RANKS

Enlisted Ranks

	E-1	E-2	E-3	E-4	E-5	E-6	E-7	E-8	E-9	Special					
Army	Private (PV1)	Private (PV2)	Private First Class (PFC)	Corporal (CPL) 	Sergeant (SGT)	Staff Sergeant (SSG)	Sergeant First Class (SFC)	Master Sergeant (MSG)	First Sergeant (1SG)	Sergeant Major (SGM)	Command Sergeant Major (CSM)	Sergeant Major of the Army (SMA)	Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman (SEAC)		
	No Insignia														
Marines	Private (Pvt)	Private First Class (PFC)	Lance Corporal (LCpl)	Corporal (Cpl)	Sergeant (Sgt)	Staff Sergeant (SSgt)	Gunnery Sergeant (GySgt)	Master Sergeant (MSGt)	First Sergeant (1stSgt)	Master Gunnery Sergeant (MGySgt)	Sergeant Major (SgtMaj)	Sergeant Major of the Marine Corps (SMMC)	Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman (SEAC)		
	No Insignia														
Navy	Seaman Recruit (SR)	Seaman Apprentice (SA)	Seaman (SN)	Petty Officer Third Class (PO3)	Petty Officer Second Class (PO2)	Petty Officer First Class (PO1)	Chief Petty Officer (CPO)	Senior Chief Petty Officer (SCPO)	Command Senior Chief Petty Officer (CMDSC)	Master Chief Petty Officer (MCPO)	Command Master Chief Petty Officer (CMDCM)	Force/Fleet Master Chief Petty Officer (FORMC) (FLTMC)	Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman (SEAC)		
	No Insignia														
Air Force	Airman Basic (AB)	Airman (Airmn)	Airman First Class (A1C)	Senior Airman (SrA)	Staff Sergeant (SSgt)	Technical Sergeant (TSgt)	Master Sergeant (MSgt)	First Sergeant (MSgt)	Senior Master Sergeant (SMSgt)	First Sergeant (SMSgt)	Chief Master Sergeant (CMSgt)	First Sergeant (CMSgt)	Command Chief Master Sergeant (CCM)	Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force (CMSAF)	Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman (SEAC)
	No Insignia														
Space Force	Specialist 1 (Spc 1)	Specialist 2 (Spc 2)	Specialist 3 (Spc 3)	Specialist 4 (Spc 4)	Sergeant (Sgt)	Technical Sergeant (TSgt)	Master Sergeant (MSgt)	Senior Master Sergeant (SMSgt)	Chief Master Sergeant (CMSgt)	Chief Master Sergeant of the Space Force (CMSSF)	Senior Enlisted Advisor to the Chairman (SEAC)	No Insignia			
	No Insignia														
Coast Guard	Seaman Recruit (SR)	Seaman Apprentice (SA)	Seaman (SN)	Petty Officer Third Class (PO3)	Petty Officer Second Class (PO2)	Petty Officer First Class (PO1)	Chief Petty Officer (CPO)	Senior Chief Petty Officer (SCPO)	Master Chief Petty Officer (MCPO)	Fleet/Command Master Chief (CMC)	Master Chief Petty Officer of the Coast Guard (MCPOCG)	No Insignia			
															

Officer Ranks

	O-1	O-2	O-3	O-4	O-5	O-6	O-7	O-8	O-9	O-10	Special
Army	Second Lieutenant (2LT) 	First Lieutenant (1LT) 	Captain (CPT) 	Major (MAJ) 	Lieutenant Colonel (LTC) 	Colonel (COL) 	Brigadier General (BG) 	Major General (MG) 	Lieutenant General (LTG) 	General (GEN) 	General of the Army (GA)
Marines	Second Lieutenant (2nd Lt) 	First Lieutenant (1st Lt) 	Captain (Capt) 	Major (Maj) 	Lieutenant Colonel (Lt Col) 	Colonel (Col) 	Brigadier General (BGen) 	Major General (Maj Gen) 	Lieutenant General (Lt Gen) 	General (Gen) 	Not Used
Navy	Ensign (ENS) 	Lieutenant Junior Grade (LTJG) 	Lieutenant (LT) 	Lieutenant Commander (LCDR) 	Commander (CDR) 	Captain (CAPT) 	Rear Admiral (RDML) 	Rear Admiral (RADM) 	Vice Admiral (VADM) 	Admiral (ADM) 	Fleet Admiral (FADM)
Air Force	Second Lieutenant (2d Lt) 	First Lieutenant (1st Lt) 	Captain (Capt) 	Major (Maj) 	Lieutenant Colonel (Lt Col) 	Colonel (Col) 	Brigadier General (Brig Gen) 	Major General (Maj Gen) 	Lieutenant General (Lt Gen) 	General (Gen) 	General of the Air Force (GAF)
Space Force	Second Lieutenant (2d Lt) 	First Lieutenant (1st Lt) 	Captain (Capt) 	Major (Maj) 	Lieutenant Colonel (Lt Col) 	Colonel (Col) 	Brigadier General (Brig Gen) 	Major General (Maj Gen) 	Lieutenant General (Lt Gen) 	General (Gen) 	Not Used
Coast Guard	Ensign (ENS) 	Lieutenant Junior Grade (LTJG) 	Lieutenant (LT) 	Lieutenant Commander (LCDR) 	Commander (CDR) 	Captain (CAPT) 	Rear Admiral (RDML) 	Rear Admiral (RADM) 	Vice Admiral (VADM) 	Admiral (ADM) 	Not Used

Warrant Officer Ranks

Army					Navy				
W-1 Warrant Officer (WO1) 	W-2 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO2) 	W-3 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO3) 	W-4 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO4) 	W-5 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO5) 	W-1 Warrant Officer (WO1) 	W-2 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO2) 	W-3 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO3) 	W-4 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO4) 	W-5 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO5)
Marines					Coast Guard				
W-1 Warrant Officer (WO) 	W-2 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO2) 	W-3 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO3) 	W-4 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO4) 	W-5 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO5) 	W-1 Not Used	W-2 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO2) 	W-3 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO3) 	W-4 Chief Warrant Officer (CWO4) 	W-5 Not Used
Air Force					Space Force				
Not Used					Not Used				

REFERENCES

[*AFDP 3-99, SDP 3-99, The Department of the Air Force Role in Joint All-Domain Operations*](#) 19 November 2021

[*The Combined Joint Task Forces Concept*](#) Accessed June 2022

[*Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1958*](#) 6 August 1958

[*DoD Dictionary of Military and Associated Terms*](#) August 2022

[*DoD Directive 5100.1, Reference a*](#) 21 December 2010

[*The Enlisted Force Structure*](#) 16 May 2022

[*Executive Orders | National Archives*](#) 5 March 2003

[*The First Gulf War*](#) Accessed June 2022

[*Global Vigilance, Global Reach, Global Power for America*](#) March-April 2014

[*Guidance on Fostering Professionalism within the Department of Defense*](#) 12 February 2015

[*H.R.3622 - Goldwater-Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1986*](#) 1 October 1986

[*Joint Doctrine Home*](#) Accessed June 2022

[*The Joint Staff*](#) Accessed June 2022

[*JP 1, Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States*](#) 25 March 2013

[*JP 3-0, Joint Campaigns and Operations*](#) 18 June 2022

[*JP 3-30, Joint Air Operations*](#) 17 September 2021

[*JP 3-33, Joint Task Force Headquarters*](#) 31 January 2018

[*JP 5-0, Joint Planning*](#) 1 December 2020

[*National Security Act of 1947*](#) 26 July 1947

[*The Noncommissioned Officer and Petty Officer*](#) 2014, National Defense University Press

[*Title 10, U.S. Code*](#) 10 August 1956



U.S. AIR FORCE

THE CASE FOR CHANGE



**OPTIMIZING THE AIR FORCE FOR
GREAT POWER COMPETITION**

A LEGACY OF ADAPTATION

The United States faces a time of consequence marked by significant shifts in the strategic environment. With maturing domains like space, cyber, and information warfare gaining prominence, the global landscape is more complex and dynamic than ever before. Heightened risks of major conflicts; uncertain air, space, and cyber superiority; rapid technological change; employment of asymmetric means; and enduring fiscal pressure all underscore the need for urgent and focused enterprise-level efforts to address these challenges effectively. To remain ready, the United States Air Force must change.

The Air Force has a rich history of successfully reckoning with transformational change. Since its inception in 1947, it has consistently evolved by reorienting and “reoptimizing” itself to align with dynamically changing demands at key inflection points. During the Cold War era, when confronting the Soviet Union, the Air Force embraced advanced conventional technology to overcome Soviet conventional mass while also prioritizing nuclear readiness for strategic deterrence. During the Unipolar Moment—after the fall of the Berlin Wall and the success of Desert Storm—in light of a perceived reduction in the global threat, the Air Force optimized for regional threats and coercive operations by prioritizing efficiency and cost savings. Following the aftermath of the terrorist attacks of September 11th, the Air Force optimized for flexibility and prioritized tailored support to the Joint Force, largely supporting uncontested, ground-centric operations to counter violent extremism.

Today, a new key inflection point is upon us. We cannot afford to be complacent, holding on to outdated structures. The Air Force built for the previous era is no longer optimized for the current strategic landscape. History has shown that we can successfully navigate these turning points—now is the time to do so again. Our motivation is crystal clear: change is not an option but a necessity. We must adapt to effectively demonstrate our readiness and capability to deter, and, if required, to prevail in conflict.

Four core areas demand our attention: how we develop our people, generate readiness, project power, and develop capabilities. These pillars define our path forward. To forge ahead, we must prioritize organizational alignment, streamline decision-making, and place mission outcomes above narrow functional competence. This journey requires rigorous self-assessment, transparent communication, and a resilient, adaptable institution. Equally important is building a dedicated workforce to ensure we attract, train, and retain the best. Throughout its history, the United States Air Force has thrived by embracing adaptability and change.

As we confront this new strategic environment, we must be true to our legacy and rise to meet the challenge.



A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "D. W. Allvin".

David W. Allvin
General, USAF
Chief of Staff

OPTIMIZING FOR THE COLD WAR

During the Cold War, the United States and the Soviet Union were locked in a period of heightened geopolitical tension and competition, marked by an escalating nuclear and conventional arms race. The US prioritized developing stealth and precision technologies to offset its numerical inferiority in conventional forces, seeking a qualitative military advantage.

DEVELOP PEOPLE



Deterrence-focused Airmen with an “always at war” ethos. Pre-positioned, standardized, and trained for rapid, large-scale mobilization. Practiced experts in their specific task set.

GENERATE READINESS



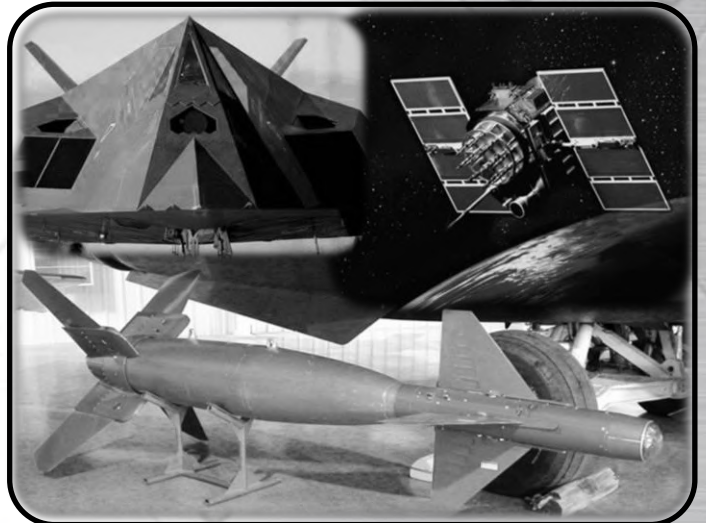
Realistic, threat-informed, high-end training; large-scale mobilization exercises; and responsive nuclear alert forces regularly assessed for readiness.

PROJECT POWER



Extensive network of overseas basing with a large forward presence to enable rapid mobilization. Heavy reliance on strategic nuclear forces to deter adversary aggression.

DEVELOP CAPABILITIES



Development of stealth aircraft, precision-guided weapons, and persistent space capabilities to offset Soviet conventional quantitative overmatch with American technological superiority.

OPTIMIZING FOR THE UNIPOLAR MOMENT

The success of the Gulf War, coupled with the dissolution of the Soviet Union, marked the end of the Cold War, driving the US military and USAF transformation. Amid this Unipolar Moment, the US military massively downsized while utilizing the flexibility of airpower in a series of campaigns seen in the Balkans, the former Republic of Yugoslavia, and Iraq.

DEVELOP PEOPLE



Increasingly specialized Airmen for technical and operational proficiency in expeditionary roles. Total Force Airmen dramatically decreased as part of overall US military "Peace Dividend" drawdown.

GENERATE READINESS



Readiness regionally focused, rotational, and marked by episodic air campaigns. Nuclear stockpiles downsized and alert posture deemphasized in favor of conventional employment on a rotational basis.

PROJECT POWER



Massive force build-up—completed on US timeline and marked by uncontested delivery of military assets. Overseas basing consolidated and CENTCOM infrastructure surged.

DEVELOP CAPABILITIES



Lacking a peer adversary, capabilities development increasingly tailored to achieve industrial efficiencies. Less frequent major weapons procurement driven by increasing requirements.



OPTIMIZING FOR COUNTERING VIOLENT EXTREMISM

The terrorist attacks on September 11th, 2001, marked a new era centered on the “Global War on Terrorism” (GWOT). Innovations in technology and tactics focused on emergent requirements driving the USAF to optimize its capabilities and support the Joint Force through on-demand power projection and sustainment accomplished by continuous rotational deployments.

DEVELOP PEOPLE



Highly adaptable Airmen deployed to unique operational environments, consistently performing non-traditional roles and rapidly acquiring skillsets outside of their initial training.

GENERATE READINESS



Optimized supply chains for efficiency and continuous employment of rotational forces, enabling sustained engagements while managing operational demands.

PROJECT POWER



Uncontested air domain control achieved through flexible and highly customizable capabilities tailored for specific and diverse mission requirements.

DEVELOP CAPABILITIES



Expedited acquisition processes driven by urgent operational requirements necessitating flexibility and adaptability across multiple domains.



CURRENT ENVIRONMENT

Today, the Air Force once again finds itself at a critical juncture—an era of Great Power Competition marked by a new security environment, a rapidly evolving character of war, and a formidable competitor. Continued Air Force dominance in this new era requires understanding its challenges and the attributes needed to succeed. Only then can we meet the demands of high-end conflict.

The **current security environment** is dynamic and characterized by aggressive state actors and transnational threats. The People's Republic of China's (PRC's) military advancements threaten our intended mode of warfare and utilize assertive strategies to impose costs and deny US power projection capabilities. Concurrently, Russian aggression imperils European stability, openly challenging established norms and the rules-based international order. These challenges are unfolding against the backdrop of resurging tensions in the Middle East, marked by conflicts among key states and multiple extremist groups, and further compounded by the provocative actions of North Korea.

The **character of war** is also swiftly evolving. Competitors now routinely employ asymmetric means to achieve both military and national objectives. The ascending domains of space, cyber, and information have gained prominence as viable battlespaces and expanded the ways from which our adversaries can inflict harm. New technology, such as hypersonic weapons, AI, low-cost drones, uncrewed underwater vehicles, and sophisticated cyber-attacks, challenge traditional US advantages and threaten forces at home and abroad. Finally, the expansion of nuclear capabilities, advanced delivery methods, and the emergence of a tripolar nuclear world is particularly alarming and necessitates the maintenance of a credible deterrent.

The PRC is the Air Force's most formidable competitor since the Soviet Union and perhaps in its history. For the last several decades, while the nation was focused on countering violent extremism, the PRC's military strategy was laser-focused on negating US competitive advantages. Recently, it has become a stark and compelling challenge. The PRC's long-term strategy, deeply rooted in the pursuit of "national rejuvenation," seeks to reshape the current international order, with China demonstrating astonishing growth in economic, diplomatic, military, and technological arenas.

Success in today's strategic environment requires a force **aligned and focused** on the requirements and attributes that will keep us competitive. The Air Force must deliver combat-effective, **agile and adaptive** airpower at scale. The complexity and speed at which combat may unfold demands greater preparation, and prioritizing readiness based on **mission effectiveness over functional competence** will be essential to our ability to **rapidly project and execute the mission with precision**. We must also increase the scale and complexity of our exercises and enhance internal inspections to ensure **effective and persistent self-assessment**. Similarly, we can no longer design and build the pieces of our Air Force separately and solve the integration challenges after the fact. We must pursue **deliberate integration of mission systems** in their design and ensure the platforms we build and operate align with these systems. While physical limits constrain the development and production of hardware, the responsiveness of software and mission systems is limited only by the speed of coding. The ubiquity and accessibility of data dictate that the entity capable of gaining insights and capitalizing on them faster will gain the advantage. This requires ruthless introspection to evaluate what is working and what isn't, an **enterprise focused on solutions**, and a commitment to take corrective actions and **follow through**.

OPTIMIZING FOR GREAT POWER COMPETITION

URGENT THREATS



Complex security environment defined by the PRC pacing challenge and the acute threat of Russia.

ACCELERATED CHANGE



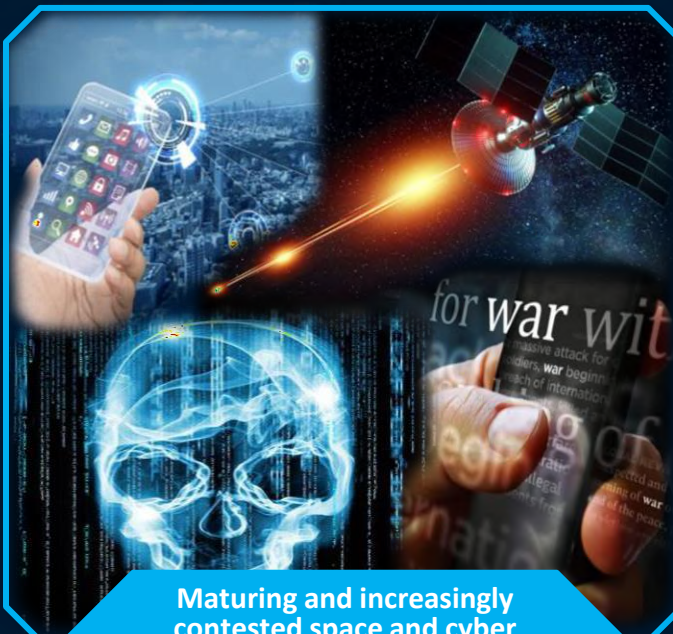
Disruptive technologies mark inflection points including low-cost drones, quantum computing, AI, and hypersonics.

CONTESTED ENVIRONMENTS



State actors engaging in aggressive and asymmetric actions, challenging traditional warfare methods.

ASCENDING DOMAINS



Maturing and increasingly contested space and cyber domains more critical to warfare's evolving character.

DEVELOP PEOPLE

Developing personnel is a deliberate priority requiring a dedicated and unified effort to attract, retain, and nurture the talent and specialized skills demanded by the emerging strategic landscape. The Air Force must cultivate Mission Ready Airmen—individuals with the expertise and versatile skillsets required to win in various operational scenarios. The personnel we need requires optimizing the force we have by **centralizing force development, reinvigorating our warrior ethos to create Mission Ready Airmen, and establishing robust and effective “paths” for technical areas critical to creating competitive advantage.**

Centralizing specific facets of force development under a single commander will streamline the coordination, integration, and execution of Air Force training and education initiatives. This centralization will enable the identification and evaluation of specific areas of Airman Development that are common and would benefit from a concentrated, integrated approach. This will ensure a more standardized Airman experience and development with a shared understanding of the threat environment. The desired outcome is the development of the right Airmen for the right place and time, a skilled cadre well-prepared for future challenges, and a cohesive workforce adept at competing effectively—poised to surge and sustain operations during times of conflict. This transition also requires the appropriate renaming of AETC to Airman Development Command, reinforcing its focus on shaping the Airmen of tomorrow.

Reinvigorating our warrior ethos and creating Mission Ready Airmen is not simply a policy or project but a deliberate, enduring necessity. It begins in Basic Military Training (BMT) and our pre-commissioning programs with education and training focused on understanding threats, Mission Command, the Air Force's role in defending against those threats, and the significance of teams with a deep grasp of the mission. It emphasizes the need to transcend syllabus-driven, technical training for specialized roles with an appreciation of their overarching role in a challenging environment and as empowered members of small teams tasked with anticipating and solving complex, undefined problems under contested conditions.

Establishing robust and effective “paths” for critical technical areas is key to sustaining a workforce equipped with deep expertise and the skills essential for maintaining competitiveness. Leveraging our nation's top talent will prove to be a decisive advantage in the era of Great Power Competition. This initiative will entail the establishment of robust and effective pathways (technical warrant officers, technical tracks, and tailored career categories) for individuals specializing in critical technical areas, notably cyber and IT career fields, vital to maintaining a competitive edge. Achieving this objective requires different incentives for Airmen who are passionate to serve and excel in highly perishable and rapidly evolving skill sets—yet may not aspire to pursue a formal leadership track.



Resilient, Mission Ready Airmen with diverse skillsets prepared to execute a wide range of operations in complex, contested scenarios.

GENERATE READINESS

Strategic adjustments are necessary to optimize our readiness for the present and future operating environments. The Air Force must enable our forces to adapt and excel in real-world operational scenarios, equipping them to confront dynamic challenges and deter adversaries. This requires realigning from functional readiness to mission readiness, prioritizing mission-focused assessments and inspections, and enhancing mission support effectiveness. Doing so will ensure a warfighting posture best positioned to succeed in a Great Power environment.

Prioritizing mission readiness over functional competence centers our focus on the most demanding and complex scenarios. We will implement large-scale exercises and mission-focused training encompassing multiple operational plans to holistically assess our ability to rapidly and effectively generate and deploy forces. This not only serves as a powerful deterrent by showcasing our capabilities but also enhances unit cohesion through comprehensive team training. Training will involve all essential force elements, enabling us to execute complex combat operations at scope and scale, such as Agile Combat Employment (ACE). Foundational to this approach is the development of tailored Force Generation Models based on the AFFORGEN concept but designed to meet mission needs in support of strategic requirements.

Mission-focused assessments and inspections demand a prioritization of Mission Readiness over Platform Readiness. We will conduct a comprehensive overhaul of how we conduct readiness assessments to align operational capabilities seamlessly with mission requirements. This transformation involves evaluating, assessing, and integrating relevant readiness data to measure what is needed for GPC. To provide clear readiness guidance, standards, and goals must be achieved through a holistic and risk-informed process. Inspections will use validated readiness data to inform senior leaders and certification determinations. This reinvigoration will allow us to assess our readiness, better advocate for it, and understand where we are truly taking risks when making resourcing and programming decisions. In doing so, the Air Force will ensure that our readiness evaluations align with the demands of high-end conflict.

Finally, the Air Force will prioritize support critical to combat mission effectiveness. This will ensure the support capabilities most relevant to readiness, and important to the combat mission, are prioritized for resourcing. This will ensure the prioritization of our support functions to meet GPC requirements, guaranteeing that the necessary capabilities are resilient, survivable, and sustainable, ready to be delivered at any time or under any circumstances.



Specialized power projection, achieving mission readiness through large-scale exercises and mission-focused training.

PROJECT POWER

Power projection is at the heart of our National Defense Strategy. Our ability to demonstrate rapid military power projection is core to integrated deterrence and lessens our nation's likelihood of being drawn into conflict. To ensure the effectiveness of our Air Force in competition today and the next fight, we will need to restructure our force presentation for optimal power projection. To do this, the Air Force will clearly **define and assemble modular "Units of Action," articulating each Unit of Action's four main elements, clarifying the relationship between the Combat Wings and the Base Commander, and streamlining Service Components aligned directly to Combatant Commands.**

The Air Force will **create coherent, standardized, and well-defined Units of Action** to present a clear and cohesive structure for effective combat operations and force presentation. We will define the types of Air Force operational wings (Units of Action): Deployable Combat Wings (DCW), In-Place Combat Wings (ICW), and Combat Generation Wings (CGW). These wings will prioritize readying whole units that can be combat-effective on Day One of a conflict. They will train together and, as applicable, deploy and fight together—enhancing their ability to provide direct support to Combatant Commanders. Taken together, these Units of Action will form a significant portion of the Air Force, providing a clear understanding of “how much” Air Force combat capability we possess and have ready, enabling us to assess associated risks.

We will also **articulate the three layers** of each Unit of Action, including **the command layer, mission layer, and sustaining layer**, along with its foundational elements. The command layer will be an empowered echelon comprised of a senior leader and support staff to execute command and control of the unit. The mission layer will include at least one Mission Generation Force Element (MGFE) with modularity to attach additional MGFEs to the unit as the mission requires. Finally, in addition to organic sustainment forces resident in MGFEs, the sustaining layer will include standardized combat support to accomplish base operating support, air operations, sustainment, and protection. This modularity provides the flexibility to present clear and credible combat capability tailored to Combatant Commands, while allowing the Air Force to better “see ourselves.”

Optimizing for power projection also requires the Air Force to **clarify the relationship between Combat Wings and the Base Commander**. This seamless partnership and mutual understanding enables Combat Wings and their command team to focus solely on their warfighting tasks, while allowing the Base Command to focus on effectively operating the base in competition, crisis, and conflict.

Streamlining Service Components aligned directly to Combatant Commands ensures the Air Force better prepares, presents, and generates airpower effects for the Joint Force. This direct alignment, notably the elevation of AFCYBER as a standalone service component, enables service component commands to focus on preparation and presentation for their combat missions. This realignment also allows institutional commands to be solely responsible for developing Airmen, generating readiness, and delivering capabilities for today and tomorrow.



Optimized, well-articulated "Units of Action" designed for mission effectiveness, modularity, and rapid force presentation.

DEVELOP CAPABILITIES

To win in future conflicts, we must optimize our capability development pipeline through an enterprise-wide integrated force design. This involves streamlined decision-making, data-driven prioritization, and the integration of emerging technology across the Air Force. To achieve this, the Air Force must **establish a single authoritative entity focused on identifying and prioritizing future operational capabilities, drive cross-platform mission systems integration and capability development, establish focused acquisition Systems Centers for effective portfolio and life cycle management, and establish relevant Secretariat offices which inform Department of the Air Force senior leaders on enterprise decisions.** This will result in a more agile and technologically advanced warfighting posture, positioning the Air Force for success.

Establishing a single authoritative capabilities command will prioritize and coordinate Air Force integrated system-of-systems capability with new technology requirements. This command will align future capabilities with Air Force operating concepts, aggregate and prioritize MAJCOM requirements, ensure coherences across systems, and provide a unified demand signal for materiel needs. This integrated approach ensures the development of operationally necessary capabilities, breaks down organizational stovepipes, and allows operational commanders to focus on warfighting readiness.

Driving cross-platform mission systems integration and capability development reprioritizes "platform-centric" kill chains to integrated, mission-focused "system-of-systems" kill webs. This underscores the importance of adopting common open architectures and cross-platform integration from the outset, enabling greater flexibility, agility, and rapid system upgrades at the speed of software coding. The Air Force will establish an office responsible for executing early systems acquisition prototyping, systems engineering, and integration—able to generate a healthy tension between operators and technical experts to ensure a more viable and executable future force.

Establishing and elevating acquisition Systems Centers responsible for integrated enterprise-level portfolio and life cycle management of weapon systems in three key areas: nuclear materiel management; air dominance; and information, cyber, and electronic warfare dominance will facilitate collaboration across functional and specialized areas. This approach is consistent with viewing the enterprise as an integrated system-of-systems.

Establishing Secretariat offices capable of facilitating DAF-level enterprise integration, providing overarching guidance and prioritized demand signals in areas such as capability development, program analysis and evaluation, and sensitive activities will enable DAF senior leaders to make informed decisions and ensure coherence across the Department. These offices will also promote integration across the Joint Force where appropriate, fostering a more unified and effective military approach.



Horizontal and vertical integration to deliver connected and interoperable systems at speed and scale.

CONCLUSION: THE CALL TO CHANGE

The current strategic landscape demands adaptation to meet present and future challenges. With multifaceted geopolitical tensions, the global ambitions of the People's Republic of China, and the rapid ascent of disruptive technologies, we cannot afford to underestimate the realities of the security environment we face today. In our increasingly complex world, change is an imperative. We cannot afford to fail.

We have successfully undergone transformations in the past. However, the Air Force's previous adaptations are no longer sufficient for the landscape we find ourselves in today. To ensure our readiness, we must once again evolve and remain responsive to the current security environment. Embracing change is not a choice; it is a necessity. We must "reoptimize" our Service into an enterprise prepared for high-end conflicts and long-term strategic competition.

We must be clear-eyed and accept the fact that we will not achieve perfection right out of the gate during this change journey. However, we must solve for agility—have confidence in the fundamental logic and analysis that has given us this direction, and move out, knowing that we can and will adjust along the way. We can change course, but we must be in motion to do so—otherwise we're not changing course, just changing our minds—and falling behind.

We're out of time . . . we have to follow through now.



This presentation and all images in it are property of the Department of the Air Force and may not be used commercially or in any other manner that could imply endorsement of an individual, for-profit business, non-profit organization, or any other non-Federal entity's product or service. All other materials herein are property of their respective owner(s), may be subject to copyright and/or trademark protection, and are provided for information, scholarly, and/or commentary purposes only. Such use is believed to constitute fair use, as provided for in 17 U.S.C. Section 107. Unauthorized duplication, redistribution, retention, or modification of copyrighted materials is prohibited.

NATIONAL SECURITY STRATEGY

OCTOBER 2022



THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON



THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

October 12, 2022

From the earliest days of my Presidency, I have argued that our world is at an inflection point. How we respond to the tremendous challenges and the unprecedented opportunities we face today will determine the direction of our world and impact the security and prosperity of the American people for generations to come. The 2022 National Security Strategy outlines how my Administration will seize this decisive decade to advance America's vital interests, position the United States to outmaneuver our geopolitical competitors, tackle shared challenges, and set our world firmly on a path toward a brighter and more hopeful tomorrow.

Around the world, the need for American leadership is as great as it has ever been. We are in the midst of a strategic competition to shape the future of the international order. Meanwhile, shared challenges that impact people everywhere demand increased global cooperation and nations stepping up to their responsibilities at a moment when this has become more difficult. In response, the United States will lead with our values, and we will work in lockstep with our allies and partners and with all those who share our interests. We will not leave our future vulnerable to the whims of those who do not share our vision for a world that is free, open, prosperous, and secure. As the world continues to navigate the lingering impacts of the pandemic and global economic uncertainty, there is no nation better positioned to lead with strength and purpose than the United States of America.

From the moment I took the oath of office, my Administration has focused on investing in America's core strategic advantages. Our economy has added 10 million jobs and unemployment rates have reached near record lows. Manufacturing jobs have come racing back to the United States. We're rebuilding our economy from the bottom up and the middle out. We've made a generational investment to upgrade our Nation's infrastructure and historic investments in innovation to sharpen our competitive edge for the future. Around the world, nations are seeing once again why it's never a good bet to bet against the United States of America.

We have also reinvigorated America's unmatched network of alliances and partnerships to uphold and strengthen the principles and institutions that have enabled so much stability, prosperity, and growth for the last 75 years. We have deepened our core alliances in Europe and the Indo-Pacific. NATO is stronger and more united than it has ever been, as we look to welcome two capable new allies in Finland and Sweden. We are doing more to connect our partners and strategies across regions through initiatives like our security partnership with Australia and the United Kingdom (AUKUS). And we are forging creative new ways to work in common cause with partners around issues of shared interest, as we are with the European Union, the Indo-Pacific Quad, the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework, and the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity.

These partnerships amplify our capacity to respond to shared challenges and take on the issues that directly impact billions of people's lives. If parents cannot feed their children, nothing else matters. When countries are repeatedly ravaged by climate disasters, entire futures are wiped out. And as we have all experienced, when pandemic diseases proliferate and spread, they can worsen inequities and bring the entire world to a standstill. The United States will continue to prioritize leading the international response to these transnational challenges, together with our partners, even as we face down concerted efforts to remake the ways in which nations relate to one another.

In the contest for the future of our world, my Administration is clear-eyed about the scope and seriousness of this challenge. The People's Republic of China harbors the intention and, increasingly, the capacity to reshape the international order in favor of one that tilts the global playing field to its benefit, even as the United States remains committed to managing the competition between our countries responsibly. Russia's brutal and unprovoked war on its neighbor Ukraine has shattered peace in Europe and impacted stability everywhere, and its reckless nuclear threats endanger the global non-proliferation regime. Autocrats are working overtime to undermine democracy and export a model of governance marked by repression at home and coercion abroad.

These competitors mistakenly believe democracy is weaker than autocracy because they fail to understand that a nation's power springs from its people. The United States is strong abroad because we are strong at home. Our economy is dynamic. Our people are resilient and creative. Our military remains unmatched—and we will keep it that way. And it is our democracy that enables us to continually reimagine ourselves and renew our strength.

So, the United States will continue to defend democracy around the world, even as we continue to do the work at home to better live up to the idea of America enshrined in our founding documents. We will continue to invest in boosting American competitiveness globally, drawing dreamers and strivers from around the world. We will partner with any nation that shares our basic belief that the rules-based order must remain the foundation for global peace and prosperity. And we will continue to demonstrate how America's enduring leadership to address the challenges of today and tomorrow, with vision and clarity, is the best way to deliver for the American people.

This is a 360-degree strategy grounded in the world as it is today, laying out the future we seek, and providing a roadmap for how we will achieve it. None of this will be easy or without setbacks. But I am more confident than ever that the United States has everything we need to win the competition for the 21st century. We emerge stronger from every crisis. There is nothing beyond our capacity. We can do this—for our future and for the world.

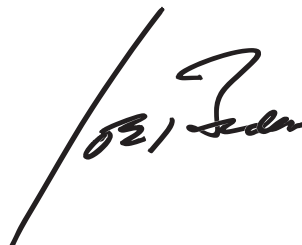
A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Joe Biden", with a long diagonal line extending from the bottom left of the signature.



Table of Contents

PART I: THE COMPETITION FOR WHAT COMES NEXT	6
Our Enduring Vision	6
Our Enduring Role.....	7
The Nature of the Competition Between Democracies and Autocracies	8
Cooperating to Address Shared Challenges in an Era of Competition.....	9
Overview of Our Strategic Approach.....	10
PART II: INVESTING IN OUR STRENGTH.....	14
Investing in Our National Power to Maintain a Competitive Edge	14
Implementing a Modern Industrial and Innovation Strategy.....	14
Investing In Our People	15
Strengthening Our Democracy	16
Using Diplomacy to Build the Strongest Possible Coalitions.....	16
Transformative Cooperation.....	16
An Inclusive World	18
A Prosperous World	19
Modernizing and Strengthening Our Military.....	20
PART III: OUR GLOBAL PRIORITIES	23
Out-Competing China and Constraining Russia	23
China.....	23
Russia.....	25
Cooperating on Shared Challenges	27
Climate and Energy Security	27
Pandemics and Biodefense	28
Food Insecurity	29
Arms Control and Non-Proliferation	29
Terrorism	30
Shaping the Rules of the Road	32
Technology	32
Securing Cyberspace	34
Trade and Economics	34
PART IV: OUR STRATEGY BY REGION	37



Promote a Free and Open Indo-Pacific	37
Deepen Our Alliance with Europe	38
Foster Democracy and Shared Prosperity in the Western Hemisphere	40
Support De-Escalation and Integration in the Middle East.....	42
Build 21st Century U.S.-Africa Partnerships	43
Maintain a Peaceful Arctic.....	44
Protect Sea, Air, and Space	45
PART V: CONCLUSION.....	48



PART I: THE COMPETITION FOR WHAT COMES NEXT

“The world is changing. We’re at a significant inflection point in world history. And our country and the world—the United States of America has always been able to chart the future in times of great change. We’ve been able to constantly renew ourselves. And time and again, we’ve proven there’s not a single thing we cannot do as a nation when we do it together—and I mean that—not a single solitary thing.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR

United States Coast Guard Academy's 140th Commencement Exercises

Our Enduring Vision

We are now in the early years of a decisive decade for America and the world. The terms of geopolitical competition between the major powers will be set. The window of opportunity to deal with shared threats, like climate change, will narrow drastically. The actions we take now will shape whether this period is known as an age of conflict and discord or the beginning of a more stable and prosperous future.

We face two strategic challenges. The first is that the post-Cold War era is definitively over and a competition is underway between the major powers to shape what comes next. No nation is better positioned to succeed in this competition than the United States, as long as we work in common cause with those who share our vision of a world that is free, open, secure, and prosperous. This means that the foundational principles of self-determination, territorial integrity, and political independence must be respected, international institutions must be strengthened, countries must be free to determine their own foreign policy choices, information must be allowed to flow freely, universal human rights must be upheld, and the global economy must operate on a level playing field and provide opportunity for all.

The second is that while this competition is underway, people all over the world are struggling to cope with the effects of shared challenges that cross borders—whether it is climate change, food insecurity, communicable diseases, terrorism, energy shortages, or inflation. These shared challenges are not marginal issues that are secondary to geopolitics. They are at the very core of national and international security and must be treated as such. By their very nature, these challenges require governments to cooperate if they are to solve them. But we must be clear-eyed that we will have to tackle these challenges within a competitive international environment where heightening geopolitical competition, nationalism and populism render this cooperation even more difficult and will require us to think and act in new ways.



This National Security Strategy lays out our plan to achieve a better future of a free, open, secure, and prosperous world. Our strategy is rooted in our national interests: to protect the security of the American people; to expand economic prosperity and opportunity; and to realize and defend the democratic values at the heart of the American way of life. We can do none of this alone and we do not have to. Most nations around the world define their interests in ways that are compatible with ours. We will build the strongest and broadest possible coalition of nations that seek to cooperate with each other, while competing with those powers that offer a darker vision and thwarting their efforts to threaten our interests.

Our Enduring Role

The need for a strong and purposeful American role in the world has never been greater. The world is becoming more divided and unstable. Global increases in inflation since the COVID-19 pandemic began have made life more difficult for many. The basic laws and principles governing relations among nations, including the United Nations Charter and the protection it affords all states from being invaded by their neighbors or having their borders redrawn by force, are under attack. The risk of conflict between major powers is increasing. Democracies and autocracies are engaged in a contest to show which system of governance can best deliver for their people and the world. Competition to develop and deploy foundational technologies that will transform our security and economy is intensifying. Global cooperation on shared interests has frayed, even as the need for that cooperation takes on existential importance. The scale of these changes grows with each passing year, as do the risks of inaction.

Although the international environment has become more contested, the United States remains the world's leading power. Our economy, our population, our innovation, and our military power continue to grow, often outpacing those of other large countries. Our inherent national strengths—the ingenuity, creativity, resilience, and determination of the American people; our values, diversity, and democratic institutions; our technological leadership and economic dynamism; and our diplomatic corps, development professionals, intelligence community, and our military—remain unparalleled. We are experienced in using and applying our power in combination with our allies and partners who add significantly to our own strengths. We have learned lessons from our failures as well as our successes. The idea that we should compete with major autocratic powers to shape the international order enjoys broad support that is bipartisan at home and deepening abroad.

The United States is a large and diverse democracy, encompassing people from every corner of the world, every walk of life, every system of belief. This means that our politics are not always smooth—in fact, they're often the opposite. We live at a moment of passionate political intensities and ferment that sometimes tears at the fabric of the nation. But we don't shy away from that fact or use it as an excuse to retreat from the wider world. We will continue to reckon openly and humbly with our divisions and we will work through our politics transparently and democratically. We know that for all of the effort that it takes, our democracy is worth it. It is the only way to ensure that people are truly able to live lives of dignity and freedom. This American project will never be complete—democracy is always a work in progress—but that will not stop us from defending our values and continuing to pursue our national security interests in the world. The quality of our democracy at home affects the strength and credibility of our leadership abroad—just as the character of the world we inhabit affects our ability to enjoy security, prosperity, and freedom at home.



Our rivals' challenges are profound and mounting. Their problems, at both home and abroad, are associated with the pathologies inherent in highly personalized autocracies and are less easily remedied than ours. Conversely, the United States has a tradition of transforming both domestic and foreign challenges into opportunities to spur reform and rejuvenation at home. This is one reason that prophecies of American decline have repeatedly been disproven in the past—and why it has never been a good bet to bet against America. We have always succeeded when we embrace an affirmative vision for the world that addresses shared challenges and combine it with the dynamism of our democracy and the determination to out-compete our rivals.

The Nature of the Competition Between Democracies and Autocracies

The range of nations that supports our vision of a free, open, prosperous, and secure world is broad and powerful. It includes our democratic allies in Europe and the Indo-Pacific as well as key democratic partners around the world that share much of our vision for regional and international order even if they do not agree with us on all issues, and countries that do not embrace democratic institutions but nevertheless depend upon and support a rules-based international system.

Americans will support universal human rights and stand in solidarity with those beyond our shores who seek freedom and dignity, just as we continue the critical work of ensuring equity and equal treatment under law at home. We will work to strengthen democracy around the world because democratic governance consistently outperforms authoritarianism in protecting human dignity, leads to more prosperous and resilient societies, creates stronger and more reliable economic and security partners for the United States, and encourages a peaceful world order. In particular, we will take steps to show that democracies deliver—not only by ensuring the United States and its democratic partners lead on the hardest challenges of our time, but by working with other democratic governments and the private sector to help emerging democracies show tangible benefits to their own populations. We do not, however, believe that governments and societies everywhere must be remade in America's image for us to be secure.

The most pressing strategic challenge facing our vision is from powers that layer authoritarian governance with a revisionist foreign policy. It is their behavior that poses a challenge to international peace and stability—especially waging or preparing for wars of aggression, actively undermining the democratic political processes of other countries, leveraging technology and supply chains for coercion and repression, and exporting an illiberal model of international order. Many non-democracies join the world's democracies in forswearing these behaviors. Unfortunately, Russia and the People's Republic of China (PRC) do not.

Russia and the PRC pose different challenges. Russia poses an immediate threat to the free and open international system, recklessly flouting the basic laws of the international order today, as its brutal war of aggression against Ukraine has shown. The PRC, by contrast, is the only competitor with both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to advance that objective.

Just as the United States and countries around the world benefited greatly from the post-Cold War international order, so too did the PRC and Russia. The PRC's economy and geopolitical influence grew rapidly. Russia joined the G8 and G20 and recovered economically in the 2000s. And yet, they concluded that the success of a free and open rules-based international order posed a threat to their regimes and stifled their ambitions. In their own ways, they now seek to remake



the international order to create a world conducive to their highly personalized and repressive type of autocracy.

Their pursuit of this vision is complicated by several factors. The PRC's assertive behavior has caused other countries to push back and defend their sovereignty, for their own, legitimate reasons. The PRC also retains common interests with other countries, including the United States, because of various interdependencies on climate, economics, and public health. Russia's strategic limitations have been exposed following its war of aggression against Ukraine. Moscow also has some interest in cooperation with countries that do not share its vision, especially in the global south. As a result, the United States and our allies and partners have an opportunity to shape the PRC and Russia's external environment in a way that influences their behavior even as we compete with them.

Some parts of the world are uneasy with the competition between the United States and the world's largest autocracies. We understand these concerns. We also want to avoid a world in which competition escalates into a world of rigid blocs. We do not seek conflict or a new Cold War. Rather, we are trying to support every country, regardless of size or strength, in exercising the freedom to make choices that serve their interests. This is a critical difference between our vision, which aims to preserve the autonomy and rights of less powerful states, and that of our rivals, which does not.

Cooperating to Address Shared Challenges in an Era of Competition

Heightened competition between democracies and autocracies is just one of two critical trends we face. The other is shared challenges—or what some call transnational challenges—that do not respect borders and affect all nations. These two trends affect each other—geopolitical competition changes, and often complicates, the context in which shared challenges can be addressed while those problems often exacerbate geopolitical competition, as we saw with the early phases of the COVID-19 pandemic when the PRC was unwilling to cooperate with the international community. We cannot succeed in our competition with the major powers who offer a different vision for the world if we do not have a plan to work with other nations to deal with shared challenges and we will not be able to do that unless we understand how a more competitive world affects cooperation and how the need for cooperation affects competition. We need a strategy that not only deals with both but recognizes the relationship between them and adjusts accordingly.

Of all of the shared problems we face, climate change is the greatest and potentially existential for all nations. Without immediate global action during this crucial decade, global temperatures will cross the critical warming threshold of 1.5 degrees Celsius after which scientists have warned some of the most catastrophic climate impacts will be irreversible. Climate effects and humanitarian emergencies will only worsen in the years ahead—from more powerful wildfires and hurricanes in the United States to flooding in Europe, rising sea levels in Oceania, water scarcity in the Middle East, melting ice in the Arctic, and drought and deadly temperatures in sub-Saharan Africa. Tensions will further intensify as countries compete for resources and energy advantage—increasing humanitarian need, food insecurity and health threats, as well as the potential for instability, conflict, and mass migration. The necessity to protect forests globally, electrify the transportation sector, redirect financial flows and create an energy revolution to head off the climate crisis is reinforced by the geopolitical imperative to reduce our collective dependence on states like Russia that seek to weaponize energy for coercion.



It is not just climate change. COVID-19 has shown that transnational challenges can hit with the destructive force of major wars. COVID-19 has killed millions of people and damaged the livelihoods of hundreds of millions, if not more. It exposed the insufficiency of our global health architecture and supply chains, widened inequality, and wiped out many years of development progress. It also weakened food systems, brought humanitarian need to record levels, and reinforced the need to redouble our efforts to reduce poverty and hunger and expand access to education in order to get back on track to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030. Meanwhile, communicable diseases like Ebola continue to reemerge and can only be dealt with if we act early and with other nations. The pandemic has made clear the need for international leadership and action to create stronger, more equitable, and more resilient health systems—so that we can prevent or prepare for the next pandemic or health emergency before it starts.

The global economic challenges resulting from the COVID-19 pandemic have been extended and deepened globally as uneven, recovering demand has outpaced suppliers and put strains on supply chains. Consumers and policymakers the world over have also struggled with surging energy prices and mounting food insecurity, which sharpen security challenges like migration and corruption. Moreover, autocratic governments often abuse the global economic order by weaponizing its interconnectivity and its strengths. They can arbitrarily raise costs by withholding the movement of key goods. They leverage access to their markets and control of global digital infrastructure for coercive purposes. They launder and hide their wealth, often the proceeds of foreign corrupt practices, in major economies through shell and front companies. Nefarious actors—some state sponsored, some not—are exploiting the digital economy to raise and move funds to support illicit weapons programs, terrorist attacks, fuel conflict, and to extort everyday citizens targeted by ransomware or cyber-attacks on national health systems, financial institutions and critical infrastructure. These various factors constrain our policy options, and those of our allies and partners, to advance our security interests and meet the basic needs of our citizens.

We have also experienced a global energy crisis driven by Russia’s weaponization of the oil and gas supplies it controls, exacerbated by OPEC’s management of its own supply. This circumstance underscores the need for an accelerated, just, and responsible global energy transition. That’s why — even as we continue to explore all opportunities with our allies and partners to stabilize energy markets and get supplies to those who need it — we are also focused on implementing the most significant piece of climate legislation in our nation’s history, to bring innovative energy technologies to scale as quickly as possible.

We must work with other nations to address shared challenges to improve the lives of the American people and those of people around the world. We recognize that we will undertake such effort within a competitive environment where major powers will be actively working to advance a different vision. We will use the impulses released by an era of competition to create a race to the top and make progress on shared challenges, whether it is by making investments at home or by deepening cooperation with other countries that share our vision.

Overview of Our Strategic Approach

Our goal is clear—we want a free, open, prosperous, and secure international order. We seek an order that is free in that it allows people to enjoy their basic, universal rights and freedoms. It is open in that it provides all nations that sign up to these principles an opportunity to participate in,



and have a role in shaping, the rules. It is prosperous in that it empowers all nations to continually raise the standard of living for their citizens. And secure, in that it is free from aggression, coercion and intimidation.

Achieving this goal requires three lines of effort. We will: 1) invest in the underlying sources and tools of American power and influence; 2) build the strongest possible coalition of nations to enhance our collective influence to shape the global strategic environment and to solve shared challenges; and 3) modernize and strengthen our military so it is equipped for the era of strategic competition with major powers, while maintaining the capability to disrupt the terrorist threat to the homeland. This is covered in Part II of this strategy.

We will use these capabilities to outcompete our strategic competitors, galvanize collective action on global challenges, and shape the rules of the road for technology, cybersecurity, and trade and economics. This is covered in Part III. Our approach encompasses all elements of national power—diplomacy, development cooperation, industrial strategy, economic statecraft, intelligence, and defense—and is built on several key pillars.

First, we have broken down the dividing line between foreign policy and domestic policy. We understand that if the United States is to succeed abroad, we must invest in our innovation and industrial strength, and build our resilience, at home. Likewise, to advance shared prosperity domestically and to uphold the rights of all Americans, we must proactively shape the international order in line with our interests and values. In a competitive world, where other powers engage in coercive or unfair practices to gain an edge over the United States and our allies, this takes on a special importance. We must complement the innovative power of the private sector with a modern industrial strategy that makes strategic public investments in America's workforce, and in strategic sectors and supply chains, especially critical and emerging technologies, such as microelectronics, advanced computing, biotechnologies, clean energy technologies, and advanced telecommunications.

Second, our alliances and partnerships around the world are our most important strategic asset and an indispensable element contributing to international peace and stability. A strong and unified NATO, our alliances in the Indo-Pacific, and our traditional security partnerships elsewhere do not only deter aggression; they provide a platform for mutually beneficial cooperation that strengthens the international order. We place a premium on growing the connective tissue—on technology, trade and security—between our democratic allies and partners in the Indo-Pacific and Europe because we recognize that they are mutually reinforcing and the fates of the two regions are intertwined. The United States is a global power with global interests. We are stronger in each region because of our affirmative engagement in the others. If one region descends into chaos or is dominated by a hostile power, it will detrimentally impact our interests in the others.

Third, this strategy recognizes that the PRC presents America's most consequential geopolitical challenge. Although the Indo-Pacific is where its outcomes will be most acutely shaped, there are significant global dimensions to this challenge. Russia poses an immediate and ongoing threat to the regional security order in Europe and it is a source of disruption and instability globally but it lacks the across the spectrum capabilities of the PRC. We also recognize that other smaller autocratic powers are also acting in aggressive and destabilizing ways. Most notably, Iran interferes in the internal affairs of neighbors, proliferates missiles and drones through proxies, is plotting to harm Americans, including former officials, and is advancing a nuclear program



beyond any credible civilian need. The Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) continues to expand its illicit nuclear weapons and missile programs.

Fourth, we will avoid the temptation to see the world solely through the prism of strategic competition and will continue to engage countries on their own terms. We will pursue an affirmative agenda to advance peace and security and to promote prosperity in every region. A more integrated Middle East that empowers our allies and partners will advance regional peace and prosperity, while reducing the resource demands the region makes on the United States over the long term. In Africa, the dynamism, innovation, and demographic growth of the region render it central to addressing complex global problems. The Western Hemisphere directly impacts the United States more than any other region so we will continue to revive and deepen our partnerships there to advance economic resilience, democratic stability, and citizen security.

Fifth, we recognize that globalization has delivered immense benefits for the United States and the world but an adjustment is now required to cope with dramatic global changes such as widening inequality within and among countries, the PRC's emergence as both our most consequential competitor and one of our largest trading partners, and emerging technologies that fall outside the bounds of existing rules and regulations. We have an affirmative agenda for the global economy to seize the full range of economic benefits of the 21st century while advancing the interests of American workers. Recognizing we have to move beyond traditional Free Trade Agreements, we are charting new economic arrangements to deepen economic engagement with our partners, like the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework for Prosperity (IPEF); a global minimum tax that ensures corporations pay their fair share of tax wherever they are based in the world; the Partnership for Global Investment and Infrastructure (PGII) to help low- and middle-income countries secure high-standard investment for critical infrastructure; updated rules of the road for technology, cyberspace, trade, and economics; and ensuring the transition to clean energy unlocks economic opportunities and good jobs around the world.

Finally, the community of nations that shares our vision for the future of international order is broad and includes countries on every continent. We share in common a desire for relations among nations to be governed by the UN Charter; for the universal rights of all individuals—political, civil, economic, social and cultural—to be upheld; for our environment, air, oceans, space, cyberspace and arteries of international commerce to be protected and accessible for all; and for international institutions, including the United Nations, to be modernized and strengthened to better address global challenges and deliver more tangible benefits for our citizens. The order we seek builds on what came before, but addresses serious shortcomings, new realities, and the attempts by some states to advance a much less free and open model. To preserve and increase international cooperation in an age of competition, we will pursue a dual-track approach. On one track, we will cooperate with any country, including our geopolitical rivals, that is willing to work constructively with us to address shared challenges. We will also fully engage with, and work to strengthen, international institutions. On the other track, we will deepen our cooperation with democracies and other like-minded states. From the Indo-Pacific Quad (Australia, India, Japan, United States) to the U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council, from AUKUS (Australia, United Kingdom, United States) to I2-U2 (India, Israel, UAE, United States), we are creating a latticework of strong, resilient, and mutually reinforcing relationships that prove democracies can deliver for their people and the world.

The world is now at an inflection point. This decade will be decisive, in setting the terms of our competition with the PRC, managing the acute threat posed by Russia, and in our efforts to deal



with shared challenges, particularly climate change, pandemics, and economic turbulence. If we do not act with urgency and creativity, our window of opportunity to shape the future of international order and tackle shared challenges will close. Those actions must begin with developing the means to execute our strategy, by making renewed investments at home and abroad.



PART II: INVESTING IN OUR STRENGTH

“As we look ahead, we will lead. We will lead on all the greatest challenges of our time—from COVID to climate, peace and security, human dignity and human rights. But we will not go it alone. We will lead together with our Allies and partners and in cooperation with all those who believe, as we do, that this is within our power to meet these challenges, to build a future that lifts all of our people and preserves this planet. But none of this is inevitable; it’s a choice. And I can tell you where America stands: We will choose to build a better future.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR

76th Session of the United Nations General Assembly

Investing in Our National Power to Maintain a Competitive Edge

To outcompete our rivals and tackle shared challenges, America will need to maintain and refine its competitive edge by making critical domestic investments. In an interconnected world, there is no bright line between foreign and domestic policy. The future of America’s success in the world depends upon our strength and resilience at home—and especially the strength of our middle class, which is critical to our national security as an engine of economic growth and a key source of democratic vibrance and cohesion. The reverse is also true. Our success at home requires robust and strategic engagement in the world in line with our interests and values to make life better, safer, and fairer for the American people. That is why we must make far-reaching investments in the sources of our natural strength while building our resilience.

Implementing a Modern Industrial and Innovation Strategy

The private sector and open markets have been, and continue to be, a vital source of our national strength and a key driver of innovation. However, markets alone cannot respond to the rapid pace of technological change, global supply disruptions, nonmarket abuses by the PRC and other actors, or the deepening climate crisis. Strategic public investment is the backbone of a strong industrial and innovation base in the 21st century global economy.

That is why the United States is pursuing a modern industrial and innovation strategy. We are identifying and investing in key areas where private industry, on its own, has not mobilized to protect our core economic and national security interests, including bolstering our national resilience. We are securing our critical infrastructure, advancing foundational cybersecurity for critical sectors from pipelines to water, and working with the private sector to improve security defenses in technology products. We are securing our supply chains, including through new forms of public-private collaboration, and using public procurement in critical markets to stimulate demand for innovation. In 2021, we boosted our competitiveness by enacting the largest investment in physical infrastructure in nearly a century, including historic investments in



transportation, broadband, clean water, and energy infrastructure that will increase economic growth for decades to come. We recognize the importance of the semiconductor supply chain to our competitiveness and our national security, and we are seeking to reinvigorate the semiconductor industry in the United States. The CHIPS and Science Act authorizes \$280 billion for civilian investment in research and development, especially in critical sectors such as semiconductors and advanced computing, next-generation communications, clean energy technologies, and biotechnologies. Through the National Biotechnology and Biomanufacturing Initiative, we are investing more than \$2 billion to harness the full potential of biotechnology and biomanufacturing, create jobs at home, strengthen supply chains, and reduce carbon emissions.

In 2022, we enacted the Inflation Reduction Act which will invest in domestic energy production and manufacturing, and reduce carbon emissions by roughly 40 percent by 2030. Combatting the climate crisis, bolstering our energy security, and hastening the clean energy transition is integral to our industrial strategy, economic growth, and security. We are incubating and deploying new technologies and solutions, allowing us to lead the world while creating new markets and scalable approaches. Together, these investments will keep the United States at the leading edge, increase economic capacity, and support millions of jobs and trillions of dollars in economic activity over the next decade. Across these efforts, we are mobilizing the talent, grit, and innovation of American workers, who can out-compete anyone. We are also prioritizing equity and investing in regional economic development to ensure the future is made across all of America, by all Americans.

As we do this work, we are also protecting our investments and bolstering their resilience through tracking, attributing, and defending against the activities of malicious actors in cyberspace. And we are countering intellectual property theft, forced technology transfer, and other attempts to degrade our technological advantages by enhancing investment screening, export controls, and counterintelligence resources. Just as we seek to pool technical expertise and complementary industrial capacity with our allies and partners, we are also enhancing our collective capacity to withstand attempts to degrade our shared technology advantages, including through investment screening and export controls, and the development of new regimes where gaps persist.

Investing In Our People

We are focused on strengthening the economy by building from the bottom up and the middle out. To that end, we know the most impactful public investments are the ones we make in our people. We seek to increase equitable access to affordable health care and child care; career-long training and skill building; and high-quality education and training, including science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM), especially for women and girls. These investments will boost our economic capacity by ensuring our workforce is better educated, healthier, and more productive. This stronger workforce will also build enduring advantages that bolster our strength and resilience. We are also supporting workers by promoting union organizing and collective bargaining, and improving workers' job quality.

As we create the conditions for our people to thrive, we will also continue to make America the destination of choice for talent around the world. Since the founding of our Nation, America has been strengthened and renewed by immigrants seeking opportunity and refuge on our shores—a unique strategic advantage. We will continue working with Congress and taking executive action to ensure our immigration and refugee systems are fair, orderly, humane, easier to navigate, and



consistent with our values and the law. And we will take further measures to ensure the United States remains the world's top destination for talent.

Strengthening Our Democracy

Our democracy is at the core of who we are, and America's democratic experiment has long been a source of inspiration for people around the world. Our system of government enshrines the rule of law and strives to protect the equality and dignity of all individuals. Deliberation and informed debate propel us to correct our mistakes, better meet public needs, and expand the circle of opportunity. We have not always lived up to our ideals and in recent years our democracy has been challenged from within. But we have never walked away from our ideals and in each challenging moment, citizens have stepped forward to uphold them. In times of crisis or lapses in judgment, we look to more democracy—not less—to forge the path forward. Our democracy is a work in progress—and by reckoning with and remedying our own shortcomings, we can inspire others around the world to do the same.

As Americans, we must all agree that the people's verdict, as expressed in elections, must be respected and protected. We also believe that critical reforms continue to be needed to strengthen our system of governance. This is why we have taken executive action and urged essential legislation to protect and promote voting rights and expand democratic participation, and why we are building on the work of generations of activists to advance equity and root out systemic disparities in our laws, policies, and institutions. Indeed, pluralism, inclusion, and diversity are a source of national strength in a rapidly changing world. We are reaffirming the rights to free speech, a free press, peaceful assembly, and other core civil liberties. And at the same time, we are standing up to threats to our democracy such as domestic terrorism by implementing our nation's first-ever National Strategy for Countering Domestic Terrorism and tackling head-on global forces like weaponized corruption, information manipulation operations, political interference, and attacks on the rule of law, including in elections. America will not tolerate foreign interference in our elections. We will act decisively to defend, and deter disruptions to our democratic processes, and we will respond to future interference using all appropriate tools of national power.

Using Diplomacy to Build the Strongest Possible Coalitions

The United States' unrivaled network of allies and partners protects and advances our interests around the world—and is the envy of our adversaries. Building on this network, we will assemble the strongest possible coalitions to advance and defend a world that is free, open, prosperous, and secure. These coalitions will include all nations that share these objectives. At the heart of this coalition, to ensure it is as transformative as possible, are democratic nations who share our interests and values. To make our coalitions as inclusive as possible, we will also work with any country that supports a rules-based order while we continue to press all partners to respect and advance democracy and human rights.

Transformative Cooperation

To solve the toughest problems the world faces, we need to produce dramatically greater levels of cooperation. The key to doing this is to recognize that the core of our inclusive coalition are those partners who most closely share our interests. America's treaty alliances with other



democratic countries are foundational to our strategy and central to almost everything we do to make the world more peaceful and prosperous. Our NATO and bilateral treaty allies should never doubt our will and capacity to stand with them against aggression and intimidation. As we modernize our military and work to strengthen our democracy at home, we will call on our allies to do the same, including by investing in the type of capabilities and undertaking the planning necessary to bolster deterrence in an increasingly confrontational world.

America's alliances and partnerships have played a critical role in our national security policy for eight decades, and must be deepened and modernized to do so into the future. NATO has responded with unity and strength to deter further Russian aggression in Europe, even as NATO also adopted a broad new agenda at the 2022 Madrid Summit to address systemic challenges from the PRC and other security risks from cyber to climate, as well as agreeing to Finland and Sweden's application to join the alliance. The newly established U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council is coordinating approaches to setting the rules of the road on global technology, economic, and trade issues based on shared democratic values. Our AUKUS security partnership with Australia and the United Kingdom promotes stability in the Indo-Pacific while deepening defense and technology integration. We continue to deepen cooperation with the Five Eyes (with Australia, Canada, New Zealand, and the United Kingdom). The revitalized Quad, which brings the United States together with Japan, India, and Australia, addresses regional challenges and has demonstrated its ability to deliver for the Indo-Pacific, combating COVID-19 and climate change, to deepening cybersecurity partnerships and promoting high standards for infrastructure and health security. Our intelligence relationships with our allies are a strategic asset that will increasingly factor in to our competition with our rivals, especially in technological competition.

We will continue to prioritize seeking out new ways to integrate our alliances in the Indo-Pacific and Europe and develop new and deeper means of cooperation. We have revitalized the G7 as the steering committee of the world's advanced industrial democracies and believe it has a critical role to play in supporting our shared vision for the international order. The G7 is at its strongest when it also formally engages other countries with aligned goals, such as at the 2022 summit where Argentina, India, Indonesia, Senegal, South Africa, and Ukraine also participated. U.S. interests are best served when our European allies and partners play an active role in the Indo-Pacific, including in supporting freedom of navigation and maintaining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait. Similarly, we want our Indo-Pacific allies to be engaged cooperatively with our European allies on shaping the order to which we all aspire, and by standing up to Russia and cooperating with the European Union and United Kingdom on our competition with the PRC. This is not a favor to the United States. Our allies recognize that a collapse of the international order in one region will ultimately endanger it in others.

These democratic allies and partners are also essential to supporting democracy and human rights around the world. Actions to bolster democracy and defend human rights are critical to the United States not only because doing so is consistent with our values, but also because respect for democracy and support for human rights promotes global peace, security, and prosperity. Global threats to accountable and transparent governance also threaten our own democratic system. We will continually update our range of tools to advance democracy and counter authoritarianism. The Presidential Initiative for Democratic Renewal qualitatively increases our ability to combat defining challenges of the 2020s, like grand corruption, digital repression, and attacks on elections and independent media. By the same token, we are responding to the ever-evolving ways in which authoritarians seek to subvert the global order, notably by weaponizing



information to undermine democracies and polarize societies. We are doing so by working with governments, civil society, independent media, and the private sector to prevent credible information from being crowded out, exposing disinformation campaigns, and strengthening the integrity of the media environment - a bedrock of thriving democracies. Together with our allies and partners, we are also holding states accountable for violations and abuses of human rights, including against ethnic and religious minorities, treating the fight against corruption as the core national security interest it is, countering transnational repression, and standing with people around the world on the front lines of the fight for dignity, equality and justice. We reaffirm our commitment to work with the international community to achieve sustainable, long-term solutions to what is the most severe refugee crisis since World War Two—including through resettlement. We raised our annual refugee admissions cap to 125,000 and are rebuilding and improving the U.S. Refugee Admissions Program to enable us to achieve that goal.

An Inclusive World

The vast majority of countries want a stable and open rules-based order that respects their sovereignty and territorial integrity, provides a fair means of economic exchange with others and promotes shared prosperity, and enables cooperation on shared challenges. They strongly disapprove of aggression, coercion, and external interference. They have no interest in overturning longstanding rules and norms to make the world safe for aggression and repression.

We will help construct and preserve coalitions that engage all of these countries and leverage their collective strengths. We recognize that some may harbor reservations about American power and our foreign policy. Others may not be democratic but nevertheless depend upon a rules-based international system. Yet what we share in common, and the prospect of a freer and more open world, makes such a broad coalition necessary and worthwhile. We will listen to and consider ideas that our partners suggest about how to do this.

Building this inclusive coalition requires reinforcing the multilateral system to uphold the founding principles of the United Nations, including respect for international law. 141 countries expressed support at the United Nations General Assembly for a resolution condemning Russia's unprovoked aggression against Ukraine. We continue to demonstrate this approach by engaging all regions across all issues, not in terms of what we are against but what we are for. This year, we partnered with ASEAN to advance clean energy infrastructure and maritime security in the region. We kickstarted the Prosper Africa Build Together Campaign to fuel economic growth across the continent and bolster trade and investment in the clean energy, health, and digital technology sectors. We are working to develop a partnership with countries on the Atlantic Ocean to establish and carry out a shared approach to advancing our joint development, economic, environmental, scientific, and maritime governance goals. We galvanized regional action to address the core challenges facing the Western Hemisphere by spearheading the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity to drive economic recovery and by mobilizing the region behind a bold and unprecedented approach to migration through the Los Angeles Declaration on Migration and Protection. In the Middle East, we have worked to enhance deterrence toward Iran, de-escalate regional conflicts, deepen integration among a diverse set of partners in the region, and bolster energy stability.

A prime example of an inclusive coalition is IPEF, which we launched alongside a dozen regional partners that represent 40 percent of the world's GDP. This framework's four pillars—trade and the digital economy, supply chains and resilience, clean energy and decarbonization,



and tax and anticorruption—will allow this partnership to determine the rules of the road for an economically vital region, and therefore the global economy.

The United States, alongside our G7 partners, launched PGII to meet the enormous infrastructure need in low- and middle-income countries. PGII is catalyzing public and private finance to advance climate and energy security, health and health security, digital connectivity, and gender equality—all while creating opportunities for American businesses. We secured over \$3 billion in commitments from the Gulf Cooperation Council for projects that align with PGII goals. We have taken a similar approach in a number of other development initiatives, also built around multi-stakeholder coalitions that can mobilize a wide array of resources to show in various ways that “democracy delivers,” including the longstanding President’s Emergency Plan for AIDS Relief (PEPFAR), and the Global Fund. We are rallying the world to take bold action and raise our collective ambition to reach the Global Fund’s \$18 billion target to fight HIV/AIDS, tuberculosis, and malaria over the next three years, and requested \$2 billion in our FY 2023 budget to anchor a \$6 billion three-year pledge from the United States. This investment will strengthen health systems, accelerate progress to achieve universal health coverage, and expand the global health workforce.

The United States will work pragmatically with any partner willing to join us in constructive problem-solving, reinforcing and building new ties based on shared interests. This includes not just nation states, but also civil society groups, private companies, philanthropies, and sub-national governments at home and around the world. Through proven initiatives like Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance; new platforms that meet the moment, such as COVAX, and new historic efforts to improve global health security financing, including the Financial Intermediary Fund for Pandemic Prevention, Preparedness, and Response, we will forge fit-for-purpose coalitions and public-private alliances to take on the world’s toughest challenges.

A Prosperous World

We also will build new ways to work with allies and partners on development and the expansion of human dignity because we recognize they are integral to the security and prosperity of all Americans. Infectious diseases, terrorism, violent extremism, irregular migration, and other threats often emerge or accelerate due to deeper development challenges, and once they do, they do not recognize national borders. Transnational threats, in turn, undermine development, fuel poverty and human suffering, and feed a vicious circle.

The COVID-19 pandemic has eroded development gains and illuminated persistent inequities. Protracted conflicts, growing fragility, a resurgence of authoritarianism, and ever-more frequent climate shocks threaten people’s lives and livelihoods and global stability. Russia’s war against Ukraine has only aggravated these threats, contributing to a surge in food and energy prices, exacerbating poverty and eroding food security worldwide.

We will work to confront these shared challenges and recommit to advancing the Sustainable Development Goals by pursuing more inclusive development partnerships, especially by putting local partners in the driver’s seat, and by deploying a more expansive set of tools, including catalytic financing and integrated humanitarian, development, and peacebuilding actions. We are already applying this approach to helping vulnerable nations build resilience to the devastating impacts of the climate crisis through the President’s Emergency Plan for Adaptation and



Resilience (PREPARE) and in support of democratic renewal through the Partnerships for Democratic Development (PDD). We are also implementing this development approach to advance global health security and systems and to take principled humanitarian action while addressing the root causes of fragility, conflict, and crisis, including through the Global Fragility Act. We will use our humanitarian, development, and peacebuilding tools more cohesively. And we will invest in women and girls, be responsive to the voices and focus on the needs of the most marginalized, including the LGBTQI+ community; and advance inclusive development broadly.

Across our development work, we will continue to employ best practices that distinguish the United States and our partners from our competitors: transparency and accountability; high environmental, social, labor, and inclusion standards; respect for human rights; and local partnerships supported by foreign assistance and sound, sustainable financing. The international financial institutions, including the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, are also a force multiplier for our values and interests. Stronger, more stable growth abroad means a stronger economy here at home. As other economies prosper, demand for U.S. exports of goods and services increases, creating U.S. jobs. We will work to enhance the responsiveness of these institutions to U.S. priorities, including how to better support developing countries as they weather the pandemic and now the spillovers of the Russian war on Ukraine.

Modernizing and Strengthening Our Military

The American military is the strongest fighting force the world has ever known. America will not hesitate to use force when necessary to defend our national interests. But we will do so as the last resort and only when the objectives and mission are clear and achievable, consistent with our values and laws, alongside non-military tools, and the mission is undertaken with the informed consent of the American people.

Our approach to national defense is described in detail in the 2022 National Defense Strategy. Our starting premise is that a powerful U.S. military helps advance and safeguard vital U.S. national interests by backstopping diplomacy, confronting aggression, deterring conflict, projecting strength, and protecting the American people and their economic interests. Amid intensifying competition, the military's role is to maintain and gain warfighting advantages while limiting those of our competitors. The military will act urgently to sustain and strengthen deterrence, with the PRC as its pacing challenge. We will make disciplined choices regarding our national defense and focus our attention on the military's primary responsibilities: to defend the homeland, and deter attacks and aggression against the United States, our allies and partners, while being prepared to fight and win the Nation's wars should diplomacy and deterrence fail. To do so, we will combine our strengths to achieve maximum effect in deterring acts of aggression—an approach we refer to as integrated deterrence (see text box on page 22). We will operate our military using a campaigning mindset—sequencing logically linked military activities to advance strategy-aligned priorities. And, we will build a resilient force and defense ecosystem to ensure we can perform these functions for decades to come. We ended America's longest war in Afghanistan, and with it an era of major military operations to remake other societies, even as we have maintained the capacity to address terrorist threats to the American people as they emerge.



A combat-credible military is the foundation of deterrence and America's ability to prevail in conflict. We will modernize the joint force to be lethal, resilient, sustainable, survivable, agile, and responsive, prioritizing operational concepts and updated warfighting capabilities. The war in Ukraine highlights the criticality of a vibrant Defense Industrial Base for the United States and its allies and partners. It must not only be capable of rapidly manufacturing proven capabilities needed to defend against adversary aggression, but also empowered to innovate and creatively design solutions as battlefield conditions evolve. As emerging technologies transform warfare and pose novel threats to the United States and our allies and partners, we are investing in a range of advanced technologies including applications in the cyber and space domains, missile defeat capabilities, trusted artificial intelligence, and quantum systems, while deploying new capabilities to the battlefield in a timely manner. Incorporating allies and partners at every stage of defense planning is crucial to meaningful collaboration. We also seek to remove barriers to deeper collaboration with allies and partners, to include issues related to joint capability development and production to safeguard our shared military-technological edge.

Nuclear deterrence remains a top priority for the Nation and foundational to integrated deterrence. A safe, secure, and effective nuclear force undergirds our defense priorities by deterring strategic attacks, assuring allies and partners, and allowing us to achieve our objectives if deterrence fails. Our competitors and potential adversaries are investing heavily in new nuclear weapons. By the 2030s, the United States for the first time will need to deter two major nuclear powers, each of whom will field modern and diverse global and regional nuclear forces. To ensure our nuclear deterrent remains responsive to the threats we face, we are modernizing the nuclear Triad, nuclear command, control, and communications, and our nuclear weapons infrastructure, as well as strengthening our extended deterrence commitments to our Allies. We remain equally committed to reducing the risks of nuclear war. This includes taking further steps to reduce the role of nuclear weapons in our strategy and pursuing realistic goals for mutual, verifiable arms control, which contribute to our deterrence strategy and strengthen the global non-proliferation regime.

The most important investments are those made in the extraordinary All-Volunteer Force of the Army, Marine Corps, Navy, Air Force, Space Force, Coast Guard—together with our Department of Defense civilian workforce. Our service members are the backbone of America's national defense and we are committed to their wellbeing and their families while in service and beyond. We will maintain our foundational principle of civilian control of the military, recognizing that healthy civil-military relations rooted in mutual respect are essential to military effectiveness. We will strengthen the effectiveness of the force by promoting diversity and inclusion; intensifying our suicide prevention efforts; eliminating the scourges of sexual assault, harassment, and other forms of violence, abuse, and discrimination; and rooting out violent extremism. We will also uphold our Nation's sacred obligation to care for veterans and their families when our troops return home.



Integrated Deterrence

The United States has a vital interest in deterring aggression by the PRC, Russia, and other states. More capable competitors and new strategies of threatening behavior below and above the traditional threshold of conflict mean we cannot afford to rely solely on conventional forces and nuclear deterrence. Our defense strategy must sustain and strengthen deterrence, with the PRC as our pacing challenge.

Our National Defense Strategy relies on integrated deterrence: the seamless combination of capabilities to convince potential adversaries that the costs of their hostile activities outweigh their benefits. It entails:

- **Integration across domains**, recognizing that our competitors' strategies operate across military (land, air, maritime, cyber, and space) and non-military (economic, technological, and information) domains—and we must too.
- **Integration across regions**, understanding that our competitors combine expansive ambitions with growing capabilities to threaten U.S. interests in key regions and in the homeland.
- **Integration across the spectrum of conflict** to prevent competitors from altering the status quo in ways that harm our vital interests while hovering below the threshold of armed conflict.
- **Integration across the U.S. Government** to leverage the full array of American advantages, from diplomacy, intelligence, and economic tools to security assistance and force posture decisions.
- **Integration with allies and partners** through investments in interoperability and joint capability development, cooperative posture planning, and coordinated diplomatic and economic approaches.

Integrated deterrence requires us to more effectively coordinate, network, and innovate so that any competitor thinking about pressing for advantage in one domain understands that we can respond in many others as well. This augments the traditional backstop of combat-credible conventional and strategic capabilities, allowing us to better shape adversary perceptions of risks and costs of action against core U.S. interests, at any time and across any domain.



PART III: OUR GLOBAL PRIORITIES

“[T]he challenges we face today are great indeed, but our capacity is greater. Our commitment must be greater still. So let’s stand together to again declare the unmistakable resolve that nations of the world are united still, that we stand for the values of the U.N. Charter, that we still believe by working together we can bend the arc of history toward a freer and more just world for all our children, although none of us have fully achieved it. We’re not passive witnesses to history; we are the authors of history. We can do this—we have to do it—for ourselves and for our future, for humankind.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR

77th Session of the United Nations General Assembly

The steps outlined in the previous section—building our strength at home to maintain a competitive edge; using our diplomatic power to build the strongest possible coalition to support a world that is open, free, prosperous, and secure; and modernizing and strengthening our military will position the United States to strengthen an international order that has delivered broad benefits for the American people for decades and to outcompete our rivals who offer a different vision. The breadth and complexity of our global interests mean that we need to use that power strategically. Three interlinked lines of effort are of paramount importance—dealing with the challenges to the international order posed by our strategic competitors, addressing shared global challenges, and shaping the rules of the road for technology, cybersecurity, and trade and economics.

Out-Competing China and Constraining Russia

The PRC and Russia are increasingly aligned with each other but the challenges they pose are, in important ways, distinct. We will prioritize maintaining an enduring competitive edge over the PRC while constraining a still profoundly dangerous Russia.

China

The PRC is the only competitor with both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to do it. Beijing has ambitions to create an enhanced sphere of influence in the Indo-Pacific and to become the world’s leading power. It is using its technological capacity and increasing influence over international institutions to create more permissive conditions for its own authoritarian model, and to mold global technology use and norms to privilege its interests and values. Beijing frequently uses its economic power to coerce countries. It benefits from the openness of the international economy while limiting access to its domestic market, and it seeks to make the world more dependent on the PRC while reducing its own dependence on the world. The PRC is



also investing in a military that is rapidly modernizing, increasingly capable in the Indo-Pacific, and growing in strength and reach globally – all while seeking to erode U.S. alliances in the region and around the world.

At the same time, the PRC is also central to the global economy and has a significant impact on shared challenges, particularly climate change and global public health. It is possible for the United States and the PRC to coexist peacefully, and share in and contribute to human progress together.

Our strategy toward the PRC is threefold: 1) to invest in the foundations of our strength at home – our competitiveness, our innovation, our resilience, our democracy, 2) to align our efforts with our network of allies and partners, acting with common purpose and in common cause, and 3) compete responsibly with the PRC to defend our interests and build our vision for the future. The first two elements— invest and align— are described in the previous section and are essential to out-competing the PRC in the technological, economic, political, military, intelligence, and global governance domains.

Competition with the PRC is most pronounced in the Indo-Pacific, but it is also increasingly global. Around the world, the contest to write the rules of the road and shape the relationships that govern global affairs is playing out in every region and across economics, technology, diplomacy, development, security, and global governance.

In the competition with the PRC, as in other arenas, it is clear that the next ten years will be the decisive decade. We stand now at the inflection point, where the choices we make and the priorities we pursue today will set us on a course that determines our competitive position long into the future.

Many of our allies and partners, especially in the Indo-Pacific, stand on the frontlines of the PRC's coercion and are rightly determined to seek to ensure their own autonomy, security, and prosperity. We will support their ability to make sovereign decisions in line with their interests and values, free from external pressure, and work to provide high-standard and scaled investment, development assistance, and markets. Our strategy will require us to partner with, support, and meet the economic and development needs of partner countries, not for the sake of competition, but for their own sake. We will act in common purpose to address a range of issues – from untrusted digital infrastructure and forced labor in supply chains and illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing. We will hold Beijing accountable for abuses – genocide and crimes against humanity in Xinjiang, human rights violations in Tibet, and the dismantling of Hong Kong's autonomy and freedoms – even as it seeks to pressure countries and communities into silence. We will continue prioritizing investments in a combat credible military that deters aggression against our allies and partners in the region, and can help those allies and partners defend themselves.

We have an abiding interest in maintaining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait, which is critical to regional and global security and prosperity and a matter of international concern and attention. We oppose any unilateral changes to the status quo from either side, and do not support Taiwan independence. We remain committed to our one China policy, which is guided by the Taiwan Relations Act, the Three Joint Communiques, and the Six Assurances. And we will uphold our commitments under the Taiwan Relations Act to support Taiwan's self-defense and to maintain our capacity to resist any resort to force or coercion against Taiwan.



Though allies and partners may have distinct perspectives on the PRC, our diplomatic approach, and the PRC's own behavior, has produced significant and growing opportunities to align approaches and deliver results. Across Europe, Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and Latin America, countries are clear-eyed about the nature of the challenges that the PRC poses. Governments want sustainable public finances. Workers want to be treated with dignity and respect. Innovators want to be rewarded for their ingenuity, risk-taking, and persistent efforts. And enterprising businesses want open and free waters through which their products can be traded.

While we compete vigorously, we will manage the competition responsibly. We will seek greater strategic stability through measures that reduce the risk of unintended military escalation, enhance crisis communications, build mutual transparency, and ultimately engage Beijing on more formal arms control efforts. We will always be willing to work with the PRC where our interests align. We can't let the disagreements that divide us stop us from moving forward on the priorities that demand that we work together, for the good of our people and for the good of the world. That includes on climate, pandemic threats, nonproliferation, countering illicit and illegal narcotics, the global food crisis, and macroeconomic issues. In short, we'll engage constructively with the PRC wherever we can, not as a favor to us or anyone else, and never in exchange for walking away from our principles, but because working together to solve great challenges is what the world expects from great powers, and because it's directly in our interest. No country should withhold progress on existential transnational issues like the climate crisis because of bilateral differences.

While we have profound differences with the Chinese Communist Party and the Chinese Government, those differences are between governments and systems – not between our people. Ties of family and friendship continue to connect the American and the Chinese people. We deeply respect their achievements, their history, and their culture. Racism and hate have no place in a nation built by generations of immigrants to fulfill the promise of opportunity for all. And we intend to work together to solve issues that matter most to the people of both countries.

Russia

Over the past decade, the Russian government has chosen to pursue an imperialist foreign policy with the goal of overturning key elements of the international order. This culminated in a full-scale invasion of Ukraine in an attempt to topple its government and bring it under Russian control. But, this attack did not come out of the blue; it was preceded by Russia's 2014 invasion of Ukraine, its military intervention in Syria, its longstanding efforts to destabilize its neighbors using intelligence and cyber capabilities, and its blatant attempts to undermine internal democratic processes in countries across Europe, Central Asia, and around the world. Russia has also interfered brazenly in U.S. politics and worked to sow divisions among the American people. And Russia's destabilizing actions are not limited to the international arena. Domestically, the Russian government under President Putin violates its citizens' human rights, suppresses its opposition, and shuts independent media. Russia now has a stagnant political system that is unresponsive to the needs of its people.

The United States, under successive administrations, made considerable efforts at multiple points to reach out to Russia to limit our rivalry and identify pragmatic areas of cooperation. President Putin spurned these efforts and it is now clear he will not change. Russia now poses an immediate and persistent threat to international peace and stability. This is not about a struggle between the West and Russia. It is about the fundamental principles of the UN Charter, which



Russia is a party to, particularly respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity, and the prohibition against acquiring territory through war.

We are leading a united, principled, and resolute response to Russia's invasion and we have rallied the world to support the Ukrainian people as they bravely defend their country. Working with a broad and durable international coalition, we have marshalled near-record levels of security assistance to ensure Ukraine has the means to defend itself. We have provided humanitarian, economic and development assistance to strengthen Ukraine's sovereign, elected government and help the millions of refugees who have been forced to flee their homes. We will continue to stand with the people of Ukraine as they fight back against Russia's naked aggression. And we will rally the world to hold Russia accountable for the atrocities they have unleashed across Ukraine.

Alongside our allies and partners, America is helping to make Russia's war on Ukraine a strategic failure. Across Europe, NATO and the European Union are united in standing up to Russia and defending shared values. We are constraining Russia's strategic economic sectors, including defense and aerospace, and we will continue to counter Russia's attempts to weaken and destabilize sovereign nations and undermine multilateral institutions. Together with our NATO Allies, we are strengthening our defense and deterrence, particularly on the eastern flank of the Alliance. Welcoming Finland and Sweden to NATO will further improve our security and capabilities. And we are renewing our focus on bolstering our collective resilience against shared threats from Russia, including asymmetric threats. More broadly, Putin's war has profoundly diminished Russia's status vis-a-vis China and other Asian powers such as India and Japan. Moscow's soft power and diplomatic influence have waned, while its efforts to weaponize energy have backfired. The historic global response to Russia's war against Ukraine sends a resounding message that countries cannot enjoy the benefits of global integration while trampling on the core tenets of the UN Charter.

While some aspects of our approach will depend on the trajectory of the war in Ukraine, a number of elements are already clear. First, the United States will continue to support Ukraine in its fight for its freedom, we will help Ukraine recover economically, and we will encourage its regional integration with the European Union. Second, the United States will defend every inch of NATO territory and will continue to build and deepen a coalition with allies and partners to prevent Russia from causing further harm to European security, democracy, and institutions. Third, the United States will deter and, as necessary, respond to Russian actions that threaten core U.S. interests, including Russian attacks on our infrastructure and our democracy. Fourth, Russia's conventional military will have been weakened, which will likely increase Moscow's reliance on nuclear weapons in its military planning. The United States will not allow Russia, or any power, to achieve its objectives through using, or threatening to use, nuclear weapons. America retains an interest in preserving strategic stability and developing a more expansive, transparent, and verifiable arms control infrastructure to succeed New START and in rebuilding European security arrangements which, due to Russia's actions, have fallen in to disrepair. Finally, the United States will sustain and develop pragmatic modes of interaction to handle issues on which dealing with Russia can be mutually beneficial.

The United States respects the Russian people and their contributions to science, culture and constructive bilateral relations over many decades. Notwithstanding the Russian government's strategic miscalculation in attacking Ukraine, it is the Russian people who will determine Russia's future as a major power capable of once more playing a constructive role in



international affairs. The United States will welcome such a future, and in the meantime, will continue to push back against the aggression perpetrated by the Russian government.

Cooperating on Shared Challenges

The United States must maintain and increase international cooperation on shared challenges even in an age of greater inter-state competition. In an ideal world, governments would compete responsibly where their interests diverge and cooperate where they converge—but things have not always worked out this way in practice. The United States, for example, has made clear that we will not support the linkage of issues in a way that conditions cooperation on shared challenges, but some in Beijing have been equally clear that the PRC should expect concessions on unrelated issues as a prerequisite to cooperation on shared challenges, such as climate change. We have also seen how the PRC chose not to cooperate adequately with the World Health Organization and the international community on the global response to COVID-19, including on the investigation into its origins. It also continues to endanger the world with inadequate action on climate change domestically, particularly regarding massive coal power use and build up.

Our strategy to tackle the shared challenges that require global cooperation involves two simultaneous tracks: on one track, we will fully engage all countries and institutions to cooperate on shared threats, including by pressing for reforms where institutional responses have proven inadequate. At the same time, we will also redouble our efforts to deepen our cooperation with like-minded partners. Across both tracks, we will also seek to harness the positive effects of competition, promoting a race to the top, to increase international efforts on these challenges.

Climate and Energy Security

The climate crisis is the existential challenge of our time. A warming planet endangers Americans and people around the world—risking food and water supplies, public health, and infrastructure and our national security. Without immediate global action to reduce emissions, scientists tell us we will soon exceed 1.5 degrees of warming, locking in further extreme heat and weather, rising sea levels, and catastrophic biodiversity loss.

Global action begins at home, where we are making unprecedented generational investments in the clean energy transition through the IRA, simultaneously creating millions of good paying jobs and strengthening American industries. We are enhancing Federal, state, and local preparedness against and resilience to growing extreme weather threats, and we're integrating climate change into our national security planning and policies. This domestic work is key to our international credibility, and to getting other countries to up their own ambition and action.

The United States is galvanizing the world and incentivizing further action. Building on the Leaders' Summit on Climate, Major Economies Forum, and Paris Agreement process, we are helping countries meet and strengthen their nationally determined contributions, reduce emissions, tackle methane and other super pollutants, promote carbon dioxide removals, adapt to the most severe impacts of climate change, and end deforestation over the next decade. We're also using our economic heft to drive decarbonization. Our steel agreement with the EU, the first-ever arrangement on steel and aluminum to address both carbon intensity and global overcapacity, is a model for future climate-focused trade mechanisms. And we are ending public



finance for unabated coal power, and mobilizing financing to speed investments in adaptation and the energy transition.

Events like Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine have made clear the urgent need to accelerate the transition away from fossil fuels. We know that long-term energy security depends on clean energy. Recognizing this transition will not happen overnight, we will work with partners and allies to ensure energy security and affordability, secure access to critical mineral supply chains, and create a just transition for impacted workers. Through collaborative work in the International Energy Agency, the U.S.-EU Task Force on European Energy Security, the Clean Energy Ministerial and Mission Innovation, Power Africa, the Eastern Mediterranean Gas Forum, the Partnership for Transatlantic Energy and Climate Cooperation, and other critical fora, we will drive concrete action to achieve an energy secure future.

Many low-income and lower-middle income countries need assistance, especially for mitigation and adaptation efforts. That is why we are aiming to provide over \$11 billion in annual climate funding, and are pressing partners to increase their own contributions. We are embedding climate change into the investment strategies of our development finance institutions, including through PGII, and working with international organizations like the World Bank and regional development banks to do the same.

Pandemics and Biodefense

COVID-19 has killed nearly 6.5 million people around the world, including more than 1 million Americans, but the next pandemic could be much worse—as contagious but more lethal. We have a narrow window of opportunity to take steps nationally and internationally to prepare for the next pandemic and to strengthen our biodefense.

In the United States, that requires preparing for catastrophic biological risks, including by improving early warning and disease surveillance, data sharing and forecasting; speeding development, domestic manufacturing, and delivery of medical countermeasures; advancing safe biotechnology development and manufacturing; and overcoming inequities in care quality and access.

Internationally, it requires action on multiple fronts. The United States has recommitted to COVAX, to which we are the largest donor, the World Health Organization, and a cooperative approach toward global health security. We recognize that no one is safe until everyone is safe, which is why we have donated more vaccines internationally than any other country, with no political strings attached. We are working with allies and partners, including philanthropic organizations and the private sector, to boost sustainable vaccine manufacturing in Africa and South Asia.

We recognize that we must engage with all countries on global public health, including those with whom we disagree, because pandemics know no borders. We also acknowledge that some of our international institutions have fallen short in the past and need to be reformed. While we believe that many of these reforms can be agreed upon and implemented over the lifetime of this administration, we also recognize that ultimately some may fall short because other countries do not share our belief in greater transparency and sharing critical data with the international community. Therefore, as we engage globally and through international institutions, we will also deepen our cooperation with like-minded states to push for reforms on pandemic preparedness and if necessary to work more closely together to set higher standards that others can emulate.



We will also tackle the increasing risk posed by deliberate and accidental biological risks, including through our ability to rapidly detect, identify, and attribute agents, and to develop medical countermeasures. Working with partners and allies, we will strengthen the Biological Weapons Convention to deter state biological warfare capabilities; prevent terrorist acquisition or use of biological weapons; and reinforce international norms against biological weapons' development and use. We will also reduce biological risks associated with advancements in technologies and dual-use research and development, including by establishing and strengthening international biosafety and biosecurity norms and practices.

Food Insecurity

Global food systems today are under threat from a variety of sources, including Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the economic impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic, climate events, and protracted conflicts—all of which threaten to push 75-95 million more people into extreme poverty in 2022 than were expected before the pandemic. The food insecurity crisis has become particularly dangerous because of Russia's aggression against Ukraine, which took much of Ukraine's grain off the market and exacerbated an already worsening global food insecurity problem. To address the needs of the hundreds of millions of people now suffering as a result, the United States is providing more humanitarian assistance than ever before. We remain the largest contributor to the World Food Programme and the leading donor in nearly every country experiencing a humanitarian food crisis.

Over the longer term, we are rallying the world to find ways to deal with the broad set of challenges for the world's food supply achieving sustained global food security demands constant vigilance and action by all governments, in partnership with multilateral institutions and non-governmental organizations. Working together with our partners, we launched the Roadmap for Global Food Security: A Call to Action which urges the more than 100 signatory states to take several actions including keeping food and agricultural markets open, increasing fertilizer production, and investing in climate-resilient agriculture. The United States is also implementing the Global Food Security Strategy, which focuses on reducing global poverty, hunger, and malnutrition by supporting inclusive and sustainable agriculture-led economic growth; strengthening resilience among people and food systems; and supporting well-nourished healthy populations, especially among women and children. This requires working across entire food systems to consider every step from cultivation to consumption, and to integrate these efforts within larger climate, health, conflict mitigation, and peacebuilding work. To ensure these efforts are durable and sustainable requires centering equity and inclusion, and partnering both with local partners and international bodies. Going forward, the United States must continue to address both acute needs and work collaboratively to build sustained food security for the long term.

Arms Control and Non-Proliferation

Nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons proliferation is a vitally important and enduring global challenge, requiring sustained collaboration to prevent the spread of weapons of mass destruction and fissile material, their means of delivery, and enabling technologies. The United States will work with allies and partners, civil society, and international organizations to strengthen arms control and nonproliferation mechanisms, especially during times of conflict when escalation risks are greater. We will address the existential threat posed by the proliferation



of nuclear weapons through renewed arms control and nonproliferation leadership. We will continue to seek pragmatic engagement with competitors about strategic stability and risk reduction. Our approach will emphasize measures that head off costly arms races, reduce the likelihood of miscalculation, and complement U.S. and allied deterrence strategies.

We will lead bilateral and multilateral arms control efforts and strengthen existing regimes, frameworks, and institutions, including the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty Organization, International Atomic Energy Agency, and other United Nations bodies, to extend the more than seven-decade record of nuclear non-use. We will support the Organization for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons and the Biological Weapons Convention and reinforce norms against the possession and use of chemical and biological weapons. We will continue to lead the world in coordinated efforts to lock down nuclear and radiological materials and prevent terrorist acquisition. And we will ensure multilateral export control regimes are equipped to address destabilizing emerging technologies and to align export policies in likeminded states toward countries of concern.

Terrorism

Today's terrorist threat is more ideologically diverse and geographically diffuse than that of two decades ago. Al-Qa'ida, ISIS, and associated forces have expanded from Afghanistan and the Middle East into Africa and Southeast Asia.

Syria, Yemen, and Somalia remain terrorist sanctuaries; local affiliates have become entrenched actors in regional conflicts. Many of these groups still intend to carry out or inspire others to attack the United States and our interests abroad, even as years of sustained counterterrorism and law enforcement pressure have constrained their capabilities, and enhanced security measures and information sharing have improved our defenses. Meanwhile, we face sharply increased threats from a range of domestic violent extremists here in the United States.

America remains steadfast in protecting our country and our people and facilities overseas from the full spectrum of terrorism threats that we face in the 21st century. As the threat evolves, so too must our counterterrorism approach. To that end, last year, we ended America's longest war, in Afghanistan, having long ago achieved our objective of delivering justice to Osama Bin Laden and other key leadership of al-Qa'ida. We are confident in our ability to maintain the fight against al-Qa'ida, ISIS, and associated forces from over the horizon, as we demonstrated with the operation to kill Ayman al-Zawahiri. We will ensure Afghanistan never again serves as a safe haven for terrorist attacks on the United States or our allies and we will hold the Taliban accountable for its public commitments on counterterrorism.

Around the world, we will increase cooperation and support to trusted partners, shifting from a strategy that is "U.S.-led, partner-enabled" to one that is "partner-led, U.S.-enabled." That requires building or expanding systems to prevent, detect, and respond to threats as they develop—including by strengthening partners' law enforcement and judicial systems, improving threat information sharing, enhancing border security, countering terrorist financing, targeting terrorist prevention and extremist disengagement programming, and preventing online and offline terrorist recruitment and mobilization to violence. It also necessitates addressing the root causes of radicalization by leveraging U.S. and partner efforts to support effective governance, promote stabilization and economic development, and resolve ongoing conflicts.



Where necessary, we will use force to disrupt and degrade terrorist groups that are plotting attacks against the United States, our people, or our diplomatic and military facilities abroad. We will do so consistent with domestic and international law and in a manner that minimizes civilian casualties, while promoting greater transparency and accountability. We are committed to continuing to work with the Congress to replace outdated authorizations for the use of military force with a narrow and specific framework appropriate to ensure that we can continue to protect Americans from terrorist threats. Here at home, we will continue to work with state, local, tribal, and territorial partners and the private sector to share information and disrupt terrorist plots that threaten our citizens.

We face an increased and significant threat within the United States from a range of domestic violent extremists, including those motivated by racial or ethnic prejudice, as well as anti-government or anti-authority sentiment. Continuing to implement our first-ever National Strategy for Countering Domestic Terrorism will enable us to better understand and share information regarding the domestic terrorist threat, prevent recruitment and mobilization to violence, and disrupt and deter domestic terrorist activity and any transnational linkages—all while reinforcing respect for civil rights and civil liberties. Already, we are providing more and better information on domestic violent extremist threats to state, local, territorial, and tribal partners, and using new mechanisms, such as smartphone-based applications, to do so in real time. We are investing millions of dollars in data-driven violence prevention efforts, including through grant programs available to Federal, state, territorial, tribal, and nonprofit partners, as well as to houses of worship as they face increased threats. We are working with like-minded governments, civil society, and the technology sector to address terrorist and violent extremist content online, including through innovative research collaborations. And we are confronting the long-term contributors to domestic violent extremist threats, including working with Congress to advance commonsense gun laws and policies, and addressing the crisis of disinformation and misinformation, often channeled through social and other media platforms, that can fuel extreme polarization and lead some individuals to violence.



Combatting Transnational Organized Crime

Transnational organized crime impacts a growing number of victims while amplifying other consequential global challenges, from migration to cyber-attacks. Transnational criminal organizations (TCOs) are involved in activities such as the trafficking of drugs and other illicit goods, money laundering, theft, human smuggling and trafficking, cybercrime, fraud, corruption, and illegal fishing and mining. These activities feed violence in our communities, endanger public safety and health, and contribute to tens of thousands of drug-overdose deaths in the United States each year. They degrade the security and stability of our neighbors and partners by undermining the rule of law, fostering corruption, acting as proxies for hostile state activities, and exploiting and endangering vulnerable populations. We will accelerate our efforts to curb the threat posed by transnational organized crime, integrating the vital work of law enforcement with diplomatic, financial, intelligence, and other tools, and in coordination with foreign partners. As part of this effort, we will work to reduce the availability of illicit drugs in the United States, especially the growing scourge of fentanyl and methamphetamines, by bringing all the tools of government to bear to interdict drugs and disrupt TCO's supply chains and the financial networks that enable their corrosive activities. Recognizing that this is a problem with global reach we will work closely with our international partners to stop TCOs from getting precursor chemicals and work closely with private industry to increase vigilance and prevent the diversion of chemicals for illicit fentanyl production.

Shaping the Rules of the Road

Since 1945, the United States has led the creation of institutions, norms, and standards to govern international trade and investment, economic policy, and technology. These mechanisms advanced America's economic and geopolitical aims and benefited people around the world by shaping how governments and economies interacted—and did so in ways that aligned with U.S. interests and values. These mechanisms have not kept pace with economic or technological changes, and today risk being irrelevant, or in certain cases, actively harmful to solving the challenges we now face—from insecure supply chains to widening inequality to the abuses of the PRC's nonmarket economic actions. We are endeavoring to strengthen and update the UN system and multilateral institutions generally. Nowhere is this need more acute than in updating the rules of the road for technology, cyberspace, trade, and economics.

By doing so in close coordination with our allies and partners, we will establish fair rules while also sustaining our economic and technological edge and shape a future defined by fair competition—because when American workers and companies compete on a level playing field, they win.

Technology

Technology is central to today's geopolitical competition and to the future of our national security, economy and democracy. U.S. and allied leadership in technology and innovation has long underpinned our economic prosperity and military strength. In the next decade, critical and emerging technologies are poised to retool economies, transform militaries, and reshape the



world. The United States is committed to a future where these technologies increase the security, prosperity, and values of the American people and like-minded democracies. Our technology strategy will enable the United States and like-minded democracies to work together to pioneer new medicines that can cure diseases, increase the production of healthy foods that are sustainably grown, diversify and strengthen our manufacturing supply chains, and secure energy without reliance on fossil fuels, all while delivering new jobs and security for the American people and our allies and partners. With bipartisan support, we have launched a modern industrial strategy and already secured historic investments in clean energy, microelectronics manufacturing, research, and development, and biotechnology, and we will work with Congress to fully fund historic new authorizations for research and development. We also are doubling down on our longstanding and asymmetric strategic advantage: attracting and retaining the world's best talent. Attracting a higher volume of global STEM talent is a priority for our national security and supply chain security, so we will aggressively implement recent visa actions and work with Congress to do more.

These investments will enable the United States to anchor an allied techno-industrial base that will safeguard our shared security, prosperity and values. This means working with allies and partners to harness and scale new technologies, and promote the foundational technologies of the 21st century, especially microelectronics, advanced computing and quantum technologies, artificial intelligence, biotechnology and biomanufacturing, advanced telecommunications, and clean energy technologies. We also will partner with like-minded nations to co-develop and deploy technologies in a way that benefits all, not only the powerful, and build robust and durable supply chains so that countries cannot use economic warfare to coerce others.

We are already rallying like-minded actors to advance an international technology ecosystem that protects the integrity of international standards development and promotes the free flow of data and ideas with trust, while protecting our security, privacy, and human rights, and enhancing our competitiveness. That includes work through the U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council to foster transatlantic coordination on semiconductor and critical mineral supply chains, trustworthy artificial intelligence, disinformation, the misuse of technology threatening security and human rights, export controls, and investment screening, as well as through the Indo-Pacific Quad on critical and emerging technologies, open, next-generation digital infrastructure, and people-to-people exchanges. Across this work, we seek to bolster U.S. and allied technology leadership, advance inclusive and responsible technology development, close regulatory and legal gaps, strengthen supply chain security, and enhance cooperation on privacy, data sharing, and digital trade.

We must ensure strategic competitors cannot exploit foundational American and allied technologies, know-how, or data to undermine American and allied security. We are therefore modernizing and strengthening our export control and investment screening mechanisms, and also pursuing targeted new approaches, such as screening of outbound investment, to prevent strategic competitors from exploiting investments and expertise in ways that threaten our national security, while also protecting the integrity of allied technological ecosystems and markets. We will also work to counter the exploitation of American's sensitive data and illegitimate use of technology, including commercial spyware and surveillance technology, and we will stand against digital authoritarianism.

To achieve these goals, the digital backbones of the modern economy must be open, trusted, interoperable, reliable, and secure. That requires working with a broad range of partners to



advance network infrastructure resilience in 5G and other advanced communication technologies, including by promoting vendor diversity and securing supply chains. These investments cannot just be made in wealthy countries; we must also focus on providing high-quality digital infrastructure in low- and middle-income countries, bridging digital divides by emphasizing access among marginalized groups. To ensure these investments support positive technological outcomes, we will partner with industry and governments in shaping technological standards that ensure quality, consumer safety, and global interoperability, and to advance the open and transparent standards process that has enabled innovation, growth, and interconnectivity for decades. And in all that we do we will strive to ensure that technology supports, and does not undermine, democracy, and is developed, deployed, and governed in accordance with human rights.

Securing Cyberspace

Our societies, and the critical infrastructure that supports them, from power to pipelines, is increasingly digital and vulnerable to disruption or destruction via cyber attacks. Such attacks have been used by countries, such as Russia, to undermine countries' ability to deliver services to citizens and coerce populations. We are working closely with allies and partners, such as the Quad, to define standards for critical infrastructure to rapidly improve our cyber resilience, and building collective capabilities to rapidly respond to attacks. In the face of disruptive cyber attacks from criminals, we have launched innovative partnerships, to expand law enforcement cooperation, deny sanctuary to cyber criminals and counter illicit use of cryptocurrency to launder the proceeds of cybercrime. As an open society, the United States has a clear interest in strengthening norms that mitigate cyber threats and enhance stability in cyberspace. We aim to deter cyber attacks from state and non state actors and will respond decisively with all appropriate tools of national power to hostile acts in cyberspace, including those that disrupt or degrade vital national functions or critical infrastructure. We will continue to promote adherence to the UN General Assembly-endorsed framework of responsible state behavior in cyberspace, which recognizes that international law applies online, just as it does offline.

Trade and Economics

America's prosperity also relies on a fair and open trade and international economic system. The United States has long benefited from international trade's ability to promote global economic growth, lower consumer prices, and access to foreign markets to promote U.S. exports and jobs. At the same time, the longstanding rules that govern trade and other means of economic exchange have been violated by non-market actors, like the PRC; were designed to privilege corporate mobility over workers and the environment, thereby exacerbating inequality and the climate crisis; and fail to cover the frontiers of the modern economy, including digital trade. The United States must once again rally partners around rules for creating a level playing field that will enable American workers and businesses—and those of partners and allies around the world—to thrive.

As our recent work to create IPEF and the Americas Prosperity for Economic Prosperity show, we are working to update the current trading system to promote equitable and resilient growth—encouraging robust trade, countering anticompetitive practices, bringing worker voices to the decision-making table, and ensuring high labor and environmental standards. We will seek new export opportunities that benefit American workers and companies, especially small- and



medium-sized enterprises, push back on abuses by non-market economies, and enforce rules against unfair trade and labor practices, including intellectual property theft, discriminatory regulations, forced labor, the denial of the right to organize, and other forms of labor repression. We will also use trade tools to advance climate priorities, as we are doing with the landmark steel and aluminum agreement with the EU. These arrangements will be accompanied by real adjustment assistance, ensuring all Americans have a dignified place in our shared future. Taken together, these efforts will create growth and innovation that benefits not only Americans, but people around the world.

Beyond trade, we are working to build an international economic system fit for contemporary realities. We will tackle the harms caused to U.S. workers, consumers, and businesses by currency manipulation; counter corruption and illicit finance; and end the race to the bottom for corporate taxation through promotion of the OECD's Global Minimum Tax. We will partner with countries on sustainable development, including by responding to global debt challenges and financing quality infrastructure through PGII. We will explore the merits and responsibly lead development of digital assets, including a digital dollar, with high standards and protections for stability, privacy, and security to benefit a strong and inclusive U.S. financial system and reinforce its global primacy. And we will address growth-stymying legal, structural, and cultural barriers that undermine labor force participation for women and marginalized groups. We will also support efforts by the international financial institutions will also need to continue to evolve to meet the challenges of our times. Many of the biggest challenges in our world today—such as pandemics and health, climate change, fragility, migration and refugee flows—cross borders and disproportionately affect the poorest, most vulnerable populations. Bolstering these institutions is also critical to tackling serious long-term challenges to the international order, such as those posed by the PRC.

Hostages and Wrongful Detainees

Using human beings as pawns is antithetical to American values and to the global order to which we aspire. Yet, that is what governments, regimes, and non-state actors do when they hold Americans against their will as hostages and wrongful detainees. We are working with our partners to deter and thwart those inhumane tactics. That includes our issuance in July 2022 of an executive order implementing a recent U.S. law called the Levinson Act and unlocking new tools for punishing those who wrongfully kidnap or detain Americans abroad. And it includes working with key international partners to promote and implement the Canadian-launched Declaration Against Arbitrary Detention in State-to-State Relations so as to turn the tide against this inhumane practice and forge international norms against it.



Countering Corruption

Corruption poses a fundamental threat to the rule of law. When government officials abuse public power for private gain, it degrades the business environment, subverts economic opportunity, and exacerbates inequality. Corruption also contributes to reduced public trust in state institutions, which in turn can add to the appeal of illiberal actors who exploit popular grievances for political advantage. In today's globalized world, international financial systems are used to stash illicit wealth abroad and to send bribes across borders. The United States Strategy on Countering Corruption recognizes the unique threat corruption poses to our national security and places a special emphasis on recognizing the ways in which corrupt actors have used the U.S. financial system and other rule-of-law based systems to launder their ill-gotten gains. In response to Russia's continued invasion of Ukraine, the United States ramped up its kleptocracy initiatives aimed at recovering corruption proceeds as well as both identifying and repatriating the laundered proceeds of crime. Finally, the United States will elevate and expand the scale of diplomatic engagement and foreign assistance, including by enhancing partner governments' capacities to fight corruption in cooperation with U.S. law enforcement authorities and bolstering the prevention and oversight capacities of willing governments.



PART IV: OUR STRATEGY BY REGION

“There’s a fundamental truth of the 21st century within each of our own countries and as a global community that our own success is bound up with others succeeding as well. To deliver for our own people, we must also engage deeply with the rest of the world. To ensure that our own future, we must work together with other partners—our partners—toward a shared future. Our security, our prosperity, and our very freedoms are interconnected, in my view, as never before. And so, I believe we must work together as never before.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR.

76th Session of the United Nations General Assembly

The United States can meet the challenges of this decisive decade only by partnering with countries and people around the world. Americans rely on and benefit from our broad and deep relationships in every region; invest in and trade with nearly every country; and study, work, and live on every continent. Our future and the world’s are interlinked. That is why our strategy is global.

Promote a Free and Open Indo-Pacific

The Indo-Pacific fuels much of the world’s economic growth and will be the epicenter of 21st century geopolitics. As an Indo-Pacific power, the United States has a vital interest in realizing a region that is open, interconnected, prosperous, secure, and resilient.

The United States will work with other regional states to keep the Indo-Pacific open and accessible and ensure that nations are free to make their own choices, consistent with obligations under international law. We support open societies through investments in democratic institutions, free press, and civil society and are cooperating with partners to counter information manipulation and corruption. And we will affirm freedom of the seas and build shared regional support for open access to the South China Sea—a thoroughway for nearly two-thirds of global maritime trade and a quarter of all global trade.

A free and open Indo-Pacific can only be achieved if we build collective capacity. We are deepening our five regional treaty alliances and closest partnerships. We affirm the centrality of ASEAN, and seek deeper bonds with Southeast Asian partners. We will expand our regional diplomatic, development, and economic engagement, with a particular focus on Southeast Asia and the Pacific Islands. As we work with South Asian regional partners to address climate change, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the PRC’s coercive behavior, we will promote prosperity and economic connectivity across the Indian Ocean region. The Quad and AUKUS will also be critical to addressing regional challenges, and we will further reinforce our collective strength by weaving our allies and partners closer together—including by encouraging tighter linkages between likeminded Indo-Pacific and European countries.



The prosperity of everyday Americans is linked to the Indo-Pacific and the United States has long been a regional trade and investment leader. With our regional partners, we are developing IPEF to drive inclusive, broad-based prosperity and advance our shared interests in resilient, fair, digital, and low-carbon economies. Leadership through Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) will complement these efforts.

For 75 years, the United States has maintained a strong and consistent defense presence and will continue to meaningfully contribute to the region's stability and peace. We reaffirm our iron-clad commitments to our Indo-Pacific treaty allies—Australia, Japan, the Republic of Korea, the Philippines, and Thailand—and we will continue to modernize these alliances. We reaffirm our unwavering commitment to the defense of Japan under our mutual security treaty, which covers the Senkaku Islands. As India is the world's largest democracy and a Major Defense Partner, the United States and India will work together, bilaterally and multilaterally, to support our shared vision of a free and open Indo-Pacific. We will seek sustained diplomacy with North Korea to make tangible progress toward the complete denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula, while strengthening extended deterrence in the face of North Korean weapons of mass destruction and missile threats. The brutal military coup in Burma has undermined regional stability, and we will continue working closely with allies and partners, including ASEAN, to help restore Burma's democratic transition.

We will also work to enhance partners' resilience to transnational challenges, including climate and biological threats. The Indo-Pacific is the epicenter of the climate crisis but is also essential to climate solutions, and our shared responses to the climate crisis are a political imperative and an economic opportunity. We are also partnering to help the region build resilience to pandemic disease and to strengthen their health systems, drive investments in global health security, and expand the region's ability to prevent, detect, and respond to emergencies.

We have entered a consequential new period of American foreign policy that will demand more of the United States in the Indo-Pacific than has been asked of us since the Second World War. No region will be of more significance to the world and to everyday Americans than the Indo-Pacific. We are ambitious because we know that we and our allies and partners hold a common vision for its future.

Deepen Our Alliance with Europe

With a relationship rooted in shared democratic values, common interests, and historic ties, the transatlantic relationship is a vital platform on which many other elements of our foreign policy are built. Europe has been, and will continue to be, our foundational partner in addressing the full range of global challenges. To effectively pursue a common global agenda, we are broadening and deepening the transatlantic bond—strengthening NATO, raising the level of ambition in the U.S.-EU relationship, and standing with our European allies and partners in defense of the rules-based system that underpins our security, prosperity, and values.

Today, Europe stands at the front lines of the fight to defend the principles of freedom, sovereignty, and non-aggression, and we will continue to work in lockstep to ensure that freedom prevails. America remains unequivocally committed to collective defense as enshrined in NATO's Article 5 and will work alongside our NATO Allies to deter, defend against, and build resilience to aggression and coercion in all its forms. As we step up our own sizable



contributions to NATO capabilities and readiness—including by strengthening defensive forces and capabilities, and upholding our long-standing commitment to extended deterrence—we will count on our Allies to continue assuming greater responsibility by increasing their spending, capabilities, and contributions. European defense investments, through or complementary to NATO, will be critical to ensuring our shared security at this time of intensifying competition. We stand behind NATO’s continued adaptation to modern security challenges, including its emphasis on defense in cyberspace, climate security, and the growing security risks presented by the PRC’s policies and actions.

America maintains our fundamental commitment to the pursuit of a Europe that is whole, free, and at peace. Russia’s further invasion of Ukraine poses a grave threat to this vision, which is why we are determined to support Ukraine in defending its sovereignty and territorial integrity while imposing severe costs on Moscow for its aggression. We have supported Ukraine with security, humanitarian, and financial assistance. We have joined with allies and partners in Europe and around the globe to impose sanctions and export controls that will degrade Russia’s ability to wage future wars of aggression. We have partnered with the European Commission on an ambitious plan to reduce Europe’s dependence on Russian fossil fuels, strengthen European energy security, and advance shared climate goals. Across these efforts, the EU—an integrated market of over 450 million people—is an indispensable partner, and we support efforts to foster EU unity. We also encourage close cooperation on matters of mutual interest between the EU and the United Kingdom. In addition, we underscore our support for the Good Friday Agreement which is the bedrock of peace, stability, and prosperity in Northern Ireland.

As we support Ukraine, we will also work to enhance the stability and resilience of other democracies. We will support the European aspirations of Georgia and Moldova and their commitment to important institutional reforms. We will assist partners in strengthening democratic institutions, the rule of law, and economic development in the Western Balkans. We will back diplomatic efforts to resolve conflict in the South Caucasus. We will continue to engage with Turkey to reinforce its strategic, political, economic, and institutional ties to the West. We will work with allies and partners to manage the refugee crisis created by Russia’s war in Ukraine. And, we will work to forestall terrorist threats to Europe. Elsewhere in Eurasia, we will continue to support the independence, sovereignty and territorial integrity of Central Asia. We will foster efforts to enhance resilience and democratic development in the five countries in this region. We will continue to work through the C5+1 diplomatic platform (Kazakhstan, Kyrgyz Republic, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan and the United States) to advance climate adaptation, improve regional energy and food security, enhance integration within the region, and build greater connectivity to global markets.

Though rooted in transatlantic strength and stability, our agenda with European allies and partners is global. We will work with the EU to strengthen trade, investment, and technological cooperation grounded in shared democratic values—promoting an open and inclusive global economy, setting high standards for trade, ensuring fair competition, supporting labor rights, driving decarbonization, fighting corruption, and protecting our innovations from uses that run counter to our interests and values. Through the G7, we will work with France, Germany, Italy, and the United Kingdom to galvanize international cooperation on the world’s most pressing challenges. We will jointly defend human rights, whether in Belarus or Xinjiang. To enact this ambitious agenda, we will deepen our strategic alignment—consulting regularly, sharing information and intelligence, and acting together.



Foster Democracy and Shared Prosperity in the Western Hemisphere

No region impacts the United States more directly than the Western Hemisphere. With \$1.9 trillion in annual trade, shared values and democratic traditions, and familial bonds, nations of the Western Hemisphere, especially in North America, are key contributors to U.S. prosperity and resilience. But the COVID-19 pandemic and ensuing recession have exacerbated longstanding structural challenges, fueled political and social unrest, undermining faith in democracy's ability to deliver, and spurred unprecedented levels of irregular migration to the United States and throughout the region. Recognizing the direct link between the region's prosperity and security and that of our own, it is vital for the United States to revitalize our partnerships to build and preserve economic resilience, democratic stability, and citizen security within the hemisphere. We will advance these efforts through regular interactions, multilateral and institutional collaboration, and regional initiatives, and by implementing the commitments made at the Ninth Summit of the Americas.

The movement of people throughout the Americas, including over six million Venezuelans forced to leave their homes since 2015, affects all of Latin America and the Caribbean and reinforces the need for regional action. The Los Angeles Declaration on Migration and Protection complements U.S. efforts at home to modernize its border infrastructure and build a fair, orderly, and humane immigration system with a bold hemisphere-wide partnership centered on the principle of responsibility-sharing, stability and assistance for affected communities, the expansion of legal pathways, humane migration management, and a coordinated emergency response. The United States is also leading the charge to expand legal pathways for migration and to combat illicit human smuggling and trafficking that prey on vulnerable migrants. These efforts combined aim to stabilize migrant populations and replace irregular migration with orderly flows that can fuel economic growth in the United States and across the region. We will pursue these collaborative efforts while ensuring a fundamentally fair, orderly, and humane approach to migration management that bolster border security and protects our nation.

Ending and mitigating the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic and advancing health security are imperative for the wellbeing of the entire hemisphere. In addition to donating over 72 million vaccines, through the Action Plan on Health and Resilience in the Americas we are partnering with the region to prevent, prepare for, and respond to future pandemic threats and other public health emergencies while also expanding the equitable delivery of healthcare and public services to remote, vulnerable, and marginalized populations. In addition to supporting countries, especially in Central America and the Caribbean, in reaching a 70 percent COVID-19 vaccination rate, associated partnerships are boosting increased vaccine manufacturing capability and helping train 500,000 public health and medical professionals by 2027 through the Americas Health Corps.

Together with regional partners we are deepening economic cooperation to ensure durable and inclusive economic growth that delivers for our working people. Our priority is to work with Canada and Mexico to advance a North American vision for the future that draws on our shared strengths and bolsters U.S. global competitiveness. Similarly, the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity will guide our regional economic engagement by focusing on the largest drivers of bottom-up and middle-out growth, updating tools for the new and complex challenges facing us today and in the decades to come with a focus on reinvigorating regional economic



institutions, securing supply chains, creating clean energy jobs and promoting decarbonization, ensuring sustainable and inclusive trade, and making game-changing investments that increase the effectiveness of public administration.

Tackling the climate crisis and harnessing the dynamism of the region will be central to our approach, and we will use mitigation and adaptation efforts to fuel a sustainable economic recovery and protect forest ecosystems, including by promoting trade and investment in clean energy to achieve a collective target of 70 percent installed capacity for renewable energy generation in the region's electricity sector by 2030 and mobilizing financing and other forms of support to promote conservation of the Amazon. The United States and the Caribbean Community also launched the Partnership to Address the Climate Crisis 2030 to expand access to project financing, attract private investment in clean energy infrastructure and climate adaptation projects, and enhance local capacity to assess, plan for, predict, mitigate, and respond to extreme weather events and related risks in a changing climate.

The United States derives security and economic benefits from the region's democratic stability and institutions, as our shared values provide a basis for collaboration and peaceful dispute resolution. To help preserve and enhance these traditions, we will support partners striving to build transparent, inclusive, and accountable institutions. Together, we will support effective democratic governance responsive to citizen needs, defend human rights and combat gender-based violence, tackle corruption, and protect against external interference or coercion, including from the PRC, Russia, or Iran. Through reinvigorated and representative Inter-American institutions, and in partnership with civil society and other governments, we will support democratic self-determination for the people of Venezuela, Cuba, Nicaragua, and any country where the popular will is suppressed. In Haiti, which suffers from an extended humanitarian, political, and economic crisis, we will mobilize the international community to help restore security, rebuild governing institutions, and support a foundation of prosperity by which the Haitian people can determine their own future.

We will also assist partners in facing security threats. These challenges may be internal—including from local gangs, or transnational, including from criminal organizations that traffic drugs and humans and undertake other illegal operations—or external, as malign actors seek to gain military or intelligence footholds in the region. These threats impact security throughout the Americas, including here at home, and we will therefore promote collaboration to help assist civilian police and, strengthen justice systems in the Americas, and expand information sharing with our partners.

These priorities—expanding economic opportunities, strengthening democracy, and building security—are mutually reinforcing and contribute to national, regional, and global stability. We have an overriding strategic interest in pursuing and strengthening collaboration through intensified diplomatic engagement with hemispheric partners and institutions based on the premise that advance a vision of a region that is secure, middle class, and democratic is fundamentally in the national security interest of the United States. The challenge and the stakes of this undertaking are accentuated by the backdrop of increased geopolitical and geoeconomics volatility, the interrelated challenges posed by phenomena like climate change, global pandemics, and mass migration, and the recognition that the security and prosperity of the United States hinges on that of our neighbors.



Support De-Escalation and Integration in the Middle East

Over the past two decades, U.S. foreign policy has focused predominantly on threats emanating from the Middle East and North Africa. We have too often defaulted to military-centric policies underpinned by an unrealistic faith in force and regime change to deliver sustainable outcomes, while failing to adequately account for opportunity costs to competing global priorities or unintended consequences. It is time to eschew grand designs in favor of more practical steps that can advance U.S. interests and help regional partners lay the foundation for greater stability, prosperity, and opportunity for the people of the Middle East and for the American people.

The United States has set forth a new framework for U.S. policy in the region based on America's unparalleled comparative advantage in building partnerships, coalitions, and alliances to strengthen deterrence, while using diplomacy to de-escalate tensions, reduce risks of new conflicts, and set a long-term foundation for stability.

This framework has five principles. First, the United States will support and strengthen partnerships with countries that subscribe to the rules-based international order, and we will make sure those countries can defend themselves against foreign threats. Second, the United States will not allow foreign or regional powers to jeopardize freedom of navigation through the Middle East's waterways, including the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab al Mandab, nor tolerate efforts by any country to dominate another—or the region—through military buildups, incursions, or threats. Third, even as the United States works to deter threats to regional stability, we will work to reduce tensions, de-escalate, and end conflicts wherever possible through diplomacy. Fourth, the United States will promote regional integration by building political, economic, and security connections between and among U.S. partners, including through integrated air and maritime defense structures, while respecting each country's sovereignty and independent choices. Fifth, the United States will always promote human rights and the values enshrined in the UN Charter.

This new framework builds on the recent progress regional states have made to bridge their enduring divides. We will continue to work with allies and partners to enhance their capabilities to deter and counter Iran's destabilizing activities. We will pursue diplomacy to ensure that Iran can never acquire a nuclear weapon, while remaining postured and prepared to use other means should diplomacy fail. Iran's threats against U.S. personnel as well as current and former U.S. officials will not be tolerated, and as we have demonstrated, we will respond when our people and interests are attacked. As we do so, we will always stand with the Iranian people striving for the basic rights and dignity long denied them by the regime in Tehran.

More broadly we will combine diplomacy, economic aid, and security assistance to local partners to alleviate suffering, reduce instability, and prevent the export of terrorism or mass migration from Yemen, Syria, and Libya, while working with regional governments to manage the broader impact of these challenges. We will seek to extend and deepen Israel's growing ties to its neighbors and other Arab states, including through the Abraham Accords, while maintaining our ironclad commitment to its security. We will also continue to promote a viable two state solution that preserves Israel's future as a Jewish and democratic state while meeting Palestinian aspirations for a secure and viable state of their own. As President Biden stated during his visit to the West Bank in July 2022, "Two States along the 1967 lines, with mutually agreed swaps, remain the best way to achieve equal measure of security, prosperity, freedom, and democracy for Palestinians as well as Israelis."



This new framework relies on a sustainable and effective military posture focused on deterrence, strengthening partner capacity, enabling regional security integration, countering terrorist threats, and ensuring the free flow of global commerce. In conjunction with the use of other instruments of national power, these military activities also help counter external actors' military expansion in the region. We will not use our military to change regimes or remake societies, but instead limit the use of force to circumstances where it is necessary to protect our national security interests and consistent with international law, while enabling our partners to defend their territory from external and terrorist threats.

We will encourage economic and political reforms that help unlock the region's potential, including by fostering greater economic integration to drive growth and create jobs. We will encourage energy producers to use their resources to stabilize global energy markets, while also preparing for a clean energy future and protecting American consumers. We will also continue to support our democratic partners and demand accountability for violations of human rights, recognizing that while true reform can only come from within, the United States still has an important role to play. The United States is the largest bilateral donor of humanitarian assistance and a longstanding champion for principled, needs-based humanitarian action. We will sustain our leadership on humanitarian assistance and manage long-term refugee and displacement crises, which help realize human dignity and bolster stability. And we will accelerate our support to regional partners to help them build greater resilience, as the future of the Middle East will be defined as much by climate, technological, and demographic changes as by traditional security matters.

Build 21st Century U.S.-Africa Partnerships

Africa's governments, institutions, and people are a major geopolitical force, one that will play a crucial role in solving global challenges in the coming decade. Africa is more youthful, mobile, educated, and connected than ever before. African countries comprise one of the largest regional voting groups at the UN and their citizens lead major international institutions. The continent's booming population, vital natural resources, and vibrant entrepreneurship, coupled with the African Continental Free Trade Area, have the potential to drive transformative economic growth. Our partnerships with African states over the past three decades helped lay the groundwork for this growth. To accelerate it, U.S.-Africa partnerships must adapt to reflect the important geopolitical role that African nations play globally.

Advancing America's national interests will hinge in part on working more closely, not only with African nations, but also with regional bodies, such as the African Union, subnational governments, civil society, and private sector and diaspora communities. We will continue to invest in the region's largest states, such as Nigeria, Kenya, and South Africa, while also deepening our ties to medium and small states. We will engage African countries as equal partners to achieve our shared priorities from health and pandemic preparedness to climate change. We will also press partners about human rights, corruption, or authoritarian behavior, and deepen partnerships with countries that make progress toward more open and democratic governance. In coordination with international partners and regional bodies, we will counter democratic backsliding by imposing costs for coups and pressing for progress on civilian transitions. And we will listen to African leaders and people as they articulate their vision for



their foreign partnerships, including expectations for transparency, accountability, fairness, inclusion, and equity.

Enhancing Africa's peace and prosperity will bolster Africa's ability to solve regional and global problems. The region's commitment and capacity to renew democracy, as well as anticipate, prevent, and address emerging and long running conflicts can lead to favorable outcomes for Africans and Americans. We will support African-led efforts to work toward political solutions to costly conflicts, increasing terrorist activity, and humanitarian crises, such as those in Cameroon, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Mozambique, Nigeria, Somalia, and the Sahel, and invest in local and international peacebuilding and peacekeeping to prevent new conflicts from emerging. Consistent with our broader counterterrorism approach, we will disrupt and degrade terrorist threats against the United States while supporting partners to prevent terrorist expansion. We will work with our African and international partners to tackle the root causes of terrorism, including by countering corruption, strengthening accountability and justice, investing in inclusive economic development, and advancing human rights, including women's rights, and also push back on the destabilizing impact of the Russia-backed Wagner Group.

We will support accelerating growth through private sector investment, help Africa unlock its digital economy, double down on tackling food insecurity, and expand clean energy infrastructure through the Prosper Africa, Feed the Future, and Power Africa initiatives. We will support climate adaptation, conservation, and a just energy transition, as sub-Saharan African countries are already experiencing severe climate impacts, compounding land use, migration challenges, and rising food and commodity prices, made worse by Russia's further invasion of Ukraine. Quality healthcare systems are essential to economic growth, and we will build on our decades-long partnerships to invest in health security and health systems infrastructure, and the ongoing COVID-19 response. We will also work with African governments to create the business environments and make the investments in human capital and capacity development to attract investors, grow businesses, and create good jobs across sectors—and to bolster U.S.-Africa trade and create new opportunities for U.S. businesses. We will seek to offer opportunities that reflect America's competitive advantages, promoting inclusive growth, respecting workers' rights, and protecting the region's resources for future generations.

Maintain a Peaceful Arctic

The United States seeks an Arctic region that is peaceful, stable, prosperous, and cooperative. Climate change is making the Arctic more accessible than ever, threatening Arctic communities and vital ecosystems, creating new potential economic opportunities. and intensifying competition to shape the region's future. Russia has invested significantly in its presence in the Arctic over the last decade, modernizing its military infrastructure and increasing the pace of exercises and training operations. Its aggressive behavior has raised geopolitical tensions in the Arctic, creating new risks of unintended conflict and hindering cooperation. The PRC has also sought to increase its influence in the Arctic by rapidly increased its Arctic investments, pursuing new scientific activities, and using these scientific engagements to conduct dual-use research with intelligence or military applications.

We will uphold U.S. security in the region by improving our maritime domain awareness, communications, disaster response capabilities, and icebreaking capacity to prepare for increased international activity in the region. We will exercise U.S. Government presence in the region as



required, while reducing risk and preventing unnecessary escalation. Arctic nations have the primary responsibility for addressing regional challenges, and we will deepen our cooperation with our Arctic allies and partners and work with them to sustain the Arctic Council and other Arctic institutions despite the challenges to Arctic cooperation posed by Russia's war in Ukraine. We will continue to protect freedom of navigation and determine the U.S. extended continental shelf in accordance with international rules. We must build resilience to and mitigate climate change in the region, including through agreements to reduce emissions and more cross-Arctic research collaboration. As economic activity in the Arctic increases, we will invest in infrastructure, improve livelihoods, and encourage responsible private sector investment by the United States, our allies, and our partners, including in critical minerals, and improve investment screening for national security purposes. Across these efforts, we will uphold our commitment to honor Tribal sovereignty and self-governance through regular, meaningful, and robust consultation and collaboration with Alaska Native communities.

Protect Sea, Air, and Space

People around the world depend on the sea, air, and space for their security and prosperity. The world's interconnected oceans, lands, waterways, and other ecosystems generate economic opportunity and enable critical commercial and military activity. They contain biodiversity vital to food security, clean air and water, a stable climate, and health and wellbeing. Threats to these systems—including excessive maritime and airspace claims, pollution and unregulated deforestation, and wildlife trafficking and illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing—impact governments' abilities to meet basic human needs and contribute to political, economic, and social instability. We will stand up for freedom of navigation and overflight, support environmental protection, and oppose destructive distant water fishing practices by upholding international laws and norms, including the customary international law rules in the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea. And we will promote Antarctica's status as a continent reserved for peace and science in accordance with the provisions of the Antarctic Treaty of 1959.

Space exploration and use benefits humanity, from creating economic opportunities to developing new technologies and enabling climate surveillance. America will maintain our position as the world's leader in space and work alongside the international community to ensure the domain's sustainability, safety, stability, and security. We must lead in updating outer space governance, establishing a space traffic coordination system and charting a path for future space norms and arms control. Working with allies and partners, we will develop policies and regulations that enable the burgeoning U.S. commercial space sector to compete internationally. We will enhance the resilience of U.S. space systems that we rely on for critical national and homeland security functions. These efforts aim to protect U.S. interests in space, avoid destabilizing arms races, and responsibly steward the space environment.



Sharpen Our Tools of Statecraft

Our national security institutions and workforce underpin America's global leadership and the security, prosperity, and freedoms of the American people. To achieve our ambitious aims, we must modernize and adapt our tools of statecraft for today's challenges. For example, we are:

- Strengthening American diplomacy by modernizing the Department of State, including through the recent creation of a new bureau for cyberspace and digital policy and special envoy for critical and emerging technologies.
- Adapting the Intelligence Community (IC), including by aligning our organizations to better address competition, embracing new data tools, and enhancing integration of open source material.
- Enhancing U.S. and global early warning and forecasting for infectious disease threats and pandemics by increasing support for the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's (CDC) Center for Outbreak, Forecasting, and Analytics and foreign assistance for global health security.
- Reorganizing the Office of the Under Secretary of Defense for Policy to sharpen its focus on emerging technologies and elevate senior leader attention to critical regions. Bolstering the Department of Homeland Security's (DHS) Cybersecurity Service by reimagining how DHS hires, develops, and retains top-tier and diverse cyber talent.
- Making development assistance more accessible and equitable by increasing engagement with and shifting 25 percent of U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID) funding to local partners, and double USAID's work on empowering women and girls.
- Expanding our engagement with stakeholders and build our capacity to partner with the private sector, philanthropy, diaspora communities, and civil society.
- Prioritizing technology's role in national security by elevating the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy to a cabinet-level agency and full member of the National Security Council.

The success of these efforts and our foreign policy will require strengthening the national security workforce by recruiting and retaining diverse, high-caliber talent. We are:

- Prioritizing diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility to ensure national security institutions reflect the American public they represent.
- Creating more effective and efficient hiring, recruitment, retention, and talent development practices, particularly in STEM fields, economics, critical languages, and regional affairs.
- Supporting professional development opportunities—for both leadership and technical skills—at all levels of the workforce.
- Opening opportunities for the national security workforce to move among institutions, both within and outside government, and carry the skills they develop back to their home agencies.
- Equipping the workforce with cutting-edge technology and better integrate data and analytic tools to support decision-making.
- Prioritizing human resources capabilities and personnel, who will drive and steward all of these initiatives.



The health of our national security institutions and workforce relies on faith in the apolitical nature of Federal law enforcement agencies, the IC, our diplomats, civil servants, Federally funded research and development institutions, and military as we work together in national service.



PART V: CONCLUSION

We are confident that the United States, alongside our allies and partners, is positioned to succeed in our pursuit of a free, open, prosperous, and secure global order. With the key elements outlined in this strategy, we will tackle the twin challenges of our time: out-competing our rivals to shape the international order while tackling shared challenges, including climate change, pandemic preparedness, and food security, that will define the next stage of human history. We will strengthen democracy across the world, and multilateral institutions, as we look to the future to chart new and fair rules of the road for emerging technology, cybersecurity, and trade and economics. And we will do all this and more by leveraging our considerable advantages and our unparalleled coalition of allies and partners.

As we implement this strategy, we will continually assess and reassess our approach to ensure we are best serving the American people. We will be guided by the indisputable fact that the strength and quality of the American project at home is inextricably linked with our leadership in the world and our ability to shape the terms of the world order. This National Security Strategy will be evaluated by an overriding metric: whether it makes life better, safer, and fairer for the people of the United States, and whether it lifts up the countries and people around the world who share our vision for the future.

We are motivated by a clear vision of what success looks like at the end of this decisive decade.

By enhancing our industrial capacity, investing in our people, and strengthening our democracy, we will have strengthened the foundation of our economy, bolstered our national resilience, enhanced our credibility on the world stage, and ensured our competitive advantages.

By deepening and expanding our diplomatic relationships not only with our democratic allies but with all states who share our vision for a better future, we will have developed terms of competition with our strategic rivals that are favorable to our interests and values and laid the foundation to increase cooperation on shared challenges.

By modernizing our military, pursuing advanced technologies, and investing in our defense workforce, we will have strengthened deterrence in an era of increasing geopolitical confrontation, and positioned America to defend our homeland, our allies, partners, and interests overseas, and our values across the globe.

By leveraging our national strengths and rallying a broad coalition of allies and partners, we will advance our vision of a free, open, prosperous, and secure world, outmaneuvering our competitors, and making meaningful progress on issues like climate change, global health, and food security to improve the lives not just of Americans but of people around the world.

This is what we must achieve in this decisive decade. As we have done throughout our history, America will seize this moment and rise to the challenge. There is no time to waste.



Fact Sheet: 2022 National Defense Strategy

Today, the Department of Defense transmitted to Congress the classified 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS).

For the first time, the Department conducted its strategic reviews in a fully integrated way – incorporating the Nuclear Posture Review (NPR) and Missile Defense Review (MDR) in the NDS – ensuring tight linkages between our strategy and our resources. The unclassified NDS will be forthcoming.

Consistent with the President’s Interim National Security Strategic Guidance, the classified NDS sets out how the Department of Defense will contribute to advancing and safeguarding vital U.S. national interests – protecting the American people, expanding America’s prosperity, and realizing and defending our democratic values.

The Defense priorities are:

1. Defending the homeland, paced to the growing multi-domain threat posed by the PRC
2. Deterring strategic attacks against the United States, Allies, and partners
3. Deterring aggression, while being prepared to prevail in conflict when necessary, prioritizing the PRC challenge in the Indo-Pacific, then the Russia challenge in Europe
4. Building a resilient Joint Force and defense ecosystem.

The Department will act urgently to sustain and strengthen deterrence, with the People’s Republic of China (PRC) as our most consequential strategic competitor and the pacing challenge for the Department.

Russia poses acute threats, as illustrated by its brutal and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine. We will collaborate with our NATO Allies and partners to reinforce robust deterrence in the face of Russian aggression.

The Department will remain capable of managing other persistent threats, including those from North Korea, Iran, and violent extremist organizations.

Changes in global climate and other dangerous transboundary threats, including pandemics, are transforming the context in which the Department operates. We will adapt to these challenges, which increasingly place pressure on the Joint Force and the systems that support it.

Recognizing growing kinetic and non-kinetic threats to the United States’ homeland from our strategic competitors, the Department will take necessary actions to increase resilience – our ability to withstand, fight through, and recover quickly from disruption.

Mutually-beneficial Alliances and partnerships are an enduring strength for the United States, and are critical to achieving our objectives, as the unified response to Russia's further invasion of Ukraine has demonstrated. Answering this "call to action," the Department will incorporate ally and partner perspectives, competencies, and advantages at every stage of defense planning.

The Department will advance our goals through three primary ways: integrated deterrence, campaigning, and actions that build enduring advantages.

- Integrated deterrence entails developing and combining our strengths to maximum effect, by working seamlessly across warfighting domains, theaters, the spectrum of conflict, other instruments of U.S. national power, and our unmatched network of Alliances and partnerships. Integrated deterrence is enabled by combat-credible forces, backstopped by a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent.
- Campaigning will strengthen deterrence and enable us to gain advantages against the full range of competitors' coercive actions. The United States will operate forces, synchronize broader Department efforts, and align Department activities with other instruments of national power, to undermine acute forms of competitor coercion, complicate competitors' military preparations, and develop our own warfighting capabilities together with Allies and partners.
- Building enduring advantages for the future Joint Force involves undertaking reforms to accelerate force development, getting the technology we need more quickly, and making investments in the extraordinary people of the Department, who remain our most valuable resource.

The Department will develop, design, and manage our forces – linking our operational concepts and capabilities to achieve strategic objectives. This requires a Joint Force that is lethal, resilient, sustainable, survivable, agile, and responsive.

CHAIRMAN OF THE JOINT CHIEFS OF STAFF

NATIONAL MILITARY STRATEGY

2022



STRATEGIC DISCIPLINE



CHAIRMAN'S FOREWORD

The Joint Force is at an *inflection point* during what will be a *decisive decade*. Geopolitical relationships are shifting, economies are rising – and falling, rapid technological advances are fueling militaries' modernizations at scale, and external factors like climate change and pandemics are changing the way people live, work, and go to war. An undeniable and intentional violation of sovereignty has shocked the international system. Large-scale combat has now been introduced into the strategic competition between autocracies and democracies, further stressing the rules-based international order.



For the first time in our Nation's history, the United States faces two major nuclear powers that may employ nuclear coercion as a way to meet their national objectives. Both the People's Republic of China (PRC) and Russia possess the will and the means to pose an existential threat to our way of life. The PRC is our most consequential strategic competitor, modernizing its military and preparing to fight and win a war with the United States. Russia poses acute threats, pursuing power and influence through cyber-attacks and disinformation campaigns, while its attack on Ukraine represents a moment on par with 9/11 in terms of global consequence and challenge to U.S. and international security.

The current environment requires the Joint Force to strengthen and integrate deterrence across domains, theaters, and the spectrum of conflict; modernize the nuclear enterprise; assure allies and partners; and prepare to prevail in great power conflict. The United States must meet this challenge with alacrity, discipline, and fortitude – the window to seize the strategic initiative is *now*. This National Military Strategy (NMS) is a wakeup call: **Adapt Now, or Lose Later.**

This NMS renews our focus on campaigning now and building and sustaining warfighting advantage in tandem. Both are critical to prevail in war, and both are necessary to preserve the peace. War is a terrible endeavor, and Great Power War is especially terrible – but it is not inevitable, so our Nation strives for peace. As the U.S. does so, its Joint Force will defend, deter, modernize – and prevail if deterrence fails – realizing that the surest way to prevent escalation and war is always being prepared to defeat our Nation's foes.

The time is now and the window of strategic opportunity we have is closing. What we do in the next few years is going to set conditions for victory or defeat in the next war. We must adapt now in order to win the next war, and by doing so, we will deter the war from happening in the first place.


MARK A. MILLEY
General, U.S. Army

The 2022 NMS is the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff's (CJCS) strategic guidance that provides the logic and framework to achieve the 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS) priorities and build the future Joint Force. This NMS offers guidance for every Active Duty, Reserve, National Guard, and civilian member to take bold and transformative action now to protect the security of the American people and defend the democratic ideals at the heart of the American way of life. This strategy is about the Joint Force obtaining lasting positions of relative advantage in peace and achieving decisive victory in war.

STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT

- ▶ **THREATS.** The classified NMS clearly describes the near and real threats faced by the Joint Force in the strategic environment. As our most consequential strategic competitor, the PRC is unequivocal in its pursuit to reshape an authoritarian world order with no democratic values. The PRC is the pacing challenge for the Department. Russia is an acute threat with aggressive intent – as seen by its brutal and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine – that seeks to consolidate and strengthen its perceived Eurasian sphere of influence to counter Western influence. Other persistent threats include North Korea, Iran, and violent extremist organizations.
- ▶ **TECHNOLOGICAL TRENDS.** Both commercial and military technologies will advance rapidly and proliferate the global technology landscape. These capabilities alone may not ensure military victory, but creative application will shape the outcome of any contest.
- ▶ **EXTERNAL TRENDS.** Pandemics, climate change, demographic changes, and resource scarcity will destabilize the security environment and impose changes and constraints on domestic political contexts.
- ▶ **MILITARY TRENDS.** For the first time, the United States will simultaneously contend with two major nuclear powers. Future warfare will include advanced threats to the Homeland, elements in the Gray-Zone, and protracted conflicts in contested environments. Militaries that incorporate new technology with innovative operational concepts and develop leadership to harness the changes will create decisive advantage.
- ▶ **GEOPOLITICAL TRENDS.** Amidst institutional and economic fragility and the ongoing health crisis, adversaries will test the post-World War II international order, attempting to weaken U.S. leadership and rewrite international rules and norms to their own benefit.
- ▶ **ECONOMIC TRENDS.** Growing economic strength drives global influence and undergirds other elements of national power, which will continue to fuel the PRC's coercive actions.



The nature of the problem the 2022 NMS aims to solve is meeting the Joint Force Strategic Objectives in the context of the strategic environment. The solution to the problem is informed by the NDS' strategic approach. The result is a theory of success that allows the Joint Force to operate from an advantageous position with respect to threats, maintain awareness of strategic trends, remain in line with civilian guidance, and advance toward our objectives.

So how does the Joint Force rapidly develop future warfighting advantage while deterring effectively today, with the PRC as the pacing challenge?

This is the central military problem this NMS seeks to solve.

The NDS strategic approach employs three strategic ways (integrated deterrence, campaigning, and building enduring advantage) to foster Integrated Deterrence. Aligned with the NDS, the NMS implements Integrated Deterrence through ruthless prioritization to calibrate decision-making and activities of the Joint Force now in order to succeed.

INTEGRATED DETERRENCE

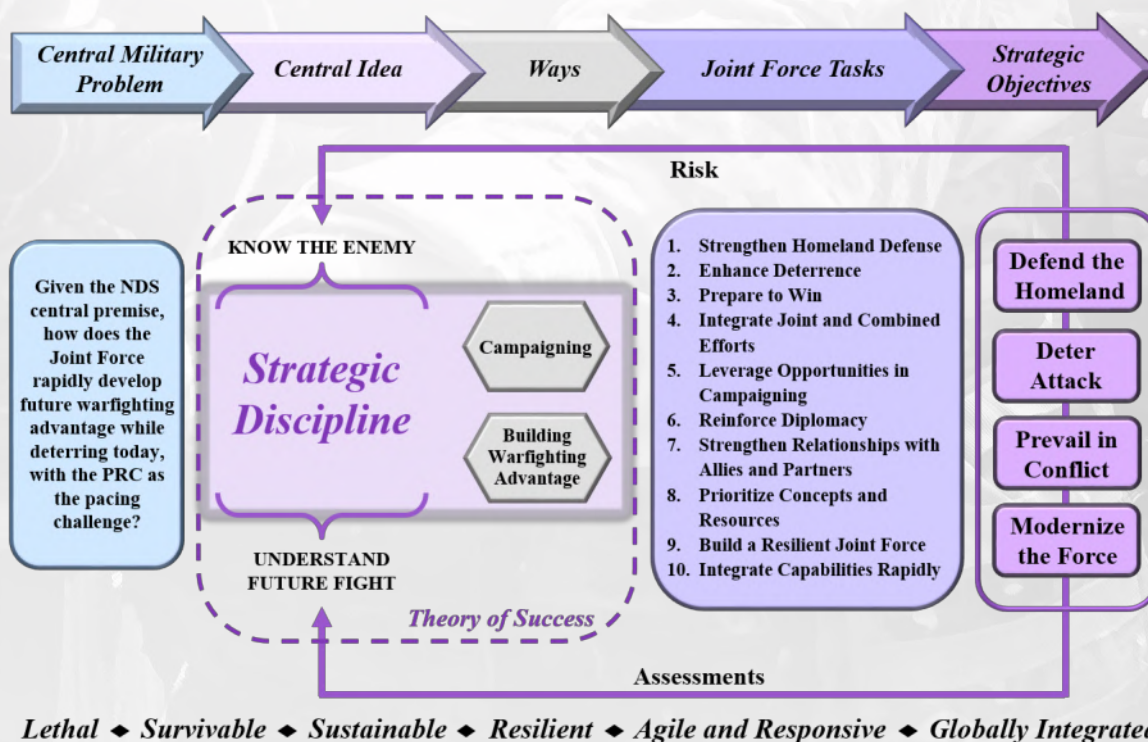
Integrated Deterrence, the NDS' principal strategic approach, generates warfighting advantages by synchronizing operations across warfighting domains, theaters, the spectrum of conflict, instruments of national power, the interagency, private sector, and allies and partners.

Integrated Deterrence influences adversary decision calculus by affecting perception of costs, benefits, and consequences of restraint.

The Joint Force's contribution to Integrated Deterrence is combat-credible forces, backstopped by a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent.

Through the NMS' theory of success, the Joint Force contributes to Integrated Deterrence to reduce an adversary's perceived benefit and increase the adversary's perceived cost of aggression, incentivizing restraint as a result.

IMPLEMENTING INTEGRATED DETERRENCE



"You want to deter your potential opponent from even thinking or contemplating that they could have a war with the United States."

General Milley, CJCS
(Brookings Institution, 2 December 2020)

The NMS seeks to solve the central military problem within the framework of the NDS through an informed theory of success that enables disciplined decision-making by framing risk and assessing progress toward strategic objectives.

The NMS Theory of Success is to *exercise Strategic Discipline to continuously calibrate Joint Force weight of effort between campaigning and rapidly building warfighting advantage to deter now and reduce future risk.*

STRATEGIC DISCIPLINE

Strategic Discipline is the ruthless prioritization and calibration of Joint Force operations, activities, and investments, consistent with policy guidance and strategic aims, between the Joint Force strategic ways of campaigning and building warfighting advantage.

Strategic Discipline is enabled by a robust understanding of the strategic environment, including a deep awareness of our adversaries and ourselves, ally and partner equities, and the future character of warfare. This understanding is enhanced by strategic assessments that enable risk decisions to bias toward decreasing future risk. This approach provides the Joint Force with the agility to focus on enduring priorities and generate military options for emergent changes.

Campaigning

Campaigning is how the DoD sequences day-to-day defense initiatives and develops advantageous conditions to deter conflict, accomplish strategic objectives, and prevail against adversaries across the spectrum of conflict, to include the Gray-Zone.



Risk

To implement the NMS effectively, the Joint Force must take a globally integrated approach to risk while thinking across multiple time horizons. Decision-makers must consider transferring risk away from priority threats/theaters and be more risk tolerant in the present to reduce risk in the future.

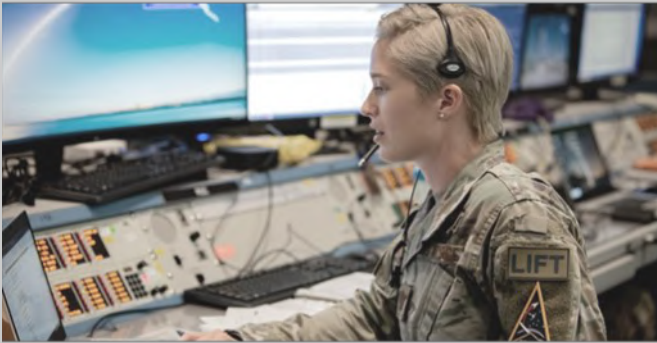


Building Warfighting Advantage

Building Warfighting Advantage requires deliberate investment to develop leaders, concepts, and capabilities through materiel and non-materiel solutions in order to achieve strategic objectives in the future.

Assessments

Joint assessments guide the Chairman's military advice and the balance of resource decisions between future modernization and current requirements. These assessments guide iterative adjustments to implement NDS Defense Priorities and Joint Force Strategic Objectives.



1. **STRENGTHEN HOMELAND DEFENSE**

Modernize and integrate to protect our way of life.

2. **ENHANCE DETERRENCE**

Develop capabilities that deter adversaries from advancing their goals, employing their military strengths, or attacking U.S. interests.

3. **PREPARE TO WIN**

Ensure a properly trained and resourced combat force capable of defeating our adversaries abroad.

4. **INTEGRATE JOINT FORCE AND COMBINED EFFORTS**

Synchronize actions with allies, partners, and the interagency to address trans-regional, all-domain, and multi-functional challenges and continuously advance national security objectives.

5. **LEVERAGE OPPORTUNITIES IN CAMPAIGNING**

Proactively identify and leverage opportunities to frustrate adversaries' strengths, exploit vulnerabilities, and expand U.S. partnerships, access, and basing.

6. **REINFORCE DIPLOMACY**

Support diplomatic efforts to preserve the rules-based international order and provide credible military options that enable leaders to interact from a position of strength.

7. **STRENGTHEN RELATIONSHIPS WITH ALLIES AND PARTNERS**

Seek opportunities to collaborate and improve interoperability with allies and partners to confront enduring and emerging challenges. Foster strong relationships now — because we cannot surge trust in crisis.

8. **PRIORITIZE CONCEPTS AND RESOURCES**

Refocus our current warfighting ideas, systems, and practices to improve combat effectiveness.

9. **BUILD A RESILIENT JOINT FORCE**

Harness robust and effective combat capabilities that can resist degradation and quickly reconstitute in future combat.

10. **INTEGRATE CAPABILITIES RAPIDLY**

Timely integrate advanced capabilities to amplify existing warfighting advantages.

"We are now in the seventy-sixth year of the great-power peace following World War II and the structure is under stress. We can see it fraying at the edge. And with history as our guide, we would be wise to lift our gaze from the never-ending urgency of the present and set the conditions for a future that prevents great-power war."

General Milley, CJCS
(US Air Force Academy Graduation, 26 May 2021)

JOINT FORCE STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES

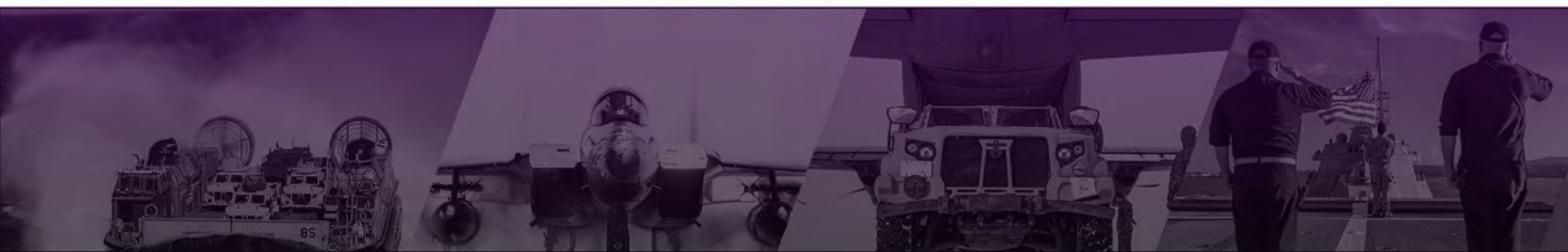
- ▶ **Defend the U.S. Homeland** against all-domain threats, prioritizing the PRC.
- ▶ **Deter strategic attacks** and other aggression against the United States, allies, and partners.
- ▶ Ensure the Joint Force possesses the combat-credible capabilities necessary to **prevail in conflict** against the PRC in the Indo-Pacific, then Russia in Europe.
- ▶ **Focus technical and non-technical modernization** into a resilient Joint Force and maintain the ability to respond to crises.



CONCLUSION

To meet the challenges described, now and in the coming decisive decade, this strategy outlines the Joint Force's vision to deter, and if necessary, to defeat potential adversaries now and into the future. We're at an inflection point, requiring the Joint Force to exercise Strategic Discipline to sustain and strengthen Integrated Deterrence – we must Adapt Now, or Lose Later.

The success of this strategy depends on the innovation and discipline of the Joint Force and its leaders at every rank. Future Joint Force success – like the past – will continue to be anchored by the American people and our values, the U.S. government, and our allies and partners. The Joint Force will defend, deter, modernize – and prevail if deterrence fails.



DEFENSE SPACE STRATEGY SUMMARY



JUNE 2020

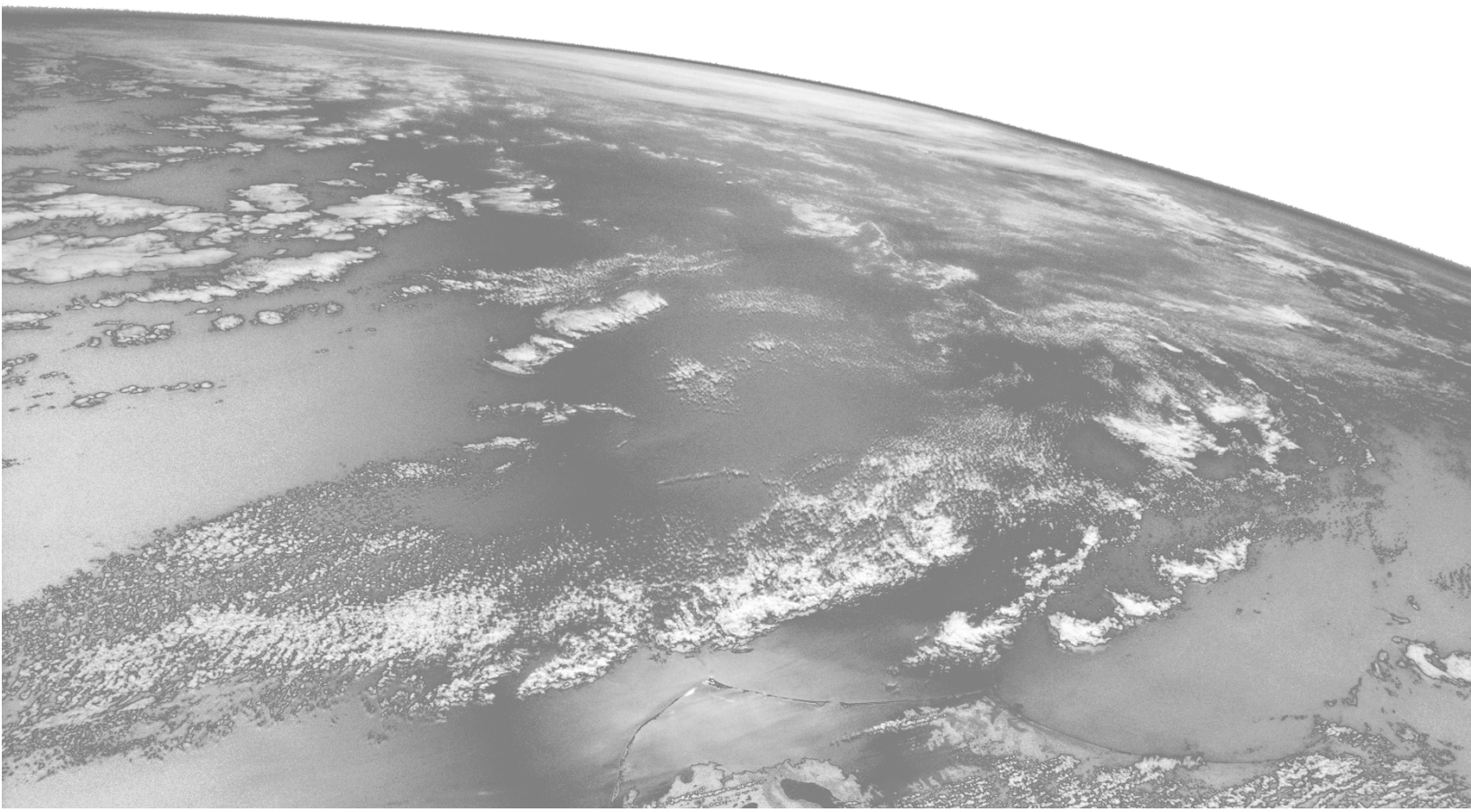


Image courtesy of NASA

DEFENSE SPACE STRATEGY SUMMARY



JUNE 2020



This page left intentionally blank

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Executive Summary	1
Desired Conditions.....	2
Strategic Context.....	3
Strategic Approach.....	6
Conclusion.....	10

This page left intentionally blank

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Department of Defense (DoD) is embarking on the most significant transformation in the history of the U.S. national security space program. Space is now a distinct warfighting domain, demanding enterprise-wide changes to policies, strategies, operations, investments, capabilities, and expertise for a new strategic environment. This strategy identifies how DoD will advance spacepower to enable the Department to compete, deter, and win in a complex security environment characterized by great power competition.

Space is vital to our Nation's security, prosperity, and scientific achievement. Space-based capabilities are integral to modern life in the United States and around the world and are an indispensable component of U.S. military power. Ensuring the availability of these capabilities is fundamental to establishing and maintaining military superiority across all domains and to advancing U.S. and global security and economic prosperity. Space, however, is not a sanctuary from attack and space systems are potential targets at all levels of conflict. In particular, China and Russia present the greatest strategic threat due to their development, testing, and deployment of counterspace capabilities and their associated military doctrine for employment in conflict extending to space. China and Russia each have weaponized space as a means to reduce U.S. and allied military effectiveness and challenge our freedom of operation in space.

Rapid increases in commercial and international space activities worldwide add to the complexity of the space environment. Commercial space activities provide national and homeland security benefits with new technologies and services and create new economic opportunities in established and emerging markets. The same activities, however, also create challenges in protecting critical technology, ensuring operational security, and maintaining strategic advantages. Internationally, allies and partners also recognize the benefits of space for military operations, and increasingly understand the threats to those space activities. Allies and partners who are actively expanding their defense space programs, present novel opportunities to increase defense collaboration and cooperation.

In response to this new security environment, and in accordance with the 2018 National Strategy for Space (NSfS) and the 2018 National Defense Strategy (NDS), this Defense Space Strategy (DSS) provides guidance to DoD for achieving desired conditions in space over the next 10 years. The DoD desires a secure, stable, and accessible space domain, whose use by the United States and our allies and partners is underpinned by comprehensive, sustained military strength. The strategy includes a phased approach for the defense enterprise to move with purpose and speed across four lines of effort (LOEs): (1) build a comprehensive military advantage in space; (2) integrate space into national, joint, and combined operations; (3) shape the strategic environment; and (4) cooperate with allies, partners, industry, and other U.S. Government departments and agencies.

The Department is taking innovative and bold actions to ensure space superiority and to secure the Nation's vital interests in space now and in the future. Establishing the U.S. Space Force (USSF) as the newest branch of our Armed Forces and the U.S. Space Command (USSPACECOM) as a unified combatant command, as well as undertaking significant space acquisition reform across the DoD, has set a strategic path to expand spacepower for the Nation. It is a path that embraces space as a unique domain of national military power that, together with the other domains, underpins multi-domain joint and combined military operations to advance national security.

DESIRED CONDITIONS

This Defense Space Strategy (DSS) is designed to achieve the following desired conditions at an accelerated pace over the next 10 years, focusing on the military application of spacepower through control, exploitation, and influence of space to achieve strategic, operational, and tactical objectives.

DESIRED CONDITIONS:

The space domain is secure, stable, and accessible. The use of space by the United States and our allies and partners is underpinned by sustained, comprehensive U.S. military strength. The United States is able to leverage our use of space to generate, project, and employ power across all domains throughout the spectrum of conflict.

To achieve these desired conditions, DoD will advance spacepower through the pursuit of the following defense objectives:

Maintain Space Superiority: DoD will establish, maintain, and preserve U.S. freedom of operations in the space domain. DoD will be prepared to protect and defend U.S. and, as directed, allied, partner, and commercial space capabilities and to deter and defeat adversary hostile use of space.



Provide Space Support to National, Joint, and Combined Operations: DoD space forces will deliver advanced space capabilities and effects to enable national, joint, and combined operations in any domain through sustained, comprehensive space military advantages. DoD will leverage and bolster a thriving domestic civil and commercial space industry.

Ensure Space Stability: In cooperation with allies and partners, DoD will maintain persistent presence in space in order to: deter aggression in space; provide for safe transit in, to, and through space; uphold internationally accepted standards of responsible behavior as a good steward of space; and support U.S. leadership in space traffic management and the long-term sustainability of outer space activities.

SPACEPOWER:

The sum of a nation's capabilities to leverage space for diplomatic, information, military, and economic activities in peace or war in order to attain national objectives.

STRATEGIC CONTEXT

Great power competition defines the strategic environment. Space is both a source of and conduit for national power, prosperity, and prestige. As a result, space is a domain that has reemerged as a central arena of great power competition, primarily with China and Russia.

CENTRAL PROBLEM:

The U.S. defense space enterprise was not built for the current strategic environment. The intentions and advancements of potential adversaries in space are threatening the ability of the United States to deter aggression, to protect U.S. national interests, and to fight and win future conflicts.

More than any other nation, the United States relies on space-based capabilities to project and employ power on a global scale. Today, U.S. reliance on space has increased to the point where space capabilities not only enhance, but enable our way of life and way of war. U.S. national security and prosperity require unfettered access to and freedom to operate in the space domain.



The reemergence of great power competition and a rapid expansion of allied, partner, and commercial activities in space in recent years have drastically changed the character of the space domain. The actions, intentions, and military strategies of potential adversaries have transformed space into a warfighting domain. In parallel, growth in allied, partner, and commercial space capabilities has added complexity to the space operating environment while creating an unprecedented level of collaborative opportunities.

These factors amplify the need to strengthen the U.S. defense posture and present several threats, challenges, and opportunities as the Department seeks to attain its desired conditions.

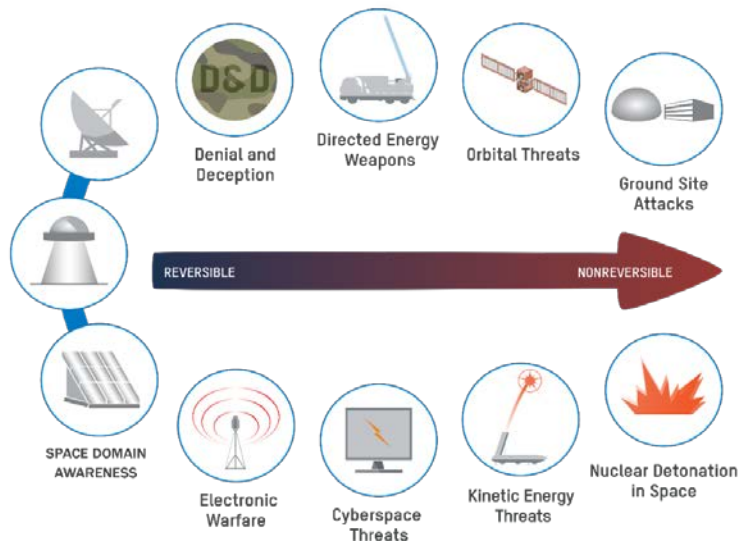
THREATS, CHALLENGES, AND OPPORTUNITIES

Threats: China and Russia present the most immediate and serious threats to U.S. space operations, although threats from North Korea and Iran are also growing. Chinese and Russian strategic intentions and capabilities present urgent and enduring threats to the ability of the Department to achieve its desired conditions in space. China and Russia have analyzed U.S. dependencies on space and have developed doctrine, organizations, and capabilities specifically designed to contest or deny U.S. access to and operations in the domain. Concurrently, their use of space is expanding significantly. Both countries consider space access and denial as critical components of their national and military strategies. Specifically, Chinese and Russian military doctrines indicate that they view space as important to modern warfare and consider the use of counterspace capabilities as a means for reducing U.S., allied, and partner military effectiveness and for winning future wars. China and Russia have weaponized space as a way to deter and counter a possible U.S. intervention during a regional military conflict.

Challenges: Several factors may limit DoD's ability to achieve its desired conditions:

- ▶ The DoD will continue to depend on space to project power and to respond rapidly to crises worldwide to a greater extent than potential adversaries operating in their respective regions.
- ▶ The DoD has limited operational experience with conflict beginning in or extending into space, despite rapid counterspace advancements by potential adversaries.
- ▶ International understanding and agreement of what constitutes unsafe, irresponsible, or threatening behavior in space is nascent.
- ▶ U.S. activities, both terrestrial and in space, are increasingly exposed by advances in potential adversary, rest-of-world, and commercial space-based capabilities, impeding the U.S. military's freedom of maneuver and action in all domains. Meanwhile, potential adversaries are leveraging technological advancements in the commercial space sector at decreased costs and broader accessibility to expand their space technologies and capabilities.
- ▶ Public understanding of their reliance on space systems, the changing character of the space domain, and the significantly growing counterspace threats to the United States and its allies and partners remains cursory.

COUNTERSPACE CONTINUUM



Opportunities: The emerging strategic environment also presents numerous opportunities that may enhance the Department's ability to attain its desired conditions:

- ▶ National leadership recognizes the criticality of space to national security and prosperity. Space, including space security, is a top national priority with increasing resources to ensure continued U.S. leadership in this critical domain. Strategic guidance, including the National Security Strategy, the NDS, and the NSfS underscore the Nation's vital interest of unfettered access to, and freedom to operate in, space.

- ▶ The creation of new space-focused organizations in DoD offers an historic opportunity to reform every aspect of our defense space enterprise. The USSF, the newest branch of the Armed Forces, will bring unity, focus, and advocacy to organizing, training, and equipping space forces. USSPACECOM, the newest combatant command, will bring additional operational focus to deterring threats and shaping the security environment in space. Concurrent with ongoing space acquisition activities within the Department of the Air Force, the Space Development Agency was established under a new model for rapid acquisition to rapidly develop and field new space capabilities. Taken together, the establishment of these organizations institutionalizes the commitment of both the legislative and executive branches of government to champion strategic change across the national security space enterprise. These new institutions bring focus and momentum to addressing current and future challenges.



- ▶ New leadership and management for space acquisition has been established to unify the Department's space acquisition efforts into a streamlined structure for better integration and speed of delivery. A new Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Space Acquisition and Integration ASAF(A&I), along with a new Space Force Acquisition Council (SFAC), will simplify the leadership and synchronization of the DoD's space development efforts by overseeing and directing: the Space Development Agency, the Space and Missile Systems Center, and the Space Rapid Capabilities Office. When the transfer of the Space Development Agency is completed, the Department will have a new unified structure.
- ▶ The United States has long maintained a robust and prolific arrangement of alliances and partnerships built on trust, common values, and shared national interests. This approach creates an important advantage for the United States and its allies and partners. Many U.S. allies and partners acknowledge space as an integral component of their respective national security strategies and recognize the increasing counterspace threats posed by potential adversaries. As a result, they are increasingly interested in collaborating in the development of space capabilities, sharing space-related information and intelligence, and partnering in space operations to secure access to, and ensure freedom of action in, space.
- ▶ Commercial space activities have expanded significantly in both volume and diversity, resulting in new forms of commercial capabilities and services that leverage commoditized, off-the-shelf technologies and lower barriers for market entry. These developments are contributing to a burgeoning space industry driven by entrepreneurial innovation and investment, advanced technology, decreased costs, and increased demand for space-based services. The DoD has an opportunity to leverage innovation and cost-effective investments driven by the private sector, presenting opportunities for collaboration to develop game-changing capabilities with a more streamlined and responsive acquisition process.

STRATEGIC APPROACH

The Department is rapidly transforming its approach to space from a support function to a warfighting domain in order to achieve our desired conditions and strategic objectives over the next 10 years in the face of identified threats, challenges, and opportunities.

CENTRAL IDEA:

The Department will grow its spacepower capacity over the next 10 years to ensure space superiority and secure the Nation's vital interests. The Department will take action rapidly to leverage opportunities and U.S. strengths in close cooperation with our allies, partners, and industry.



Generating an enduring superior spacepower capacity will take a number of years and will require DoD to rely in the near-term on enhancing existing capabilities. The Department will expand its space partnerships and will establish new and deeper pathways to collaborate with allies, partners, industry, and other U.S. Government departments and agencies, making cooperation and collaboration a matter of course in future capability development and operations. These actions will be undertaken while the Department builds comprehensive military spacepower through a trained and ready force that is integrated into Joint Force plans to

support the Department's objectives to compete, deter, and win across the spectrum of conflict. This will require embracing space as a unique domain of national and military power while also embracing principles of joint warfare.

The Department will pursue the following prioritized lines of effort (LOEs) to achieve our desired conditions while addressing identified threats, opportunities, and challenges:

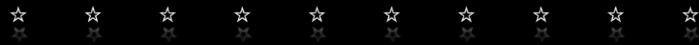
- 1) **Build a comprehensive military advantage in space.**
- 2) **Integrate military spacepower into national, joint, and combined operations.**
- 3) **Shape the strategic environment.**
- 4) **Cooperate with allies, partners, industry, and other U.S. Government departments and agencies.**

LOE 1: Build a comprehensive military advantage in space. The Department must transform its space enterprise by: reforming its organizations; fielding resilient architectures; building capabilities to counter hostile uses of space; and developing spacepower expertise, doctrine, and operational concepts commensurate with the threat. DoD will develop an agile space enterprise that can take advantage of emerging technological and commercial innovation in order to continually outpace adversary threats. Space superiority will be achieved through on-orbit, multi-domain, and cross-component operations that are fully integrated with our allies and partners. The establishment of the USSF as a new branch of the Armed Forces offers a historic and immediate opportunity to rapidly transform the enterprise to achieve space superiority. Additionally, the creation of a new ASAF (A&I) and SFAC will further unify DoD space acquisition efforts, improving the synchronization of space systems and programs and ensuring integration across the national security space enterprise. DoD components will prioritize necessary resources for this LOE for the duration of the DSS timeframe. Specific objectives include:



- ▶ Build out the U.S. Space Force.
- ▶ Develop and document doctrinal foundations of military spacepower.
- ▶ Develop and expand space warfighting expertise and culture.
- ▶ Field assured space capabilities.
- ▶ Develop and field capabilities that counter hostile use of space.
- ▶ Improve intelligence and command and control (C2) capabilities that enable military advantage in the space domain.

LOE 2: Integrate military spacepower into national, joint, and combined operations. Military spacepower achieves its greatest potential when combined with all other forms of military power. The integration of superior space capabilities into and throughout the Joint Force, along with operational integration with allies and partners, is essential for securing our military advantage against threats in space. As DoD builds superior space forces, it must further develop and enhance integration of space warfighting doctrine, capabilities, and personnel into national, joint, and combined operations. The establishment of USSPACECOM as a new combatant command provides a full-time operational focus on deterrence, integration, and employment of military spacepower. DoD components will prioritize necessary resources for this LOE for the duration of the DSS timeframe. Specific objectives include:



- ▶ Enable USSPACECOM to plan, exercise, and execute joint and combined space operations across the spectrum of conflict.
- ▶ Realign operational authorities and update rules of engagement.
- ▶ Integrate space warfighting operations, intelligence, capabilities, and personnel into military plans and staffs.
- ▶ Update security classification for DoD space programs.
- ▶ Integrate allies and partners into plans, operations, exercises, engagements, and intelligence activities.

LOE 3: Shape the strategic environment. DoD will deter aggression and attacks in space and, if deterrence fails, be capable of winning wars that extend into space. Additionally, DoD will take actions that enhance domain stability and reduce the potential for miscalculations. In this context, international views about space as a warfighting domain and what constitutes acceptable and unacceptable behavior in that domain are nascent or, in some cases, non-



existent. DoD will partner with the Department of State (DoS) to work closely with allies and partners in order to develop common understandings of appropriate behavior in space. The United States must align with allies and partners to engage proactively and assertively with the wider international community, including with potential adversaries, to advance U.S., allied, and partner national security interests and to reduce the possibility of mishaps and misperceptions. This LOE must be executed in close cooperation with DoS and across all key DoD components, utilizing appropriate authorities,

without adversely affecting space capability development, production, and fielding activities. Overall, LOE 3 activities are enduring but critical in the near-term in order to leverage U.S. strengths as the Department develops space warfighting policy and builds associated warfighting capacity.

Specific objectives include:

- ▶ Inform international and public audiences of growing adversarial threats in space.
- ▶ Deter adversary aggression against the space capabilities of the United States and its allies, partners, and commercial interests.
- ▶ Coordinate space messaging.
- ▶ Promote standards and norms of behavior in space favorable to U.S., allied, and partner interests.

LOE 4: Cooperate with allies, partners, industry, and other U.S. Government departments and agencies. Partnering is both inherent in the first three LOEs and a distinct LOE in its own right. In close partnership with key U.S. departments and agencies, DoD must enhance space cooperation with international partners and commercial entities, many of whose space capabilities are already integral to collective security. DoD will promote burden-sharing with our allies and partners, developing and leveraging cooperative opportunities in policy, strategy, capabilities, and operational realms. Pursuit of LOE 4 will be ongoing, with the most significant attention needed in the short-term to lay foundations for benefits over the long-term. Specific objectives include:



- ▶ Expand information sharing relationships with capable allies and partners.
- ▶ Align with allies and partners on space policy.
- ▶ Join with allies, partners, and other U.S. Government departments and agencies to promote favorable standards and norms of behavior in space.
- ▶ Expand cooperative research, development, and acquisition (RD&A) with allies and partners.
- ▶ Leverage commercial technological advancements and acquisition processes.
- ▶ Modernize DoD's approach to the commercial licensing approval process.



CONCLUSION



This strategy provides an opportunity to build upon existing work by taking immediate and enduring steps to generate and employ a superior spacepower capacity. Successful implementation of this strategy requires embracing space activities as a unique source of national and military power and incorporating the principles of joint warfare into space operations. Implementation of the strategy will posture the Department to achieve its strategic objectives with the necessary prioritization of resources and risk management to advance U.S. national interests.

This page left intentionally blank





DEFENSE SPACE STRATEGY

FACT SHEET

JUNE 2020

- ▶ The Defense Space Strategy (DSS) identifies how DoD will advance spacepower to enable the Department to compete, deter, and win in a complex security environment characterized by great power competition.
 - Unfettered access to and freedom to operate in space is vital to our Nation's security, prosperity, and scientific achievement. Ensuring the availability of space-based capabilities is fundamental to establishing and maintaining military superiority across all domains and to advancing U.S. and global security and economic prosperity.
 - The DoD is adapting to a new security environment in which space is now a contested, warfighting domain. This requires comprehensive Department-wide changes to ensure U.S. space superiority and to secure the Nation's vital interests in space.
 - This strategy will align the DoD space enterprise by providing strategic direction to leverage historic opportunities for reform due to the establishment of the U.S. Space Force, U.S. Space Command, and the Space Development Agency, along with enhanced space acquisition efforts.
 - The strategy embraces space as a unique domain of military power that, together with the other domains, underpins multi-domain joint and combined operations to advance national security.



SPACEPOWER:

The sum of a nation's capabilities to leverage space for diplomatic, information, military, and economic activities in peace or war in order to attain national objectives.

- ▶ The DSS describes how the Department will address threats, challenges, and opportunities in the current and future security environments.
 - China and Russia have weaponized space and turned it into a warfighting domain. They present the greatest strategic threat due to their development, testing, and deployment of counterspace capabilities and their associated military doctrine for employment in conflict extending to space.
 - In parallel, the rapid expansion of allied, partner, and commercial activities in space in recent years has added complexity to the space operating environment while creating unprecedented opportunities for collaboration.



CENTRAL PROBLEM:

The U.S. defense space enterprise was not built for the current strategic environment. The intentions and advancements of potential adversaries in space are threatening the ability of the United States to deter aggression, to protect U.S. national interests, and to fight and win future conflicts.

- ▶ The DSS provides guidance to DoD for achieving our desired conditions in space at an accelerated pace over the next 10 years, focusing on the military application of spacepower. DoD will advance spacepower through the pursuit of the following objectives:
 - Maintain Space Superiority
 - Provide Space Support to National, Joint, and Combined Operations
 - Ensure Space Stability

DESIRED CONDITIONS:

The space domain is secure, stable, and accessible. The use of space by the United States and our allies and partners is underpinned by sustained U.S. military strength.

- ▶ The strategy guides the most significant transformation in the history of the U.S. national security space program with a phased approach across four lines of effort:
 - ✓ **Build a comprehensive military advantage in space**
 - Transform the DoD space enterprise by reforming organizations, to include building out the U.S. Space Force; field assured and resilient architectures; improve intelligence, command and control, and our ability to counter hostile uses of space; and develop spacepower culture, expertise, doctrine, and operational concepts commensurate with the threat.
 - ✓ **Integrate military spacepower into national, joint, and combined operations**
 - Develop and enhance the integration of spacepower doctrine, capabilities, and personnel into national, joint, and combined operations, to include integrating space warfighting operations, intelligence, capabilities, and personnel into military plans and staffs; enable U.S. Space Command to bring full-time operational focus to deterrence and employment of military spacepower; realign operational authorities and update rules of engagement; update security classification for DoD space programs; and integrate allies and partners into space activities.
 - ✓ **Shape the strategic environment**
 - Deter adversary aggression and attacks in space; align with allies and partners to develop and promote standards and norms of appropriate behavior in space to reduce the potential for miscalculations; inform international and public audiences of growing adversarial threats in space; and advance U.S., allied, and partner national security interests.
 - ✓ **Cooperate with allies, partners, industry, and U.S. Government departments and agencies.**
 - Enhance space cooperation within the U.S. Government and with the international community and commercial sector to leverage opportunities in policy, strategy, capabilities, information sharing, and operations.



Fact Sheet: 2023 DoD Cyber Strategy

This week, the Department of Defense (DoD) transmitted to Congress the classified *2023 DoD Cyber Strategy*. The *2023 DoD Cyber Strategy* establishes how the Department will operate in and through cyberspace to protect the American people and advance the defense priorities of the United States.

This strategy is subordinate to the *2022 National Security Strategy* and the *2022 National Defense Strategy*. It complements the *2023 National Cybersecurity Strategy* and builds upon and supersedes the *2018 DoD Cyber Strategy*. An unclassified summary is forthcoming.

The *2023 DoD Cyber Strategy* is grounded in real-world experience. Since 2018, the Department has conducted a number of significant cyberspace operations through its policy of defending forward, actively disrupting malicious cyber activity before it can affect the U.S. Homeland. This strategy is further informed by Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine, which has demonstrated how cyber capabilities may be used in large-scale conventional conflict.

These experiences have shaped the Department's approach to the cyber domain:

- The Department will maximize its cyber capabilities in support of **integrated deterrence**, employing cyberspace operations in concert with other instruments of national power.
- The Department will **campaign** in and through cyberspace below the level of armed conflict to reinforce deterrence and frustrate adversaries.
- Finally, the Department recognizes that the United States' **global network of Allies and partners** represents a foundational advantage in the cyber domain that must be protected and reinforced.

The Department confronts an increasingly contested cyberspace:

- **The People's Republic of China (PRC)** represents the Department's pacing challenge in the cyber domain. The PRC has made significant investments in military cyber capabilities and empowered a number of proxy organizations to pursue malicious cyber activities against the United States.
- **Russia** poses an acute threat in cyberspace, evidenced by its malign influence efforts against the United States and repeated cyber attacks against Ukrainian civilian critical infrastructure.
- **North Korea, Iran, and Violent Extremist Organizations** remain persistent cyber threats.
- **Transnational Criminal Organizations** represent a unique threat in cyberspace due to their technical aptitude and often close alignment with the foreign policy objectives of their host governments.

In order to address current and future cyber threats, the Department will pursue four complementary lines of effort:

- **Defend the Nation.** The Department will campaign in and through cyberspace to generate insights about malicious cyber actors, as well as defend forward to disrupt and degrade these actors' capabilities and supporting ecosystems. Additionally, DoD will work with its interagency partners to leverage all available authorities to enable the cyber resilience of U.S. critical infrastructure and to counter threats to military readiness.

- **Prepare to Fight and Win the Nation's Wars.** The Department will ensure the cybersecurity of the DoD Information Network and will further invest in the Joint Force's cyber resilience. Additionally, the Department will use cyberspace operations to generate asymmetric advantages in support of the Joint Force's plans and operations.
- **Protect the Cyber Domain with Allies and Partners.** The Department will assist U.S. Allies and partners in building their cyber capacity and capability, as well as expand avenues of potential cyber cooperation. DoD will continue to conduct hunt forward operations to build cyber resiliency and will reinforce responsible state behavior by encouraging adherence to international law and internationally recognized cyberspace norms.
- **Build Enduring Advantages in Cyberspace.** The Department will optimize the organizing, training, and equipping of the Cyber Operations Forces and Service-retained cyber forces. Furthermore, DoD will invest in the enablers of cyberspace operations, including intelligence, science and technology, cybersecurity, and culture.

With a robust and integrated cyber capability, the Department will work to deter conflict where it can and prevail where it must.

NATIONAL CYBERSECURITY STRATEGY

MARCH 2023



THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON



THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

March 1, 2023

Digital technologies today touch nearly every aspect of American life. The openness and connection enabled by access to the Internet are game-changers for communities everywhere, as we have all experienced throughout the COVID-19 pandemic. That's why, thanks to the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, my Administration is investing \$65 billion to make sure every American has access to reliable, high-speed Internet. And when we pick up our smart phones to keep in touch with loved ones, log on to social media to share our ideas with one another, or connect to the Internet to run a business or take care of any of our basic needs, we need to be able to trust that the underlying digital ecosystem is safe, reliable, and secure. This National Cybersecurity Strategy details the comprehensive approach my Administration is taking to better secure cyberspace and ensure the United States is in the strongest possible position to realize all the benefits and potential of our digital future.

Cybersecurity is essential to the basic functioning of our economy, the operation of our critical infrastructure, the strength of our democracy and democratic institutions, the privacy of our data and communications, and our national defense. From the very beginning of my Administration, we have moved decisively to strengthen cybersecurity. I appointed senior cybersecurity officials at the White House and issued an Executive Order on Improving the Nation's Cybersecurity. Working in close cooperation with the private sector, my Administration has taken steps to protect the American people from hackers, hold bad actors and cybercriminals accountable, and defend against the increasingly malicious cyber campaigns targeting our security and privacy. And we've worked with our allies and partners around the world to improve our capacity to collectively defend against and respond to cyber threats from authoritarian states that go against our national interests.

This strategy recognizes that robust collaboration, particularly between the public and private sectors, is essential to securing cyberspace. It also takes on the systemic challenge that too much of the responsibility for cybersecurity has fallen on individual users and small organizations. By working in partnership with industry; civil society; and State, local, Tribal, and territorial governments, we will rebalance the responsibility for cybersecurity to be more effective and more equitable. We will realign incentives to favor long-term investments in security, resilience, and promising new technologies. We will collaborate with our allies and partners to strengthen norms of responsible state behavior, hold countries accountable for irresponsible behavior in cyberspace, and disrupt the networks of criminals behind dangerous cyberattacks around the globe. And we will work with the Congress to provide the resources and tools necessary to ensure effective cybersecurity practices are implemented across our most critical infrastructure.

As I have often said, our world is at an inflection point. That includes our digital world. The steps we take and choices we make today will determine the direction of our world for decades

to come. This is particularly true as we develop and enforce rules and norms for conduct in cyberspace. We must ensure the Internet remains open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure—anchored in universal values that respect human rights and fundamental freedoms. Digital connectivity should be a tool that uplifts and empowers people everywhere, not one used for repression and coercion. As this strategy details, the United States is prepared to meet this challenge from a position of strength, leading in lockstep with our closest allies and working with partners everywhere who share our vision for a brighter digital future.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Joe Biden". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style. A long, straight diagonal line extends from the bottom left of the signature towards the top left of the page.



TABLE OF CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION	1
PILLAR ONE DEFEND CRITICAL INFRASTRUCTURE	7
PILLAR TWO DISRUPT AND DISMANTLE THREAT ACTORS.....	14
PILLAR THREE SHAPE MARKET FORCES TO DRIVE SECURITY AND RESILIENCE.....	19
PILLAR FOUR INVEST IN A RESILIENT FUTURE.....	23
PILLAR FIVE FORGE INTERNATIONAL PARTNERSHIPS TO PURSUE SHARED GOALS	29
IMPLEMENTATION	34



INTRODUCTION

The Internet has transformed our world. In a single generation, it has revolutionized the way we innovate, communicate, and share information on a global scale, catalyzing unprecedented advancements in human prosperity, equality, and connectivity. Upon this Internet backbone we have built a flourishing digital ecosystem, combining systems and technologies with our economies, our societies, and ourselves.

In doing so, the digital ecosystem has come to reflect the values of its architects and its users. Technologies have promoted democracy, free speech, innovation, and equality. But they also have been misused to enable transnational repression and digital authoritarianism; steal data and intellectual property; distribute disinformation; disrupt critical infrastructure; proliferate online harassment, exploitation, and abuse; enable criminals and foster violent extremism; and threaten peace and stability. People and technology are increasingly linked, further enabling the very best, as well as the worst, of humanity.

In this decisive decade, we have grand ambitions for the further values-driven development of our digital ecosystem. We are building a smart grid, powered by distributed renewable electricity and balanced with intelligent systems, that promises a bright and resilient future of energy abundance. We envision a maturing “Internet of Things” (IoT), comprising everything from consumer goods to digitized industrial controls to constellations of satellites, that will increase efficiency and safety while providing game-changing insights into our environment and economy. We are laying the foundations for real-time global collaboration leveraging vast amounts of data and computing power that will unlock scientific discoveries and other public goods of which we cannot yet conceive.

Achieving this vision of a prosperous, connected future will depend upon the cybersecurity and resilience of its underlying technologies and systems. We have learned hard lessons and made significant progress in the collaborative defense of our digital ecosystem. Every day, cyber defenders foil state-backed attacks and prevent criminal plots around the world. But the underlying structural dynamics of the digital ecosystem frustrate their efforts. Its components remain prone to disruption, vulnerable to exploitation, and are often co-opted by malicious actors.

We must make fundamental changes to the underlying dynamics of the digital ecosystem, shifting the advantage to its defenders and perpetually frustrating the forces that would threaten it. Our goal is a defensible, resilient digital ecosystem where it is costlier to attack systems than defend them, where sensitive or private information is secure and protected, and where neither incidents nor errors cascade into catastrophic, systemic consequences. In creating these conditions, we can and must seize the opportunity to instill our most cherished values, as embodied by the Declaration for the Future of the Internet (DFI) and by the Freedom Online Coalition.

This strategy will position the United States and its allies and partners to build that digital ecosystem together, making it more easily and inherently defensible, resilient, and aligned with our values. By the end of this decisive decade, we will achieve these outcomes so we can confidently take bold leaps into a digitally-enabled future that benefits us all.



THE STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT

The United States has made significant progress toward achieving the President’s affirmative vision for a digitally-enabled future, but emerging trends are creating both new opportunities for further advancement and new challenges to overcome. Malicious actors threaten our progress toward a digital ecosystem that is inclusive, equitable, promotes prosperity, and aligns with our democratic values.

EMERGING TRENDS

The world is entering a new phase of deepening digital dependencies. Driven by emerging technologies and ever more complex and interdependent systems, dramatic shifts in the coming decade will unlock new possibilities for human flourishing and prosperity while also multiplying the systemic risks posed by insecure systems.

Software and systems are growing more complex, providing value to companies and consumers but also increasing our collective insecurity. Too often, we are layering new functionality and technology onto already intricate and brittle systems at the expense of security and resilience. The widespread introduction of artificial intelligence systems—which can act in ways unexpected to even their own creators—is heightening the complexity and risk associated with many of our most important technological systems.

The Internet continues to connect individuals, businesses, communities, and countries on shared platforms that enable scaled business solutions and international exchange. But this accelerating global interconnectivity also introduces risks. An attack on one organization, sector, or state can rapidly spill over to other sectors and regions, as happened during Russia’s 2017 “NotPetya” cyberattack on Ukraine, which spread across Europe, Asia, and the Americas, causing billions of dollars in damage. The potential cost of attacks like this will only grow as interdependencies increase.

Digital technologies increasingly touch the most sensitive aspects of our lives, providing convenience, but also creating new, often unforeseen risks. The COVID-19 pandemic has pushed us to live ever more deeply in a digital world. As our lives become intertwined with video and audio streaming, wearable devices, and biometric technologies, the quantity and intimacy of personal data collection is growing exponentially. Theft of that data is also growing rapidly, and opening up novel vectors for malicious actors to surveil, manipulate, and blackmail individuals.

Next-generation interconnectivity is collapsing the boundary between the digital and physical worlds, and exposing some of our most essential systems to disruption. Our factories, power grids, and water treatment facilities, among other essential infrastructure, are increasingly shedding old analog control systems and rapidly bringing online digital operational technology (OT). Advanced wireless technologies, IoT, and space-based assets—including those enabling positioning, navigation, and timing for civilian and military uses, environmental and weather monitoring, and everyday Internet-based activities from banking to telemedicine—will accelerate this trend, moving many of



our essential systems online and making cyberattacks inherently more destructive and impactful to our daily lives.

MALICIOUS ACTORS

Malicious cyber activity has evolved from nuisance defacement, to espionage and intellectual property theft, to damaging attacks against critical infrastructure, to ransomware attacks and cyber-enabled influence campaigns designed to undermine public trust in the foundation of our democracy. Once available only to a small number of well-resourced countries, offensive hacking tools and services, including foreign commercial spyware, are now widely accessible. These tools and services empower countries that previously lacked the ability to harm U.S. interests in cyberspace and enable a growing threat from organized criminal syndicates.

The governments of China, Russia, Iran, North Korea, and other autocratic states with revisionist intent are aggressively using advanced cyber capabilities to pursue objectives that run counter to our interests and broadly accepted international norms. Their reckless disregard for the rule of law and human rights in cyberspace is threatening U.S. national security and economic prosperity.

The People's Republic of China (PRC) now presents the broadest, most active, and most persistent threat to both government and private sector networks and is the only country with both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to do so. Over the last ten years, it has expanded cyber operations beyond intellectual property theft to become our most advanced strategic competitor with the capacity to threaten U.S. interests and dominate emerging technologies critical to global development. Having successfully harnessed the Internet as the backbone of its surveillance state and influence capabilities, the PRC is exporting its vision of digital authoritarianism, striving to shape the global Internet in its image and imperiling human rights beyond its borders.

For more than two decades, the Russian government has used its cyber capabilities to destabilize its neighbors and interfere in the domestic politics of democracies around the world. Russia remains a persistent cyber threat as it refines its cyber espionage, attack, influence, and disinformation capabilities to coerce sovereign countries, harbor transnational criminal actors, weaken U.S. alliances and partnerships, and subvert the rules-based international system. Like its 2017 "NotPetya" attack, Russia's cyberattacks in support of its 2022 brutal and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine have resulted in irresponsible spillover impacts onto civilian critical infrastructure in other European countries.

The governments of Iran and the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) are similarly growing in their sophistication and willingness to conduct malicious activity in cyberspace. Iran has used cyber capabilities to threaten U.S. allies in the Middle East and elsewhere, while the DPRK conducts cyber activities to generate revenue through criminal enterprises, such as through the theft of cryptocurrency, ransomware, and the deployment of surreptitious information technology (IT) workers for the purposes of fueling its nuclear ambitions. Further maturation of these capabilities could have significant impacts on U.S., allied, and partner interests.



The cyber operations of criminal syndicates now represent a threat to the national security, public safety, and economic prosperity of the United States and its allies and partners. Ransomware incidents have disrupted critical services and businesses across the country and around the world, from energy pipelines and food companies, to schools and hospitals. Total economic losses from ransomware attacks continue to climb, reaching billions of U.S. dollars annually. Criminal syndicates often operate out of states that do not cooperate with U.S. law enforcement and frequently encourage, harbor, or tolerate such activities. These and other malicious cyber activities continue to threaten Americans across society, including disproportionately affecting those without the resources necessary to protect themselves, recover, or seek recourse.

OUR APPROACH: A PATH TO RESILIENCE IN CYBERSPACE

Deep and enduring collaboration between stakeholders across our digital ecosystem will be the foundation upon which we make it more inherently defensible, resilient, and aligned with U.S. values. This strategy seeks to build and enhance collaboration around five pillars: (1) Defend Critical Infrastructure, (2) Disrupt and Dismantle Threat Actors, (3) Shape Market Forces to Drive Security and Resilience, (4) Invest in a Resilient Future, and (5) Forge International Partnerships to Pursue Shared Goals. Each effort requires unprecedented levels of collaboration across its respective stakeholder communities, including the public sector, private industry, civil society, and international allies and partners. The pillars organizing this strategy articulate a vision of shared purpose and priorities for these communities, highlight challenges they face in achieving this vision, and identify strategic objectives around which to organize their efforts.

To realize the vision these pillars lay out, we will make **two fundamental shifts** in how the United States allocates roles, responsibilities, and resources in cyberspace. In realizing these shifts, we aspire not just to improve our defenses, but to change those underlying dynamics that currently contravene our interests.

REBALANCE THE RESPONSIBILITY TO DEFEND CYBERSPACE

The most capable and best-positioned actors in cyberspace must be better stewards of the digital ecosystem. Today, end users bear too great a burden for mitigating cyber risks. Individuals, small businesses, state and local governments, and infrastructure operators have limited resources and competing priorities, yet these actors' choices can have a significant impact on our national cybersecurity. A single person's momentary lapse in judgment, use of an outdated password, or errant click on a suspicious link should not have national security consequences. Our collective cyber resilience cannot rely on the constant vigilance of our smallest organizations and individual citizens.

Instead, across both the public and private sectors, we must ask more of the most capable and best-positioned actors to make our digital ecosystem secure and resilient. In a free and interconnected society, protecting data and assuring the reliability of critical systems must be the responsibility of the owners and operators of the systems that hold our data and make our society function, as well as



of the technology providers that build and service these systems. Government's role is to protect its own systems; to ensure private entities, particularly critical infrastructure, are protecting their systems; and to carry out core governmental functions such as engaging in diplomacy, collecting intelligence, imposing economic costs, enforcing the law, and, conducting disruptive actions to counter cyber threats. Together, industry and government must drive effective and equitable collaboration to correct market failures, minimize the harms from cyber incidents to society's most vulnerable, and defend our shared digital ecosystem.

REALIGN INCENTIVES TO FAVOR LONG-TERM INVESTMENTS

Our economy and society must incentivize decision-making to make cyberspace more resilient and defensible over the long term. Balancing short-term imperatives against a long-term vision will be no easy task. We must defend the systems we have now, while investing in and building toward a future digital ecosystem that is more inherently defensible and resilient.

This strategy outlines how the Federal Government will use all tools available to reshape incentives and achieve unity of effort in a collaborative, equitable, and mutually beneficial manner. We must ensure that market forces and public programs alike reward security and resilience, build a robust and diverse cyber workforce, embrace security and resilience by design, strategically coordinate research and development investments in cybersecurity, and promote the collaborative stewardship of our digital ecosystem. To achieve these goals, the Federal Government will focus on points of leverage, where minimally invasive actions will produce the greatest gains in defensibility and systemic resilience.

The Federal Government is making generational investments in renewing our infrastructure, digitizing and decarbonizing our energy systems, securing our semiconductor supply chains, modernizing our cryptographic technologies, and rejuvenating our foreign and domestic policy priorities. The United States has an opportunity to rebalance the incentives necessary to lay a stronger, more resilient foundation on which to build the future of our digital ecosystem.

BUILDING ON EXISTING POLICY

This strategy, while laying out a new approach to our cybersecurity, builds on significant achievements already shaping our strategic environment and digital ecosystem. In its first days, the Biden-Harris Administration assumed responsibility for managing the fallout from Russia's compromise of the SolarWinds Orion platform and the PRC's compromise of servers running Microsoft Exchange. The President elevated White House leadership on cybersecurity, appointing experienced, senior leaders in new positions at the National Security Council (NSC) and the Office of National Cyber Director (ONCD), and moved quickly to fold lessons learned from these and other incidents into executive actions.

These forward-leaning efforts have laid the foundation upon which this strategy is built. It was developed alongside the National Security Strategy and National Defense Strategy by a broad



interagency team and through a months-long consultation process with the private sector and civil society. It is informed by and implements the values of the DFI, the Freedom Online Coalition, and other long-standing efforts to realize a democratic vision for our digital ecosystem. It carries forward the foundational direction of Executive Order (EO) 14028, “Improving the Nation’s Cybersecurity,” National Security Memorandum (NSM) 5, “Improving Cybersecurity for Critical Infrastructure Control Systems,” NSM 8, “Improving the Cybersecurity of National Security, Department of Defense (DoD), and Intelligence Community Systems,” and other executive actions. It integrates cybersecurity into the once-in-a-generation new investments made by the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, the Inflation Reduction Act, the Creating Helpful Incentives to Produce Semiconductors (CHIPS) and Science Act, and EO 14017, “America’s Supply Chains.”

This strategy also builds on the work of prior administrations. It replaces the 2018 National Cyber Strategy but continues momentum on many of its priorities, including the collaborative defense of the digital ecosystem. The Administration remains committed to enhancing the security and resilience of U.S. space systems, including by implementing Space Policy Directive 5, “Cybersecurity Principles for Space Systems.” The Administration also continues to implement critical efforts to secure next-generation technologies, including through the National Artificial Intelligence Initiative and the National Strategy to Secure 5G, among other existing policies and initiatives.

This strategy’s goals for securing Federal systems and collaborating with the private sector build on EO 13800, “Strengthening the Cybersecurity of Federal Networks and Critical Infrastructure,” EO 13691, “Promoting Private Sector Cybersecurity Information Sharing,” and EO 13636, “Improving Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity,” and fit within the frameworks established by Presidential Policy Directive 21, “Critical Infrastructure Security and Resilience,” and Presidential Policy Directive 41, “United States Cyber Incident Coordination.” It carries forward and evolves many of the strategic efforts originally initiated by the 2008 Comprehensive National Cybersecurity Initiative.



PILLAR ONE | DEFEND CRITICAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Defending the systems and assets that constitute our critical infrastructure is vital to our national security, public safety, and economic prosperity. The American people must have confidence in the availability and resilience of this infrastructure and the essential services it provides. We aim to operationalize an enduring and effective model of collaborative defense that equitably distributes risk and responsibility, and delivers a foundational level of security and resilience for our digital ecosystem.

Collaboration to address advanced threats will only be effective if owners and operators of critical infrastructure have cybersecurity protections in place to make it harder for adversaries to disrupt them. The Administration has established new cybersecurity requirements in certain critical sectors. In other sectors, new authorities will be required to set regulations that can drive better cybersecurity practices at scale. This Administration has conducted sector-specific engagement with industry to construct consistent, predictable regulatory frameworks for cybersecurity that focus on achieving security outcomes and enabling continuity of operations and functions, while promoting collaboration and innovation.

Private sector entities have made significant commitments to engage in collaborative defense efforts. The “Shields Up” campaign preceding Russia’s 2022 brutal and unprovoked war on Ukraine, to proactively increase preparedness and promote effective measures to combat malicious activity, is an example of public-private collaboration that must be scaled and repeated.

We must build new and innovative capabilities that allow owners and operators of critical infrastructure, Federal agencies, product vendors and service providers, and other stakeholders to effectively collaborate with each other at speed and scale. Federal agencies that support critical infrastructure providers must enhance their own capabilities and their ability to collaborate with other Federal entities. When incidents occur, Federal response efforts must be coordinated and tightly integrated with private sector and State, local, Tribal, and territorial (SLTT) partners.

Finally, the Federal Government can better support the defense of critical infrastructure by making its own systems more defensible and resilient. This Administration is committed to improving Federal cybersecurity through long-term efforts to implement a zero trust architecture strategy and modernize IT and OT infrastructure. In doing so, Federal cybersecurity can be a model for critical infrastructure across the United States for how to successfully build and operate secure and resilient systems.



STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 1.1: ESTABLISH CYBERSECURITY REQUIREMENTS TO SUPPORT NATIONAL SECURITY AND PUBLIC SAFETY

The American people must have confidence in the critical services underpinning their lives and the nation's economy. While voluntary approaches to critical infrastructure cybersecurity have produced meaningful improvements, the lack of mandatory requirements has resulted in inadequate and inconsistent outcomes. Today's marketplace insufficiently rewards—and often disadvantages—the owners and operators of critical infrastructure who invest in proactive measures to prevent or mitigate the effects of cyber incidents.

Regulation can level the playing field, enabling healthy competition without sacrificing cybersecurity or operational resilience. Our strategic environment requires modern and nimble regulatory frameworks for cybersecurity tailored for each sector's risk profile, harmonized to reduce duplication, complementary to public-private collaboration, and cognizant of the cost of implementation. New and updated cybersecurity regulations must be calibrated to meet the needs of national security and public safety, in addition to the security and safety of individuals, regulated entities, and their employees, customers, operations, and data.

The Administration has made progress in this area, establishing cybersecurity requirements in key sectors such as oil and natural gas pipelines, aviation, and rail, led by the Transportation Security Administration and water systems, led by the Environmental Protection Agency. A collaborative process between industry and regulators will produce regulatory requirements that are operationally and commercially viable and will ensure the safe and resilient operation of critical infrastructure. The most effective and efficient regulatory frameworks will be those put in place well before a crisis, rather than through the imposition of emergency regulations after a crisis occurs.

ESTABLISH CYBERSECURITY REGULATIONS TO SECURE CRITICAL INFRASTRUCTURE

The Federal Government will use existing authorities to set necessary cybersecurity requirements in critical sectors. Where Federal departments and agencies have gaps in statutory authorities to implement minimum cybersecurity requirements or mitigate related market failures, the Administration will work with Congress to close them. Where states or independent regulators have authorities that can be used to set cybersecurity requirements, the Administration will encourage them to use those authorities in a deliberate and coordinated manner.

Regulations should be performance-based, leverage existing cybersecurity frameworks, voluntary consensus standards, and guidance—including the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA)'s Cybersecurity Performance Goals and the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) Framework for Improving Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity—and be agile enough to adapt as adversaries increase their capabilities and change their tactics. In setting cybersecurity regulations for critical infrastructure, regulators are encouraged to drive the adoption of secure-by-



design principles, prioritize the availability of essential services, and ensure that systems are designed to fail safely and recover quickly. Regulations will define minimum expected cybersecurity practices or outcomes, but the Administration encourages and will support further efforts by entities to exceed these requirements.

Further, these and other critical sectors rely upon the cybersecurity and resilience of their third-party service providers. Cloud-based services enable better and more economical cybersecurity practices at scale, but they are also essential to operational resilience across many critical infrastructure sectors. The Administration will identify gaps in authorities to drive better cybersecurity practices in the cloud computing industry and for other essential third-party services, and work with industry, Congress, and regulators to close them.

HARMONIZE AND STREAMLINE NEW AND EXISTING REGULATION

Effective regulations minimize the cost and burden of compliance, enabling organizations to invest resources in building resilience and defending their systems and assets. By leveraging existing international standards in a manner consistent with current policy and law, regulatory agencies can minimize the burden of unique requirements and reduce the need for regulatory harmonization.

Where Federal regulations are in conflict, duplicative, or overly burdensome, regulators must work together to minimize these harms. When necessary, the United States will pursue cross-border regulatory harmonization to prevent cybersecurity requirements from impeding digital trade flows. Where feasible, regulators should work to harmonize not only regulations and rules, but also assessments and audits of regulated entities. ONCD, in coordination with the Office of Management and Budget (OMB), will lead the Administration's efforts on cybersecurity regulatory harmonization. The Cyber Incident Reporting Council will coordinate, deconflict, and harmonize Federal incident reporting requirements.

ENABLE REGULATED ENTITIES TO AFFORD SECURITY

Different critical infrastructure sectors have varying capacities to absorb the costs of cybersecurity, ranging from low-margin sectors that cannot easily increase investment without intervention, to those where the marginal costs of improving cybersecurity can be absorbed. In some sectors, regulation may be necessary to create a level playing field so that companies are not trapped in a competition to underspend their peers on cybersecurity. In other sectors, regulators are encouraged to ensure that necessary investments in cybersecurity are incentivized through the rate-making process, tax structures, or other mechanisms. In setting new cybersecurity requirements, regulators are encouraged to consult with regulated entities to understand how those requirements will be resourced. In seeking new regulatory authority, the Administration will work with Congress to develop regulatory frameworks that take into account the resources necessary to implement them.



STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 1.2: SCALE PUBLIC-PRIVATE COLLABORATION

Defending critical infrastructure against adversarial activity and other threats requires a model of cyber defense that emulates the distributed structure of the Internet. We will realize this distributed, networked model by developing and strengthening collaboration between defenders through structured roles and responsibilities and increased connectivity enabled by the automated exchange of data, information, and knowledge. Combining organizational collaboration and technology-enabled connectivity will create a trust-based “network of networks” that builds situational awareness and drives collective and synchronized action among the cyber defenders that protect our critical infrastructure.

CISA is the national coordinator for critical infrastructure security and resilience. In this role, CISA coordinates with Sector Risk Management Agencies (SRMAs) to enable the Federal Government to scale its coordination with critical infrastructure owners and operators across the United States. SRMAs have day-to-day responsibility and sector-specific expertise to improve security and resilience within their sectors. In turn, SRMAs support individual owners and operators in their respective sectors who are responsible for protecting the systems and assets they operate. Information sharing and analysis organizations (ISAOs), sector-focused information sharing and analysis centers (ISACs), and similar organizations facilitate cyber defense operations across vast and complex sectors.

The Federal Government will continue to enhance coordination between CISA and other SRMAs, invest in the development of SRMA capabilities, and otherwise enable SRMAs to proactively respond to the needs of critical infrastructure owners and operators in their sectors. The Federal Government will collaborate with industry to define sector-by-sector needs and assess gaps in current SRMA capabilities. Investment by the Federal Government in building out the capabilities of SRMAs will enable security and resilience improvements across critical infrastructure. SRMAs will coordinate with CISA to improve their ability to be proactive and responsive to the needs of their sectors. SRMAs must also continue to support the maturation of third-party collaboration mechanisms. Building on decades of experience collaborating with ISACs and ISAOs, the Federal Government will work with these and other groups to develop a shared vision of how this model should evolve.

Accelerating operational collaboration will require the use of technology solutions to share information and coordinate defensive efforts. We must complement human-to-human collaboration efforts with machine-to-machine data sharing and security orchestration. Realizing this model will enable real-time, actionable, and multi-directional sharing to drive threat response at machine speed. In partnership with the private sector, CISA and SRMAs will explore technical and organizational mechanisms to enhance and evolve machine-to-machine sharing of data. The Federal Government will also deepen operational and strategic collaboration with software, hardware, and managed service providers with the capability to reshape the cyber landscape in favor of greater security and resilience.



STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 1.3: INTEGRATE FEDERAL CYBERSECURITY CENTERS

The Federal Government must coordinate the authorities and capabilities of the departments and agencies that are collectively responsible for supporting the defense of critical infrastructure. Federal Cybersecurity Centers serve as collaborative nodes that fuse together whole-of-government capabilities across the homeland defense, law enforcement, intelligence, diplomatic, economic, and military missions. Once fully integrated, they will drive intragovernmental coordination and enable the Federal Government to effectively and decisively support non-Federal partners.

The Administration has made progress toward this goal, establishing the Joint Cyber Defense Collaborative (JCDC) at CISA to integrate cyber defense planning and operations across the Federal Government and with the private sector and international partners; strengthening the capabilities of the National Cyber Investigative Joint Task Force (NCIJTF) to coordinate law enforcement and other disruption actions; and revitalizing the Cyber Threat Intelligence Integration Center's (CTIIC) role in coordinating intelligence collection, analysis, and partnerships.

Operational collaboration models at SRMAs, such as the Department of Energy (DOE)'s Energy Threat Analysis Center (ETAC) pilot, DoD's Defense Industrial Base Collaborative Information Sharing Environment (DCISE), and the National Security Agency (NSA)'s Cybersecurity Collaboration Center provide opportunities to enable timely, actionable, and relevant information sharing directly with private sector partners in their respective sectors.

Further efforts will be required to strengthen and integrate the Federal Government's operational capabilities and improve integration of the Federal Cybersecurity Centers. ONCD will lead the Administration's efforts to enhance the integration of centers such as these, identify gaps in capabilities, and develop an implementation plan to enable collaboration at speed and scale.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 1.4: UPDATE FEDERAL INCIDENT RESPONSE PLANS AND PROCESSES

The private sector is capable of mitigating most cyber incidents without direct Federal assistance. When Federal assistance is required, the Federal Government must present a unified, coordinated, whole-of-government response. Organizations targeted by cyber threats must know which government agencies to contact for what purposes. The Federal Government must provide clear guidance on how private sector partners can reach Federal agencies for support during cyber incidents and what forms of support the Federal Government may provide.

Consistent with Presidential Policy Directive 41, "United States Cyber Incident Coordination,"—which defines lead roles for the Department of Justice (DOJ), Department of Homeland Security (DHS), and the Office of the Director of National Intelligence in threat, asset, and intelligence



response efforts, respectively—CISA will lead a process to update the subordinate National Cyber Incident Response Plan (NCIRP) to strengthen processes, procedures, and systems to more fully realize the policy that “a call to one is a call to all.” When any Federal agency receives a request for assistance, the agency will know what support the wider Federal Government can provide, how to contact the right Federal agencies that can provide such support, and have access to effective information sharing mechanisms. Because most Federal responses take place through field offices, the NCIRP will bolster coordination at the local level, taking lessons from the successes of the Joint Terrorism Task Forces.

When incidents do occur, the Cyber Incident Reporting for Critical Infrastructure Act of 2022 (CIRCIA) will enhance our awareness and ability to respond effectively. CIRCIA will require covered entities in critical infrastructure sectors to report covered cyber incidents to CISA within hours. These timely notifications and CISA’s rapid sharing of relevant information with DOJ and other incident response stakeholders will strengthen our collective defense, improve efforts to identify the root causes of incidents, and inform decision-making within government on how to respond. CISA will consult with SRMAs, DOJ, and other Federal agencies during the CIRCIA rule-making and implementation process to integrate incident reporting systems and ensure real-time sharing and actioning of all relevant incident information.

Following major incidents, we will ensure that the cybersecurity community benefits from lessons learned through the Cyber Safety Review Board (CSRB). Established by EO 14028, “Improving the Nation’s Cybersecurity,” the CSRB brings together public and private sector cybersecurity leaders to review major cyber incidents, conduct authoritative fact-finding, generate insights that will inform and guide industry remediations, and provide recommendations for improving the nation’s cybersecurity posture going forward. The Administration will work with Congress to pass legislation to codify the CSRB within DHS and provide it the authorities it needs to carry out comprehensive reviews of significant incidents.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 1.5: MODERNIZE FEDERAL DEFENSES

The Federal Government requires secure and resilient information, communications, and operational technology and services to perform its duties. In its first months, this Administration set a new strategic direction for Federal cybersecurity, publishing EO 14028, “Improving the Nation’s Cybersecurity,” which led to the release of NSM 8, “Improving the Cybersecurity of National Security, the Defense Department, and Intelligence Community Systems,” and the OMB Federal zero trust architecture strategy.

Building on this momentum, the Administration will drive long-term efforts to defend the Federal enterprise and modernize Federal systems in accordance with zero trust principles that acknowledge threats must be countered both inside and outside traditional network boundaries. By making its



own networks more defensible and resilient, the Federal Government will be a model for private sector emulation.

COLLECTIVELY DEFEND FEDERAL CIVILIAN AGENCIES

Federal civilian executive branch (FCEB) agencies are responsible for managing and securing their own IT and OT systems. With different agency structures, missions, capabilities, and resourcing, FCEB cybersecurity outcomes vary. We must continue to build a model for Federal cybersecurity that balances the individual authorities and capabilities of agencies with the security benefits achieved through a collective approach to defense.

We will continue to build Federal cohesion through focused action across the Federal Government. OMB, in coordination with CISA, will develop a plan of action to secure FCEB systems through collective operational defense, expanded availability of centralized shared services, and software supply chain risk mitigation. These efforts will build on prior programs and prioritize actions that advance a whole-of-government approach to defending FCEB information systems. The software supply chain risk mitigation objective, developed in coordination with NIST, will build on the implementation of EO 14028, “Improving the Nation’s Cybersecurity,” including the Software Bills of Material (SBOM) efforts, NIST’s Secure Software Development Framework, and related efforts to improve open-source software security.

MODERNIZE FEDERAL SYSTEMS

The Federal Government must replace or update IT and OT systems that are not defensible against sophisticated cyber threats. The OMB zero trust architecture strategy directs FCEB agencies to implement multi-factor authentication, encrypt their data, gain visibility into their entire attack surface, manage authorization and access, and adopt cloud security tools. These and other cybersecurity goals cannot be achieved unless Federal IT and OT systems are modernized so they are capable of leveraging critical security technologies. OMB will lead development of a multi-year lifecycle plan to accelerate FCEB technology modernization, prioritizing Federal efforts on eliminating legacy systems which are costly to maintain and difficult to defend. The plan will identify milestones to remove all legacy systems incapable of implementing our zero trust architecture strategy within a decade, or otherwise mitigate risks to those that cannot be replaced in that timeframe. Replacing legacy systems with more secure technology, including through accelerating migration to cloud-based services, will elevate the cybersecurity posture across the Federal Government and, in turn, improve the security and resilience of the digital services it provides to the American people.

DEFEND NATIONAL SECURITY SYSTEMS

National security systems (NSS) store and process some of the Federal Government’s most sensitive data and must be secured against a wide range of cyber and physical threats, including insider threats, cyber criminals, and the most sophisticated nation-state adversaries. The Director of the NSA, as the National Manager for NSS, will coordinate with OMB to develop a plan for NSS at FCEB agencies that ensures implementation of the enhanced cybersecurity requirements of NSM-8.



PILLAR TWO | DISRUPT AND DISMANTLE THREAT ACTORS

The United States will use all instruments of national power to disrupt and dismantle threat actors whose actions threaten our interests. These efforts may integrate diplomatic, information, military (both kinetic and cyber), financial, intelligence, and law enforcement capabilities. Our goal is to make malicious actors incapable of mounting sustained cyber-enabled campaigns that would threaten the national security or public safety of the United States.

Coordinated efforts by Federal and non-Federal entities have proven effective in frustrating the malicious cyber activity of foreign government, criminal, and other threat actors. The Federal Government has increased its capacity to respond to cyber incidents; arrested and successfully prosecuted transnational cybercriminals and state-sponsored actors; imposed sanctions on malicious cyber actors, including bans on travel and denying access to money service providers; and deprived threat actors of access to digital infrastructure and victim networks. The Federal Government has also targeted financial infrastructure used for illicit activity; established new diplomatic initiatives attributing disruptive, destructive, or otherwise destabilizing cyber activities to hold actors accountable for their malicious behavior; and recovered billions of dollars' worth of ill-gotten assets.

We will build upon these successes to enable more sustained and effective disruption of adversaries. Our efforts will require greater collaboration by public and private sector partners to improve intelligence sharing, execute disruption campaigns at scale, deny adversaries use of U.S.-based infrastructure, and thwart global ransomware campaigns.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 2.1: INTEGRATE FEDERAL DISRUPTION ACTIVITIES

Disruption campaigns must become so sustained and targeted that criminal cyber activity is rendered unprofitable and foreign government actors engaging in malicious cyber activity no longer see it as an effective means of achieving their goals. DOJ and other Federal law enforcement agencies have pioneered the integrated deployment of domestic legal authorities with private industry and international allies and partners to disrupt online criminal infrastructure and resources, from taking down notorious botnets to seizing cryptocurrency gleaned from ransomware and fraud campaigns. Information generated from these investigations enables other efforts, such as victim notification, issuance of cybersecurity advisories, private-sector actions, sanctions designations, diplomatic actions, and intelligence operations.

The Department of Defense's strategic approach of defending forward has helped generate insights on threat actors, identify and expose malware, and disrupt malicious activity before it could affect its intended targets. Informed by lessons learned and the rapidly-evolving threat environment, DoD will develop an updated departmental cyber strategy aligned with the National Security Strategy,



National Defense Strategy, and this National Cybersecurity Strategy. DoD's new strategy will clarify how U.S. Cyber Command and other DoD components will integrate cyberspace operations into their efforts to defend against state and non-state actors capable of posing strategic-level threats to U.S. interests, while continuing to strengthen their integration and coordination of operations with civilian, law enforcement, and intelligence partners to disrupt malicious activity at scale.

To increase the volume and speed of these integrated disruption campaigns, the Federal Government must further develop technological and organizational platforms that enable continuous, coordinated operations. The NCIJTF, as a multi-agency focal point for coordinating whole-of-government disruption campaigns, will expand its capacity to coordinate takedown and disruption campaigns with greater speed, scale, and frequency. Similarly, DoD and the Intelligence Community are committed to bringing to bear their full range of complementary authorities to disruption campaigns.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 2.2: ENHANCE PUBLIC-PRIVATE OPERATIONAL COLLABORATION TO DISRUPT ADVERSARIES

The private sector has growing visibility into adversary activity. This body of insight is often broader and more detailed than that of the Federal Government, due in part to the sheer scale of the private sector and its threat hunting operations, but also due to the rapid pace of innovation in tooling and capabilities. Effective disruption of malicious cyber activity requires more routine collaboration between the private sector entities that have unique insights and capabilities and the Federal agencies that have the means and authorities to act. The 2021 takedown of the Emotet botnet showed the potential of this collaborative approach, with Federal agencies, international allies and partners, and private industry cooperating to disrupt the botnet's operations. Given the interest of the cybersecurity community and digital infrastructure owners and operators in continuing this approach, we must sustain and expand upon this model so that collaborative disruption operations can be carried out on a continuous basis.

Private sector partners are encouraged to come together and organize their efforts through one or more nonprofit organizations that can serve as hubs for operational collaboration with the Federal Government, such as the National Cyber-Forensics and Training Alliance (NCFTA). Threat-specific collaboration should take the form of nimble, temporary cells, comprised of a small number of trusted operators, hosted and supported by a relevant hub. Using virtual collaboration platforms, members of the cell would share information bidirectionally and work rapidly to disrupt adversaries. The Federal Government will rapidly overcome barriers to supporting and leveraging this collaboration model, such as security requirements and records management policy.



STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 2.3: INCREASE THE SPEED AND SCALE OF INTELLIGENCE SHARING AND VICTIM NOTIFICATION

The timely sharing of threat intelligence between Federal and non-Federal partners enhances collaborative efforts to disrupt and dismantle adversaries. Open-source cybersecurity intelligence and private sector intelligence providers have greatly increased collective awareness of cyber threats, but national intelligence that only the government can collect remains invaluable. For instance, the NSA Cybersecurity Collaboration Center's national intelligence-driven engagement with industry has been highly effective at disrupting adversary activity targeting the Defense Industrial Base. Similarly, CISA enables persistent, multi-directional threat information sharing with the private sector through the JCDC and, in coordination with the FBI, uses that information to accelerate victim notification and to reduce the impact of identified intrusions.

The Federal Government will increase the speed and scale of cyber threat intelligence sharing to proactively warn cyber defenders and notify victims when the government has information that an organization is being actively targeted or may already be compromised. SRMAs, in coordination with CISA, law enforcement agencies, and the CTIIC, will identify intelligence needs and priorities within their sector and develop processes to share warnings, technical indicators, threat context, and other relevant information with both government and non-government partners. These processes must provide mechanisms for the private sector to provide timely feedback and their own threat intelligence to the Federal Government to improve targeting of cyber threats for disruption and further intelligence collection. The Federal Government will also review declassification policies and processes to determine the conditions under which extending additional classified access and expanding clearances is necessary to provide actionable intelligence to owners and operators of critical infrastructure.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 2.4: PREVENT ABUSE OF U.S.-BASED INFRASTRUCTURE

Malicious cyber actors exploit U.S.-based cloud infrastructure, domain registrars, hosting and email providers, and other digital services to carry out criminal activity, malign influence operations, and espionage against individual victims, businesses, governments, and other organizations in the United States and abroad. Often, these services are leased through foreign resellers who have multiple degrees of separation from their U.S.-based providers, hindering the ability of those providers to address abuse complaints or respond to legal process from U.S. authorities. The Federal Government will work with cloud and other internet infrastructure providers to quickly identify malicious use of U.S.-based infrastructure, share reports of malicious use with the government, make it easier for victims to report abuse of these systems, and make it more difficult for malicious actors to gain access to these resources in the first place.



All service providers must make reasonable attempts to secure the use of their infrastructure against abuse or other criminal behavior. The Administration will prioritize adoption and enforcement of a risk-based approach to cybersecurity across Infrastructure-as-a-Service providers that addresses known methods and indicators of malicious activity including through implementation of EO 13984, “Taking Additional Steps to Address the National Emergency with Respect to Significant Malicious Cyber-Enabled Activities.” Implementation of this order will make it more difficult for adversaries to abuse U.S.-based infrastructure while safeguarding individual privacy.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 2.5: COUNTER CYBERCRIME, DEFEAT RANSOMWARE

Ransomware is a threat to national security, public safety, and economic prosperity. Ransomware operators have disrupted hospitals, schools, pipeline operations, government services, and other critical infrastructure and essential services. Operating from safe havens like Russia, Iran, and North Korea, ransomware actors exploit poor cybersecurity practices to take control of victim networks and rely on cryptocurrencies to receive extortion payments and launder their proceeds.

Given ransomware’s impact on key critical infrastructure services, the United States will employ all elements of national power to counter the threat along four lines of effort: (1) leveraging international cooperation to disrupt the ransomware ecosystem and isolate those countries that provide safe havens for criminals; (2) investigating ransomware crimes and using law enforcement and other authorities to disrupt ransomware infrastructure and actors; (3) bolstering critical infrastructure resilience to withstand ransomware attacks; and (4) addressing the abuse of virtual currency to launder ransom payments.

As ransomware is a borderless challenge requiring international cooperation, the White House has convened the Counter-Ransomware Initiative (CRI) with participation from more than thirty countries. The CRI has conducted global exercises to build resilience and, as of January 2023, launched an international counter ransomware task force, led by Australia, to share information regarding the actors and infrastructure conducting ransomware attacks that will support and further accelerate CRI member countries’ existing, often coordinated disruption efforts. The CRI will also drive synchronization of policy and diplomatic efforts across its members.

The Administration is committed to mounting disruption campaigns and other efforts that are so sustained, coordinated, and targeted that they render ransomware no longer profitable. The Joint Ransomware Task Force (JRTF), co-chaired by CISA and the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), will coordinate, deconflict, and synchronize existing interagency efforts to disrupt ransomware operations and provide support to private sector and SLTT efforts to increase their protections against ransomware.

Our approach will also include targeting the illicit cryptocurrency exchanges on which ransomware operators rely and improving international implementation of standards for combatting virtual asset illicit finance. The United States subjects financial institutions offering covered services in



cryptocurrencies to Anti-Money Laundering and Countering the Financing of Terrorism (AML/CFT) controls, and the Department of the Treasury, the Secret Service, DOJ, the FBI, and private sector partners are collaborating to trace and interdict ransomware payments. The CRI has gained the commitment of members to implement international AML/CFT standards, including know-your-customer (KYC) rules, to make it harder for ransomware actors to launder cryptocurrency proceeds from attacks. Over the long term, the United States will support implementation of international AML/CFT standards globally to mitigate the use of cryptocurrencies for illicit activities that undermine our national interest as part of our efforts to implement EO 14067, “Ensuring Responsible Development of Digital Assets.”

Ultimately, the most effective way to undermine the motivation of these criminal groups is to reduce the potential for profit. For this reason, the Administration strongly discourages the payment of ransoms. At the same time, victims of ransomware – whether or not they choose to pay a ransom – should report the incident to law enforcement and other appropriate agencies. These reports enhance the Federal Government’s ability to provide victim support, to prevent further use of cryptocurrencies to evade AML/CFT controls, and to reduce the likelihood that future ransomware attacks will be successful.



PILLAR THREE | SHAPE MARKET FORCES TO DRIVE SECURITY AND RESILIENCE

To build the secure and resilient future we want, we must shape market forces to place responsibility on those within our digital ecosystem that are best positioned to reduce risk. We will shift the consequences of poor cybersecurity away from the most vulnerable, making our digital ecosystem more worthy of trust. In this effort, we will not replace or diminish the role of the market, but channel market forces productively toward keeping our country resilient and secure. Our goal is a modern digital economy that promotes practices that enhance the security and resilience of our digital ecosystem while preserving innovation and competition.

Continued disruptions of critical infrastructure and thefts of personal data make clear that market forces alone have not been enough to drive broad adoption of best practices in cybersecurity and resilience. In too many cases, organizations that choose not to invest in cybersecurity negatively and unfairly impact those that do, often disproportionately impacting small businesses and our most vulnerable communities. While market forces remain the first, best route to agile and effective innovation, they have not adequately mobilized industry to prioritize our core economic and national security interests.

To address these challenges, the Administration will shape the long-term security and resilience of the digital ecosystem, against both today's threats and tomorrow's challenges. We must hold the stewards of our data accountable for the protection of personal data; drive the development of more secure connected devices; and reshape laws that govern liability for data losses and harm caused by cybersecurity errors, software vulnerabilities, and other risks created by software and digital technologies. We will use Federal purchasing power and grant-making to incentivize security. And we will explore how the government can stabilize insurance markets against catastrophic risk to drive better cybersecurity practices and to provide market certainty when catastrophic events do occur.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 3.1: HOLD THE STEWARDS OF OUR DATA ACCOUNTABLE

Securing personal data is a foundational aspect to protecting consumer privacy in a digital future. Data-driven technologies have transformed our economy and offer convenience for consumers. But the dramatic proliferation of personal information expands the threat environment and increases the impact of data breaches on consumers. When organizations that have data on individuals fail to act as responsible stewards for this data, they externalize the costs onto everyday Americans. Often, the greatest harm falls upon the vulnerable populations for whom risks to their personal data can produce disproportionate harms.



The Administration supports legislative efforts to impose robust, clear limits on the ability to collect, use, transfer, and maintain personal data and provide strong protections for sensitive data like geolocation and health information. This legislation should also set national requirements to secure personal data consistent with standards and guidelines developed by NIST. By providing privacy requirements that evolve with threats, the United States can pave the way for a more secure future.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 3.2: DRIVE THE DEVELOPMENT OF SECURE IOT DEVICES

Internet of Things (IoT) devices, including both consumer goods like fitness trackers and baby monitors, as well as industrial control systems and sensors, introduce new sources of connectivity in our homes and businesses. However, many of the IoT devices deployed today are not sufficiently protected against cybersecurity threats. Too often they have been deployed with inadequate default settings, can be difficult or impossible to patch or upgrade, or come equipped with advanced—and sometimes unnecessary—capabilities that enable malicious cyber activities on critical physical and digital systems. Recent IoT vulnerabilities have shown just how easily bad actors can exploit these devices to construct botnets and conduct surveillance.

The Administration will continue to improve IoT cybersecurity through Federal research and development (R&D), procurement, and risk management efforts, as directed in the IoT Cybersecurity Improvement Act of 2020. In addition, the Administration will continue to advance the development of IoT security labeling programs, as directed under EO 14028, “Improving the Nation’s Cybersecurity.” Through the expansion of IoT security labels, consumers will be able to compare the cybersecurity protections offered by different IoT products, thus creating a market incentive for greater security across the entire IoT ecosystem.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 3.3: SHIFT LIABILITY FOR INSECURE SOFTWARE PRODUCTS AND SERVICES

Markets impose inadequate costs on—and often reward—those entities that introduce vulnerable products or services into our digital ecosystem. Too many vendors ignore best practices for secure development, ship products with insecure default configurations or known vulnerabilities, and integrate third-party software of unvetted or unknown provenance. Software makers are able to leverage their market position to fully disclaim liability by contract, further reducing their incentive to follow secure-by-design principles or perform pre-release testing. Poor software security greatly increases systemic risk across the digital ecosystem and leave American citizens bearing the ultimate cost.

We must begin to shift liability onto those entities that fail to take reasonable precautions to secure their software while recognizing that even the most advanced software security programs cannot



prevent all vulnerabilities. Companies that make software must have the freedom to innovate, but they must also be held liable when they fail to live up to the duty of care they owe consumers, businesses, or critical infrastructure providers. Responsibility must be placed on the stakeholders most capable of taking action to prevent bad outcomes, not on the end-users that often bear the consequences of insecure software nor on the open-source developer of a component that is integrated into a commercial product. Doing so will drive the market to produce safer products and services while preserving innovation and the ability of startups and other small- and medium-sized businesses to compete against market leaders.

The Administration will work with Congress and the private sector to develop legislation establishing liability for software products and services. Any such legislation should prevent manufacturers and software publishers with market power from fully disclaiming liability by contract, and establish higher standards of care for software in specific high-risk scenarios. To begin to shape standards of care for secure software development, the Administration will drive the development of an adaptable safe harbor framework to shield from liability companies that securely develop and maintain their software products and services. This safe harbor will draw from current best practices for secure software development, such as the NIST Secure Software Development Framework. It also must evolve over time, incorporating new tools for secure software development, software transparency, and vulnerability discovery.

To further incentivize the adoption of secure software development practices, the Administration will encourage coordinated vulnerability disclosure across all technology types and sectors; promote the further development of SBOMs; and develop a process for identifying and mitigating the risk presented by unsupported software that is widely used or supports critical infrastructure. In partnership with the private sector and the open-source software community, the Federal Government will also continue to invest in the development of secure software, including memory-safe languages and software development techniques, frameworks, and testing tools.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 3.4: USE FEDERAL GRANTS AND OTHER INCENTIVES TO BUILD IN SECURITY

Federal grant programs offer strategic opportunities to make investments in critical infrastructure that are designed, developed, fielded, and maintained with cybersecurity and all-hazards resilience in mind. Through programs funded by the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, the Inflation Reduction Act, and the CHIPS and Science Act, the United States is making once-in-a-generation investments in our infrastructure and the digital ecosystem that supports it. This Administration is committed to making investments in a manner that increases our collective systemic resilience.

The Federal Government will collaborate with SLTT entities, the private sector, and other partners to balance cybersecurity requirements for applicants with technical assistance and other forms of support. Together, we can drive investment in critical products and services that are secure- and resilient-by-design, and sustain and incentivize security and resilience throughout the lifecycle of



critical infrastructure. The Federal Government will also prioritize funding for cybersecurity research, development, and demonstration (RD&D) programs aimed at strengthening critical infrastructure cybersecurity and resilience. And, the Administration will work with Congress to develop other incentive mechanisms to drive better cybersecurity practices at scale.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 3.5: LEVERAGE FEDERAL PROCUREMENT TO IMPROVE ACCOUNTABILITY

Contracting requirements for vendors that sell to the Federal Government have been an effective tool for improving cybersecurity. EO 14028, “Improving the Nation’s Cybersecurity,” expands upon this approach, ensuring that contract requirements for cybersecurity are strengthened and standardized across Federal agencies. Continuing to pilot new concepts for setting, enforcing, and testing cybersecurity requirements through procurement can lead to novel and scalable approaches.

When companies make contractual commitments to follow cybersecurity best practices to the Federal Government, they must live up to them. The Civil Cyber-Fraud Initiative (CCFI) uses DOJ authorities under the False Claims Act to pursue civil actions against government grantees and contractors who fail to meet cybersecurity obligations. The CCFI will hold accountable entities or individuals that put U.S. information or systems at risk by knowingly providing deficient cybersecurity products or services, knowingly misrepresenting their cybersecurity practices or protocols, or knowingly violating obligations to monitor and report cyber incidents and breaches.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 3.6: EXPLORE A FEDERAL CYBER INSURANCE BACKSTOP

When catastrophic incidents occur, it is a government responsibility to stabilize the economy and provide certainty in uncertain times. In the event of a catastrophic cyber incident, the Federal Government could be called upon to stabilize the economy and aid recovery. Structuring that response before a catastrophic event occurs—rather than rushing to develop an aid package after the fact—could provide certainty to markets and make the nation more resilient. The Administration will assess the need for and possible structures of a Federal insurance response to catastrophic cyber events that would support the existing cyber insurance market. In developing this assessment, the Administration will seek input from, and consult with, Congress, state regulators, and industry stakeholders.



PILLAR FOUR | INVEST IN A RESILIENT FUTURE

A resilient and flourishing digital future tomorrow begins with investments made today. We can build a more secure, resilient, privacy-preserving, and equitable digital ecosystem through strategic investments and coordinated, collaborative action. In doing so, the United States will maintain its leading role as the world's foremost innovator in secure and resilient next-generation technologies and infrastructure.

Foundational elements of our digital ecosystem, like the Internet, are products of sustained and mutually-supporting investments by both public and private sector entities. However, public and private investments in cybersecurity have long trailed the threats and challenges we face. As we build a new generation of digital infrastructure, from next-generation telecommunications and IoT to distributed energy resources, and prepare for revolutionary changes in our technology landscape brought by artificial intelligence and quantum computing, the need to address this investment gap has grown more urgent.

The Federal Government must leverage strategic public investments in innovation, R&D, and education to drive outcomes that are economically sustainable and serve the national interest. We will leverage the National Science Foundation's (NSF) Regional Innovation Engines program, long-standing Secure and Trustworthy Cyberspace program; new grant programs and funding opportunities established in the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, Inflation Reduction Act, and CHIPS and Science Act; Manufacturing Institutes; and other elements of the Federal research and development enterprise.

These investments will assure continued U.S. leadership in technology and innovation as part of a modern industrial and innovation strategy. Decades of adversaries and malicious actors weaponizing our technology and innovation against us—to steal our intellectual property, interfere in or influence our electoral process, and undercut our national defenses—has demonstrated that leadership in innovation without security is not enough. We will complement our efforts to out-innovate other countries with focused, coordinated action to optimize critical and emerging technologies for cybersecurity as they are developed and deployed. We will ensure that resilience is not a discretionary element of new technical capabilities but a commercially viable element of the innovation and deployment process.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 4.1: SECURE THE TECHNICAL FOUNDATION OF THE INTERNET

The Internet is critical to our future but retains the fundamental structure of its past. Many of the technical foundations of the digital ecosystem are inherently vulnerable. Every time we build something new on top of this foundation, we add new vulnerabilities and increase our collective risk



exposure. We must take steps to mitigate the most urgent of these pervasive concerns such as Border Gateway Protocol vulnerabilities, unencrypted Domain Name System requests, and the slow adoption of IPv6. Such a “clean-up” effort to reduce systemic risk requires identification of the most pressing of these security challenges, further development of effective security measures, and close collaboration between public and private sectors to reduce our risk exposure without disrupting the platforms and services built atop this infrastructure. The Federal Government will lead by ensuring that its networks have implemented these and other security measures while partnering with stakeholders to develop and drive adoption of solutions that will improve the security of the Internet ecosystem and support research to understand and address reasons for slow adoption.

Preserving and extending the open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure Internet requires sustained engagement in standards development processes to instill our values and ensure that technical standards produce technologies that are more secure and resilient. As autocratic regimes seek to change the Internet and its multistakeholder foundation to enable government control, censorship, and surveillance, the United States and its foreign and private sector partners will implement a multi-pronged strategy to preserve technical excellence, protect our security, drive economic competitiveness, promote digital trade, and ensure that the “rules of the road” for technology standards favor principles of transparency, openness, consensus, relevance, and coherence. By supporting non-governmental Standards Developing Organizations (SDOs), the United States will partner with industry leaders, international allies, academic institutions, professional societies, consumer groups, and nonprofits, to secure emerging technologies, enable interoperability, foster global market competition, and protect our national security and economic advantage.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 4.2: REINVIGORATE FEDERAL RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT FOR CYBERSECURITY

Through Federal efforts to prioritize research and development in defensible and resilient architectures and reduce vulnerabilities in underlying technologies, we can ensure that the technologies of tomorrow are more secure than those of today.

As part of the update to the Federal Cybersecurity Research and Development Strategic Plan, the Federal Government will identify, prioritize, and catalyze the research, development, and demonstration (RD&D) community to proactively prevent and mitigate cybersecurity risks in existing and next generation technologies. Departments and agencies will direct RD&D projects to advance cybersecurity and resilience in areas such as artificial intelligence, operational technologies and industrial control systems, cloud infrastructure, telecommunications, encryption, system transparency, and data analytics used in critical infrastructure. These efforts will be supported by the Federal RD&D enterprise, including the NSF, DOE National Laboratories, and other Federally funded research and development centers (FFRDCs), and through partnerships with academia, manufacturers, technology companies, and owners and operators.



These RD&D investments will focus on securing three families of technologies that will prove decisive for U.S. leadership in the coming decade: computing-related technologies, including microelectronics, quantum information systems, and artificial intelligence; biotechnologies and biomanufacturing; and clean energy technologies. This effort will facilitate the proactive identification of potential vulnerabilities, as well as the research to mitigate them. It will also support a larger modern industrial and innovation strategy to promote coordinated and strategic innovation and create markets for trustworthy products and services by comprehensively leveraging Federal investment vehicles, Federal purchasing power, and Federal regulations.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 4.3: PREPARE FOR OUR POST-QUANTUM FUTURE

Strong encryption is foundational to cybersecurity and global commerce. It is the primary way we protect our data online, validate end users, authenticate signatures, and certify the accuracy of information. But quantum computing has the potential to break some of the most ubiquitous encryption standards deployed today. We must prioritize and accelerate investments in widespread replacement of hardware, software, and services that can be easily compromised by quantum computers so that information is protected against future attacks.

To balance the promotion and advancement of quantum computing against threats posed to digital systems, NSM 10, “Promoting United States Leadership in Quantum Computing While Mitigating Risks to Vulnerable Cryptographic Systems,” establishes a process for the timely transition of the country’s cryptographic systems to interoperable quantum-resistant cryptography. The Federal Government will prioritize the transition of vulnerable public networks and systems to quantum-resistant cryptography-based environments and develop complementary mitigation strategies to provide cryptographic agility in the face of unknown future risks. The private sector should follow the government’s model in preparing its own networks and systems for our post-quantum future.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 4.4: SECURE OUR CLEAN ENERGY FUTURE

Our accelerating national transition to a clean energy future is bringing online a new generation of interconnected hardware and software systems that have the potential to strengthen the resiliency, safety, and efficiency of the U.S. electric grid. These technologies, including distributed energy resources, “smart” energy generation and storage devices, advanced cloud-based grid management platforms, and transmission and distribution networks designed for high-capacity controllable loads are far more sophisticated, automated, and digitally interconnected than prior generations of grid systems.



As the United States makes a generational investment in new energy infrastructure, the Administration will seize this strategic opportunity to build in cybersecurity proactively through implementation of the Congressionally-directed National Cyber-Informed Engineering Strategy, rather than developing a patchwork of security controls after these connected devices are widely deployed. The Administration is coordinating the work of stakeholders across the Federal Government, industry, and SLTT to deploy a secure, interoperable network of electric vehicle chargers, zero-emission fueling infrastructure, and zero-emission transit and school buses. DOE, through efforts such as the Clean Energy Cybersecurity Accelerator (CECA) and the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law-directed Energy Cyber Sense program, and the National Labs are leading the government's effort to secure the clean energy grid of the future and generating security best practices that extend to other critical infrastructure sectors. DOE will also continue to promote cybersecurity for electric distribution and distributed energy resources in partnership with industry, States, Federal regulators, Congress, and other agencies.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 4.5: SUPPORT DEVELOPMENT OF A DIGITAL IDENTITY ECOSYSTEM

Enhanced digital identity solutions and infrastructure can enable a more innovative, equitable, safe and efficient digital economy. These solutions can support easier and more secure access to government benefits and services, trusted communication and social networks, and new possibilities for digital contracts and payment systems.

Today, the lack of secure, privacy-preserving, consent-based digital identity solutions allows fraud to flourish, perpetuates exclusion and inequity, and adds inefficiency to our financial activities and daily life. Identity theft is on the rise, with data breaches impacting nearly 300 million victims in 2021 and malicious actors fraudulently obtaining billions of dollars in COVID-19 pandemic relief funds intended for small businesses and individuals in need. This malicious activity affects us all, creating significant losses for businesses and producing harmful impacts on public benefit programs and those Americans who use them. Operating independently, neither the private nor public sectors have been able to solve this problem.

The Federal Government will encourage and enable investments in strong, verifiable digital identity solutions that promote security, accessibility and interoperability, financial and social inclusion, consumer privacy, and economic growth. Building on the NIST-led digital identity research program authorized in the CHIPS and Science Act, these efforts will include strengthening the security of digital credentials; providing attribute and credential validation services; conducting foundational research; updating standards, guidelines, and governance processes to support consistent use and interoperability; and develop digital identity platforms that promote transparency and measurement. Acknowledging that States are piloting mobile drivers' licenses, we note and encourage a focus on privacy, security, civil liberties, equity, accessibility, and interoperability.



In developing these capabilities, our digital identity policies and technologies will protect and enhance individual privacy, civil rights, and civil liberties; guard against unintended consequences, bias, and potential abuse; enable vendor choice and voluntary use by individuals; increase security and interoperability; promote inclusivity and accessibility; and improve transparency and accountability in the use of technology and individuals' data.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 4.6: DEVELOP A NATIONAL STRATEGY TO STRENGTHEN OUR CYBER WORKFORCE

Today, there are hundreds of thousands of unfilled vacancies in cybersecurity positions nationwide, and this gap is growing. Both private sector and public sector employers face challenges in recruiting, hiring, and retaining professionals to fill these vacancies, which negatively impacts our collective cybersecurity. To address this challenge, ONCD will lead the development and oversee implementation of a National Cyber Workforce and Education Strategy.

This strategy will take a comprehensive and coordinated approach to expanding the national cyber workforce, improving its diversity, and increasing access to cyber educational and training pathways. It will address the need for cybersecurity expertise across all sectors of the economy, with a special focus on critical infrastructure, and will enable the American workforce to continue to innovate in secure and resilient next-generation technologies. The strategy will strengthen and diversify the Federal cyber workforce, addressing the unique challenges the public sector faces in recruiting, retaining, and developing the talent and capacity needed to protect Federal data and IT infrastructure. And, the strategy will recognize that cyber workforce challenges are not unique to the United States, expanding upon and drawing inspiration from efforts underway in other countries.

The strategy will build on existing efforts to develop our national cybersecurity workforce including the National Initiative for Cybersecurity Education (NICE), the CyberCorps: Scholarship for Service program, the National Centers of Academic Excellence in Cybersecurity program, the Cybersecurity Education Training and Assistance Program, and the registered apprenticeships program. The strategy will also leverage ongoing workforce development programs at NSF and other science agencies to augment Federal Government programs.

It will tackle head on the lack of diversity in the cyber workforce. Employers are hiring from too small a pool of talent and from professional networks that are not able to draw from the full diversity of the country. Women, people of color, first-generation professionals and immigrants, individuals with disabilities, and LGBTQI+ individuals are among the communities which are underrepresented in the field. Addressing systemic inequities and overcoming barriers that inhibit diversity in the cyber workforce is both a moral necessity and a strategic imperative.

To recruit and train the next generation of cybersecurity professionals to secure our digital ecosystem will require Federal leadership and enduring partnership between public and private sectors. Building and maintaining a strong cyber workforce cannot be achieved unless a cybersecurity career is within reach for any capable American who wishes to pursue it and every



organization with an unfilled position plays a part in training the next generation of cybersecurity talent.



PILLAR FIVE | FORGE INTERNATIONAL PARTNERSHIPS TO PURSUE SHARED GOALS

The United States seeks a world where responsible state behavior in cyberspace is expected and rewarded and where irresponsible behavior is isolating and costly. To achieve this goal, we will continue to engage with countries working in opposition to our larger agenda on common problems while we build a broad coalition of nations working to maintain an open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure Internet.

For decades, we have worked through international institutions to define and advance responsible state behavior in cyberspace. We have used multilateral processes such as the United Nations (UN) Group of Governmental Experts and Open-Ended Working Group to develop a framework that includes a set of peacetime norms and confidence-building measures, which all UN member states have affirmed in the UN General Assembly. We have supported the expansion of the Budapest Convention on Cybercrime and other global efforts to make cyberspace more secure. We will continue these efforts while recognizing the need to work with partners to thwart the dark vision for the future of the Internet that the PRC and other autocratic governments promote. We will do so by demonstrating to economies and societies the value of openness and jointly imposing consequences for behavior that runs counter to agreed norms of state behavior.

To counter common threats, preserve and reinforce global Internet freedom, protect against transnational digital repression, and build toward a shared digital ecosystem that is more inherently resilient and defensible, the United States will work to scale the emerging model of collaboration by national cybersecurity stakeholders to cooperate with the international community. We will expand coalitions, collaboratively disrupt transnational criminals and other malicious cyber actors, build the capacity of our international allies and partners, reinforce the applicability of existing international law to state behavior in cyberspace, uphold globally accepted and voluntary norms of responsible state behavior in peacetime, and punish those that engage in disruptive, destructive, or destabilizing malicious cyber activity.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 5.1: BUILD COALITIONS TO COUNTER THREATS TO OUR DIGITAL ECOSYSTEM

In April 2022, the United States and 60 countries launched the Declaration for the Future of the Internet (DFI), bringing together a broad, diverse coalition of partners—the largest of its kind—around a common, democratic vision for an open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure digital future. Through the DFI, the Freedom Online Coalition, and other partnerships and mechanisms, the United States is rallying like-minded countries, the international business community, and other stakeholders to advance our vision for the future of the Internet that



promotes secure and trusted data flows, respects privacy, promotes human rights, and enables progress on broader challenges.

Through mechanisms like the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (“the Quad”) between the United States, India, Japan, and Australia, the United States and its international allies and partners are advancing these shared goals for cyberspace. These include improving information sharing between computer emergency response teams and the development of a digital ecosystem based on shared values. The Indo-Pacific Economic Framework for Prosperity (IPEF) and the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity (APEP) create opportunities for the United States and regional governments to collaborate in setting rules of the road for the digital economy, including facilitating the development of technical standards, mechanisms to enable cross-border data flows that protect privacy while avoiding strict data localization requirements, and actions to foster supply chain security and resilience. Through the U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council (TTC), we are coordinating across the Atlantic to combat shared threats and demonstrate how market approaches to digital trade, technology, and innovation can improve the lives of our citizens and be a force for greater prosperity. The United States is also working closely with Australia and the United Kingdom through the trilateral security and technology pact (“AUKUS”) to secure critical technologies, improve cyber coordination, and share advanced capabilities.

Through these and other partnerships, the United States and international counterparts can advance common cybersecurity interests by sharing cyber threat information, exchanging model cybersecurity practices, comparing sector-specific expertise, driving secure-by-design principles, and coordinating policy and incident response activities. Furthermore, multistakeholder partnerships and coalitions that also include private sector and civil society organizations, such as the Christchurch Call to Action to Eliminate Terrorist and Violent Extremist Content Online, the Freedom Online Coalition, and the Global Partnership for Action on Gender-Based Online Harassment and Abuse, are crucial to tackling systemic issues. We will leverage these partnerships to enable effective operational collaboration to defend our shared digital ecosystem. We will also support and help build, as needed, new and innovative partnerships—as in the case of the international Counter-Ransomware Initiative—that bring together unique collections of stakeholders to address new and emerging cybersecurity challenges.

Because most malicious cyber activity targeting the United States is carried out by actors based in foreign countries or using foreign computing infrastructure, we must strengthen the mechanisms we have to collaborate with our allies and partners so that no adversary can evade the rule of law. The United States will work with its allies and partners to develop new collaborative law enforcement mechanisms for the digital age. For example, the European Cybercrime Centre has played a vital role in modernizing legal frameworks, training law enforcement, improving attribution, collaborating with private sector partners, and responding to malicious cyber activities in Europe. To extend this model, we will support efforts to build effective hubs with partners in other regions.



STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 5.2: STRENGTHEN INTERNATIONAL PARTNER CAPACITY

As we build a coalition to advance shared cybersecurity priorities and promote a common vision for the digital ecosystem, the United States will strengthen the capacity of like-minded states across the globe to support these goals. We must enable our allies and partners to secure critical infrastructure networks, build effective incident detection and response capabilities, share cyber threat information, pursue diplomatic collaboration, build law enforcement capacity and effectiveness through operational collaboration, and support our shared interests in cyberspace by adhering to international law and reinforcing norms of responsible state behavior.

To accomplish this goal, the United States will marshal expertise across agencies, the public and private sectors, and among advanced regional partners to pursue coordinated and effective international cyber capacity-building and operational collaboration efforts. Within the law enforcement community, DOJ will continue to build a more robust cybercrime cooperation paradigm through bilateral and multilateral engagement and agreements, formal and informal cooperation, and providing international and regional leadership to strengthen cybercrime laws, policies, and operations. DoD will continue to strengthen its military-to-military relationships to leverage allies' and partners' unique skills and perspectives while building their capacity to contribute to our collective cybersecurity posture. The Department of State will continue to coordinate whole-of-government efforts to ensure Federal capacity building priorities are strategically aligned and further U.S., allied, and partner interests.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 5.3: EXPAND U.S. ABILITY TO ASSIST ALLIES AND PARTNERS

As recent cyberattacks against Costa Rica, Albania, and Montenegro have demonstrated, allies and partners who fall victim to a significant cyberattack may seek support from the United States and allied and partner nations to investigate, responding to, and recover from such incidents. Providing this support will not only assist with partner recovery and response, but will also advance U.S. foreign policy and cybersecurity goals. Close cooperation with an affected ally or partner demonstrates solidarity in the face of adversary activity and can accelerate efforts to expose counter-normative state behavior and impose consequences.

The Administration will establish policies for determining when it is in the national interest to provide such support, develop mechanisms for identifying and deploying department and agency resources in such efforts, and, where needed, rapidly seek to remove existing financial and procedural barriers to provide such operational support. As one example, the United States is leading a North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) effort to build a virtual cyber incident



support capability that enables Allies to more effectively and efficiently support each other in response to significant malicious cyber activities.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 5.4: BUILD COALITIONS TO REINFORCE GLOBAL NORMS OF RESPONSIBLE STATE BEHAVIOR

Every member of the United Nations has made a political commitment to endorse peacetime norms of responsible state behavior in cyberspace that includes refraining from cyber operations that would intentionally damage critical infrastructure contrary to their obligations under international law.

While our adversaries know that such commitments are not self-enforcing, the growing influence of this framework has led states to call out those who act contrary to it. Increasingly, a community of nations has collaborated to produce coordinated statements of attribution that carry the simultaneous diplomatic condemnation of many governments and strengthening the coalition committed to a stable cyberspace.

The United States, as a core part of its renewed, active diplomacy, will hold irresponsible states accountable when they fail to uphold their commitments. To effectively constrain our adversaries and counter malicious activities below the threshold of armed conflict, we will work with our allies and partners to pair statements of condemnation with the imposition of meaningful consequences. These efforts will require collaborative use of all tools of statecraft, including diplomatic isolation, economic costs, counter-cyber and law enforcement operations, or legal sanctions, among others.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE 5.5: SECURE GLOBAL SUPPLY CHAINS FOR INFORMATION, COMMUNICATIONS, AND OPERATIONAL TECHNOLOGY PRODUCTS AND SERVICES

Complex and globally interconnected supply chains produce the information, communications, and operational technology products and services that power the U.S. economy. From raw materials and basic components to finished products and services—both virtual and physical—we depend upon a growing network of foreign suppliers. This dependency on critical foreign products and services from untrusted suppliers introduces multiple sources of systemic risk to our digital ecosystem. Mitigating this risk will require long-term, strategic collaboration between public and private sectors at home and abroad to rebalance global supply chains and make them more transparent, secure, resilient, and trustworthy.

Critical inputs, components, and systems must increasingly be developed at home or in close coordination with allies and partners who share our vision of an open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure Internet. Building on the National Strategy to Secure 5G, we are working with our partners to develop secure, reliable, and trustworthy supply chains for 5G and next-generation



wireless networks including through Open Radio Access Networks (Open RAN) and collaborative initiatives to diversify suppliers. Such efforts include DoD testing of Open RAN implementations across multiple bases, with multi-million dollar smart warehouse and logistics projects, and National Telecommunications and Information Administration’s (NTIA) work to catalyze the development and adoption of open, interoperable, and standards-based networks through the Public Wireless Supply Chain Innovation Fund. Extending this model to other critical technologies will require long-term, strategic collaboration between public and private sectors at home and abroad to rebalance global supply chains and make them more secure, resilient, and trustworthy. The Bipartisan Infrastructure Law mandates “Build America, Buy America” for Federally-funded projects, including for digital infrastructure. Through EO 14017, “America’s Supply Chains,” the CHIPS and Science Act, and the Inflation Reduction Act, the Federal Government has introduced new industrial and innovation strategy tools to help restore production of critical goods to the United States and its close partners while securing our information technology and advanced manufacturing supply chains.

The United States will work with our allies and partners, including through regional partnerships like IPEF, the Quad Critical and Emerging Technology Working Group, and the TTC, to identify and implement best practices in cross-border supply chain risk management and work to shift supply chains to flow through partner countries and trusted vendors. This effort will prioritize opportunities to provide higher levels of assurance that digital technologies will function as expected and to attract countries to support the shared vision of an open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure Internet. The Department of State will further accelerate these efforts through the new International Technology Security and Innovation Fund to support the creation of secure and diverse supply chains for semiconductors and telecommunications. Finally, through implementation of EO 13873, “Securing the Information and Communications Technology and Services Supply Chain,” as well as EO 14034 “Protecting Americans’ Sensitive Data From Foreign Adversaries,” we will work to prevent unacceptable and undue risks to our national security from information and communications technology and services subject to control or influence from adversarial governments.



IMPLEMENTATION

Realizing the strategic objectives outlined in this strategy will require a strong focus on implementation. Under the oversight of NSC staff and in coordination with OMB, ONCD will coordinate implementation of this strategy. ONCD will work with interagency partners to develop and publish an implementation plan to set out the Federal lines of effort necessary to implement this strategy. Where implementation of this strategy requires review of existing policy or the development of new policy, NSC staff will lead this effort through the process described in NSM-2, “Renewing the National Security Council System.”

ASSESSING EFFECTIVENESS

In implementing this strategy, the Federal Government will take a data-driven approach. We will measure investments made, our progress toward implementation, and ultimate outcomes and effectiveness of these efforts. ONCD, in coordination with NSC staff, OMB, and departments and agencies, will assess the effectiveness of this strategy and report annually to the President, the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs, and Congress on the effectiveness of this strategy, associated policy, and follow-on actions in achieving its goals.

INCORPORATING LESSONS LEARNED

The Federal Government will prioritize capturing lessons learned from cyber incidents and apply those lessons in the implementation of this strategy. The CSRB completed its first review on the Log4j vulnerability in summer 2022, during which the CSRB compiled an authoritative account of what happened, from the discovery of the vulnerability to the progression of the largest-scale cyber incident response in history. The CSRB also provided industry, Federal agencies, and the software development community with clear, actionable recommendations based on what the review discovered, so that the community can be better protected going forward.

When the CSRB concludes its reviews, the Federal Government will address its recommendations by improving its own operations through executive action where possible, and will work with Congress to enhance authorities, as necessary. Federal agencies also will promote and amplify CSRB recommendations that are directed to network defenders in the private sector. Beyond the CSRB, a broader national effort to learn from cyber incidents is required. Regulators are encouraged to build incident review processes into their regulatory frameworks. CISA and law enforcement agencies are also encouraged to build processes to routinely extract lessons learned from their investigations and incident response activities. Private companies are likewise encouraged to undertake these reviews and share findings from their efforts to inform implementation of this strategy.

MAKING THE INVESTMENT

Maintaining an open, free, global, interoperable, reliable, and secure Internet and building a more defensible and resilient digital ecosystem will require generational investments by the Federal Government, allies and partners, and by the private sector. Many Federal actions contained in this strategy are intended to increase private sector investment in security, resilience, improved collaboration, and research and development. For Federal agencies to support their private sector



partners and increase their capacity to carry out essential Federal missions, targeted investment will be required. To guide this investment, ONCD and OMB will jointly issue annual guidance on cybersecurity budget priorities to departments and agencies to further the Administration's strategic approach. ONCD will work with OMB to ensure alignment of department and agency budget proposals to achieve the goals set out in this strategy. The Administration will work with Congress to fund cybersecurity activities to keep pace with the speed of change inherent within the cyber ecosystem.



U.S. Department of Defense

2024

ARCTIC STRATEGY







2024 ARCTIC STRATEGY

This page left intentionally blank.



SECRETARY OF DEFENSE
1000 DEFENSE PENTAGON
WASHINGTON, DC 20301-1000

JUN 21 2024

MEMORANDUM FOR SENIOR PENTAGON LEADERSHIP
COMMANDERS OF THE COMBATANT COMMANDS
DEFENSE AGENCY AND DOD FIELD ACTIVITY DIRECTORS

SUBJECT: 2024 Department of Defense Arctic Strategy

The United States is an Arctic nation, and the region is critical to the defense of our homeland, the protection of U.S. national sovereignty, and our defense treaty commitments. I am issuing this 2024 Arctic Strategy to guide the U.S. Department of Defense (DoD) in a concerted approach to preserve the Arctic as a stable region in which the U.S. homeland remains secure and vital national interests are safeguarded.

Major geopolitical changes are driving the need for this new strategic approach to the Arctic, including Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, the accession of Finland and Sweden to the NATO Alliance, increasing collaboration between the People's Republic of China (PRC) and Russia, and the accelerating impacts of climate change. This increasingly accessible region is becoming a venue for strategic competition, and the United States must stand ready to meet the challenge alongside Allies and partners.

This new DoD strategy directs the Department to enhance its Arctic capabilities, deepen engagement with Allies and partners, and exercise our forces to build readiness for operations at high latitudes. The document supports the 2022 National Security Strategy as well as the 2022 National Strategy for the Arctic Region, and its lines of effort implement the 2022 National Defense Strategy direction to adopt a "monitor-and-respond" approach to preserving stability in the Arctic. This strategy represents prudent and measured efforts to protect U.S. interests in the face of new challenges and an evolving security environment.

A handwritten signature in black ink, likely belonging to the Secretary of Defense, is positioned in the lower right area of the page.

This page left intentionally blank.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY	1
U.S. DEFENSE INTERESTS IN THE ARCTIC	2
STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT	3
DEFENSE APPROACH TO MANAGING NEW CHALLENGES.....	7
CONCLUSION.....	18

This page left intentionally blank.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This strategy lays out the Department of Defense’s (DoD’s) approach to the Arctic as the region undergoes rapid geophysical and geopolitical change.¹ The strategy aligns with and nests under the 2022 National Security Strategy (NSS), 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS), and 2022 National Strategy for the Arctic Region (NSAR). It also aligns with and implements the intent of the 2023 DoD Homeland Defense Policy Guidance.

The NSAR states that the United States seeks an Arctic region that is peaceful, stable, prosperous, and cooperative. In support of this national-level objective, DoD, in cooperation with our Allies and partners², will pursue an end state that preserves the Arctic as a stable region in which the U.S. homeland remains secure and vital national interests are safeguarded.

The NDS directs that activities in the Arctic will be calibrated to reflect a “monitor-and-respond” approach that is underpinned by robust intelligence collection capabilities, security cooperation with our regional Allies and partners, and the deterrent value of DoD’s ability to deploy the Joint Force globally at the time and place of our choosing. This strategy guides DoD’s efforts to build and sustain this monitor-and-respond approach to the Arctic. Implementing this strategy will enable DoD to achieve our desired end state for the region, aligning with efforts to strengthen homeland defense, safeguard U.S. interests, and improve interoperability with Arctic Allies and partners while preserving focus on the pacing challenge of the People’s Republic of China (PRC) globally.

Climate change and shifts in the geostrategic environment drive the need for a new strategic approach to the Arctic region. This strategy will strengthen the ability of the United States to build integrated deterrence and effectively manage risk to U.S. interests in the Arctic region by **enhancing** our domain awareness and Arctic capabilities; **engaging** with Allies, partners, and key stakeholders; and **exercising** tailored presence.

Primary risks to the success of this strategy stem from the need to balance against other DoD global commitments or find ways to integrate with other resource requirements. As such, DoD Components should take these risks into account during resourcing deliberations through DoD’s established processes.

1 For the purposes of this strategy, the definition of the Arctic is the same as that used in the Arctic Research and Policy Act (ARPA) of 1984 (Pub. L. 98-373; 15 U.S.C. 4111)–“all United States and foreign territory north of the Arctic Circle and all United States territory north and west of the boundary formed by the Porcupine, Yukon, and Kuskokwim Rivers; all contiguous seas, including the Arctic Ocean and the Beaufort, Bering, and Chukchi Seas; and the Aleutian Chain.”

2 For the purposes of this strategy, “partners” refers to an array of Arctic stakeholders to include: partner nations; U.S. Federal, state, local, tribal, and territorial agencies and governments; industry; inter-governmental organizations; and non-governmental organizations.

U.S. DEFENSE INTERESTS IN THE ARCTIC

The Arctic is a strategically important region for the United States. DoD's foremost objective is to protect the security of the American people, including those that call the Arctic home.

The North American Arctic region comprises the northern approaches to the homeland and includes sovereign U.S. territory in Alaska—home to significant U.S. defense infrastructure—and the sovereign territory of North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) Allies including Canada and the Kingdom of Denmark's autonomous territory of Greenland. Vital for homeland defense, the North American Arctic region hosts aerospace warning, aerospace control, and maritime warning capabilities for the binational U.S.-Canada North American Aerospace Defense Command (NORAD). The North American Arctic region is also integral to the execution of Indo-



An Alaska Army National Guard Infantryman assigned to the Avalanche Company, 1st Battalion, 297th Infantry Regiment, conducts military tactical movements while engaging with opposing forces during a training exercise near Joint Base Elmendorf-Richardson, Alaska on December 3, 2022. (Army National Guard photo by SPC Bradford Jackson)

Pacific operations, as the northern flank for projecting military force from the U.S. homeland to that region.

Geographically, the European Arctic region comprises the Arctic territory of NATO Allies Finland, Iceland, Norway, and Sweden, as well as Russia's Kola Peninsula. Collaboration in this region among Unified Combatant Commands (CCMDs) and Arctic Allies is critical to collective defense of NATO Allies and to U.S. homeland defense. The accession of new

NATO Allies and the strengthening of the Alliance opens strategic opportunities and supports critical objectives in the NSAR. The Arctic serves as an avenue for power projection to Europe and is vital to the defense of Atlantic sea lines of communication between North America and Europe.

The Arctic includes multiple strategically significant maritime chokepoints. Reduction in sea ice due to climate change means chokepoints such as the Bering Strait between Alaska and Russia and the Barents Sea north of Norway, are becoming more navigable and more economically and militarily significant.

STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT

PRC and Russian activities in the Arctic—including their growing cooperation—the enlargement of NATO, and the increasing effects of climate change herald a new, more dynamic Arctic security environment. These changes, as well as the growing cooperation between Russia and the PRC, have the potential to alter the Arctic’s stability and threat picture. They also present opportunities for DoD to enhance security in the region by deepening cooperation with Allies and partners.

1. PRC Activities in the Arctic

The PRC includes the Arctic in its long-term planning and seeks to increase its influence and activities in the region. Though not an Arctic nation, the PRC is attempting to leverage changing dynamics in the Arctic to pursue greater influence and access, take advantage of Arctic resources, and play a larger role in regional governance.

The PRC seeks to bolster its operational expertise in the Arctic, where its presence, while limited, is increasing. The PRC operates three icebreakers—the *Xue Long*, *Xue Long 2*, and *Zhong Shan Da Xue Ji Di*—which enable the PRC’s dual civil-military research efforts in the Arctic. Over the course of the PRC’s 13 Arctic research expeditions to date, the vessels have tested unmanned underwater vehicles and polar-capable fixed-wing aircraft, among other activities. People’s Liberation Army Navy (PLAN) vessels have also demonstrated the capability and intent to operate in and around the Arctic region through exercises alongside the Russian Navy over the past several years.

Although the vast majority of the Arctic is under the jurisdiction of sovereign states, the PRC seeks to promote the Arctic region as a “global commons” in order to shift Arctic governance in its favor. The PRC’s 2018 Arctic Policy claims non-Arctic states should contribute to the region’s “shared future for mankind” due to the Arctic’s global significance. Its “Polar Silk Road” has been used to gain a footing in the Arctic by pursuing investments in infrastructure and natural resources, including in the territory of NATO Allies.



Four F-35A Lightning IIs, assigned to the 388th Fighter Wing (FW) at Hill Air Force Base in Utah, fly in formation over Denali National Park, Alaska on August 17, 2020. The 388th FW joined the 354th FW for RED FLAG-Alaska 20-3, the Pacific Air Forces’ premier large force exercise. (U.S. Air Force photo by TSgt Jerilyn Quintanilla)

2. Russian Activities in the Arctic

The Arctic plays a significant role in Russia's security and economic calculations. This importance is reflected in Russian strategic documents, including Russia's 2023 Foreign Policy Concept, which raises the Arctic to Russia's second priority region after Russia's "near abroad." Russia boasts the largest Arctic territory and the most developed regional military presence of all the Arctic nations. Of concern, Russia's Arctic capabilities have the potential to hold the U.S. homeland, as well as Allied and partner territory, at risk. The Kola Peninsula is home to Russia's Northern Fleet and important strategic nuclear forces, specifically its submarine-launched ballistic missile force. Russia continues to invest heavily in new military infrastructure and refurbishing Soviet-era installations in the Arctic. Despite some attrition of Russia's conventional land forces due to losses in Ukraine, its strategic, air, and maritime forces remain intact. Further, Russia has demonstrated the ability to reconstitute and reorganize its conventional ground forces, which illuminates the potential for future improved readiness and combat expertise in the Arctic.

In addition to nuclear, conventional, and special operations threats, Russia seeks to carry out lower-level destabilizing activities in the Arctic against the United States and our Allies, including through Global Positioning System jamming and military flights that are conducted in an unprofessional manner inconsistent with international law and custom. Russia also has a clear avenue of approach to the U.S. homeland through the Arctic and could use its Arctic-based capabilities to threaten the ability of the United States to project power both to Europe and the Indo-Pacific region, constraining our ability to respond to crises. Furthermore, Russia's maritime infrastructure could allow it to enforce excessive and illegal maritime claims along the Northern Sea Route (NSR) between the Bering Strait and Kara Strait. Russia claims the right to regulate Arctic waters along the NSR in excess of the authority permitted under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), placing excessive requirements on foreign vessels transiting the route and threatening force against vessels out of compliance with Russian regulations.

3. PRC-Russia Collaboration

Increasingly, the PRC and Russia are collaborating in the Arctic across multiple instruments of national power. While significant areas of disagreement between the PRC and Russia remain, their growing alignment in the region is of concern, and DoD continues to monitor this cooperation.

Russia's isolation as a result of its full-scale invasion of Ukraine has made it increasingly reliant on the PRC for financing energy export infrastructure in the Arctic. Over 80 percent of Russia's

natural gas production and nearly 20 percent of its petroleum production comes from the Arctic, and Russia is increasingly turning to the PRC to fund this extraction and purchase these resources.

PRC-Russia military cooperation, including joint exercises in the Arctic, continues to increase. In 2022 and 2023, PLAN and Russian Navy ships operated together in international waters off the coast of Alaska, and the Chinese Coast Guard and Russian Federal Security Service signed a memorandum of understanding on maritime law enforcement. These activities could open the door for further PRC presence in the Arctic and along the NSR.

4. Changing Security Architecture

Finland and Sweden made the decision to join the NATO Alliance in the wake of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. Seven of eight Arctic nations (Canada, Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden, and the United States) are now NATO Allies, thereby strengthening the Western security architecture in the region. The Arctic NATO Allies possess highly capable militaries, and thanks to longstanding cooperation, are all highly interoperable. NATO's enlargement, in addition



A 10th Special Forces Group (Airborne) Green Beret talks to a Danish Special Operation Forces Operator in Utqiagvik, Alaska on March 6, 2024 during Arctic Edge 24 (AE24). AE24 is an annual USNORTHCOM defense exercise emphasizing operations in an extreme cold weather and high latitude environment. (U.S. Army photo by SGT Shai Zachar)

to increasing Nordic defense cooperation, will create new opportunities for combined planning, information sharing, and exercises that will expand regional collaboration. At the same time, an extended Alliance border with Russia in the Arctic increases the need for DoD to manage risk in the region.

5. The Effects of Climate Change on the Operating Environment

Climate change is rapidly reshaping the Arctic, which is warming more than three times faster than the rest of the world. The changes in the environment not only impact Arctic communities' way of life, but also DoD's operating context. DoD, State, and local infrastructure, much of it built during the Cold War era, faces degradation due to permafrost thaw and faster-than-anticipated rates of coastal erosion. More frequent forest fires in Alaska impact training days, and increased

variability of weather can affect warfighter and equipment performance. Sustaining distributed forces and remote operating locations is even more challenging in these changing Arctic conditions.

The Arctic may experience its first practically ice-free summer by 2030, and the loss of sea ice will increase the viability of Arctic maritime transit routes and access to undersea resources. Increases in human activity will elevate the risk of accidents, miscalculation, and environmental degradation.

As these changes take place, the U.S. Joint Force must be ready and equipped to mitigate the risks associated with potential contingencies in the Arctic consistent with 2022 NDS priorities and Secretary of Defense force planning guidance. It must also take into account that the Arctic's North American and European sub-regions have vastly different operating environments. The former is dryer, colder, and sparsely populated with minimal infrastructure, whereas the latter, influenced by the Gulf Stream, is comparatively warmer, wetter, and more populous, with more robust roads, ports, and communications networks.

DEFENSE APPROACH TO MANAGING NEW CHALLENGES

END STATE

Through this strategy, DoD, in cooperation with our Allies and partners, seeks to preserve the Arctic as a stable region in which the U.S. homeland remains secure and vital national interests are safeguarded.

WAYS

DoD will reach this end state through a monitor-and-respond approach. Monitoring involves robust intelligence collection in concert with other departments, agencies, Allies, and partners to provide early indications and warning to manage risk. This includes monitoring the activities of our adversaries as well as the physical changes to the operating environment. Should the security environment shift in a way that necessitates a DoD response, DoD will remain able to deploy the Joint Force globally at the time and place of our choosing. This includes responding in the Arctic, both independently and in cooperation with Allies and partners. Consistent with the NDS concept of integrated deterrence, it also means using Joint Force operations outside the Arctic to reinforce deterrence or disrupt our competitors' actions. DoD stands ready to support whole-of-government responses using any and all instruments of U.S. national power, as appropriate.

DoD will improve its ability to monitor and respond through three lines of effort (ways) and supporting means, aligned with the 2022 NDS and 2022 NSAR. DoD will:

1. Enhance the Joint Force's Arctic capabilities. By continuing to invest in sensors, intelligence, and information-sharing capabilities, DoD will enhance our understanding of the Arctic operating environment as well as our ability to manage risk. DoD should review existing equipment and infrastructure and develop options to sustain a monitor-and-respond approach;

2. Engage with our Allies and partners; Federal, State, and local authorities; Alaska Native tribes and communities; and industry in order to strengthen integrated deterrence and increase our shared security; and

3. Exercise presence in the Arctic by training both independently and alongside Allies and partners to demonstrate interoperability and credible joint capabilities while supporting homeland defense and global power projection operations.



U.S. Coast Guard Cutter Healy (WAGB-20) travels through the Arctic on July 31, 2023. (U.S. Space Force photo by Capt Henry Cho)

Enhancing our Arctic capabilities, particularly domain awareness and communications, will enable DoD to better monitor and respond to threats from and through the Arctic, and thus better deter aggression and defend the U.S. homeland. Improvements to domain awareness and communications are a key priority in the 2022 NSAR and an important component of

deterrence in the Arctic, as laid out in the 2022 NDS. DoD should pursue early warning capabilities; discrimination sensors; tracking sensors; Command, Control, Communications, Computers, Cyber, Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (C5ISR) capabilities; improved understanding of the electromagnetic spectrum; and sensing and forecasting capabilities. DoD will prioritize efforts in the North American Arctic in cooperation with Canada, while also enhancing capabilities with Allies and partners in the European Arctic.

To function effectively in the Arctic, the Joint Force requires sufficient Arctic-capable equipment to conduct all mission-essential tasks. Military Services and CCMDs responsible for the monitor-and-respond mission should review their relevant Arctic capabilities and requirements to determine if they can achieve their missions, with focus given to interoperability in joint and combined environments.

DoD will explore options to expand collaboration with Federal interagency partners and improve information sharing with Arctic Allies and partners. DoD will leverage existing knowledge and skills of the Joint Force to improve “Arctic literacy,” training proficiency, and operational competency in the austere and demanding Arctic environment.

1. All-Domain Awareness and Missile Warning. The Arctic holds our northern approaches to the U.S. homeland, and detecting threats from afar is critical to homeland defense. The network of U.S. and Canadian radars and sensors operated by NORAD and U.S. Northern Command (USNORTHCOM) enables the detection and tracking of certain threats from and through portions of the Arctic, but modernization is needed. In implementing the 2021 Joint Statement on NORAD Modernization, DoD will work with Canada to enhance our long-range persistent aerospace and maritime surveillance capabilities. DoD will assess options for improving ground-based sensors to complement and enhance existing NORAD capabilities. DoD will also continue to research

options for new space-based missile-warning and observational systems with greater polar coverage. Together, these improvements will strengthen our ability to address current and emerging aerospace and maritime threats from and through the Arctic.

In the European Arctic, DoD will continue to partner with our Allies to enhance all-domain awareness. U.S. European Command (USEUCOM) will work through our Arctic Allies and partners to identify all activities that affect our security interests and ensure our existing network of radars and sensors continue to contribute to Arctic aerospace and missile warning.

DoD will take these steps to improve domain awareness including of the electromagnetic spectrum; missile warning; and nuclear command, control, and communications in and through the Arctic alongside priorities outlined in the 2022 Nuclear Posture Review and 2022 Missile Defense Review to address the strategic threat from competitors, including Russia and the PRC.

2. Communications and Data Architecture. Communications in the Arctic region have historically posed a particular challenge for the Joint Force due to limited legacy satellite coverage in the region. In addition to military satellite communications solutions to improve tactical and strategic communications, specifically above 65 degrees North latitude, DoD should pursue technology through commercial partners and agreements with NATO Allies and partners. Satellites providing Arctic coverage should receive particular focus. These improvements will also enhance DoD's C5ISR capabilities.

Operating alongside Allies in the Arctic will require robust data transmission capacity. By the 2030s the United States and our Arctic Allies will operate over 250 advanced multirole combat aircraft that could be deployed for Arctic operations.³ To handle the large amount of data, DoD will explore opportunities, in cooperation with Allies and partners, to improve Arctic data coverage and capacity.



A radar dome belonging to the 23rd Space Operations Squadron Detachment 1 at Pituffik Space Base, Greenland on April 4, 2023. The detachment's extreme northern location allows contact with polar orbiting satellites 10-12 times per day. (U.S. Space Force photo by SrA Kaitlin Castillo)

In tandem, DoD should analyze the capacity and capability provided by proliferated, interconnected satellite constellations and the number of downlink terminals needed to meet Joint Force demands above 65 degrees North.

³ This does not include aircraft operated by other Allies, such as members of the Joint Expeditionary Force, which may operate in the Arctic.

3. Arctic Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) Capabilities. DoD should maintain investments in manned and unmanned aerial systems that may further enhance Arctic air and maritime domain ISR and conduct analysis of requirements for future unmanned platforms that can operate in the Arctic. DoD will take an integrated approach to information sharing and will seek to increase ground-based radar data sharing and expand Space Situational Awareness sharing agreements with select Arctic Allies and space faring nations to promote the responsible use of space.

4. Sensing, Modeling, and Forecasting. One of the Joint Force's primary challenges in the Arctic is the environment itself, with weather, temperature, ice coverage, oceanographic conditions, and atmospheric conditions affecting operations in the region. Climate change is increasing the unpredictability of an already challenging environment, and there are limited sensors and data to aid forecasts and longer-term climate projections. For the Joint Force to succeed in the Arctic, it will need to be able to predict and adapt to these conditions. As such, DoD should advance analysis to better sense, model, and predict the meteorological, atmospheric, and oceanographic environment within the Arctic. This includes continuing partnerships with other Federal entities for in-situ observations, as well as prioritizing naval oceanography, ice research, coupled atmospheric and ocean modeling, and ionospheric modeling. DoD should continue existing investments in space-based capabilities to augment current forecasting, observation, and modeling capabilities.

5. Infrastructure. DoD maintains bases in the Arctic that are important for campaigning, force projection, training, missile defense, satellite downlink, and personnel recovery/search and rescue (PR/SAR). The Arctic's vast distances, especially in North America, make supporting infrastructure vital for Arctic operations and presence. However, much of the legacy Cold War-era infrastructure has declined over time due to the harsh environment, lack of investment, and climate change-driven permafrost thawing and coastal erosion.

To enhance the ability of our forces to operate in and through the Arctic and enable response to advancing adversary capabilities, DoD will continue to sustain vital infrastructure in the region and will preserve regular access to and use of key Ally and partner bases. DoD will maintain investments that increase the all-hazard resilience of the most critical terrestrial and space-based infrastructure and capabilities to support all-domain awareness and ISR in the Arctic. DoD will also maintain investments in key Alaskan and Arctic infrastructure that enables the Joint Force to rapidly project power across the Arctic. These investments will improve our ability to monitor and respond to threats in support of homeland defense and security in the Arctic. Additionally, DoD will implement its bilateral defense cooperation agreements to enable calibrated presence using existing Allied infrastructure.

6. Cold Weather Equipment and Mobility. Operating in Arctic conditions requires appropriate training, equipment, and supplies for individual service members. Ground, air, and naval mobility platforms require specific sustainment operations not only to function in extreme cold weather, but also through other difficulties that now characterize Arctic conditions throughout the year such as flooding, wildfires, thawing permafrost, and the loss of historic ice. The Joint Force should be able to conduct mission-essential tasks at extremely cold temperatures routinely reaching -50 degrees Fahrenheit or below. In some cases, equipment, including weapon systems, can be outfitted to meet Arctic specifications, and in other cases, specialized equipment is needed. The Services should therefore ensure the adequacy of their Arctic equipment (accounting for both male and female personnel) in order to conduct relevant Arctic operations as directed, in accordance with their own Arctic strategies. Arctic-specific training should ensure appropriate mastery of this equipment. DoD will explore options to improve mobility in all seasons and variable conditions across the Arctic's diverse geography and weather.

ENGAGE

Allies and partners form a center of gravity as part of integrated deterrence, and they are at the core of DoD's strategy for the Arctic as well. The region boasts a notable concentration of highly capable Allies and partners with whom the United States already shares a high degree of cooperation and aligned interests, values, and objectives. We share North American aerospace warning, aerospace control, and maritime warning responsibilities with Canada via NORAD, the world's most enduring binational command. In the European Arctic, the Joint Force works by, with, and through our Allies to deter aggression in the region. In addition to relationships with Allied and partner militaries, regular engagement and government-to-government consultations with Alaska Native tribes, communities, and corporations are critical to achieving shared objectives. Many of our Allies and partners live every day in the Arctic operational environment and can bring significant capabilities and expertise to bear.

In addition to the important work alongside Allies and partners, DoD will remain ready to cooperate in the Arctic with any state or key stakeholder that shares our interests and is willing to work constructively to address shared challenges such as PR/SAR.

1. NATO. NATO Allies have a strategic interest and a treaty obligation to defend NATO territory in the Arctic. Finland and Sweden joining the Alliance creates opportunities for further collaboration, increased information sharing, and deepened cooperation, including by strengthening domain awareness, regional planning, and capabilities. DoD will work through NATO to ensure this strategy complements ongoing initiatives, including NATO's Concept for the Deterrence and Defense of the Euro-Atlantic Area, and is supported by NATO's Regional Plan Northwest. To further strengthen deterrence and defense, DoD will continue to leverage and

participate in NATO and Ally-led Arctic exercises. Participation in such exercises will enable the Joint Force to increase warfighting skills in Arctic conditions, use lessons learned from past engagements, and provide opportunities to learn from our Allies' extensive cold weather operating experience. This collaboration, including through unity and clarity of public-facing strategic communications, will be critical to maintaining stability and deterrence.

2. Arctic Fora and Institutions. DoD, alongside our Federal interagency partners, will engage in the appropriate Arctic institutions that facilitate regional security dialogue including the Arctic Security Forces Roundtable and Arctic Chiefs-of-Defense meetings. DoD, in partnership with our Arctic Allies and partners, will develop an Arctic Security Policy Roundtable to provide timely and relevant policy guidance to the established military-to-military fora. Additionally, DoD will support, as appropriate, U.S. participation in other Arctic fora including the Arctic Coast Guard Forum and the Arctic Council. While the mandate for the Arctic Council explicitly excludes defense topics, DoD will collaborate with its Federal interagency partners to support the United States' efforts to maintain the Arctic Council as the principal multilateral forum for the Arctic.

3. Special Operations Forces. U.S. special operations forces (SOF) provide unique expertise, capabilities, and access in the Arctic that strengthen the U.S. ability to campaign in the region. DoD and Arctic Allied SOF collaborate closely, and this collaboration provides a distinct



U.S. Marines with Marine Rotational Force-Europe 21.1, Marine Forces Europe and Africa, conduct a safety of use memorandum on an assault amphibious vehicle in preparation for Exercise Reindeer II, Reindeer I, and Joint Viking in Setermoen, Norway on November 19, 2020. (U.S. Marine Corps photo by Cpl William Chockey)

advantage focused on domain awareness, early warning, and forward posture. This cooperation with our Arctic Allies, including through bilateral, multinational, and NATO Special Operations Forces Command-led exercises, should continue. U.S. and Allied SOF are also a critical source of innovation for Arctic capabilities, and the DoD should continue to leverage the advanced experimentation efforts and exercises these forces routinely conduct.

4. Total Force. Much of DoD's Arctic expertise resides in the Reserve Components, including the National Guard, and DoD will continue to rely on the capabilities and expertise provided by the Total Force to achieve success in the Arctic. The National Guard hosts cold weather training exercises, contributes to PR/SAR operations in the region, and provides a significant portion of the Joint Force's Arctic airlift capability and air-to-air refueling in Alaska and the Arctic region. The National Guard Bureau (NGB) also manages the State Partnership Program (SPP), which is a

key security cooperation mechanism for engaging with Arctic Allies in support of the CCMDs, as demonstrated by the Minnesota National Guard's ongoing partnership with Norway. DoD will continue to look for opportunities and support engagements and partnerships with Arctic countries across the Total Force, to include the SPP.

5. Indigenous and Alaska Native Tribes and Communities. Arctic Indigenous and Alaska Native tribes and communities hold valuable understanding of operating in the region and have thrived in the Arctic for thousands of years. Consistent with the NSAR, DoD will continue to consult and coordinate with Alaska Native tribes, communities, and Alaska Native corporations. Further, DoD will work to incorporate Indigenous Knowledge about the Arctic to inform and improve our ability to effectively operate in the region and to increase our understanding about potential DoD impacts on subsistence culture and ways of life.

6. Federal Interagency Partnerships. Ensuring stability and maintaining U.S. national interests in the Arctic is a whole-of-government effort requiring consistent collaboration with interagency counterparts. DoD will support wider U.S. Government engagement within Arctic multilateral fora and continue to work closely with the Department of State as we engage with our Allies and partners on Arctic security issues. DoD will continue to advance integrated deterrence in the Arctic by collaborating with interagency counterparts to identify activities and address gray zone threats from our competitors in the economic, diplomatic, and information spaces.

DoD will partner with the Department of Homeland Security (DHS), including through the U.S. Coast Guard (USCG), which plays a vital role in maintaining U.S. presence in the Arctic region and supporting domain awareness. The USCG is responsible for operating and maintaining the United States' icebreaking capability, and DoD

will continue to support the USCG's long-term acquisition of at least eight polar icebreakers that will provide needed icebreaking capability for both military and civilian purposes, including PR/SAR. While disaster response is not a force sizing or shaping requirement, DoD remains ready to support DHS and the Federal Emergency Management Agency in the event of disaster, terrorist



An Air-Deployable Expendable Ice Buoy deploys from a C-17 Globemaster III over the Arctic Ocean on July 12, 2023. The Office of Naval Research partnered with the 144th Airlift Squadron to deploy data-gathering buoys across the Arctic Ocean. This deployment supported the International Arctic Buoy Programme, which maintains a network of buoys for real-time meteorological predictions and sea ice research. (U.S. Air Force photo by Airman 1st Class Shelimar Rivera Rosado)

attack, or other mass-casualty incident in the Arctic when directed by the President or when requested by a lead Federal department or agency and approved by the Secretary of Defense.

To help improve our understanding of the Arctic environment, DoD should continue to partner with other Federal organizations such as the U.S. Global Change Research Program; U.S. National Ice Center; and the U.S. Interagency Arctic Buoy Program. DoD should formalize coordination with the Department of Commerce’s National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration to collect and disseminate critical environmental information, aiming to enhance domain awareness and improve DoD operability.

7. Arctic Literacy. Successfully campaigning in the Arctic requires specialized understanding and knowledge of the region’s unique operating environment and strategic importance. DoD will leverage the Ted Stevens Center for Arctic Security Studies (TSC) to develop security-related educational programs for both international and U.S. participants. TSC’s mission of educating military and civilian leaders on the complexities of the Arctic region is key to integrating Arctic knowledge across DoD and with our Allies and partners. DoD will also ensure collaboration between TSC and the other DoD regional and functional centers to support Arctic literacy whether in competition, crisis, or conflict. To build this enduring knowledge base, DoD will promote DoD-wide Arctic security and climate education, training, and information-sharing to ensure our workforce can operate successfully in the Arctic.

8. Arctic Research. Advancements in research and development will be fundamental to future Arctic operations to improve Joint Force Arctic capabilities and understanding of the changing environment. To drive alignment on priorities, DoD will continue to periodically host the DoD Polar Research Workshop, collaborate with the Interagency Arctic Research and Policy Committee, and adopt commercial solutions where practical. DoD will work with Allies and partners to strengthen the work of the International Cooperative Engagement Program on Polar Research (ICE-PPR), which seeks to accelerate the development of Arctic capabilities while reducing duplication of effort. DoD’s support of state-of-the-art research at DoD Laboratories will continue to further Arctic operational requirements and foster partnership with academic institutions. DoD values and will continue to support its decades-long partnership with the National Science Foundation to advance Arctic science for domestic and international entities.

EXERCISE

Continuing to exercise presence in the Arctic through training and operations will enhance deterrence by demonstrating combat-credible capabilities and the ability to respond rapidly to threats in the Arctic and elsewhere around the globe. Permanently stationed units of the Joint Force in Alaska serve as the first line of deterrence, while rotational units provide additional capabilities. Calibrated presence in the Arctic will exercise U.S. sovereignty and further uphold the navigational

rights and freedoms that are key to maintaining a stable and secure Arctic region. Training, exercising, and operating across all domains in the Arctic, with supporting infrastructure, will improve operational effectiveness by familiarizing the Joint Force with the unique and demanding operating environments of the North American and European Arctic regions. By exercising alongside Arctic Allies and partners, the Joint Force will improve interoperability and gain regional expertise.

1. Service-specific, Joint, Interagency, and Combined Exercises. Security and stability in the Arctic depend, in part, on the Joint Force’s ability to respond rapidly and effectively to threats in the region. Exercises increase interoperability with Allies and partners, validate plans, train our ability to rapidly deploy to all parts of the Arctic region, and provide an opportunity to test equipment in Arctic conditions. As such, the Joint Force will continue to exercise frequently in the Arctic through Service-specific training, joint exercises—to include with USCG—and combined exercises with our Allies and partners. DoD will ensure CCMDs with Arctic equities work toward global integration through joint exercises and ensure key exercise lessons inform capability requirements and strategic planning.



The U.S. Navy guided-missile destroyer USS Gridley (DDG 101) is moored pierside in Tromsø, Norway, during a brief stop for fuel on November 23, 2019. Gridley was underway on a scheduled deployment as the flagship of Standing NATO Maritime Group One to provide a continuous maritime capability for NATO in the North Atlantic. (U.S. Navy photo by Mass Communication Spc. 2nd Class Cameron Stoner)

In the North American Arctic region, DoD will leverage ARCTIC EDGE, DoD’s premier Arctic exercise, and U.S. Indo-Pacific Command’s (USINDOPACOM) NORTHERN EDGE to develop and strengthen homeland defense plans, exercise joint presence, and highlight global integration among USNORTHCOM, USEUCOM, and USINDOPACOM. DoD will also enhance readiness through the U.S. Navy’s biennial Operation ICE CAMP submarine exercise north of Alaska, and the U.S. Army’s annual Alaska rotation of the Joint Pacific Multinational Readiness Center. To hone Arctic early warning and missile defense capabilities, DoD will train with Canada through Operation NANOOK and through NORAD and USNORTHCOM-led operations and exercises NOBLE DEFENDER and VIGILANT SHIELD. In the European Arctic, the Joint Force will participate in USEUCOM, NATO, and Ally-hosted exercises such as NORDIC RESPONSE, DYNAMIC MONGOOSE, and ARCTIC CHALLENGE to ensure the Joint Force is familiar with the different operating conditions in the European Arctic.

In addition to exercises, the Joint Force should conduct wargames, simulations, and tabletop exercises focusing on the Arctic that challenge prevailing assumptions and explore potential gaps. The experiential learning from these exercises serves as important Arctic and climate literacy opportunities, further strengthening DoD's strategic planning and engagement with partners.

2. Arctic Operations. The Joint Force, along with our Allies, will continue to conduct routine operations in the region. These operations will include: supporting NORAD's enforcement of the U.S. and Canadian air defense identification zones consistent with international law and custom; providing integrated air and missile defense; identifying and intercepting vessels within waters under U.S. jurisdiction that are acting inconsistent with navigation rights reflected in UNCLOS;



U.S. and Canadian Soldiers practiced tactical insertion on an open ice skiway delivered by an LC-130 Hercules skiplane of the 109th Airlift Wing, New York Air National Guard, on oceanic Arctic ice near Cornwallis Island, Nunavut, Canada on March 15, 2023 during annual domestic emergency and response exercise, Guerrier Nordique 23.

U.S. Soldiers and Airmen consisted mainly of National Guard units from Connecticut, New Hampshire, Utah, New York, and Vermont. U.S. Army Soldiers came from the 11th Airborne Division out of Ft Wainwright, Alaska. Canadian Soldiers came mainly from the 35th Canadian Brigade Group.

(Vermont National Guard photo by CPT Mikel Arcovitch)

routinely deploying submarines to the region to provide undersea awareness and bolster integrated deterrence in defense of U.S. and Allied interests; dynamically deploying ground forces to the Arctic to demonstrate deterrent capabilities; continuing airborne and maritime patrols with Allies across the Arctic region to include areas such as the Greenland-Iceland-United Kingdom gap; supporting NATO's Air Policing mission in Iceland; and providing airlift and refueling capability to U.S. and appropriate Ally and partner aircraft in the Arctic region.

3. Training. To operate in the changing Arctic environment, the Joint Force must have the requisite skills, training, and experience. Each Service should regularly train Arctic capable forces individually and collectively in cold weather operational skills (e.g., skiing, snowshoeing, unit movement, medical care, equipment sustainment, and survival) required for successful Joint and combined operations in an Arctic environment.

4. Defending the Stable and Open International System. Preserving navigational rights and freedoms in increasingly accessible Arctic waterways is key to maintaining a stable and secure region. DoD will continue to monitor potential threats to freedom of navigation in the Arctic, uphold lawful uses of the seas guaranteed to all States under customary international law as reflected in UNCLOS, and protect the global mobility of U.S., Allied, and partner forces by conducting Arctic maritime exercises, operations, and transits, in coordination with these nations, as appropriate.

This strategy provides a path forward for DoD, working with U.S. Government counterparts, and with Allies and partners, to both manage risks and embrace opportunities presented by a changing Arctic region. The strategy's pragmatic and transparent approach is intended to reduce the possibility of escalation or misinterpretation.

A primary risk to the successful implementation of this strategy stems from the need to balance against other global priorities. DoD and the Joint Force have global responsibilities and must remain prepared to respond to a broad range of challenges and threats around the world.

The NDS provides the Secretary's clear guidance that DoD will monitor and respond to threats in the Arctic region. DoD will undertake prudent and calibrated efforts to that end, guided by the three lines of effort in this strategy. Resourcing deliberations via established DoD processes will include consideration of the costs of potential investments as well as the risks of failing to provide sufficient capabilities and assets to respond to threats. Where possible, DoD will utilize the collective capability of the U.S. Government and international Allies and partners to develop whole-of-government and combined capabilities.

Insufficient investments in early warning and air defense sensors in the Arctic will increase risks to the U.S. homeland. A lack of Arctic-capable domain awareness and communications capabilities would hamper the U.S. military's ability to operate in the region in response to competitor activities. Lastly, insufficient Arctic readiness will cast doubt on the credibility of the Joint Force to effectively operate in the region. To ensure the Arctic does not become a strategic blind spot, this strategy outlines a series of deliberate steps for DoD to improve its ability to monitor events in the Arctic and, when directed, execute a tailored response to national security threats alongside its interagency and international partners.

Recognizing the unique challenges of the Arctic environment and geography, which spans multiple CCMDs, Commander, USNORTHCOM will continue to serve as DoD's Arctic capability advocate. This role will coordinate with other CCMDs to identify and request resources for Arctic capability gaps, as appropriate, through DoD's established planning and programming processes as directed in the Unified Command Plan. The Under Secretary of Defense for Policy will develop Department-wide policy that builds enduring advantages in Arctic.

CONCLUSION

As the Arctic security environment evolves, DoD must remain prepared to protect our national interests. The calibrated approach laid out in this strategy will guide how DoD adapts to geopolitical and geophysical changes in the Arctic and ensure U.S. Allies and partners act cohesively in this increasingly accessible region. With the appropriate resources, this strategy will enable DoD to support whole-of-government efforts to maintain security and stability in the Arctic and beyond.

This page left intentionally blank.



AIR FORCE DOCTRINE NOTE 25-1

"FIGHT'S ON!"

WED FEB 05 2020 0006
0423 0923 1423 1923 2353
JSTW 100000 100000 100000 100000 100000

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI)



U.S. AIR FORCE

8 April 2025

Air Force Doctrine Note 25-1, *Artificial Intelligence (AI)*

Table of Contents

Foreword.....	i
Chapter 1: INTRODUCTION	1
THE PROMISE OF AI.....	1
THE RISK OF AI.....	2
Chapter 2: AI OVERVIEW.....	3
WHAT IS AI?	3
AUTOMATION VS AUTONOMY	5
Chapter 3: AI APPLICATION.....	6
HUMAN-MACHINE TEAMING	6
AI APPLICATION: AIR FORCE CORE FUNCTIONS	7
Chapter 4: CONSIDERATIONS FOR EMPLOYMENT	10
AI-READY FORCE	10
PROBLEMS AI CAN SOLVE	11
GOOD DATA AND BIAS AWARENESS.....	12
CYBER DEFENSE OF BLUE AI	12
AI AND ETHICS	13
Chapter 5: A VISION FOR THE FUTURE.....	14
Appendix: QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE DEVELOPING AN AI SOLUTION.....	15

FOREWORD

This Air Force Doctrine Note (AFDN) describes Artificial Intelligence (AI) and anticipates its role in air operations across the competition continuum. It references various sources, including pertinent joint and service policy and strategies, public law, academic and industry writings, and subject matter expert consultations. This AFDN supplements existing AI policy and strategies of the Department of Defense (DoD). It is intended to be authoritative and informational, but not directive.

This AFDN examines problems and potential solutions to support Air Force doctrine development at the operational level. It informs forecasted doctrinal gaps regarding operational topics that will have Service-wide impacts in the near term. The AFDN socializes emerging lessons learned and best practices that commanders and staffs can use in strategy development and air operations planning.

Finally, this AFDN acknowledges that opinions differ amongst AI experts regarding the exact definitions of AI-related terms and concepts. Therefore, this AFDN provides descriptions of AI-related terms to facilitate Airmen's understanding and to align future Service and Joint AI policy.

If there are any conflicts between this AFDN and a joint or service policy publication, the respective policy takes precedence for the United States Air Force (USAF) activities.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

THE PROMISE OF AI

Computers transformed how wars were fought. The British “Bombe,” an early computer, cracked the German Enigma cipher in World War II. This produced exquisite intelligence for the Allies and turned the tide in the Battle of the Atlantic.

The development of early electronic supercomputers, powered by vacuum tubes, enabled massive calculations supporting the space and missile programs. In addition, the introduction of silicon-based semiconductors revolutionized computing by enabling miniaturization. In turn, the advancement of transistors played a key role in driving innovation in both Cold War-era defensive systems and advanced weaponry. These advancements in armed platforms with onboard computing power transitioned the USAF from its reliance on mass to unprecedented precision attacks in Operation DESERT STORM.

A new data-driven era has emerged. Academic and commercial innovations are creating cutting-edge capabilities at increasingly affordable prices. Our environment is saturated with “smart” devices that connect us through a digital domain of unprecedented information. High-speed data processing, the availability of large data sets, and big data analytics from machine learning (ML) are all contributing to the emergence of new AI technologies with seemingly unlimited possibilities.

AI will supercharge Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) by providing networked sensors capable of identifying hidden “needles in a haystack” without prior threat knowledge. AI will fuel robotics advancements and enable intelligent swarms of autonomous agents to perform tasks once thought to exist solely under human control. AI is anticipated to accelerate training, create information advantage, strengthen readiness, and generate synthetic experiences that ultimately drive both machine and human learning.

AI will assist planners with advanced tools to plan for highly complicated tasks, such as sustainment, and then wargame solutions informed by real time analysis of the environment and our adversaries’ potential actions. It will assist in the testing and evaluation of various strategies and operational concepts in a virtual sandbox. In international affairs, AI will support the design and implementation of cooperation and assistance programs to strengthen strategic partnerships. It may even recommend new partnership scenarios for strategic advantage.

AI has great promise. There are significant national security implications for United States leadership in developing safe, secure, and trustworthy AI while fostering a stable and responsible international governance framework to manage risks and promote global benefits. AI will help commanders make more informed decisions across the strategic, operational, and tactical levels of warfare.

THE RISK OF AI

Despite its novelty, AI is ubiquitous and already proving its value as a force multiplier in competition and conflict. AI technology could prove to be a cost-effective way that limited-resourced countries enhance their capabilities to erode U.S. strategic advantage. In the realm of Great Power Competition, our competitors and potential adversaries, such as China and Russia, invest heavily in AI. The People's Republic of China publicly stated its goal is to lead the world in AI development by 2030. Today, China is using AI to monitor and repress its people at scale. Its access to US citizens' data, particularly Airmen, creates new pathways for AI-enabled attacks against the US and targets in the Homeland.

Both China and Russia are wagering on the potential of AI for military applications. China is accelerating efforts to become an "intelligentized" force that is optimized by human machine teaming. In addition to investing in autonomous vehicles and intelligent robotic systems, China is focused on applying AI to command decision-making, logistics, cyber operations, swarms, missile guidance, and the cognitive domain. Similarly, Russia is integrating AI into its doctrine and strategies. Russia is making great strides in Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAV), autonomous ground vehicles, and underwater systems. Both China and Russia are focused on integrating AI for more effective command and control, targeting and reconnaissance, and electronic warfare systems.

We anticipate AI will strengthen many warfighting capabilities, but warfighters must be aware of its potential pitfalls. Specifically, decision-making delegated to AI may lower the threshold for conflict by accelerating actions and responses beyond the capability of traditional "human firewalls." Also, given the collaborative nature of AI system development, which often involves commercial, academic, and military organizations with varied information security standards, it is crucial to carefully determine both the data that AI systems can access, and the individuals authorized to access that data. Further, adversary efforts and inaccurate data sets can "poison" AI systems with bad data, leading to erroneous decisions and pathways for deception and surprise. This will challenge our trust in AI and inhibit its adoption. Therefore, we must embrace responsible AI through understanding and experimentation. As Airmen, we must employ AI to enhance kinetic and non-kinetic capabilities while defeating adversary disinformation campaigns.

Since our service's inception, Airmen have harnessed new technologies to strengthen our nation's strategic advantage. AI is no different. We must accelerate ethical enterprise adoption, experimentation, and fielding of AI-enabled capabilities to rapidly develop the required infrastructure and Governance required to successfully employ AI.

CHAPTER 2: AI OVERVIEW

WHAT IS AI?

Recent technological breakthroughs and application development within the field of AI have uncovered opportunities and possibilities once considered impossible. In many ways, these exponential developments out-paced our ability to deliberately develop a shared understanding and consensus on AI-related topics. Across academia and industry, there are nuanced distinctions among AI definitions and terminology. Currently, DoD has not established a doctrinal definition for AI but has deferred to, and directed the Services to utilize, U.S. Code and Executive Orders to establish AI-related definitions and guide policy development.¹ This AFDN does not establish official Department of the Air Force (DAF) definitions for AI or its associated terms. Rather, this AFDN provides descriptions of AI terminology and concepts, which are intended to provide a better understanding of AI's potential in USAF operations. Generally speaking, AI uses technology systems, in combination with rule-based and ML approaches, to approximate aspects of human cognition. However, unlike humans, AI is limited in that it does not critically examine the validity of its system's inputs or the broader consequences of its outputs.

DESCRIPTION OF AI TERMINOLOGY

To integrate AI into military operations, it is essential to understand AI terminology. The examples in this Doctrine Note are not exhaustive but illustrate true distinctions between related and complementary AI disciplines and aspects.

The terms "**Narrow AI**" and "**Weak AI**" have slight nuanced differences but are used interchangeably in this document. These terms refer to AI systems that are limited to performing a specific task or function and do not have the ability to learn new tasks.

In contrast to Narrow or Weak AI, **Artificial General Intelligence (AGI)** aims for AI with human-like understanding, learning, and adaptation across tasks. AGI does not currently exist, and some experts argue it may never exist. However, there is consensus that AGI is not possible with today's capabilities. AGI is a long-term goal facing technical, ethical, and philosophical challenges. Despite this, there is progress towards AGI with new algorithms and hardware. While AGI systems are not ready for airpower employment, Airmen must consider ethical and practical challenges in operations and planning if AGI becomes a reality.

Expert Systems, meant to complement and not replace human experts, use human expert knowledge combined with rule-based and/or advanced mathematical

¹ 15 U.S.C. 9401(3) define artificial intelligence as: a machine-based system that can, for a given set of human-defined objectives, make predictions, recommendations, or decisions influencing real or virtual environments. Artificial intelligence systems use machine- and human-based inputs to perceive real and virtual environments; abstract such perceptions into models through analysis in an automated manner; and use model inference to formulate options for information or action."

representations to solve narrowly defined problems. A common application in decision support applications is a medical diagnosis consultant system.

Machine Learning (ML) is a field of AI concerned with the development and study of statistical algorithms that can learn from data and generalize to unseen data and thus perform tasks without explicit instructions. ML-based AI systems do not follow traditional programming rules. Instead, they draw from various disciplines such as computer science, statistics, psychology, neuroscience, economics, and control theory to analyze data and extract patterns from the data. However, ML does not possess the ability to understand or utilize these disciplines independently. Rather, it finds patterns in the data based on how it was programmed. The ML behind AI systems that defeated human champions in cognitive games such as chess or Go still required significant human knowledge to be encoded into its design before the ML process started.

Training Data is the information used to teach AI models to make predictions and classify data by identifying patterns from input-output pairs. The quality, quantity, and diversity of the training data impacts AI system performance and accuracy, with any unintended biases or inconsistencies leading to incomplete or erratic results. **Test Data** is data not used during training and is reserved to evaluate the performance of the model after training. After a system is trained and tested, additional training and testing may be required if the input data begins to differ substantially from the original training data.

Neural Networks (NN) are inspired by the human brain. NNs are composed of interconnected units called neurons arranged in multiple layers. At a minimum, an NN will have three layers (an input layer, at least one hidden layer, and an output layer). In the past, NNs were not often used due to the computational burden of training and operating them. However, with advances in computational power and access to more data, NN have become more complex and layered.

Deep Learning (DL) is merely a multi-layered neural network that employs more than one hidden NN layer to learn from complex datasets and create more accurate associations between inputs and outputs. DL models are powerful tools in AI applications because they learn complex features or patterns that are not recognizable by people.

Natural Language Processing (NLP) uses DL as a core technique to allow computers to comprehend, interpret, and generate human language using multi-layered NNs, which analyze and understand the structure and meaning of text. NLP is used for a wide range of tasks, such as machine translation and speech recognition, and is the core technology behind virtual assistants like Siri, Alexa, and translation devices.

Generative AI analyzes vast amounts of data to find patterns and connections between words, audio, images, and video to generate content. AI systems that can process multiple modalities (or types) of inputs (e.g. images, text, video, etc.) at once are called **Multimodal AI**. Unlike large language models (LLMs) that focus on language-based data, Generative AI trains algorithms on vast datasets to learn inherent patterns and structures. Post-training, these algorithms replicate data styles, characteristics, and distribution of the data to produce new content.

Large Language Model (LLM) is a type of AI model that uses probabilistic models to analyze patterns and connections between words and phrases to understand and generate human language. LLMs are trained on large amounts of text data, such as books, articles, and web pages, and use this data to learn the statistical relationships between words and phrases. LLMs are used in a wide range of applications, including virtual assistants, chatbots, language translation, and text summarization. One of the most popular LLMs is Chat Generative Pretrained Transformer (ChatGPT), which is a model developed by OpenAI. ChatGPT can generate answers to user prompts and summarize topics by using its understanding of language patterns and connections to generate coherent and relevant responses.

Computer Vision (CV) is a field of AI that extracts meaningful information from digital images, videos, and other visual inputs. It involves using techniques such as image processing, pattern recognition, and DL to analyze and interpret visual data. CV algorithms process images at the pixel level, which means they analyze the individual pixels in an image to extract features and patterns. CV's applications are wide-ranging, including areas such as surveillance, target recognition, autonomous navigation, and medical imaging.

AUTOMATION VS AUTONOMY

"Automation" and **"autonomy"** are critical terms regarding the military's employment of AI. **Automation** is a system's ability to undertake a narrow and constrained task with low levels of complexity, where that task is highly repetitive and independent of choice. **Autonomy** is a system's ability to utilize rules-based processing to undertake a variety of tasks, of varying levels of complexity, and to complete those tasks while achieving multiple goals. Both systems are constrained by the goals (and authorities) delegated to them. Stated another way, automation tasks are more comparable to the auto factory line while autonomous tasks are more like self-driving vehicles, which must dynamically react to unknown variables.

The USAF uses a mix of automated and semi-autonomous systems that augment an Airman's performance. With a holistic AI understanding, the USAF can apply the same developmental mindset to AI systems as it does to aviation, every achievement is an innovation stepping-stone. Just as pilots gain confidence and competence with each sortie, each automated or autonomous system's process repetition builds a system's competence. This competence increases an Airmen's confidence in their ability to leverage a system for decision-making.

CHAPTER 3: AI APPLICATION

HUMAN-MACHINE TEAMING

The USAF approach to AI employment will be Human-Machine Teaming (HMT). AI systems will augment the performance of Airmen and the execution of USAF operations. Ideally, HMT will function as an amplifier for Airmen capabilities. Military discretion lies with Airmen, but AI can enable faster and superior operational decisions. Though AI quickly processes large datasets, it lacks context sensitivity and reasoning. In HMT, human strengths (e.g. intuition and reasoning) and machines (e.g. fast data processing) combine to maximize capability. For AI-enabled processes, the exercise of appropriate human judgment is an important consideration, especially in strategically high-risk operations. The human-machine relationship is dynamic and situation-dependent in complex AI systems. Airpower leaders must acknowledge this conditions-based construct to make critical decisions on the input Airmen will provide the AI system. Leaders' risk tolerance decisions should inform the appropriate level of human judgment required. In situations where an occasional false prediction or misclassification is tolerable, the appropriate level of human judgment may be lower, and the machine may be granted more autonomy. Conversely, in situations where machine miscalculations would create significantly detrimental effects, the appropriate level of human judgment may be higher, resulting in closer supervision.

Common Human-Machine Teaming Constructs*

Human-in-the-Loop—The machine makes recommendations and, the person makes the decision (e.g. proximity alerts in your car).

Human-on-the-Loop—The machine makes recommendations, and the machine recommendation will be implemented unless the person vetoes the machine action (e.g. lane keeping).

Human-off/out-of-the-Loop—The machine makes the decision, and the person cannot override the machine's action (e.g. engine compression ratio, antilock braking action).

* These common constructs have been used colloquially within industry and academia to discuss the human-machine relationship within AI. This inset is included for information only and does not constitute USAF endorsement or policy for executing appropriate human judgment.

Tactics that optimize the balance between decision speed and risk tolerance will evolve to integrate HMT into Air Force AI systems. As the relationship between Airmen and AI strengthens, HMT optimization will improve through communication, coordination, cooperation, social intelligence, language exchange, and shared situational awareness. In addition, trust evaluation methods between humans and machines must consider factors like distrust, trust evolution, and team goal changes. Transparency and

explainability in AI systems are crucial for understanding system behavior and building confidence in the HMT. Training HMT as a unit helps build accurate mental models, while key design decisions impact human workload, situational awareness, and overall success. Ultimately, AI system responsivity, predictability, and “directability” enhance trust.

AI APPLICATION: AIR FORCE CORE FUNCTIONS

Future warfighting requires Airmen to understand the relationship between AI development and Air Force Functions. In coordination with the Science and Technology community, Airmen must identify operational gaps that are well-suited for AI and autonomous systems applications. HMT must capitalize on the best of human intuition and reasoning, combined with AI’s extremely fast data processing capability, to strengthen kinetic and non-kinetic effects across all missions.

AIR SUPERIORITY

The USAF is called to conduct offensive and defensive operations to achieve air superiority as part of joint operations. AI will advance our efforts in contested environments by facilitating improved and timely execution of various air missions designed to achieve air superiority and information advantage. AI-enabled early warning and detection systems, as part of our integrated air and missile defense systems, will provide data to airpower C2 systems to alert Defensive Counterair (DCA) assets to threats. For Offensive Counterair (OCA) to gain or retain air superiority it is imperative that AI-powered ISR systems, targeting mechanisms, and aircraft support all aspects of air operations ranging from Combat Air Patrol (CAP) missions over adversary terrain to Suppression of Enemy Air Defenses (SEAD), and to Air Interdiction operations designed to destroy adversary aircraft on the ground.

As an example, aircraft such as autonomous swarms and semi-autonomous Collaborative Combat Aircraft (CCA) may be used in multiple air superiority-associated missions. In a demonstration of the growing confidence and trust between humans and AI-enabled aircraft, the Secretary of the Air Force was the passenger in a modified F-16 with an AI-controlled dogfighting module in May 2024. The CCA program, and related experiments as part of the Autonomous Collaborative Platform (ACP) program, demonstrate the ability of semi-autonomous aircraft to support manned fighter aircraft. CCA’s potential capability to act as weapons platforms or ISR platforms also serves as a sign of the possibilities of HMT and human-directed engagement. The success of these initial developmental efforts represents a solid foundation for further advancement.

GLOBAL PRECISION ATTACK

In Global Precision Attack, the USAF strives to achieve technological advances to attack anywhere, anytime, more quickly, and with greater precision than ever before. AI improvements to aircraft and munition targeting are making great strides in this arena. As an example, AI CV, combined with improved target recognition and tracking algorithms, will further minimize civilian risk caused by high precision, low collateral damage munitions. Additionally, continued use of AI-enabled modeling will improve U.S. stealth

capabilities and continue to offer options for striking targets in denied areas. In the realm of targeting and “sensor-2-shooter” integration, AI empowers an automated C2 capability to accelerate the decision cycle, rationalize risk, and enable effects faster. Advancements in CCA and preventative maintenance are just two examples of AI-enabled airpower tools to achieve and improve Global Precision Attack.

RAPID GLOBAL MOBILITY

The Agile Combat Employment scheme of maneuver requires adaptive basing and rapid, responsive logistics in contested environments. AI will prioritize operating location selection by analyzing the criteria of potential locations for survivability, efficiency, resiliency, and sustainment capacities. AI systems use predicative analysis to detect failure and usage trends at scale to improve predictive maintenance processes while optimizing the inventory and transportation procedures to strengthen adaptive logistics planning and execution. To these ends, there have been many breakthroughs in how we execute logistics for dispersed operations. One example is AFWERX collaboration with an industry partner to develop a semi-autonomous airlift capability. During the Bamboo Eagle/Agile Flag exercises in August 2024, an Air Expeditionary Wing’s A4 successfully leveraged the semi-autonomous airlift asset to deliver over 20 urgently needed Mission Capable Parts orders to multiple geographically separated locations. These just-in-time airlift operations, controlled at the tactical level, relieved pressure on traditional airlift assets. Further, it provided flexibility for the A4 and maintenance personnel while accelerating an aircraft’s return time to a mission capable status. These experiments show the promise AI and ML-enabled systems represent for future USAF operations.

GLOBAL INTELLIGENCE, SURVEILLANCE, AND RECONNAISSANCE

The operational capability for multi-intelligence, cross domain data fusion shows promise with multi-modal AI (i.e. systems that can translate and process data sets that are in different formats and of different types). These AI systems can assist with real-time pop-up threat detection and identification along with multi-domain situational awareness synchronization. AI-enabled programs can be leveraged to eliminate disconnects between Service-unique intelligence platforms and processing programs. In addition, autonomous ISR platforms offer the potential for persistent audio, visual, signals, or electromagnetic collections in previously denied areas.

COMMAND AND CONTROL

AI will assist the processes of targeting, resource allocation, planning, and scheduling in support of multi-domain C2 and battle management. AI-enabled communications networks will provide resiliency and survivability for C2 in contested, degraded, and operationally limited environments. For example, if communication between two operation centers is severed, AI-driven communications networks could re-direct communication pathways to instantaneously restore a connection. In addition, if a higher echelon’s C2 capability is degraded, an AI-enabled communications system could re-vector data feeds to subordinate C2 elements to maintain C2.

Autonomous Collaborative Platforms

The Air Force is developing ACP, variants of semi-autonomous aircraft, which work in concert with more expensive crewed, platforms, to provide the ability to operate runway flexible aircraft capable of expeditionary launch and recovery operations to complement major weapons systems already in acquisition. The ACP Ecosystem of Capabilities includes CCA and collaborative mobility, surveillance, bomber, and training aircraft.

CCA use semi-autonomous software to enable seamless and effective collaboration with and augmentation of the performance of manned combat aircraft by providing enhanced situational awareness, greater lethality, and improved survivability in highly contested environments.

CCA development will leverage the existing crewed-uncrewed teaming efforts from previous generations of ACP development such as the XQ-58A and XQ-67A. These generations of ACP have proven the ability to build relevant combat capability fast while treating low cost as the primary objective. More modern CCA, such as the YFQ-42A and the YFQ-44A will build on success of previous ACP development.



Concepts of the uncrewed fighter aircraft YFQ-42A (bottom) and the YFQ-44A are pictured in artwork. The aircraft are designed to leverage autonomous capabilities and crewed-uncrewed teaming to defeat enemy threats in contested environments. (U.S. Air Force artwork courtesy of General Atomics Aeronautical Systems, Inc. and Anduril Industries)

CHAPTER 4: CONSIDERATIONS FOR EMPLOYMENT

The USAF must be positioned to capitalize on the commercial sector's AI advancements. Current and forthcoming DoD and USAF policy and governance structures for AI will shape the manner AI is employed across the USAF. This section highlights several considerations planners and commanders should understand when harnessing AI for their mission.

AI-READY FORCE

USAF personnel must be AI fluent to integrate its capabilities into operations. In the context of this doctrine note, AI fluent implies proficiency beyond simple literacy. Airmen should not just possess a basic AI understanding, but they should comprehend the application, interpretation, and effective navigation of AI systems. Airmen must seek to utilize AI-powered tools and experiment with available tools to find areas for improvement, how to provide feedback, and apply corrective actions. AI capability awareness and understanding underpins effective collaboration with automated systems, informed decision-making, and risk mitigation. AI fluency keeps personnel competitive, enables a strategic edge for the integration of more technologies and lays the foundation for our AI ecosystem.

DATA

Data must be treated as a valuable enterprise-level asset. Everyone in the enterprise must understand the importance of data management and collection efforts, including the curation of records and information made available for AI development and implementation. The collection and management of high-quality data is a critical challenge in the development and implementation of AI tools. The accuracy and reliability of AI models are heavily dependent on the quality of the data used for training and testing. Therefore, proper data management and collection efforts are essential to gather properly conditioned data across datasets. These efforts lead to better performance and practical utility of AI models. As partnerships between the USAF and industry produce excellent AI tools, data ownership, storage, and processing will present risks and opportunities for USAF decision-makers. Airmen must consider these factors when developing AI tools and implementing them within the enterprise.

COMPUTE

Currently, training and running AI models requires a massive amount of compute power, which will drive a recurring demand signal for increased computer and technology acquisitions for host platforms. This reality can be a critical deciding factor in Air Force AI integration. AI-use plans should outline computing, data collection and storage, mission assurance, communications, authorization to operate, and energy requirements for development, testing, and deployment at the enterprise level. At the same time, leaders should balance the risk associated with fielding open source and commercial AI tools with the speed and increased computing power often resident in commercial sources.

TALENT

The USAF's AI subject matter experts are sparsely scattered across staffs and in centers such as the Air Force Research Laboratory. However, to build an AI-fluent force, we must find, recruit, develop, and incentivize individuals who can build, operate, and lead an AI enterprise. This goal requires collaboration across various specialties, including partnerships between developers and operators, scientists and ethicists, coders and system architects, planners and programmers, and military personnel. Outreach to strategic partners, academia, labs, and industry underpins a future AI-fluent force.

PROBLEMS AI CAN SOLVE

AI is best suited for military applications with consistent patterns. Practical AI usage requires substantial high-quality data and computational power. In addition, understanding the problem structure is critical. While simple problems may not need advanced techniques, AI can address **complicated** and some portions of **complex** problems.

COMPLICATED PROBLEMS

Complicated problems and systems, like designing and running intricate machinery or aircraft components, involve multiple aspects and challenges that possess consistent structures and activity patterns over time. Since the problem-solving approaches are mostly the same every time, they can be adequately modeled with mathematical formulas. Specifically, AI excels in solving these problems with probabilistic mathematics to detect patterns at scale and speed. The logistics industry demonstrates AI's effectiveness in dealing with complicated problems, optimizing inventory management, transportation, and enabling predictive maintenance through accurate demand forecasting and part failure predictions.

COMPLEX PROBLEMS

Complex problems (often called "wicked") are unpredictable, with frequently changing rulesets and patterns of interaction that make it difficult or impossible to adequately or reliably model the kinds of mathematics currently used by AI. For instance, social issues are inherently complex. They typically require balancing between tightly coupled competing interests that cannot be accommodated simultaneously. They require managing human intuition and perception, including working out compromises. Current AI models struggle with complex problems. They are better suited for solving the individual, complicated tasks that make up components of the larger complex issue. For example, some complex problems, such as nuclear deterrence, fundamentally require human characteristics like an understanding of context, judgment, wisdom, and ethical considerations.



The Air Force Rapid Sustainment Office partnered with Defense Industrial Base (DIB) command, control, and communications (C3) AI to develop the Predictive Analytics and Decision Assistant (PANDA), a System of Record for achieving Condition Based Maintenance. PANDA uses AI to optimize fleet maintenance, increasing aircraft availability, and minimizing downtime. PANDA utilizes Enhanced Reliability Centered Maintenance (eRCM) and Sensor Based Algorithms (SBA) to achieve these goals. eRCM uses AI to analyze historical component failure data to predict component failures. SBA uses AI to analyze sensor data to detect degrading performance or impending component failure. PANDA synthesizes aircraft-specific performance data with airframe-wide historical failure data to preempt component failures.

GOOD DATA AND BIAS AWARENESS

AI systems need good training data. Obtaining accurate, properly labeled, and conditioned data without introducing unintended or harmful biases is a challenge. Quality results from AI depend on good data management, which includes the gathering, contextualization, extraction, and dissemination of properly curated data that sufficiently represents the problem or phenomenon to which AI is applied. This requires finding, accessing, reformatting, and restructuring data, eliminating unintentional biases, and ensuring accuracy. Unintentionally biased data or algorithms may cause discriminatory outcomes, leading to a lack of trust in AI systems. To mitigate certain unintentional biases, developers and decision-makers must address potential sources of bias throughout the AI development process using diverse datasets, transparent and explainable algorithms, and regular audits and evaluations. Only when data is accessible, understandable, and filtered can military applications be built. The accessibility of data should also be a planning consideration when deciding the classification level and network requirements for AI systems.

CYBER DEFENSE OF BLUE AI

Robust cyber defense is required for implementing AI within the USAF. The success of AI systems and AI-enabled operations relies on quality data and uncompromised processes. Cyber defense for AI systems is crucial due to their sensitivity and the

criticality of processed data. Malicious cyber activity often focuses on data poisoning to target ML models with manipulated data. Data poisoning alters the fundamental behavior of AI systems and results in false or misleading outcomes. In addition to poisoning input data, an adversary gaining access to an AI model itself could reverse engineer a system to reveal sensitive input data or manipulate control of the data output. For example, with access to an ISR model trained to detect military equipment in satellite imagery, an adversary could develop a digital camouflage to prevent detection. To prevent such threats, the cyber defense of AI systems must include multi-layer protection like access controls, encryption, network security, intrusion detection, and data verification processes. Failure to secure AI systems will lead to grave consequences.

AI AND ETHICS

The ethical use of AI tools is a significant concern. AI applications must be consistent with law, policy, and used responsibly. In line with the Deputy Secretary of Defense Memorandum on Implementing Responsible AI, all DoD AI capabilities must be responsible, equitable, traceable, reliable, and governable. The DoD Chief Digital and Artificial Intelligence Office (DoD CDAO) and the DAF Chief Data and Artificial Intelligence Office (DAF CDAO) lead the ethical development and adoption of AI-powered tools.

However, it is worth noting that our adversaries are not always beholden to the same ethical guidelines, and the DoD may encounter significant challenges when faced with systems employed with fewer ethical considerations.

CHAPTER 5: A VISION FOR THE FUTURE

True technological innovation is unlocked not by the technology itself, but how we are able to conceptualize and apply it. Our competitive advantage will be amplified by our ability to gauge and shape implications of that technology faster and more completely than our adversaries.

Recent AI developments are no exception. They require interdisciplinary efforts to achieve benefits while avoiding pitfalls. Airmen must anticipate and embrace AI's changes while navigating potential vulnerabilities and internal challenges. The USAF must invest in data collection, computing, energy, communications, human capital, and multidisciplinary knowledge to maintain a secure and ethical AI enterprise. Airmen must be ready, innovatively minded, and willing to push that technology to its limits. Our task will be to constantly demand the best of our AI tools for employment integration.

DAF Battle Network

The Advanced Battle Management System (ABMS) is a “system of systems” designed to share data seamlessly and securely across multiple weapons systems. ABMS, and overarching DAF architectures such as the DAF Battle Network, will be critical enablers to the Defense Department’s Joint All Domain Command and Control (JADC2) effort to connect sensors and shooters around the globe.



This doctrine note’s Appendix will help Airman prepare for the employment of new AI tools and pursue the right opportunities to employ AI today for victory tomorrow. For Airmen to continue their individual journey in AI knowledge, reference products and webpages of Air Force AI leaders such as AFRL, the DAF AI Accelerator at Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), and DAF Bot Operations Team (DAFBOT) at the USAF Lifecycle Management Center (LCMC).

APPENDIX: QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE DEVELOPING AN AI SOLUTION

The questions below are meant to assist an Airman's assessment of how and if AI systems can provide a solution to their problems. Airmen should also reference DAF CDAO site (ai.af.mil) for information materials, tools, and products to guide their AI journey.

- ★ Is the problem, question, or phenomenon sufficiently well-structured to apply the desired AI tools, given the inherent limitations of the mathematical tools being used?
 - ★★ The more well-structured the problem is, and the more the same rules apply to multiple instances of the phenomenon, the better suited the AI application.
- ★ Have operators who will be using the AI tool been involved in the design of the tool, and is there a plan to ensure that the AI results will be externally valid?
 - ★★ This is important to ensure developers ask questions and design AI tools relevant to the field, and useable by the Airmen. It is also important that operators are part of the data collection effort, to ensure data is collected and categorized correctly.
- ★ Are there adequate edge cases to test safety and reliability of AI, and how will they be tested?
 - ★★ Edge cases are situations in which the AI will fail or be insufficient to deal with the external realities of a situation. Ideally, testing should deliberately seek to identify and expose those edge cases to either improve the AI model or limit what the AI is asked to do. More complex situations potentially present an infinite number of edge cases, which makes reliability testing increasingly difficult, and failure in the field more likely.
- ★ Is there sufficient high quality labeled/curated/documented data for the AI system to use? Is data conditioning sufficient and congruent across aggregated datasets?
 - ★★ A lesson learned from an early AI defense project named Project Maven was that data conditioning was an even bigger challenge than creating algorithms, especially when trying to aggregate data across many separately designed systems. Data often requires annotation/labeling to indicate how and why it was collected, and that context may determine if data collected to answer one question is suitable to answer a different question in a different context. Data labeling can also create problems if the system of labeling is not consistent between different systems.
- ★ Are there protection measures for the entire system from either accidental or deliberate data poisoning, model inversion attacks, or algorithmic manipulation?
 - ★★ In addition to the internal challenges of protecting the systems and data needed to apply AI, consider how vulnerable AI applications will be to external adversarial

actions or manipulation, and if sufficient safeguards can overcome these countermeasures.

- ★ Are there sufficient, consistent, and mission assured data storage, power supply, and processing power for the AI task?
 - ★★ Many advanced AI applications require massive computing power, hence lots of data storage and energy. Even edge computing on the frontlines requires adequate power supplies and storage capability.
 - ★ Is pursuing automation in this area justified given the amount of natural learning and experience my personnel are likely to lose by trusting the machine to perform this task versus performing them with more traditional techniques?
 - ★★ One of the potential downsides of automation or applying AI to tasks (normally accomplished by humans) is humans lose the “deep knowledge” and experience in the subsumed function, and therefore are unable to handle the “handover challenge” when the automated system encounters a different situation than it was designed for. People accustomed to accepting AI generated answers will lose the benefits of research, which is slower when it comes to finding answers to known problems, but also facilitates the serendipitous learning and discovery that prepares them to handle new future problems.
 - ★ What are the opportunity costs of trying to use AI for a problem versus using more traditional means or classical computing, and why is the tradeoff potentially worth it?
 - ★★ Given a simple problem, traditional computing methods may be more than adequate to assist. Above all, consider the new resources, human capital, hours of labor, and potential new sources for potential failure across the entire ecosystem if sophisticated AI tools are applied to problems that could be adequately addressed by less sophisticated but also less vulnerable traditional methods.
-

PLANNING



U.S. AIR FORCE

22 January 2025

Air Force Doctrine Publication 5-0, *Planning*

Table of Contents

Foreword.....	i
Chapter 1: INTRODUCTION TO PLANNING	1
Chapter 2: THE AIR FORCE PLANNING PROCESS.....	5
Chapter 3: PLANNING INITIATION	10
Chapter 4: MISSION ANALYSIS	14
Chapter 5: COURSE OF ACTION DEVELOPMENT	35
Chapter 6: COURSE OF ACTION ANALYSIS AND WARGAMING.....	42
Chapter 7: COURSE OF ACTION COMPARISON	47
Chapter 8: COURSE OF ACTION APPROVAL.....	49
Chapter 9: PLANS AND ORDERS DEVELOPMENT	52
Appendix A: PLANS AND ORDERS FORMATS	64
Appendix B: CENTER OF GRAVITY ANALYSIS METHODS.....	68
Appendix C: ACTIONS AND EFFECTS	77
Appendix D: AIR COMPONENT APPROACH TEMPLATE	82
Appendix E: EXAMPLE MODIFIED FIVE-PARAGRAPH ORDER	83
Appendix F: AFPP KNEEBOARD	85
References.....	86

FOREWORD

Air Force Doctrine Publication (AFDP) 5-0, *Planning* provides a planning methodology for Airmen to solve complex problems. All Airmen should be prepared to solve problems in contested, degraded, or operationally limited environments. The Air Force planning process (AFPP) focuses on providing commanders options to accomplish their mission.

Doctrine embodies the fundamental principles by which military forces guide their actions in support of national objectives. It is a body of carefully developed and tested ideas officially approved to provide a common frame of reference for solving military problems. However, the challenge for United States Air Force (USAF) doctrine is to be simultaneously based on past experiences, applicable in the present, and leaning forward toward the future, all in equal measure.

The USAF must prepare for a new reality, one in which freedom of maneuver and freedom of action are increasingly challenged. To deter, compete, and win across the competition continuum, Airmen should be ready to conduct operations in contested, degraded, and operationally limited environments. Therefore, Airmen develop an understanding of their environment, make decisions, and converge effects when disconnected from higher headquarters (HHQ). AFDP 1, *The Air Force*, supports this effort by establishing mission command as the Airmen's philosophy for leadership and framework for the command and control (C2) of airpower. The mission command framework is centralized command, distributed control, and decentralized execution (CC-DC-DE). Mission command provides the responsiveness, flexibility, and initiative necessary to prevail in a future fight. By embracing a planning and orders development culture, USAF Service component or unit staffs (A-staffs) and Airmen at all echelons can accomplish their assigned mission while operating in uncertain, complex, and rapidly changing environments.

The AFPP is intended to provide Airmen with a conceptual framework for planning across the competition continuum. Planners must be proficient in their craft to enable Agile Combat Employment (ACE), set the conditions for victory in the six fights described in the *Air Force Future Operating Concept*, and address problems that typically aid force optimization for great power competition. The processes contained in this publication are equally useful for addressing institutional problems that require a disciplined planning methodology.

This publication should guide the air component in systematically addressing problems. All Airmen are encouraged to read this publication in conjunction with AFDP 3-0, *Operations*. Being familiar with doctrine, policy, and guidance related to the development and production of orders helps prepare us for the challenges we face. Throughout our history, innovative Airmen have developed and adapted technologies and employment methods to meet the challenges our nation has faced. AFDP 5-0, *Planning*, contributes to our distinguished lineage as overcomers.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION TO PLANNING

Planning is how Airmen address and solve complicated problems. It is the process through which Airmen frame a problem and provide solutions to achieve the full range of military objectives.

Plans and orders production allow commanders to provide subordinates formal, standardized, and authoritative guidance in a joint force recognized format.

Planning is a part of the C2 Process and a key enabler of the USAF's CC-DC-DE framework. Airmen on wing A-Staffs, and at all echelons, are problem solvers who use planning processes to produce clear plans and orders.

It is crucial that Airmen use standardized planning, orders production, and dissemination processes to foster disciplined initiative in the decentralized execution of operations. Commanders enable decentralized execution effective distribution of their intent. Tactically proficient Airmen with a mission statement, commander's intent, supporting logistics, and communication can exercise disciplined initiative and rapidly adapt to changing conditions.

The commander is the central element of all USAF planning. Commanders at all levels enable airpower and contribute to the C2 function. Planning enhances the commander's ability to make sound and timely decisions by increasing situational understanding of problems and providing a methodology to devise practical solutions.

Airmen may use the AFPP to address institutional issues while increasing familiarity with existing joint and Service planning processes. Examples of existing planning methodologies include the joint planning process (JPP), joint planning process for air (JPPA), and sister-Service planning processes. The AFPP enables Airmen to produce Service component staff estimates, base plans (BPLAN), authority-appropriate orders, USAF modified five-paragraph orders, and orders written using the mission-type order (MTO) technique.¹ **Airmen planning at any echelon through the distributed control continuum use the AFPP.²**

Contested, degraded, or operationally limited environments require commanders and staffs that can identify, understand, and methodically address problems through a repeatable process. The AFPP presented in this publication provides Airmen with an adaptable planning process to solve problems regardless of echelon or organization.

PLANNING AS A MAJOR C2 ACTIVITY

Planning the first C2 activity conducted by a commander and their staff in the overall C2 process. The four C2 activities that comprise the C2 process are: planning, preparing, executing, and assessing.³ These activities are both cumulative and continuous. The

¹ For additional information on order formats and guidance, see Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Manual (CJCSM) 3130.03A, *Planning and Execution Formats and Guidance*.

² For additional information on distributed control continuum, see AFDP 3-0.1 *Command and Control*.

³ For additional information on the C2 activities, see AFDP 3-0.1 *Command and Control*.

outputs of planning provide the foundational guidance for the remainder of the C2 process.

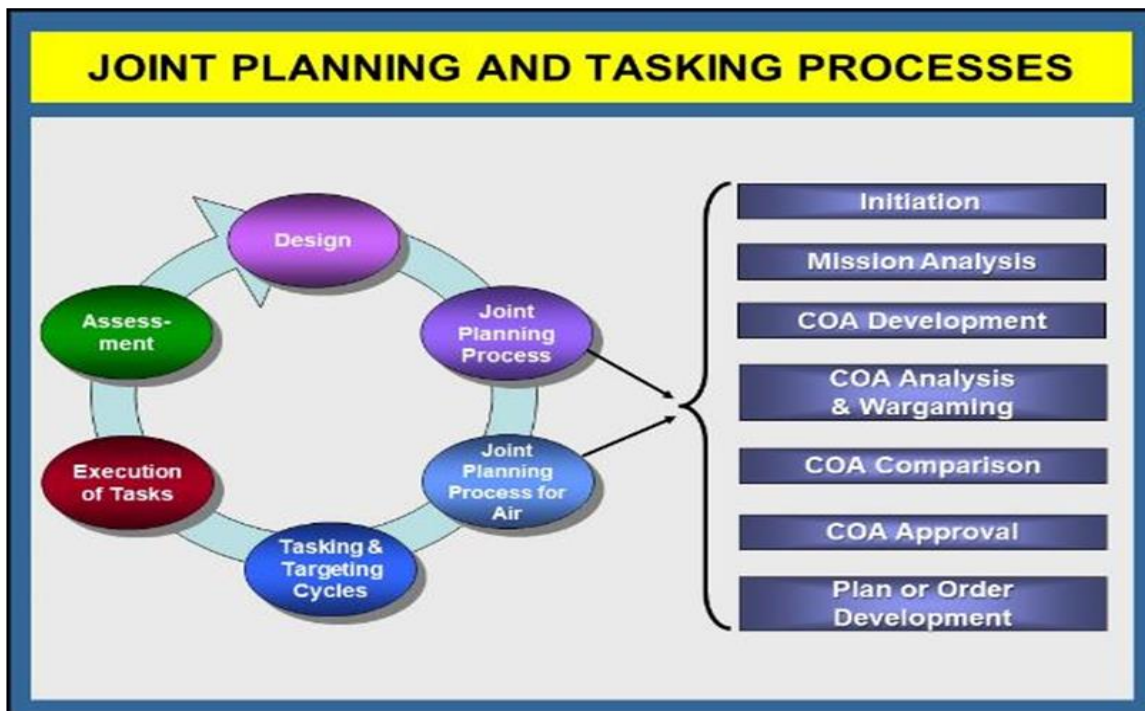
PLANNING METHODS

Several planning processes are described in this publication to highlight selection considerations for each process. **When commanders are tasked with a mission, they choose the right planning method based on the situation, guidance, and the operational environment (OE).** They should consider the level of guidance from HHQ and the type of plan or orders they want to produce. The various planning processes generally include the same steps, what differs is who is doing the planning and what plan is produced. Factors that might influence a commander's choice of planning methodology include:

- ★ HHQ guidance.
- ★ Desired output of the planning process.
- ★ Applicability of the doctrinal planning guidance to address the situation.
- ★ Command authority considerations.
- ★ A-staff's familiarity with specific planning methodologies.
- ★ Size, scope, structure, and/or the dynamic nature of the problem or task.
- ★ Time and resources available for planning.

JOINT PLANNING PROCESS (JPP)

The JPP is the method that guides the planning of joint campaigns and operations. Joint Publication (JP) 5-0, *Joint Planning*, details the JPP, used by a joint force headquarters (HQ) staff, to create or support strategic and theater-level objectives through joint operations. Airmen assigned to joint staffs generally use the JPP. Outputs of the JPP and JPPA are vital to the design efforts in the AFPP. The steps of the JPP and JPPA are identified in the figure, "Joint Planning and Tasking Processes."

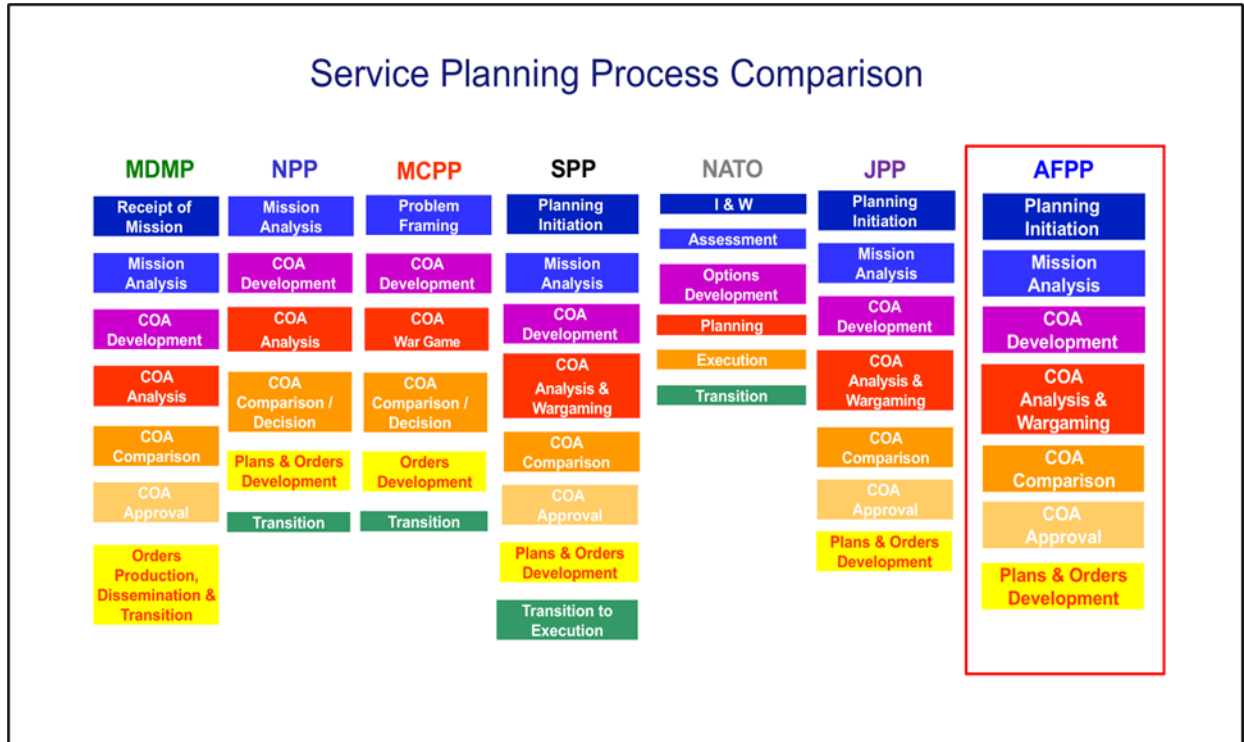


JOINT PLANNING PROCESS FOR AIR (JPPA)

The JPPA is an air-centric application of the JPP utilized by an air component commander and their staff at the operational level of war to guide the employment of joint air capabilities. **JPPA nests under JPP with specific details and considerations for joint air operations, and is captured in JP 3-30, *Joint Air Operations*.** Airmen assigned to a theater combined force air component commander (CFACC) or joint force air component commander (JFACC) generally employ JPPA to create a joint air operations plan (JAOP). The use of JPPA, and the guidance provided in JP 3-30, is ideally suited for Airmen at or in concert with the joint air operations center (JAOC). An air expeditionary task force (AETF) or wing may need to use the JPPA to plan joint air operations depending on the environment.

OTHER SERVICE PLANNING PROCESSES

All US Military Services have their own planning processes that link their planning activities to C2. The Army has the military decision-making process (MDMP), the Navy has the Navy planning process (NPP), the Marines have the Marine Corps planning process (MCP), and the Space Force has the Space Planning Process (SPP). All Services incorporate their Service-specific planning considerations into their process.



AIR FORCE PLANNING PROCESS

The AFPP is a planning method derived from the JPP for use by USAF commanders and staffs at all levels. This publication serves as the principal document for guidance on the application of the AFPP. Airmen utilize the AFPP when the guidance, mission, situation, and environment dictate the need for USAF specific outputs.

The AFPP reflects the extant best practices for planning. The AFPP presents an easily adaptable planning process for Airmen and provides tailored guidance for the planning needs of the USAF. **Airmen employ the AFPP to solve problems. The AFPP is a tool for commander's staffs to methodically develop optimal courses of action to address the range of challenges confronting their units. The result of the AFPP is a commander's plan or order.**

CHAPTER 2: THE AIR FORCE PLANNING PROCESS

The AFPP is a commander led planning methodology that integrates the activities of the staff, subordinate and adjacent units, and other partners to understand the situation and mission, develop, analyze, and compare the course of actions (COA) available, and decide on one that that best accomplishes the mission.

The AFPP can be applied to planning situations encountered by wing A-staffs in garrison or deployed. The steps of the AFPP are outlined in the figure, “Air Force Planning Process”. **This publication guides planners through the AFPP by providing an overview, inputs, activities, and results for each step. For more information on how to progress through the AFPP see Appendix F, “AFPP Kneeboard.”** Inputs, activities, and results for each step will vary based on HHQ guidance, commander’s guidance, and echelon of command. Developed operational design, operational approaches, air component design, and air component approaches can inform planning at subcomponent commands. Material more appropriate for the JPP or JPPA will be annotated with additional remarks.

- ★ The AFPP helps commanders apply thoroughness, clarity, sound judgment, logic, and professional knowledge to understand situations, develop options to solve problems, and reach decisions.
- ★ The AFPP facilitates collaborative and parallel planning as the HHQ solicits input and continuously shares information concerning future operations with subordinate and adjacent units, supported, and supporting units, and other military and civilian partners.
- ★ The AFPP drives preparation. Since time is a factor in all operations, commanders and staffs conduct a time analysis early in the planning process. This analysis helps them determine what actions are required and when those actions should begin to ensure forces are ready before execution. The AFPP is iterative and may require the commander to direct subordinates to start necessary movements, conduct task organization changes, begin information collection operations, and execute preparation activities before completing the plan.

Air Force Planning Process

1. Planning Initiation.
2. Mission Analysis.
3. Course of Action Development.
4. Course of Action Analysis and Wargaming.
5. Course of Action Comparison.
6. Course of Action Approval.
7. Plans and Orders Development.

The steps of the AFPP are detailed in the figure above. As the commander and staff conduct the AFPP they use the air component design elements to create a conceptual framework underpinning planning.

DESIGN

AFPP integrates design elements to produce an air component approach, plans, and orders that reflect the Airman's perspective.

Design and planning are inextricably linked—design is part of planning and planning informs design. Commanders and staffs, across all echelons, use design to define and refine problems that need to be solved. Simultaneously, planning efforts produce potential solutions for the identified problems. This publication specifically articulates operational design and air component design.

Effective planning starts with a joint force commander's (JFC's) operational design. Operational design is the conceptual basis and framework underpinning a campaign, operation plan, and/or orders. "Design is about creating operational vision,"⁴ to define the scope of planning. Design continues throughout planning.

Operational design enables the JFC and staff to comprehend wide-ranging solutions for mission completion and to grasp the uncertainty in a complex operational environment. The air component should actively participate in the JFC's operational design process, particularly during the early stages. Commanders and staffs use the JPPA to create plans for joint air operations while informing operational design and creating support plans and orders for the JFC. Design is integrated in planning efforts. Planners utilize the JFC's operational approach to inform the development of specific courses of action, plans, and orders. Planning and operational design facilitate the transformation of broad guidance into tactical-level tasks.

Operational design provides a methodology consisting of four continually interacting components: define the problem, analyze guidance, understand the environment, and develop a method to solve the problem to create the construct for further planning. Thirteen operational design elements assist the commander and staff in conducting the operational design methodology.⁵ Operational design normally produces planning guidance and an operational approach prior to AFPP initiation. The air component design, air component approach, and AFPP support the JFC's operational design and planning (detailed later in this chapter).

Typically, JFCs provide planning guidance and an operational approach to subordinate commanders before detailed joint planning. **The elements of design are continually evaluated and refined in the major activities of the C2 Process (planning, preparing, executing, and assessing).** Ultimately, a well-articulated and understood design helps define the problem, establish the objective, and set the stage for further planning. The "Air Component Design Elements" figure lists elements initially identified during the first

⁴ Jeffrey M. Reilly, *Operational Design: Distilling Clarity for Decisive Action* (2012).

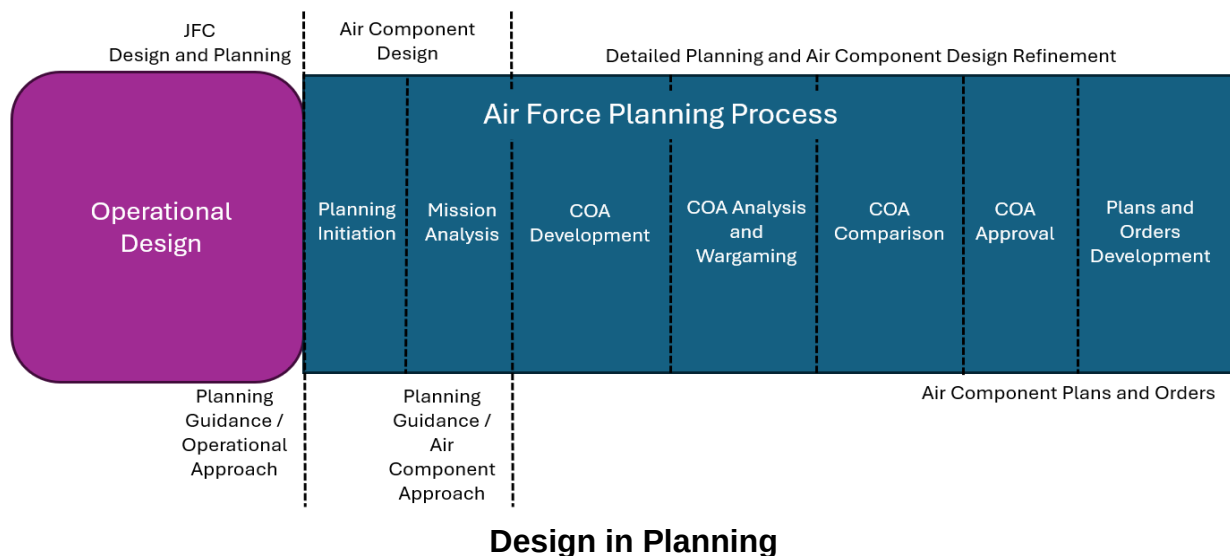
⁵ See JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*, for additional information.

two AFPP steps of planning initiation and mission analysis.

Air Component Design Elements

1. Objective.
2. Desired End State.
3. Root Cause.
4. Effects.
5. Culmination.
6. Physical Characteristics of the OE.
7. Lines of Operation and Lines of Effort.
8. Decisive Points.
9. Direct and Indirect Approach.
10. Operational Reach.
11. Arranging Operations.
12. Anticipation.
13. Forces and Functions.

Air component design is a methodology for applying adaptive thinking to identify and define problems. **The air component design is derived from the JFC's operational design**, and it requires commanders to coordinate their design efforts with higher and lower echelons as well as supporting commanders. Air component design applies to all USAF commander directed planning, regardless of the assigned unit or echelon. A commander constructs an air component approach, scoped to their applicable problem and mission, in the context of the air component design. The "Design in Planning" figure shows the relationship between operational design, air component design, and the AFPP.



Commanders and their staffs use design thinking to produce an air component approach during planning initiation and mission analysis. Sometimes the mission permits HHQ and subordinate units to conduct simultaneous design and planning. Simultaneous planning enables subordinate units to frame their efforts within the HHQ direction, ensuring alignment with the overall strategic objectives. The outputs of design reflect the commander's intent and are pivotal to further planning efforts. The broad description of actions needed to address the defined problem is conveyed with an air component approach. The initial air component approach is completed by the end of mission analysis. Plans and orders are normally produced at the end of the plans and orders development step.

ADAPTIVE THINKING

Adaptive thinking is used during all steps of the AFPP and enables problem identification and framing. Adaptive thinking is the commander and staffs' ability to critically analyze information, think creatively, make decisions, and solve problems dynamically. Thus, it is recommended that planning teams include individuals with diverse skills, knowledge, and experience to ensure the planning process is conducted from multiple viewpoints.

THE AIRMAN'S PERSPECTIVE ON PLANNING

The Airmen's perspective seeks to establish a cohesive and coherent link between objectives, effects, tasks, and actions to ensure all echelons are aligned with strategic objectives and the desired end state.

- ★ The perspective is comprehensive and integrates all domains and environments, all disciplines and partnerships, all levels, and all instruments of national power.
- ★ The perspective is about thinking creatively and reflectively while seeking solutions.
- ★ The perspective integrates all design, planning, execution, and assessment efforts into a unitary whole.
- ★ The perspective focuses on behavior and seeks to achieve objectives most effectively, then to the degree possible, most efficiently.
- ★ The perspective is unique because it places the end state and objective at the forefront of planning.

Civilian Harm Mitigation and Response (CHMR)

Commanders and their staffs have a moral and legal obligation in planning to reduce the risk of harm to civilians and civilian objects. CHMR efforts reflect the importance of protecting and respecting human life and treating civilians with dignity and respect. Prioritizing CHMR in planning only enhances the effectiveness and legitimacy of military operations and contributes to mission success. CHMR considerations should be incorporated during all steps of the AFPP.

- ★ Consider CHMR in the air component design and approach.
- ★ Planning initiation: Identify and address cognitive bias in operational art.
- ★ Mission analysis: emphasize CHMR considerations in the:
 - ★★ Analysis of centers of gravity (COGs).
 - ★★ Completion of specified, implied, and essential tasks.
 - ★★ Analysis of the assigned mission.
 - ★★ Identification and mitigation of risks.
- ★ COA development: identify potential civilian harm incidents, mitigation, and response options.
- ★ COA analysis and wargaming: Consider CHMR during analysis and wargaming of the adversary's most likely and most dangerous COAs.
- ★ COA comparison: consider differences in CHMR for each COA.
- ★ COA approval: discuss CHMR during COA Approval.
- ★ Plans and orders development: clearly describe CHMR considerations and options in the plan or order.

The remaining chapters of this publication discuss the AFPP steps. Each chapter is focused on a single step of the AFPP and is organized into overview, inputs, activities, and results sections.

CHAPTER 3: PLANNING INITIATION

The first step of the AFPP is planning initiation. **Commanders at any echelon initiate the AFPP in response to HHQ guidance and direction.** Traditionally, planning activities are led by the commander and their A3 or A5 staff. However, the commander may appoint any Airmen to serve as part of a planning team. **HHQ products support air component planning initiation by providing either an operational approach or planning guidance and commander's intent.** At lower echelons of command, analysis of this intent may suffice for design. Descriptive guidance and iterative air component design help the commander and staff ensure they understand the problem.⁶

PLANNING INITIATION INPUTS

Planning initiation normally starts in response to HHQ direction. Inputs that inform this step may include planning guidance, operational approaches, planning orders, air component approaches, and operational planning documents. Likewise, a commander may initiate planning in response to local or internal problems that require rigorous and methodological development and evaluation of options.

PLANNING INITIATION ACTIVITIES

When a new mission is identified, commanders and staffs perform the following planning initiation activities:

- ★ Alert the staff and other key participants.
- ★ Document previously identified and relevant air component design elements from operational guidance, as required.
- ★ Gather the tools. Once notified of the new planning requirement, the staff prepares for mission analysis by gathering the necessary tools and examining relevant information about friendly, neutral, and threat networks. These tools include, but are not limited to:
 - ★★ Appropriate manuals, doctrine, military terms, and symbols.
 - ★★ All documents related to the mission and the area of operations (AO), including the HHQ's planning guidance, rules of engagement (ROE), operational approach, orders, air component approach, maps and terrain products, and operational graphics.
 - ★★ HHQ and other organizations' intelligence and assessment products.
 - ★★ Both the unit's and HHQ's standing operating procedures.
- ★ Develop an initial understanding of the OE.

⁶ See AFDP 3-0.1, *Command and Control*, for additional information.

- ★ Begin or update running staff estimates (e.g., logistics estimate, intel estimate).
 - ★★ Estimates are an essential part of the air component design process. Through their estimates, the staff provides expert assessment of the OE and relevant factors affecting effective planning and execution toward the achievement of objectives and attainment of end states. **Airmen running AFPP use staff estimates to inform their planning.**
- ★ Conduct an initial assessment. During this step, the commander and staff conduct an assessment of the time and resources available to plan, prepare, and begin the execution of an operation. This initial assessment:
 - ★★ Identifies and frames the problem to address conditions that must change, or stay the same, to reach the desired system state.
 - ★★ Determines which outside agencies and organizations to contact and incorporate into the planning process.
 - ★★ Assesses the staff's experience and cohesiveness.
 - ★★ Creates a staff planning timeline that outlines how long they can spend on each step of the AFPP. The staff planning timeline indicates what products are due, who is responsible for them, and who receives them. Timelines may be compressed in crisis compared to contingency planning. Artificial intelligence (AI) may be able to expedite or improve some steps of the AFPP.
- ★ Apply adaptive thinking and the Airmen's perspective to the OE and problem.
- ★ Issue the commander's initial guidance. Initial guidance may include the following:
 - ★★ How to abbreviate the AFPP, if required. An abbreviation may involve compressing planning timelines due to not having to produce elements of mission analysis or restraining the number of COAs developed. The abbreviation of the AFPP does not involve eliminating or skipping steps but rather focuses on the allocation of time, resources, and priority of steps.
 - ★★ Necessary coordination, including liaison officers.
 - ★★ Authorization to begin information collection activities.
 - ★★ Locations, dates, and times of planning meetings.
 - ★★ Initial information requirements.
 - ★★ Additional staff tasks.

OPERATIONAL ENVIRONMENT

Planning initiation involves developing an understanding of OE as part of air component design. OE analysis is crucial for planners to define the problem and create an operational approach. This includes all the tangible and intangible factors that influence operations. Planners can gain awareness of the OE by examining guidance from HHQ, intelligence estimates, and country plans. Factors to consider when assessing the OE include physical location, potential actors and stakeholders, weather, geography, sociocultural aspects, infrastructure, communication lines, information environment, and population. Models are often used to analyze the OE, and more details can be found in the mission analysis section of this publication.

Constant analysis is essential to comprehend the OE. This is necessary because the OE is an intricate system with linkages that impact strategic, operational, and tactical levels of warfare. It is important to recognize that our understanding of the OE evolves as we gather more information. HHQ may have already conducted an analysis of the OE to guide subordinate design efforts. Airmen's analysis of the OE should be guided by HHQ, staff estimates and the commander's intent. This understanding can come from various sources, such as higher-level guidance, which includes plans, planning orders (PLANORDs), warning orders (WARNORDs), operation orders (OPORDs), execution orders (EXORDs), planning directives, operational approaches, joint intelligence preparation of the operational environment (JIPOE), intelligence preparation of the battlespace (IPB), and staff estimates.

A challenge in examining the OE is that it exists as a part of a constantly evolving series of complex systems and understanding requires a holistic analysis of the systemic interconnectivity. One way to frame the OE involves the deliberate division of the environment into two interrelated subsystems that foster a shared understanding of the OE's overarching interconnectivity. The two subsystems are the observed system and the desired system.



"In preparing for battle, I have always found that plans are useless, but planning is indispensable."

—Dwight D. Eisenhower
34th President of the United States

Planners using the AFPP focus on the systems related to their mission and problem. The air component is often provided with an understanding of the OE during planning initiation. HHQ guidance provided to the air component allows Airmen to focus on the subsystems and define the problem.

The observed system is an analysis of how the environment currently exists and functions. There is no exact prescription for visualizing the observed system because the observed system is a construct of what one has the capability to see and understand. Planners begin the development of the observed system by examining key factors such

as principal actors, the historical content of the situation, current operations, security, logistics, base infrastructure, communications, command and control, computers, intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance, and other elements related to the problem's resolution. The overarching goal of visualizing the observed system is learning how the system currently functions and understanding how the system will change in reaction to an action or series of actions. Based on the projected changes in the observed system, planners have a mechanism to exploit the changes and anticipate adversary operations. An important aspect of the observed system is setting the foundation for understanding the desired system.

The desired system analyzes the air component's objectives and how to change the observed system to achieve those objectives. In addition to objectives, the desired system assesses actors capable of influencing objectives and end states, barriers to achieving objectives, and time.

PLANNING INITIATION RESULTS

Planning initiation may result in a planning timeline, planning team roster, collection of planning guidance, initial understanding of the OE, and identification of necessary design elements. The staff may issue a preparatory order. A preparatory order describes the situation (guidance overview and OE), mission (tasks and purpose), execution (concept of operations), administration and logistics (concept of support), and C2 (command relationships and C2 structure).

CHAPTER 4: MISSION ANALYSIS

During the mission analysis step of the AFPP, the staff analyzes the HHQ's operational approach, plans, or orders to gain an understanding of the mission, intent, OE, resources available, limitations, and specified and implied tasks. This step defines and refines the problem through the study of the specified tasks and identifies the implied tasks as well as the specified and implied tasks that are essential to accomplish the mission and resolve the problem. It focuses the commander and the staff on the problem at hand and lays a foundation for effective planning. **During mission analysis, Airmen identify the elements of air component design and construct an air component approach.**

The staff performs updates, initiates, or reviews JIPOE, develops critical facts and assumptions, and determines the initial commander's critical information requirements (CCIRs). Additionally, IPB should be conducted by intelligence personnel staff within the Service and functional components and support the individual operations with force-specific micro-analysis. Throughout mission analysis, staff members have an open iterative dialogue with the commander to refine and update their guidance.

While the staff conducts their analysis, the commander conducts their own review of HHQ guidance and mission objectives. The commander's analysis and adaptive thinking provide a frame of reference that helps to quickly assess the staff's work.

Mission analysis marks the beginning of the staff estimate and is not a one-time event. Mission analysis is a continuous effort that is constantly re-evaluated as the situation develops and new information is presented. Although some activities occur before others, mission analysis typically involves substantial concurrent processing of information by the commander and staff, particularly in a crisis.

MISSION ANALYSIS INPUTS

Primary inputs to mission analysis are planning initiation results and HHQ operational or air component approaches. When the commander receives a mission tasking, analysis begins with questions like:

- ★ What is the purpose of the mission? (What problem is the commander asked to solve or what change to the OE is desired?)
- ★ What are the specified, implied, and mission essential tasks?
- ★ Will the mission achieve the desired objectives?
- ★ What limitations (i.e., constraints and restraints) have been placed on my own forces' actions?

Planning for In-residence Education

The COVID-19 outbreak impacted living conditions and operations around the world. Air Education and Training Command momentarily paused in-residence education at several institutions due to safety concerns. Gradually, guidance was received to initiate planning to conduct a safe return to in-resident education operations. Air University planning course instructors worked with commanders, staffs, and outside organizations to plan for a safe return to normal operations.

The planning process directed by the instructors was a modified version of the JPP. The use of a heavily modified JPP was the beginning of the AFPP.

Teams developed multiple COAs that informed leadership's decision to return to in-residence operations. Commander selected COAs were molded into an approved plan that was shared among organizations to develop an understanding of the mission, intent, tasks, logistics, and authorities for COVID-19 education operations. The successful planning efforts resulted in schools resuming professional military education in a safe and timely manner.

MISSION ANALYSIS ACTIVITIES

Mission Analysis enables commanders and staffs to understand the problem(s), mission, and situation. **The mission analysis activities are often simultaneously conducted.** During mission analysis, the tasks (specified, implied, and essential) and their purposes should be identified to ensure planning encompasses all requirements, including any limitations on actions that the commander or subordinate forces may take.

Development, and dissemination of an air component approach at the end of mission analysis helps commanders and staffs frame the problem and develop viable approaches to achieve the desired end state. Mission analysis should produce an understanding of the OE, observed system, desired system, and tasks the commander should accomplish in support of the HHQ. The essential tasks derived during mission analysis should be accomplished to enable the end state as expressed in the commander's operational objectives, mission, and intent statements.

Review Commander's Initial Planning Guidance. Planners should have an active dialogue with their commander to understand their initial vision, intent, and view of the problem. The commander and staff should consider the timeframe and scope of the problem. Planning leads provide the following to the rest of the staff:

- ★ JFC's narrative, mission statement, intent statement, and concept of operations (CONOPS).
- ★ Forces and capabilities available for planning.

- ★ Transportation, airlift priority, and airlift allocation.
- ★ Other capabilities available (United States [US], multinational forces and organizations, interagency support).
- ★ The political situation (e.g., host nation [HN], friendly and other foreign governments).
- ★ Time allocation.
 - ★★ Balance the desire for detailed planning against the need for speed. Be keenly aware of the time available until the commander and HHQ decide, issue orders, and begin to execute the operation.
- ★ A timeline reflecting known and assumed operational requirements (e.g., C-day, D-day) to focus the planning groups during planning.
- ★ A timeline identifying the time available to complete the planning activities based on the HHQ delivery requirements.

Review HHQ's Planning Activities and Strategic Guidance. During this mission analysis, planners should examine all HHQ guidance and policy (at least two levels above), level of operational command authority, strategic communications, WARNORDs, planning orders, alert orders, draft plans, other planning group feedback, and commander conversations. Most importantly, they seek to understand their unit's role in the HHQ mission, intent, and CONOPS.

- ★ HHQ orders should provide specific guidance to include a description of the situation, purpose, objectives, mission, tasks, and pertinent limitations.
- ★ If available, analyze the HHQ's (and JFC's) operational approach to gain an appreciation for their understanding and visualization of the situation and problem. Develop an air component approach at the air component level (air operations center [AOC] or Air Force forces [AFFOR] staff). At the AETF and wing level review the air component approach. This provides a basis for a detailed analysis of the OE and of the tasks that may describe the mission and its parameters.

Determine Facts. A fact is a statement of information known to be true and relevant to planning. A fact defines the scope of the problem. If a fact is invalidated, it should result in a new or modified plan. When facts change it may drive contingency planning. Planners should use caution in characterizing information as facts, as some data thought to be facts may be based on incomplete information or open to subjective interpretation based on the observer's perspective. **Several of the facts that inform the AFPP are determined during HHQ mission analysis. Airmen should seek to reference facts identified by HHQ to inform their planning.**

- ★ The JIPOE aids in understanding the complex, interconnected conditions and influences that bear on commander decisions. It enhances a friendly understanding of the OE and adversary intentions and behaviors. Other steps include listing the facts relevant to the situation or mission and submitting requests for information (RFIs)

early when information is needed.

- ★ Identify the adversary's system of key nodes and links (the behavioral, physical, or functional relationship between nodes) to help understand the threat networks.
- ★ Treat HHQ assumptions as facts for planning (seek to verify HHQ assumptions).
- ★ Also consider:
 - ★★ Geographic features and meteorological and oceanographic characteristics.
 - ★★ Population demographics (e.g., ethnic groups, tribes, ideological factions, religious groups and sects, language dialects, age and income groups, gender, public health issues).
 - ★★ Political and socioeconomic factors (e.g., economic system, political or tribal factions).
 - ★★ Infrastructure (e.g., transportation, energy, and information systems).
 - ★★ Law of War requirements as specified in US law, international law, or host-nation agreements (HNA).
 - ★★ Environmental conditions (e.g., earthquakes, volcanic activity, pollution, diseases).
 - ★★ Locations of intergovernmental organizations, foreign embassies, and non-governmental organizations operating within the OA.
 - ★★ Capabilities and intent of individuals, or organizations conducting cyber or information and influence operations.
 - ★★ Prevalence of misinformation, disinformation, or competitor operations in the OE related to joint force activities.

Develop Assumptions. An assumption is a belief about the current situation or future course of events, presumed to be true in the absence of facts. **Valid assumptions should be logical, and realistic, and are essential to continued planning.** It is also important to emphasize that assumptions identify risks to the plan and important decision points for executing branches and sequels. Assumptions encompass four basic categories: time, political, enemy, and friendly forces. The staff may prioritize assumptions for the commander in terms of what causes mission failure, what leads to partial mission failure, and what affects timing and tempo. Assumptions that make the mission fail are the highest priority and essential for identifying the branches and sequels in the plan.

Consider all assumptions in risk analysis. Potential plan changes due to incorrect assumptions should be addressed as branches or sequels. Include assumptions made by HHQ, however, challenge assumptions that appear unrealistic. A method for

identifying assumptions is presented in the figure, “Technique for Identifying Assumptions”. Assumptions should be continually reviewed to ensure validity. Additionally, assumptions should be turned into facts as soon as possible. Tools to validate assumptions include RFI, priority intelligence requirements (PIRs), and friendly force information requirements (FFIRs). PIRs, FFIRs, and RFIs are discussed later in this chapter.

An assumption, proved invalid, may lead to substantial changes in the approved plan. If an issue does not have this level of impact, it should not be an assumption. Never “assume away” potential problems, such as weather or likely adversary capabilities and options. Intelligence and planning staffs should keep commanders apprised of assumptions and knowledge gaps in mission analysis.

Technique for Identifying Assumptions

When identifying assumptions, consider the five A’s:

Awareness: the amount of warning or notification expected.

Assets: types and numbers available (e.g., airlift, allied capabilities, force availability).

Access: basing, overflight, and ability to stage operations.

Additional/other activity: degree and type of involvement of bordering or third-party nations (e.g., what else is going on?).

Authorities: commander-specific (e.g., JFC-delegated, cross-combatant command [CCMD] relationships).

Define and Develop a Problem Statement: The problem can be defined by determining what needs to be reconciled between the observed and desired system. Once the problem is defined, it should be communicated in a clear and concise problem statement.⁷ The statement considers how tension and competition affect the OE by identifying how to transform the observed system to the desired system—before adversaries begin to transform current conditions to their desired end state. The statement broadly describes the requirements for transformation, anticipating changes in the OE while identifying critical transitions. The problem statement provides a focus for planning efforts and helps ensure the conservation of resources during potential execution.

⁷ See JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*, for additional information.

Example Problem Statement

The XX AETF seeks to establish additional operating locations to enable ACE and defeat adversary actions. Adversaries are expected to impede the positioning of necessary resources and capabilities at remote locations. Host nation populations at desired operating locations may suffer negative economic impacts by assisting with positioning efforts. New operating locations must establish air base defense. The new operating locations will ensure a stable balance of power in the region that deters adversary aggression.

Analyze the Most Likely and Most Dangerous Threats to mission success. In AFPP, Airmen should consider the most likely and most dangerous threat that could prevent mission success and reaching the desired system. The threats should relate to the identified problem requiring action to move the observed system to the desired system. **Airmen should consider the most likely and most dangerous threat to mission success during tabletop exercises in COA analysis and wargaming.** Joint staffs at the operational level may focus on the most likely and most dangerous adversary COAs.

Develop Air Component Design. Air component design sets the stage for more detailed planning and is revisited during planning. **Airmen using the AFPP use the air component design to establish a framework for further planning.** The scope of a problem is revealed through air component design and adaptive thinking. The scope and complexity of the problem can vary. Well-structured problems may be addressed with tactics and techniques while medium-structured problems could use doctrine to develop potential solutions. Plans at the strategic level, however, usually deal with ill-structured problems that are interactively complex.

Adaptive thinking that considers CC's guidance, the OE, and **air component design produces an air component approach.** The analysis of air component design to produce an air component approach occurs throughout the AFPP. However, this analysis is particularly focused during planning initiation and mission analysis.

The air component design provides a logical framework comprised of several elements to conduct problem identification and framing. Establishing the air component design framework correlates to activities associated with conducting a comprehensive mission analysis. Furthermore, the air component design allows for the coordination of operations and activities to achieve objectives. Air component design is **iterative** and requires a consistently evolving understanding of the observed system and desired system to define the problem. Importantly, air component design empowers mission command in a contested, degraded, and operationally limited environment by providing a shared vision that analyzes key decisions and risks.

Planning Example: Operation ALLIES REFUGE, Ramstein AB

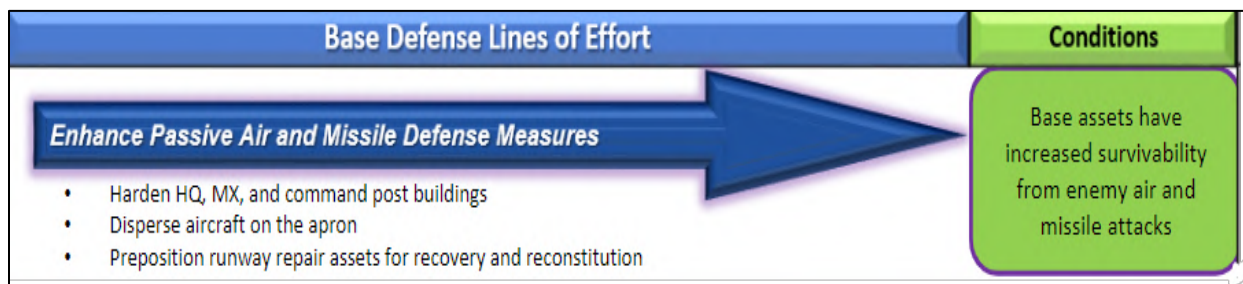
In 2021, Ramstein AB conducted crisis planning to assist in the evacuation of Special Immigrant Visa applicants and other vulnerable Afghans. With little time to prepare, the base cleared out two of its aircraft hangars and set up hundreds of cots to provide temporary shelters. However, planning efforts quickly changed when base leaders realized Ramstein AB would become a primary evacuation hub for US European Command. Ramstein AB enhanced planning efforts to encompass medical, logistics, maintenance, civil engineering, security, and food services personnel to provide necessary services and a haven for thousands of evacuees.

An undertaking of this magnitude required enormous resources, planning, and people. The modified planning efforts necessitated adjustment of non-essential services and several course of action alterations. Commander-selected COAs were developed into an approved plan that was shared among several organizations. The clearly written plan developed a shared understanding of the mission, intent, tasks, logistics, and authorities. The successful planning efforts resulted in a historic evacuee operation and the processing, security, and safety of over 35,000 Afghans.

In order for commanders and staffs to effectively develop their air component approach, they must have a clear understanding of the HHQ guidance, observed system, desired system, problem, and its root cause. This understanding allows them to analyze the operational approaches of HHQ and create their air component approach. **Commanders decide which air component design elements are depicted in their air component approach.** Air component design elements are:

- ★ *Objective*: Clearly defined, decisive, and attainable goal toward which an operation is directed.
- ★ *Desired end state*: The set of required conditions that define the achievement of the commander's objectives.
- ★ *Root cause*: The fundamental underlying reason or factor that is driving the problem, essentially the most critical aspect that needs to be addressed to solve the issue. Teams discuss lines of effort (subordinate problem sets) to address the root cause utilizing the "5 Why Analysis" method by asking "Why" as many times as needed (minimum 5) to identify the root cause of the initial problem statement.

- ★ **Effects:** Physical and/or behavioral state of a system that results from an action, a set of actions, or another effect. Desired effects should link to objectives. Effects should be measurable. Effects should be distinguishable from objectives and tasks as they support conditions for success. For more information on Effects see Appendix C, Actions and Effects.”
- ★ **Culmination:** Point in time and/or space when the operation can no longer maintain momentum.
- ★ **Physical characteristics of the OE:** Tangible factors of the OE to consider are physical size, weather/climate, and geography.
- ★ **Lines of Operation (LOO) and Lines of Effort (LOE):**
 - ★★ **LOO:** Defines the interior or exterior orientation of the force in relation to the enemy. Describe and connect a series of decisive actions that lead to control of a geographic or force-oriented objective.
 - ★★ **LOE:** Links multiple tasks and missions using the logic of purpose, cause and effect, to focus efforts towards establishing operational level objectives that can lead to strategic objectives. An LOE may represent subordinate problem sets of an overarching problem. The Base Defense Lines of Effort example illustrates how tasks can support a line of effort to achieve a condition.



- ★ **Decisive points (DPs):** Key terrain, key event, critical factor, or function that, when acted upon, enables a commander to gain a marked advantage over an enemy or contributes materially to achieving success (e.g., creating a desired effect, or achieving an objective).
- ★ **Direct and Indirect Approach:** The manner in which a commander contends with the problem. The direct approach addresses the problem’s principal strength by applying effort directly against it. An indirect approach addresses the problem by applying effort against key components of the problem to reach an effective solution.
- ★ **Operational reach:** The distance and duration across which a joint force can successfully employ military capabilities.

- ★ *Arranging Operations*: Commanders may consider organizing operations according to depth, timing, and tempo. Some ways to organize complex operations include phases, branches, sequels, and operational pauses.
- ★ *Anticipation*: Consider what might happen and look for indicators of forecasted events.
- ★ *Forces and Functions*: Comprised of all friendly, enemy, and adversary forces, capabilities, and associated functions. The functions include the mechanisms the commander may use to solve the problem (e.g., defeat the enemy or stabilize the situation).

Determine and Plan for Authorities. Commanders and planners at all echelons should be aware of their commander's authorities either in the operational or administrative branches of the chain of command. In the joint force, all authorities reside with the JFC and are delegated to subordinate commanders, with considerations for further delegation to lower echelons, through an appropriate order. Planning for the delegation of **appropriate and legitimate** authorities in contested, degraded, and operationally limited environments should be considered. Mission command requires leaders to ensure subordinates are provided and aware of the authorities they possess in the execution of their responsibilities outlined in the commander's intent. Distributed control enables commanders to delegate authorities to plan, prepare, execute, and assess activities to dispersed locations for an effective span of control and maintain the initiative, particularly in contested environments. Distributed control may be enduring or temporary to allow execution at multiple echelons. Conditions-based authorities are authorities that are often limited in duration and identified in plans approved by authorized commanders to facilitate execution that meets commander's intent. Failure to provide a subordinate with sufficient authority to act may inadvertently encourage them to operate beyond limitations. Alternatively, providing a subordinate with authority that exceeds situation or mission requirements may result in chaotic, uncoordinated operations. Plans and orders should clearly delineate distributed control and authorities.



"It is a given in future conflicts that the joint force will be conducting operations in a contested environment. We must be prepared to execute in a degraded C2 environment where clearly delineated and forward-thinking commander's intent will be a requirement. It is imperative senior leaders provide our commanders with conditions-based authorities delegated to the lowest capable and competent level and empower command by negation to accept the appropriate level of risk, all while working toward moments of clear C2."

—General Charles Q. Brown, Jr., 22nd Chief of Staff, USAF
Remarks as Commander, Pacific Air Forces, 2019

Determine Operational Limitations (Constraints and Restraints). Constraints and restraints are actions required or prohibited by higher authority that limit the commander's freedom of action. Additionally, a constraint and/or restraint can be a restriction imposed by conditions and circumstances. **Restraints are HHQ requirements placed on the command that prohibit action.** An example of a restraint is a prohibition from conducting a movement to a specific location (e.g., a bordering nation). **Constraints are HHQ requirements placed on the command that dictates action.** An example of a constraint is HHQ's direction to fly a certain mission as part of an operation within a specific time, sequence, or phase.⁸

Identify Specified, Implied, and Essential Tasks. For planners to accurately develop a mission statement and air component approach, they should be able to identify the three types of tasks that will be used to solve the problem. Specified tasks are assigned to the commander verbally or in writing by the HHQ. Specified tasks often become essential tasks. Implied tasks are tasks that are revealed by mission analysis but not explicitly stated by HHQ guidance. Implied tasks may NOT be essential to mission accomplishment but should be identified to inform further planning. Determining the essential tasks from the specified and implied tasks ensures that the commander addresses what needs to be accomplished for mission success.

- ★ **Specified tasks** are tasks specifically assigned to the commander verbally or in writing by the HHQ. These are normally written in the 'Tasks to Subordinates' paragraph and/or 'Coordinating Instructions' in the HHQ plan or order.
- ★ **Implied tasks** are tasks that mission analysis reveals the commander must perform (or prepare to perform) but are not stated explicitly in an order or elsewhere. Implied tasks do not include routine tasks or standard operating procedures (SOP) inherent in most operations. Guidance for identifying implied tasks is presented in the Deriving Implied Tasks figure.

Deriving Implied Tasks

To derive implied tasks, focus on analyzing the HHQ mission, intent, concept, and specified tasks, to include specified tasks to other units. As a technique, ask:

- ★ "In this situation, what other major tasks would my echelon normally perform?"
- ★ "What in the HHQ mission, intent, or concept implies a major (but unstated) task for the commander?" For example, if the HHQ has a deter portion of the mission, then contributing to deterrence could be an implied task.
- ★ "What task to another unit, component, or agency is likely to require significant support from the commander?"

⁸ The Law of War always applies and should be considered, along with ROE and Rules for the Use of Force, in evaluating constraints and Restraints. Refer to the Department of Defense Law of War Manual.

- ★ **Mission essential tasks** are a subset of specified and/or implied tasks the commander must accomplish to succeed at the mission. Mission essential tasks are the basis for the commander's mission statement.

Develop Commander's Mission Statement. A mission statement is a short sentence or paragraph that provides a clear statement of the action to be taken and the reason for doing so. The mission statement is written to cover the entire operation. It is the basis for planning and is included in planning guidance, staff estimates, commander's estimates, CONOPS, and the completed plan/order. The mission statement can be revised if initial circumstances change. A mission statement once approved drives the remainder of the AFPP. The commander's mission statement should address:

- ★ *Who:* The entity responsible for the mission.
- ★ *What:* The essential tasks.
- ★ *When:* Often expressed by 'when directed,' 'on order,' or 'be prepared to.'
- ★ *Where:* In the designated geographic area.
- ★ *Why:* The reason for accomplishing the essential tasks.

An example mission statement highlighting the 5 W's is presented in the Example Mission Statement figure.

Example Mission Statement

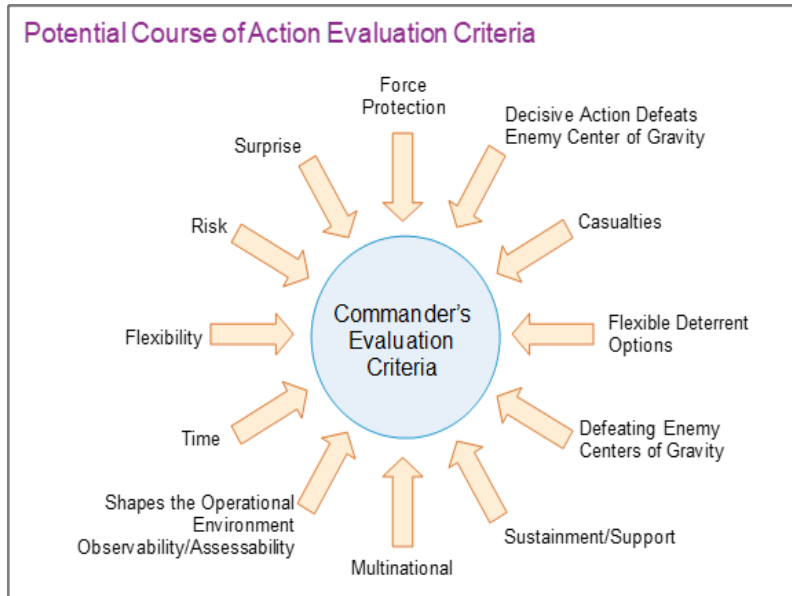
When directed, the 325th Fighter Wing will stand up the crisis action team, move required personnel and equipment to emergency divert locations, harden base facilities at Tyndall Air Force Base, open storm shelters, and establish necessary life support to ensure the safety of personnel and critical resources during hurricane conditions.

Conduct Initial Resource Review. The initial resource review in mission analysis is a first look at all resource requirements e.g., time, personnel, funding, etc.) to determine broad requirements and identify initial shortfalls. This review identifies resources required to accomplish the specified and implied tasks and highlights any disconnects that may exist. Resource shortfalls become a part of the risk discussion.

Develop COA Evaluation Criteria. COA evaluation criteria are the measures used for developing and determining an acceptable COA. The commander should include these criteria in initial planning guidance and may be determined from the commander's intent. Planners should seek to obtain COA evaluation criteria as early in the planning process as possible to inform planning efforts. They help determine supporting objectives, effects, tasks, and if or when to move to the next major operation or phase. These criteria also

become the basis for assessment.⁹

The commander and staff use the COA evaluation criteria during AFPP step five to select the best COA. **Developing initial evaluation criteria during mission analysis or as part of the commander's initial planning guidance helps eliminate bias before COA analysis and comparison.** Evaluation criteria address factors that affect mission success or may cause failure. Commanders adjust criteria and weighting according to their own experience and vision. Suggestions for possible COA criteria are in the figure, "Potential Course of Action Evaluation Criteria".



Develop Commander's Risk Assessment. A risk assessment should be conducted at all levels of command. There are two categories of military risk: risk-to-force (RF) and risk-to-mission (RM). RF is the probability and consequence of current and contingency events causing harm to the provisioning and sustainment of sufficient military resources. RM is the probability and consequence of current and contingency events causing harm to current or future military objectives.¹⁰

Commanders may delegate risk management decisions to lower echelons, however, they maintain the responsibility for overall risk. Airmen and wing A-staffs should be familiar with how to use the joint risk framework and discuss probabilities and consequences of risk events.

Staffs use historical data, intuitive analysis, modeling and simulation tools as available, and judgment to consider mission risk, mitigation, and residual risk. Risks are evaluated and presented by assessing the probability of occurrence and severity of consequence.

Staffs should address assumptions and PIR during risk assessment. PIRs are considered for risks aligned with how they impact the mission. During the risk assessment step, you may encounter additional valid and necessary assumptions. Planners should address the potential opportunities and consequences of assumptions being valid/invalid. Risk articulation is the most important conversation the planning team can have with the commander and the commander will have with HHQ. With every risk, there is an

⁹ See AFDP 3-0.1, *Command and Control*, for additional information.

¹⁰ See CJCSM 3105.01B, *Joint Risk Analysis Methodology*, for additional information.

opportunity to discuss both positive and negative aspects.

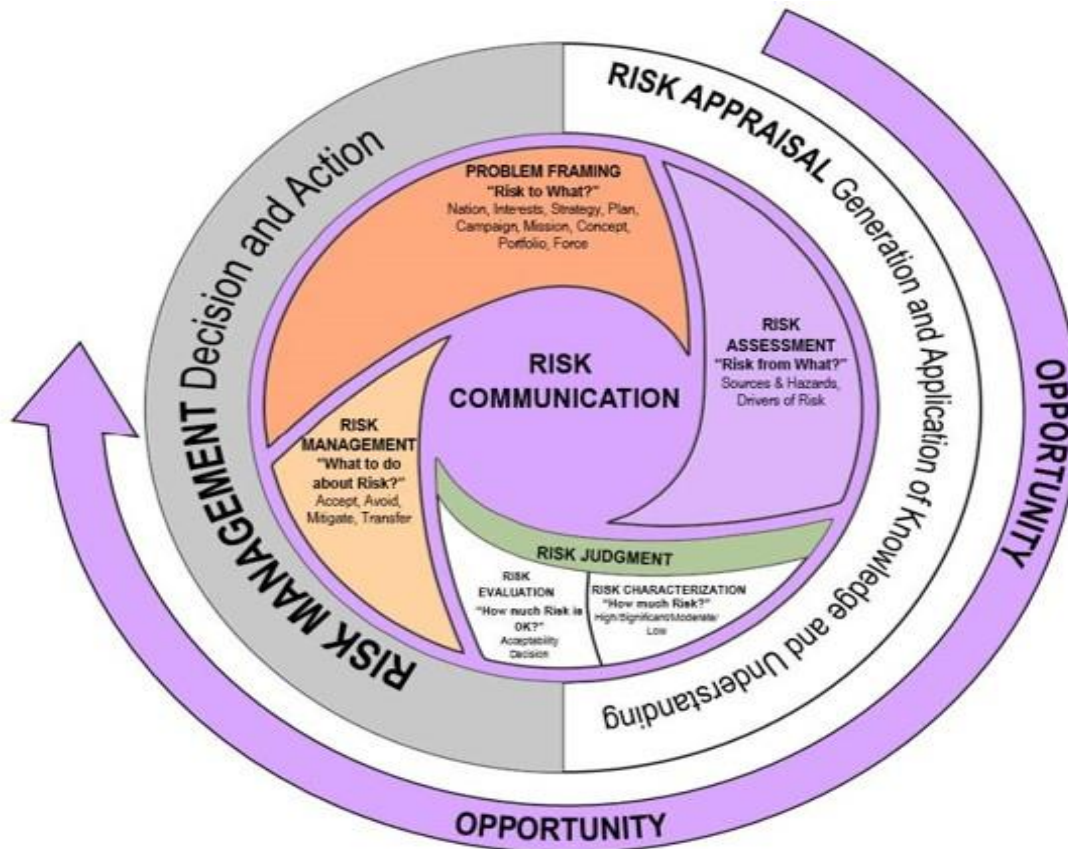
Guidance on determining the probability and consequence of an event is provided in the figure, “Probability and Consequence of Event”.

Probability of Event (P)	Consequence of Event (C) to NMS
Very Likely (~81-100%)	Extreme • RM, Mission Failure, Objectives Unachievable • RF, No Sourcing Solutions Exist for Critical Requirements
Likely (~51-80%)	Major • RM, Objectives Minimally Achieved (consider time, priority) • RF, Shortfalls Exist for Critical Requirements
Unlikely (~21-50%)	Modest • RM, Objectives Mostly Achieved (consider time, priority) • RF, Worldwide Sourcing Solution Exist for Most Requirements
Very Unlikely (~0-20%)	Minor • RM, Mission Success, Objective Achievable • RF, Joint Force Fully Sustained and Requirements Sourced

Probability and Consequence of Event

Risk should be discussed in planning using the joint risk framework. Planners may start identifying risk by asking about what resources are in jeopardy. Upon determination of what is at risk, planners assess what is placing the resource in peril. The risk assessment is provided to the appropriate commander to make a risk decision. Depending on the situation and the risk acceptance authority given to the commander, they may decide to accept, avoid, mitigate, or transfer the risk. Commanders and staffs should consider how risk management decisions may displace risks to other forces. Risk assessments and commander’s risk management decision should be addressed in the commander’s intent statement, CONOPS, or as additional guidance that describes what risks the commander allows subordinates to accept and under what conditions.¹¹ **The joint risk framework figure applies to the JPP, JPPA, and AFPP.**

¹¹ For additional information on risk assessment, see CJCSM 3105.01B, *Joint Risk Analysis Methodology*, and JP 5-0 *Joint Planning*.



The Joint Risk Framework

Determine Initial Commander's Critical Information Requirements. CCIRs are elements of information the commander identifies as being critical to facilitate timely decision-making. CCIRs belong exclusively to the commander and are not static. Commanders refine and update both decision points and associated CCIRs throughout the operation. **CCIRs are identified when using the JPP, JPPA, and AFPP.** When developing CCIRs at subcomponent commands, focus on decision points related to the air component approach. CCIRs should also be coordinated with the commander's servicing judge advocate to ensure compliance with the law and existing rules of engagement.

CCIRs may include:

- ★ *Priority intelligence requirements:* PIRs focus on the adversary and the OE and are often tied to commander's decision points. Airmen determining PIRs focus on the problem's root cause, observed system, and desired system in relation to commander's decision points (AFPP). Commanders at all levels use PIRs to drive ISR operations to support decisions and operations.
- ★ *Friendly force information requirements:* Information regarding the status of friendly forces and supporting capabilities associated with the operation.

- ★ **Essential elements of information (EEIs):** Intel gaps when PIRs cannot be answered and drive the development of detailed EEIs. EEIs form the basis for RFIs by outlining specific information requirements.
- ★ **Requests for information:** RFIs are requirements for intelligence information or products to support an operation not necessarily related to standing requirements or scheduled intelligence production. RFIs may satisfy PIRs and FFIRs.¹²

Initial CCIR identification during mission analysis can assist in identifying anticipated decision points and related information requirements. At this point, neither a COA nor a CONOPS exists, therefore, the intent is to capture ideas that may become CCIRs.¹³

Determine Decision Points. Decision points often require a commander decision that can be detailed on a decision support matrix (DSM). DSMs are useful for informing commander decisions and conducting COA analysis and wargaming. An example DSM template is found below.¹⁴

Decision Support Matrix							
Decision Point	Named Area of Interest	Target Area of Interest	Event	Decision Criteria	Sources of Decision Criteria	Assets Available	CJTF Actions
					SIGINT HUMINT MASINT IMINT		
Adversary's Assumptions			Adversary's Possible Decisions			Adversary's CCIRs	
Risk		Mission Impact		Probability		Mitigation	
Notes							
Weather, Solar, Sea State, Maneuver Rates...							

Develop Commander's Intent Statement. The commander's intent statement should articulate their vision of the mission's purpose, end state, and risks. A well-framed intent statement provides subordinates with the ability to exercise disciplined initiative. Commanders are encouraged to write their own commander's intent as it is pivotal to mission command. Commander's intent may change based on the scope of the mission

¹² For more information on PIRs, EEIs, and RFIs see Air Force Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures 3-4.14, *Contingency Intelligence Network*.

¹³ Focus on decision points related to the air component approach. Even early in planning, it may be apparent there are critical commander decisions that are required regardless of the COA selected. CCIRs are more applicable to the JPP and JPPA but can still be identified in the AFPP.

¹⁴ For more information on decision points, see JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*.

and with the planning process. The final intent statement is published in the order.

- ★ **Purpose.** Purpose delineates the reason for the military action with respect to the mission of the next higher echelon. The purpose explains why the military action is being conducted. Purpose helps the force pursue the mission without further orders, even when actions do not unfold as planned. Thus, if an unanticipated situation arises, participating commanders understand the purpose of the forthcoming action well enough to act decisively and within the bounds of the higher commander's intent (JP 5-0).
- ★ **End State.** The end state is a set of desired future conditions the commander wants to exist when an operation ends. Commanders may describe the operation's end state by stating the desired system and conditions of the friendly force in relation to the desired conditions of the enemy, terrain, and civil considerations. A clearly defined end state promotes unity of effort among the force and with unified action partners.
- ★ **Risks.** The intent statement outlines the identified risk(s) throughout the planning process. Specifically, highlight risk accepted by the commander. Significant known risks requiring additional approval are combined with constraints and restraints.

Example Commander's Intent Statement

Purpose: The purpose of this operation is to ensure air base defense by hardening facilities, employing deception schemes, establishing defense in depth force protection strategies, supporting ballistic missile defense operations, and supporting air defense sortie generation to ensure unhindered base operations.

End State: At the end of this operation, facilities will be hardened, enemy surveillance attempts degraded, force protection threats mitigated, air and missile defense units supported, and base operations fully functioning.

Risk: There is a high probability that forces will be in danger of adversary fires should air base defense efforts fail, which results in a major consequence. This presents a significant risk to air base forces. There is a likely probability that degradation to base facilities will hinder mission generation capability. This poses a major risk to air base forces' accomplishment of the mission.

Prepare or Update Staff Estimates. A staff estimate is an evaluation of how factors in a functional area support and/or impact the mission. The staff estimate process is central to formulating or updating the plan to accomplish the mission. Staff members continuously refine products as planning continues. Staff estimates focus on collecting information from a given functional area to help the commander and staff understand the situation and conduct mission analysis. The preparation and updating of staff estimates will normally be conducted by joint staffs. Airmen using the AFPP will normally reference staff estimates during planning. In staff estimates, each element:

- ★ Reviews the mission and situation from their staff functional perspective.
- ★ Examines the factors and assumptions for which they are the responsible staff.
- ★ Evaluates how factors in their functional area may influence each COA.
- ★ Provides detailed analysis of how that functional area would best support a given COA.
- ★ Reviews the tentative force structure and determine additional lift requirements.
- ★ Informs HHQ staff of logistics feasibility by leveraging the logistics overview.
- ★ Identifies existing contract availability, point of debarkation (POD), percentage of PODs, inventories, and other distribution infrastructure available.
- ★ Works to identify operational capability requirements in the plan.

Staff Estimate Functional Area Examples:

- ★ Personnel estimate: Manning.
- ★ *Intelligence estimate*: JIPOE, intelligence community factors, collection and processing, exploitation, and dissemination capabilities.
- ★ *Operations estimate*: Offensive ops, air defense, air refueling, airlift, airspace control, C2.
- ★ *Logistics estimate*: Time-phased force deployment data (TPFDD), beddown, fuel, munitions, water, supply.
- ★ *Communications estimate*: Staff, systems, and communication requirements.
- ★ *Information estimate*: Evaluation of how relevant actor perceptions, attitudes, and behaviors affect operations planning and execution.



“There will be challenges and this is much greater than just an AOC going away. Is the person that I am working for describing their priorities clearly? Are those priorities meeting with the realities of the operational environment? Is their feedback mechanism going back to command echelons so they can understand if they need to adjust their priorities?”

—General Mike Minihan, USAF

Remarks as Commander, Air Mobility Command, 2024
Doctrine Podcast: Lessons Learned in Doctrine

The exact format and level of detail vary among commands and staff sections based on theater specifics and other factors. Principal elements normally include mission, situation, functional considerations, and conclusions.

Present Commander’s Mission Analysis Brief. The mission analysis brief is presented to the commander. The mission analysis brief is to ensure the commander and planning staff have a common understanding of the environment, problem, situation, and mission and is essential to forging unity of effort. It focuses on relevant conclusions reached during mission analysis. The brief should include representatives from the entire staff and partner organizations. The “Common Mission Analysis Briefing Elements” figure depicts a common framework for the commander’s mission analysis brief.

Common Mission Analysis Briefing Elements

1. Purpose: Provide draft commander mission, obtain commander guidance.
2. Identify the relevant operating area (an area of interest may also be briefed).
3. Initial situation brief.
4. HHQ guidance, mission, and intent statements.
5. Problem statement, root cause, and subordinate problem sets.
6. Facts.
7. Assumptions.
8. Constraints and restraints.
9. CC's problem and key components.
10. End state.
11. Specified, implied, and essential tasks.
12. Commander's initial risk assessment.
13. Time analysis-Including projection of planning milestones.
14. Initial CCIRs.
15. Initial resource analysis.
16. Other guidance as applicable.
17. Air component approach, as required.
18. Proposed commander mission and intent statements.

NOTE: The briefing elements fall into two categories. Elements 1-10 "set the problem" and usually reflect information already provided. Elements 11-17 provide specific actions and needs.

MISSION ANALYSIS RESULTS

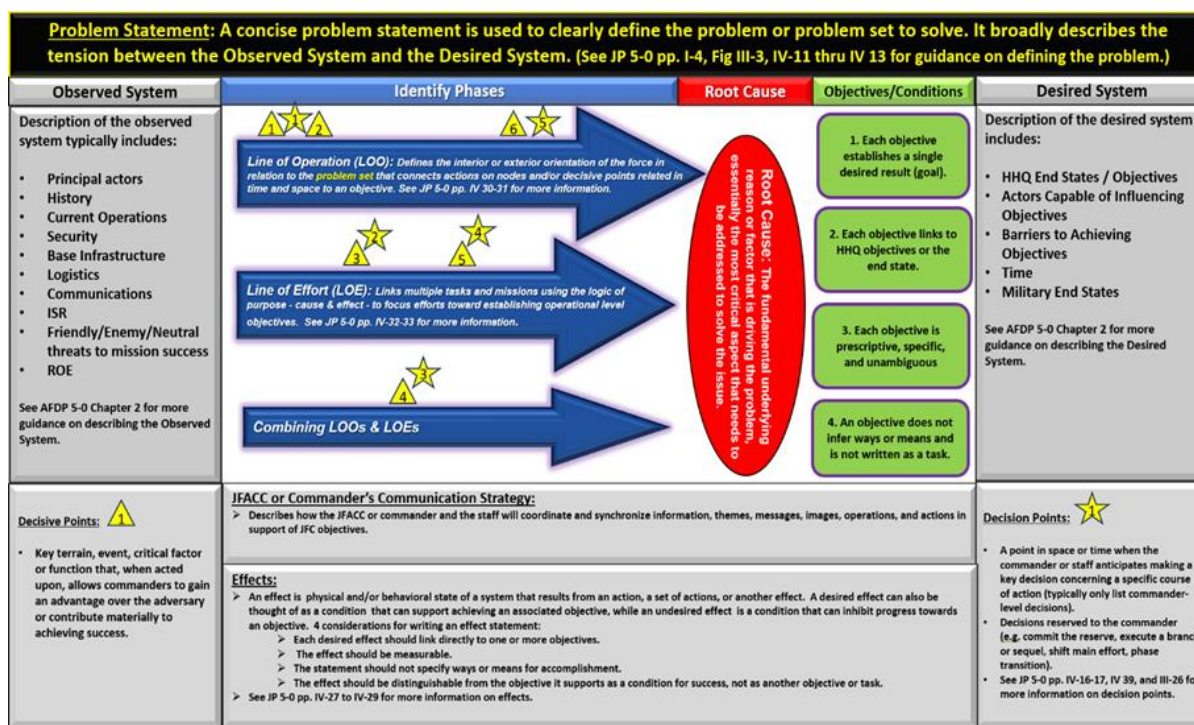
The results of mission analysis are an air component approach, specified, implied, and mission essential tasks, component(s) of the problem that need(s) to be addressed, mission statement, intent statement, updated planning guidance, and initial CCIRs. An additional output of mission analysis is the commander's approval of the staff's understanding of the observed and desired systems and refined guidance for further planning and design refinement.

Publish Commander's Refined Planning Guidance. Following the mission analysis brief, staff note guidance provided by the commander to guide further planning. Mission analysis outcomes, OE changes, and updated HHQ guidance can drive a requirement for refined planning guidance. Refined planning guidance may address the following:

- ★ Approved mission statement.
- ★ Updated commander's intent statement.

- ★ Overall narratives two echelons up.
- ★ Key elements of the OE.
- ★ Key assumptions and operational limitations.
- ★ End state and termination criteria.
- ★ Acceptable or unacceptable levels of risk in key areas.
- ★ The role of agencies and multinational partners in the pending operation and any related special considerations as required.
- ★ Air component approach.

Air Component Approach. The air component approach is a fundamental output of air component design and initially produced at the end of mission analysis. **Air component design elements are normally used to construct the air component approach.** The approach is a commander's description of the broad actions the force can take to achieve an objective, support HHQ objectives, and attain a desired end state. The ultimate purpose of an air component approach is to describe how to achieve a desired system that leads to an enduring advantage for friendly interests. The accomplishment of all objectives should lead to the desired system and set of future conditions. Tactical tasks necessary to support lines of effort or lines of operations should be depicted on the air component approach. An "Air Component Approach Template" figure is provided below. For greater detail, see Appendix D, "Air Component Approach Template."



Air Component Approach Template

HHQs may develop an operational approach that informs the air component approach efforts. An operational approach primarily differs from an air component approach by focusing on the center(s) of gravity.

CHAPTER 5: COURSE OF ACTION DEVELOPMENT

The third step of the AFPP is COA development. A COA is “any sequence of activities that an individual or unit may follow” or “scheme developed to accomplish a mission.” COA development seeks to determine “how” to use capabilities made available to accomplish the “what” derived during mission analysis. The COA is framed around time, space, and purpose. Airmen have a unique perspective on developing COAs focused on generating effects. **Commander involvement is critical.** The necessary degree of commander guidance and involvement depends on the situation.

COA DEVELOPMENT INPUTS

COAs provide potential ways to address an identified problem and create desired changes in the observed system resulting in the desired system. Inputs that inform COA development are the mission analysis results, refined air component design, and a refined air component approach.

Additional Planning Consideration

All major C2 activities may be enhanced with AI and human-machine teaming to optimize operations. First, data synthesis and processing capabilities can help planners make sense of a complex OE. Commanders and their staffs can then use their understanding of the OE to inform their air component design. As planners work to develop plans, AI can provide recommendations that influence COA development, and AI-enabled wargaming systems may allow iterative review of potential COAs in a shortened amount of time to improve the COA approval process. Subsequently, approved plans will lead to streamlined preparation. AI can make logistics and movement recommendations, enhance intelligence exploitation, and accelerate execution decisions. As the OE evolves during execution, AI can aid battle management nodes as they proactively maneuver forces to gain an advantage over the adversary. Finally, AI assisted analysis of friendly effects and adversary reactions can support operational assessment.

NOTE: AI and human-machine planning may enhance planning efforts but should not fully replace planning. An understanding of the mission and OE are cognitive planning products often considered more important than completed plans.

COA DEVELOPMENT ACTIVITIES

COAs should take into consideration the time available (time to plan), the most likely impact on the OE, and the most dangerous impact on the OE. Distinguishability is typically the most challenging facet of developing multiple COAs. Airmen typically build COAs in a "divide and conquer" fashion vs sequentially, often creating similar COAs. Staffs should consider the elements of the 5-paragraph order format as they conduct COA development. For additional information on the five-paragraph order format see Appendix A, "Plans and Order Format" and Appendix E, "Example Modified Five-Paragraph Order." The figure, "COA Development Activities" provides more information on approaches to solving the problem.

COA Development Steps

1. Brainstorm COA(s).
2. Chart or Visualize COA(s).
3. Prepare COA Statement, Sketch, and Task Organization.
4. Present COA Selection Brief.
5. Refine Air Component Design and COA(s).
6. Continue Vertical and Horizontal Parallel Planning.

DEVELOPMENT STEP 1: BRAINSTORM COA(S)

A COA is a broad potential solution to an identified problem. COA brainstorming generates options for follow-on analysis and comparison that satisfy the commander's intent and planning guidance. During COA brainstorming, planners use knowledge, skills, experience, creativity, judgment, and products developed during mission analysis to develop broad concepts. Typical activities in this step include (see "COA Development Activities" figure):

- ★ Review information from mission analysis HHQ operational approach, and air component approach if available.
- ★ Determine COA development technique-simultaneous or sequential.
- ★ Consider the elements of air component design and air component approach.
- ★ Develop alternative COA themes and approaches.
- ★ Analyze forces and capabilities, including force flow issues.
- ★ Identify command relationships.
- ★ Integrate staff estimates and updates.

DEVELOPMENT STEP 2: CHART OR VISUALIZE COA(S)

This step organizes and synchronizes COAs. Graphically depicting the COA in space and time allows the commander to visualize the COA and synchronize it with current operations and requirements. In some cases, a sketch or graphic may be useful.

- ★ Analyze mission analysis data and develop an operational timeline.
- ★ Translate specified and implied tasks into objectives using an effects-based approach by general phases.
 - ★★ Phases, such as "shaping", or "redeployment operations", are used to achieve one or more major objectives. Transitioning to the next phase indicates a change in the emphasis, e.g., "stability ops" to "redeployment ops." A single-minded focus on specific phases can help bind various facets of the problem to focus planners' ideas.¹⁵
- ★ Identify the sequencing of the operation for each COA as appropriate.
- ★ Identify main and supporting efforts by phase.
- ★ Develop initial COA sketches.
- ★ Develop initial COA statement.

DEVELOPMENT STEP 3: PREPARE COA STATEMENT, SKETCH, AND TASK ORGANIZATION

This step creates a detailed narrative, graphical depiction, and a task organization methodology that explains the "5-Ws" and "how" the COA accomplishes the mission.

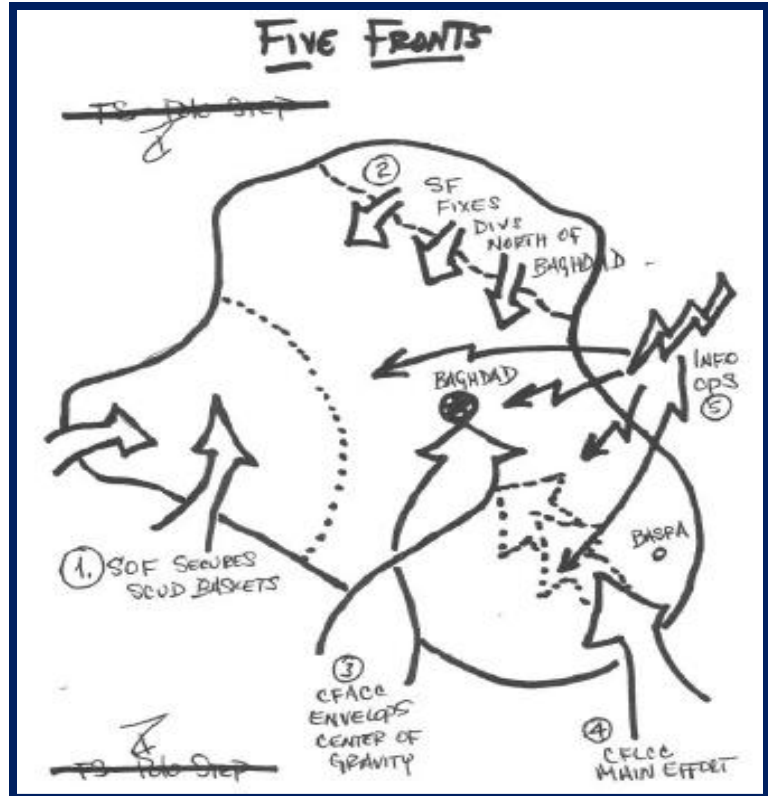
COA Statement. The COA statement is a narrative describing the CONOPS. It is typically written chronologically and addresses all phases of the operation. The statement addresses "who" (type of forces) executes "what" (tasks), expands on "when", shows "where" the commander's mission statement applies, explains the "why", and adds "how". The "how" of the statement could address the means, methods, and priority of effort that makes a COA distinguishable.

¹⁵ For additional information on operational phases and phasing, see JP 3-0, *Joint Campaigns and Operations*.

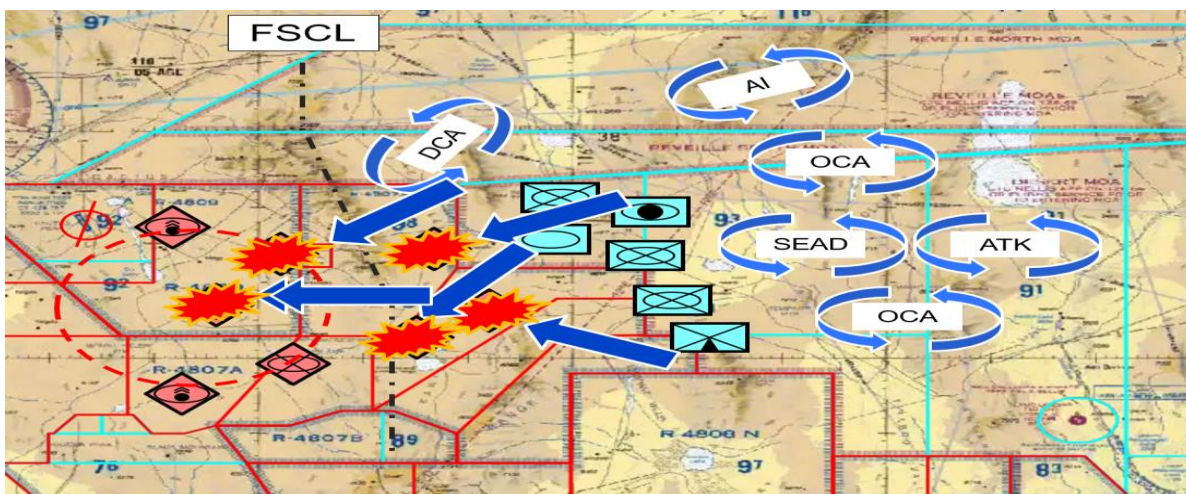
Sketch. COAs are often depicted and briefed using a combination of CONOPS graphics and sketches (the execution portion of the COA). COA sketches visualize how each COA can vary and evolve with maps and charts. An example sketch is the “Five Fronts” sketch from Gen Tommy Frank’s book, *American Soldier*.

Task Organization. The task organization should detail the relationship between tasked forces, the commander’s authorities, the overall purpose of the COA, and supporting organizations. Resourcing (main effort) should be considered in larger operations during task organization construction.

In general, air COAs may vary with respect to ends, ways, means, and/or risks.¹⁶ The staff should see how they can best synchronize (arrange in terms of time, space, and purpose) the actions of all the elements of the force once they begin to visualize COA alternatives.



Five Fronts sketch from Gen Tommy Frank’s book, *American Soldier*



Example COA Sketch

¹⁶ For more information on COA distinguishability, see JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*.

Test The Validity of Each COA. A "valid" COA should be feasible, acceptable, suitable, distinguishable, and complete. A COA should accomplish all HHQ tasks and any additional tasks identified during mission analysis. While definitions are given below, the commander retains the final judgment for COA requirements. In addition to any requirements given by the commander, examine each prospective COA for validity using the following screening criteria:

- ★ *Feasible*: The COA can accomplish the mission within the established time, space, and resource limitations.
- ★ *Acceptable*: The COA should balance cost and risk with the advantage gained.
- ★ *Suitable*: The COA can accomplish the mission within the commander's intent and planning guidance.
- ★ *Distinguishable*: Each COA should differ significantly from the others (such as scheme of maneuver, lines of effort, phasing, use of reserve forces, and task organization).
- ★ *Complete*: A COA should incorporate the following information:
 - ★★ How the decisive operation leads to mission accomplishment.
 - ★★ How shaping operations creates and preserves conditions for the success of the decisive operation or effort.
 - ★★ How sustaining operations enable shaping and decisive operations or efforts.
 - ★★ How to account for offensive, defensive, and stability or civil support tasks.
 - ★★ Tasks to be performed and conditions to be achieved (a COA should accomplish all tasks from HHQ, and additional tasks identified during mission analysis).

DEVELOPMENT STEP 4: Present COA Selection Brief

If required, a COA brief provides the commander an opportunity to provide refined guidance, including further analysis, revisions, wargaming direction, changes to design, and updated COA evaluation criteria. The "Typical COA Briefing Elements" figure guides items commonly discussed during the brief.

Typical COA Briefing Elements

1. Purpose.
2. HHQ mission and intent statements (two echelons higher).
3. Commander's mission and intent.
4. Intelligence estimate and environmental factors (JIPOE).
5. Logistics and sustainment considerations.
6. Timeline, phasing, and sequencing (correlate with previous steps).
7. Broad COA differences.
8. Depiction of each COA (e.g., charts, sketches, and statements).
9. Logistics and sustainment considerations.
10. Shortfalls, additional support, and authorities required.
11. Risks and identified mitigation measures.

DEVELOPMENT STEP 5: REFINE AIR COMPONENT DESIGN AND COA(S)

Continue to refine air component design and COAs. Changes in one COA, situation, or air design element may require corresponding changes to other COAs. Properly managed, air component design refinement is in an iterative process that keeps all products aligned and provides more refined COAs.

DEVELOPMENT STEP 6: CONTINUE VERTICAL AND HORIZONTAL PARALLEL PLANNING

Planners should integrate planning efforts with staff counterparts at HHQ and parallel agencies as appropriate. Airmen at the wing level should ensure that their planning supports the JFACC and/or commander, Air Force forces' (COMAFFOR's) guidance and direction. Expect planning adjustments as additional details become available and permit lower echelons to start planning and generate questions. If applicable, issue a preparatory order or Fragmentary Order (FRAGORD) to subordinates.

Providing sufficient guidance and time to subordinates is important in planning. A time consideration for planning is provided in "The One-Third, Two-Thirds Rule for Air Force Planning" figure.

COA DEVELOPMENT RESULTS

Proper COA development refines air component design and may produce six results: CONOPS, C2 structure and command relationships (COMREL), required capabilities, deployment and sustainment concept, COA statement (narrative description), and valid COAs.

CONOPS. A CONOPS is a verbal or graphic statement of the commander's intent to identify the overall purpose. It includes elements like a high-level view of the environment (e.g., terrain, multidomain considerations, weather, threats), an approach for how forces are to be organized, employed, and coordinated, and an initial list of tasks and responsibilities to subordinate and supporting organizations. Frequently presented as a graphic, the CONOPS is the foundational element that planners can refine and develop the COA into the execution paragraph of the plan or order.

The One-Third, Two-Thirds Rule For Air Force Planning

Planning can be a time-intensive process for both superior and subordinate organizations. Air Force commanders and planners should be aware of the timeline for subordinates to plan. As a general rule when developing a planning timeline divide the time available into thirds and seek to utilize a third of the time available for their staff. The remaining two-thirds of the time should be preserved for subordinate planning. Commanders can publish updates in the OPORD, or following Fragmentary Orders (FRAGORDs), if the situation, timeline, or plan changes.

C2 and Command Relationships (COMREL). This deliverable should narratively identify required authorities (e.g., tactical control [TACON]) or support requirements (e.g., direct support) across the entire COA (and COA phases, if appropriate) to achieve the defined objectives and end state. A simple diagram may accompany the narrative C2 and COMREL. This deliverable forms the basis of the command, signal, and communications paragraph of the resulting order or plan, and where appropriate, informs Annex J of a HHQ CONOPS or plan.¹⁷

Required Capabilities and Support. This deliverable identifies the capabilities and support necessary including additional capabilities and support needed that the unit does not own or control. Higher level assistance may be required to leverage outside agencies or other Service interdependencies.¹⁸

Deployment and Sustainment Concept. This deliverable asks how planners envision "setting the force" and how logistics for sustainment should be performed.

COA Statement. This deliverable summarizes the who, what, when, where, why, and how, emphasizing the decisive action that is necessary to change the situation firmly in the commander's favor. The COA statement should provide details on how to accomplish the mission statement.

¹⁷ See JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*, for additional information.

¹⁸ This deliverable may inform paragraph four in order production or an additional annex in a plan.

CHAPTER 6: COURSE OF ACTION ANALYSIS AND WARGAMING

COA Analysis and Wargaming is a critical step of the AFPP, but it is often overlooked due to planners' inexperience and/or time mismanagement. Wargaming provides the opportunity for planners to analyze the problem to improve the COA(s). This step provides an opportunity to visualize the friendly COAs. It is the best opportunity to analyze COAs against threats to mission success and adversary capabilities before execution. Planners should seek to accomplish some degree of analysis or wargaming regardless of how simple the problem is. **Tabletop exercises focused on the most likely and most dangerous threat to mission success are best suited for use at the AETF and wing level.** Planners using the JPP and JPPA will focus on the adversary's most likely and most dangerous COAs.¹⁹

The Importance of Wargaming

Wargaming may be manually conducted or computer-assisted. Wing A-staffs and Airmen at all echelons may be limited to manual wargaming capabilities. AI and human-machine teaming may enhance future wargaming capabilities and allow for multiple iterations of the wargame in a compressed timeframe. Wargaming's value is underscored by the more than fifty wargame iterations conducted prior to the execution of Operation DESERT STORM. COA refinement is often necessary due to wargaming. Results from each iteration should be analyzed to enhance understanding of the problem, mission, and OE. The value of planning is greater than the plan itself.

Wargaming for non-operational problems. Wargaming is a recorded "what if" session of actions and reactions designed to visualize the flow of the conflict and evaluate each COA in light of the challenges posed by the problem and OE. The plan may not involve adversary forces per se, but all plans entail other factors, interdependencies, and threats or challenges to mission accomplishment. COA analysis and wargaming should be tailored to methodically evaluate these various considerations and their outcomes.

Planners should work with the commander to further define or refine the COA evaluation criteria during this step. Solidifying the evaluation criteria before wargaming enables planners to record the strengths and weaknesses of each air COA according to those criteria. Results from COA analysis and wargaming may require refinements of the air component design and air component approach.

COA ANALYSIS AND WARGAMING INPUTS

COA analysis and wargaming inputs include the COA development results, refined air component design, and a refined air component approach. Planners may need to review or identify COA evaluation criteria to conduct COA wargaming. Additionally, the staff

¹⁹ For additional information on most likely and most dangerous COAs see JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*.

should identify or confirm the wargame methodology that will be used for COA analysis and wargaming.

COA ANALYSIS AND WARGAMING ACTIVITIES

Like other steps, COA analysis and wargaming involve open and honest discussion framed around the problem at hand. COA analysis and wargaming apply to both non-combat and combat operations. It is a deliberate attempt to visualize the flow of the operation while focusing on CCIRs and decision points for the commander. If COA modification occurs during analysis or wargaming, ensure changes are reflected in relevant mission analysis documents. Finally, a modification in one COA may affect other COAs. A suggested method for advancing through COA Analysis and Wargaming is presented in the Wargaming Steps figure.

COA Analysis Steps

1. Prepare for COA Analysis and Wargaming.
2. Conduct Analysis and Wargaming, and Record Results.
3. Refine Selected COA (as required).
4. Report Results.

ANALYSIS STEP 1: PREPARE FOR COA ANALYSIS AND WARGAMING

The most important outcome of this step is to ensure that all materials are made available, and the game is set up and chosen to test the critical events, DPs, LOOs, LOEs, deliberate timeline analysis, and/or operational phasing. Other activities may include:

- ★ Gather tools, materials, and data.
- ★ Define or refine COA evaluation criteria.
- ★ List friendly forces and review friendly COAs.
- ★ List adversary forces and prepare adversary COAs.
- ★ List known critical events and decision points.
- ★ Determine wargame participants and roles.
- ★ Select wargame method (manual or computer-assisted).
- ★ Select a means to represent the operating area, force laydown, and moves.
- ★ Select a method to record and display wargame results.

The Action-Reaction-Counteraction Wargame Methodology

This method may use a dedicated Red Team to roleplay as the adversary against Blue COA(s). It is managed by a neutral wargame director, preferably one who has not participated in COA development activities. The Red Team can advise planners of potential implications associated with each COA, and help explore unintended consequences and likely second- and third-order effects of specific actions.

The wargame proceeds through a situation, action, reaction, and counteraction drill. Conduct each drill until the event being tested is adequately discussed or time is exhausted.

Situation

- ★ Facilitator provides an overview of the wargame describing the specific event to be wargamed along with beginning and ending criteria.
- ★ Red Team presents current disposition of forces IAW specified COA.
- ★ Blue Team presents current disposition of forces IAW specified COA.

Action

- ★ Starts with the initiating event (typically friendly action) and the full range of friendly force operations that comprise that action.

Reaction

- ★ The Red Team identifies the same scope of the adversary reaction.

Counteraction

- ★ Blue Team describes all areas of counteraction. The counteraction can begin the next sequence or a separate, new action can begin the sequence.
- ★ Consider risk assessments and mitigation efforts throughout the wargame.
- ★ Identify branches, sequels, and CCIRs.

NOTE: Wargamed events can and probably will occur simultaneously.

ANALYSIS STEP 2: CONDUCT ANALYSIS/WARGAMING AND RECORD RESULTS

There are many different methods to conduct wargaming. It is rare below the air component level to have access to computer-assisted wargaming. Most wargames can be accomplished or modified to a simple tabletop format. Key to this step is the accurate recording of the wargame results for COA refinement.

Wargaming does not have to be time intensive. When facing time or personnel constraints, focusing on specific elements of the plan or operation can greatly reduce the wargame's duration. A focused key leader discussion may also suffice for wargaming. When choosing what to wargame consider:

- ★ **Tabletop Exercises:** Walk through the plan with a focus on the most likely and most dangerous threat to mission success. The problem and the anticipated changes to the observed system should be discussed.
- ★ **Critical events:** Focus on specific critical events that encompass the essence of the COA or that address events of particular interest to the commander.
- ★ **Decision points:** An identified point in time or space that require a commander's decision. Available options for the commander, to select upon reaching the decision point, should be annotated. The DSM discussed in Chapter Two can be used for annotating DPs and potential adversary or enemy reactions.
- ★ **LOO/LOE method:** Wargame a specific LOO or LOE.
- ★ **Box method:** Wargame all actions within a discrete geographic area.
- ★ **Deliberate timeline analysis:** Wargame all actions within a discrete block of time.
- ★ **Operational phasing:** Phasing organizes an operation into manageable parts. A phase integrates and synchronizes related activities to improve unity of effort during executions. Use campaign or operation phasing as the framework to identify and analyze significant actions and requirements.

During the wargame ensure all relevant data is recorded for later COA refinement and modification. The following items are typically recorded and analyzed during COA analysis and wargaming:

- ★ Timing issues and time required for objectives.
- ★ Additional resources and effort for improvements.
- ★ Potential risks and mitigations.
- ★ COA strengths and weaknesses, especially those related to evaluation criteria.
- ★ Branch and sequel requirements.
- ★ Commander's DPs and CCIRs.

ANALYSIS STEP 3: REFINE OR MODIFY EACH COA

In this step, the results of the wargame are utilized to modify and refine each COA. Airmen are encouraged to review wargame outputs utilizing the seven joint functions as a framework to ensure alignment with the joint force.²⁰ Planners should recognize the possibility that a wargame result could invalidate a potential COA. In these cases, it is the responsibility of the planning team to be transparent about the result and consider removing the COA from further consideration.

²⁰ For additional information on the joint functions, see JP 3-0, *Campaigns and Operations*.

ANALYSIS STEP 4: REPORT RESULTS

If requested, reporting results provides the commander wargame results before COA comparison. If accomplished, results should address:

- ★ COAs wargamed against the most likely and most dangerous threats to mission success.
- ★ Key strengths and weaknesses.
- ★ Potential decision points identified and associated CCIRs.
- ★ Potential branches and sequels identified.
- ★ Key changes required and made to COAs.
- ★ Invalidated COAs identified by the wargame.
- ★ Refined Blue COAs and outstanding issues.
- ★ Wargame conclusions and recommendations.

COA ANALYSIS AND WARGAMING RESULTS

The results of wargaming are refined COAs, commander DPs, refined air component design, and notes on critical events. This helps inform the commander's decisions during execution.

Additionally, the detailed notes from the analysis and wargaming provide background information to interested parties about the advantages and disadvantages of the COAs.

CHAPTER 7: COURSE OF ACTION COMPARISON

The COA comparison step of the AFPP provides the commanders and staffs an opportunity to see how the developed COAs rate against previously approved evaluation criteria. **COAs are not initially evaluated against other COAs.** Rather, each COA is assessed independently against COA evaluation criteria, and selection criteria related to the commander's intent, and then compared to other COAs after independent assessments are complete. COA comparison facilitates the commander's decision-making process by considering the ends, ways, means, and risks associated with each COA.

COA COMPARISON INPUTS

Key to this step is the COA analysis and wargaming results, refined air component design, and a refined air component approach. Planners may need to review or identify the COA evaluation criteria and definitions to conduct the COA comparison. Additionally, the staff should identify or confirm the COA comparison method and potential weighting considerations.

COA COMPARISON ACTIVITIES

Planners should consider the guidance provided in the "COA Comparison Inputs and Outputs" figure prior to starting the step.

Whichever comparison method(s) are used, this step aids in determining which COA best suits the situation and commander's needs.²¹

Some of the COA comparison methods typically used to conduct comparison:

- ✧ Simple plus, minus, neutral assessments.
- ✧ Narrative qualitative comparisons of advantages and disadvantages.
- ✧ Numerically (weighted or not weighted) comparisons with multiple evaluation criteria.

²¹ For additional information on COA comparison methods, see JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*.

Example Numerical Comparison

		Course of Action					
		COA 1		COA 2		COA 3	
Criteria	Weight	Rating	Product	Rating	Product	Rating	Product
Exploits maneuver	2	3	6	2	4	1	2
Attacks COGs	3	2	6	3	9	1	3
Integrates maneuver and interdiction	2	2	4	3	6	1	2
Exploits deception	2	1	2	2	4	3	6
Provides flexibility	2	1	2	3	6	2	4
CSS (best use of transportation)	1	3	3	2	2	1	1
Total		12		15		9	
Weighted total			23		31		18

NOTE: The higher the number, the better.

- The joint force commander's intent explained that the most important criterion was "attacking the enemy's COGs." Therefore, assign a value of 3 for that criterion and lower numbers for other criteria that the staff devises (**this is the weighing criterion**).
- For attacking the enemy COGs, COA 2 was rated the best (with a number of 3). Therefore, COA 2 = 9, COA 1 = 6, and COA 3 = 3.
- After the relative COA **rating** is multiplied by the **weight** given each criterion and the product columns are added, COA 2 (with a score of 31) is rated the most appropriate according to the criteria used to evaluate it.

Legend

COA course of action

COG center of gravity

CSS combat service support

COA COMPARISON RESULTS

Results of COA comparison are individual COA advantages and disadvantages, COA discussion notes, COA recommendations, and staff recommend COAs. Air component design and approach should be refined if necessary.

CHAPTER 8: COURSE OF ACTION APPROVAL

During the AFPP COA approval step, the planning staff work together to develop and present COAs and a recommendation to the commander for approval. The COA decision briefing summarizes the work completed to develop, analyze, and compare COAs. Afterward, the commander may brief HHQ and receive their approval if the COA is part of a larger operation or campaign. The key to COA approval is the commander and planning staff combining their experience, knowledge, skill, and creativity to analyze the data and recommendations. The commander selects a COA from the confluence of adaptive thinking and air component design. A method for progressing through the COA approval step is presented in the “COA Approval Activities” figure.

COA APPROVAL INPUTS

COA approval should be informed by the COA analysis and wargaming results, refined air component design, and a refined air component approach. COA approval is driven by the cumulative AFPP effort.

COA APPROVAL ACTIVITIES

COA Approval Steps

1. Prepare the COA decision briefing.
2. Present the COA decision briefing.
3. Commander selects or modifies COA.
4. Refine selected COA (as required).
5. Prepare briefing, message, or commander’s estimate for HHQ Approval.

APPROVAL STEP 1: PREPARE THE COA DECISION BRIEFING

Tailor the brief to fit the commander’s level of understanding at the time of the brief. If the brief occurs shortly after the COA development brief, or if a wargame brief was given, the COA decision brief may be abbreviated.

APPROVAL STEP 2: PRESENT THE COA DECISION BRIEFING

Typically, the planning lead(s) brief the commander. Principal staff directors and division chiefs should attend. When necessary, capabilities or issues should be addressed at a higher classification level, including a supplemental briefing with appropriately cleared individuals in a suitable facility.

Sample COA Decision Brief Outline

The staff prepares a briefing to the commander providing the following (as applicable):

1. Purpose of the briefing.
2. Update of the OE.
 - a. Opposing situation:
 - i. Adversary order of battle/location and disposition (threats to mission success at the AETF and Wing level).
 - ii. Logistics-summary of ability to support operations.
 - iii. Time and space factors-capability to move to and reinforce initial positions.
 - iv. Combat capability-state of training, readiness, battle experience, physical condition, morale, leadership, motivation, tactical doctrine, discipline, and significant strengths and weaknesses.
 - v. Unknowns-intelligence gaps about the adversary or OE.
 - b. Friendly military situation-implications of other component requirements on air component operations (e.g., ISR, refueling).
 - c. Status of the operational area including infrastructure, geographic terrain, information environment, and social terrain.
3. HHQ commander's mission and intent statements.
4. Operational concepts and COAs developed.
 - a. Any changes from the mission analysis briefing regarding: Assumptions, limitations, adversary and friendly centers of gravity, phasing of the operation, LOOs, and LOEs.
 - b. COAs: COA name, COA statement, COA sketch, COA architecture. Major differences between COAs, and a summary of COAs.
 - i. COA Architecture: Task organization, COMREL, support requirements, additional authorities required, additional forces needed, organization of the operational area.
 - ii. COA Analysis Summary: Wargame results/evaluation criteria/comparison methodology/strengths and weakness of each COA

APPROVAL STEP 3: COMMANDER SELECTS OR MODIFIES COA

Following the COA decision briefing the commander may:

- ★ Concur with the recommendation as presented.
- ★ Select a different COA.

- ★ Direct modification (possibly combining elements of two or more COAs).
- ★ Direct development of additional COAs.
- ★ Request additional information or analysis prior to decision.
- ★ Direct that one of the COAs be used as the basis for a deception plan.
- ★ Direct that a briefing or message be prepared to present the COA to HHQ for approval.
- ★ Defer the decision and consult with selected staff and commanders.

APPROVAL STEP 4: REFINE SELECTED COA (AS REQUIRED)

The staff refines the selected COA in accordance with the commander's guidance and briefs the commander again if required.

APPROVAL STEP 5: PRESENT SELECTED COA FOR HHQ APPROVAL

When a selected COA is part of a HHQ operation or campaign plan, the staff may prepare a commander's estimate to accompany the recommended COA. The commander's estimate provides a concise, narrative statement of how the commander intends to accomplish the mission and provides the necessary focus for plan development. HHQ will use appropriate staffing and approval processes as well as other techniques to ensure plans remain synchronized with HHQ's concept, intent, and campaign plan. Being integrated and aware of HHQ planning can help ensure the commander's selected COA receives approval from the appropriate authority.

COA APPROVAL RESULTS

A COA approval decision that informs the development of a plan or order is the primary result of this step. The elements of air component design are still being refined at the end of COA approval.

CHAPTER 9: PLANS AND ORDERS DEVELOPMENT

The plans and orders development step of AFPP explains the basic steps of writing orders with a special focus on the paragraph format. Ultimately, the order type should convey the commander's intent and direction to their subordinate commanders. While explained in the context of the AFPP, the steps and guidance provided in the chapter apply to all JPP based planning processes. In addition, we discuss the emerging efforts of writing orders utilizing the mission type order (MTO) technique, which enables commanders to distribute control of specified operations and activities to subordinate commanders.

EFFECTIVE PLANS AND ORDERS

Effective plans and orders are simple and direct to reduce misunderstanding. Orders should be brief and clear so that the subordinate units can conduct operations in contested environments if necessary. The situation determines the degree of simplicity required since simple plans executed on time are typically better than detailed plans executed late. Commanders at all echelons weigh the potential benefits of a complex plan against the risk that subordinates may fail to understand it.

As such, the language is direct. An example of this is, "The palletized cargo remains in the assembly area" instead of "The palletized cargo will not accompany the unit." Effective plans and orders directly and positively state what the commander wants the unit and its subordinate units to accomplish and why.

Effective plans and orders are brief and clear. These plans use short words, sentences, and paragraphs. Plans use acronyms unless clarity is hindered. Brief and clear orders:

- ★ Use doctrinally correct terms and symbols.
- ★ Avoid jargon.
- ★ Use plain language when a doctrinal term is not available.
- ★ Eliminate every opportunity for misunderstanding the commander's intended direction.

PLANS AND ORDERS OVERVIEW

Administrative instructions and formats for preparing plans and orders can include:²²

Types of Plans. A plan is a design for a future or anticipated operation. Plans come in many forms, and they vary in scope, complexity, and duration.

Campaigning. Campaigning is the persistent conduct of related operations, activities, and investments that align military actions with the other instruments of national power, supporting global integration across the competition continuum in pursuit of strategic objectives. Campaign and contingency plans support national strategy.

²² See CJCSM 3130.03A, *Planning and Execution Formats and Guidance*, for additional information.

Campaign Plans. JFCs develop and execute campaign plans. Developing and issuing a campaign plan is appropriate when the contemplated simultaneous or sequential military operations exceed the scope of a single major operation. Contingency plans are branches of campaign plans, typically prepared in advance of an anticipated crisis, and they should be modified during execution. Campaign and contingency plans have four levels of details: commander's estimate, base plan (BPLAN), concept plan (CONPLAN), and operation plan (OPLAN). **Doctrinally there is no separate air campaign, rather the JFACC executes joint air operations in support of a JFC's or combatant commander's (CCDR's) campaign plan.**

A campaign is a series of related operations aimed at achieving strategic and operational objectives within a given time and space.²³ CCDRs develop campaigns to support the global campaign and shape the OE in a manner that supports those strategic objectives. They conduct their campaigns primarily through military engagement, operations, posture, and other activities that seek to achieve US national objectives, protect US national interests, and prevent the need to resort to armed conflict while setting conditions to transition to contingency operations if required.

Contingency Plans. Campaign plans establish conditions for contingency operations. Plans for contingencies and conflict are often branches of, or sequels to, base campaign plans. Contingency plans are developed during ongoing steady state conditions, employing the JPP to create one of the same four levels of detail as campaign plans: commander's estimate, BPLAN, CONPLAN, or OPLAN.

Planning during a crisis entails the positioning of forces, or at least the start of that process, often concurrent with early planning. Although existing plans may not align with an emerging crisis, those plans can often be modified for a specific situation to facilitate rapid COA development. Existing planning products for force execution and deployment, particularly TPFDD built for contingencies, can often be modified in time-constrained situations. Crisis planning produces joint OPORDs and other orders associated with the time-sensitive execution of operations.

Observations should be captured during planning and after every operation in the form of lessons learned. Absorbing lessons learned and adapting to them appropriately is critical to operational success. Events should be documented in detail to provide information that improves the planning and execution of future actions. Planners should review after-action reports and other lessons-learned analyses in preparation for the planning process. These reviews ensure planners benefit from prior experience and use what they learn to inform, adapt, and improve steady state, contingency, or crisis planning.

Types of Orders. An order is a communication, written, oral, or by signal, which conveys instructions from a superior to a subordinate. In the context of joint operational planning, some of the types of written orders are:

²³ For additional information on campaigning, see JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*.

- ★ Operation Order (OPORD).
- ★ Fragmentary Order (FRAGORD).
- ★ Planning Order (PLANORD).
- ★ Warning Order (WARNORD).
- ★ Tasking Order (TASKORD).

A Note of Caution on Orders Terminology

The terminology associated with an order has a very specific meaning when used in the joint environment under a CCDR. Commanders must have the appropriate authority to issue certain orders. The guidance provided in this document is associated with their use by a commander under a CCDR command relationship. Commanders should be aware of the guidance provided in CJCSM 3130.03A, Enclosure C when developing their orders both inside and outside of this structure to ensure that the order type is appropriate and does not exceed their authority.

An *OPORD* is a directive issued by a commander to subordinate commanders to affect the coordinated execution of a national command authority operation. Commander's issue OPORDs to direct the execution of long-term operations and the execution of discrete short-term operations within the framework of a long-range OPORD. This type of order can be issued at any echelon of command.

A *FRAGORD* is a modification to an existing order, and it is fragmented by only describing the changes, additions, deletions, and modifications. FRAGORDs differ from OPORDs in the degree of detail provided. This type of order can be issued at any echelon of command.

A *PLANORD* provides essential planning guidance to develop, adapt, or refine an existing plan due to emergent changes in the environment. A PLANORD must be issued by an appropriate commander.

A *TASKORD* is a direct task for subordinate unit execution that must be done as it is imposed by an appropriate authority.

A *WARNORD* is a preliminary notice of an order or action that is to follow. WARNORDs help subordinate units and staffs prepare for new missions by describing the situation, providing initial planning guidance, and directing preparation activities. A WARNORD must be issued by an appropriate commander.²⁴

²⁴ See CJCSM 3130.03A, *Planning and Execution Formats and Guidance*, for additional information.

In addition to OPORDs, FRAGORDs, PLANORDs, and WARNORDs, USAF forces may receive the following types of orders from a joint HQ:

- ★ Alert order.
- ★ Execute order.
- ★ Prepare-to-deploy order.
- ★ Deployment order.
- ★ Redeployment order.

PLANS AND ORDERS DEVELOPMENT INPUTS

The COA approval results, refined air component design, and a refined air component approach, informs the creation of plans and orders. Information from the cumulative AFPP effort can aid in plan or order creation.

PLANS AND ORDERS DEVELOPMENT ACTIVITIES

This section outlines the basic steps for the creation of a five-paragraph order. Not all orders follow the five-paragraph format (e.g., air tasking orders and airspace control orders). However, the five-paragraph form is the Department of Defense (DoD) standard used by the joint staff and unified commands. The USAF has a modified five-paragraph order format as seen in AFDP 1-1, *Mission Command*, and in the figure. For additional information see attached Appendix A, “Plans and Order Formats,” and Appendix E, “Example Modified Five-Paragraph Order.”

If the planning processes have been followed, writing, and assembling the plan or order should not be difficult. Most of the information needed has already been discussed and refined in previous steps of the AFPP. The administrative tasks required to physically produce and synchronize the plan, or order should consume most of the time. The “Orders Development Steps” figure provides a general guide for orders creation.

**USAF Modified
Five-Paragraph Order
Format (JP 5-0)**

- 1. Situation**
- 2. Mission**
- 3. Execution**
- 4. Force Sustainment**
- 5. Command, Signal
and Communications**

Orders Development Steps

1. Develop base paragraphs:
 - a. Review approved information, products, guidance, etc.
 - b. Finalize intent statement and CONOPS.
 - c. Assign production tasks.
 - d. Synchronize with parallel and supporting plans and orders.
2. Publish base order or plan.
3. Develop appropriate annexes.
4. Issue FRAGORDs to disseminate annexes and updates (as required).

ORDERS STEP 1: DEVELOP BASE PARAGRAPHS

Paragraph 1: Situation. The situation paragraph describes the OE including areas of interest and the geographically defined area of operations. The planning work completed to understand the OE provides information for completing this paragraph. Additionally, assumptions the commander and staff made about the mission and problem are captured in the situation paragraph. The other sub-paragraphs within the situation paragraph are the adversary and friendly components. Both sub-paragraphs are intended to describe for the reader the composition, disposition, and strength of the forces and describe how the adversary is expected to employ their capabilities. In the friendly sub-paragraph, the mission and intent of commanders of higher echelon commanders are included so the subordinates can clearly understand how the nesting of tasks, purposes, and missions are related to unity of effort.

Paragraph 2: Mission Statement. The mission statement paragraph is solely comprised of the mission statement. The mission statement is developed during mission analysis and refined once a COA is chosen. The five elements of a mission statement answer these questions:

- ★ Who will execute the operation (unit or organization)?
- ★ What is the unit's essential task (normally a tactical mission task or tactical enabling task)?
- ★ Where will the operation occur (assigned area, objective, engagement areas, or grid coordinates)?
- ★ When will the operation begin (by time or event)?
- ★ Why will the force conduct the operation (for what purpose)?

Paragraph 3: Execution. The execution paragraph describes the commander's approach to achieving mission success-the "how" of an operation. It begins with the commander's intent and CONOPS and continues with tasks directed to subordinate units.

These tasks identify which subordinate force is the main effort for the operation and what forces are supporting, shaping, or sustaining elements to execute the scheme of movement and maneuver that result in mission accomplishment. The execution paragraph includes prioritized tasks. Lastly, the execution paragraph includes coordinating instructions that are specified tasks applicable to all forces. Coordinating instructions usually include constraints and restraints, commander's critical information requirements, and other information that is common to all subordinates and not stated in unit SOP.

★ **Commander's Intent Statement.** The commander's intent statement is developed through the planning process. In the order writing process, the commander's intent statement is refined into a clear and concise statement that frames the operation's purpose, desired end state, and risk. It remains nested within higher echelon commander's intent and guidance with an awareness of the larger operational and strategic context. The intent includes purpose, end state, and risk the commander is willing to accept. An intent statement may also include method and mission essential tasks.

★ **CONOPS.** The CONOPS is a statement that directs the way subordinate units cooperate to accomplish the mission and establishes the sequence of actions the force uses to achieve the end state. In the CONOPS, the commander describes how the actions of subordinate units fit together to accomplish the overall mission (essential task and purpose) within the assigned area. Commanders and their staffs describe the CONOPS by defining time, space, and resources.

Time refers to the sequencing and synchronization of tasks or operations to attain end state conditions with the least cost in personnel and resources.

Space refers to the establishment of an assigned area: AO, zones, and sectors.

Resources refer to designating the priority and allocation of resourcing based on the assignment of the main effort, supporting efforts, and reserves.

The CONOPS also includes:

- ★ The central approach the commander intends to accomplish the mission.
- ★ Provides for the integration, synchronization, and sequencing of time, space, forces, and resources.
- ★ Provides for the tempo of the operation.
- ★ Relates and nests the objectives and effects to those of the higher commander.

In developing the CONOPS, commanders and staff ensure their concept nests with that of their HHQ. Nesting a concept is a planning technique to achieve unity of purpose whereby each succeeding echelon's CONOPS are aligned by purpose with the higher echelons' CONOPS. An effective CONOPS describes how the forces support a mission of the HHQ and how the actions of subordinate units fit together to accomplish a mission.

Paragraph 4: Force Sustainment. Force sustainment describes all required aspects of sustaining the force during an operation (typically broken down into individual phases of the operation). It includes a description of the quantities of all classes of supply, where they are, and what the resupply plan is across the area of operations. It gives an estimate of resupply rates based on forecasted consumption. The paragraph may also include the concept for maintenance (preventative, repair, and replacement) of key pieces of equipment. Time and quantity requirements should be primary planning factors. It should cover functional areas of logistics, transportation, personnel policies, maintenance, health services, and administration.

- ★ **Logistics.** This paragraph addresses the commander's logistics priorities and intent: basing, combat, general, and geospatial engineering requirements, required contracted support, and environmental considerations. Identify the priority and movement of logistic support for each option and phase of the concept.
- ★ **Personnel.** Identify detailed planning requirements and subordinate taskings. Assign tasks for establishing and operating personnel facilities, managing accurate and timely personnel accountability and strength reporting, and making provisions for staffing them. Discuss the administrative management of participating personnel. Refer to annex E (if published).

Paragraph 5: Command, Signal, and Communications. The purpose of this section is to summarize command arrangements and their respective roles and responsibilities. The section identifies changes to major C2 organizations, the commander's battle rhythm, and the staff's expected duty hours. The locations of headquarters and command posts should be annotated. Additionally, this section discusses the scope of communications systems and procedures required to support the mission. The procedures should detail a primary, alternate, contingency, and emergency (PACE) plan for an organization's internal and external communications.

- ★ **Command.** Include a designation of supported and supporting commanders, coordination instructions, and a listing of the command relationship's organizational structure, expected to exist in support of mission execution. This section describes the location(s) of the command and subordinate commands as well as alternate HQ locations. Additionally, COMREL should be detailed in this section along with the plan for succession of command.
- ★ **Signal and communications.** This section describes the means of communication equipment for the force, (e.g., voice, digital, satellite communications, mesh networks, common operating picture, etc.) and usually defines any shortfalls in communications equipment requirements for the force to operate. It prioritizes the ways communication is conducted during the operation through a PACE plan. The purpose of a good PACE plan is to establish redundancy so that communications are always available. Most units have two PACE plans: one for communications to HHQ and one for subordinate units. A PACE plan for a HHQ is likely established by the HHQ.

ORDERS STEP 2: PUBLISH BASE ORDER

Due to the time involved in creating detailed annexes and appendices, the commander approves, and the staff publishes the base order (five-paragraphs) as soon as possible to allow subordinate units to begin subsequent planning and preparation. Updates to the base order can be published in a FRAGORD on their own or with the annexes developed in step 3. If annexes are intentionally omitted with no plan for further development indicate this on the order.

ORDERS STEP 3: DEVELOP APPROPRIATE ANNEXES

Orders at echelons below the AETF do not normally have annexes. However, the more complex an operation becomes and/or the greater the number of capabilities involved, the greater the need for the detail provided in annexes. In these circumstances, the key to the success of a good order is well-written annexes, appendices, tabs, and exhibits further detailing concepts or subjects that do not need to be specified in the main paragraphs of the order.

Commanders and staffs are not required to develop any or all the annexes listed below. The number and type depend on the commander, echelon of command, and needs of a particular operation. Minimizing the number of annexes keeps the order consistent with completeness and clarity. If the information relating to an annex's subject is brief, the order writer places the information in the base order and omits the annex. Staffs list annexes under an appropriate heading at the end of the document they expand. For example, they list annexes at the end of the base order, appendices at the end of annexes, and so forth.

When an annex is not required, staffs indicate this by stating "omitted." For example, the order writer would state, "Annex R (Reports) omitted." If the situation requires an additional annex not shown below, leaders can add to this structure.

Amplify information in annexes where necessary by appendices to annexes, tabs to appendices, and exhibits to tabs. Ensure annexes, appendices, and associated pieces comply with the general sequential structure outlined in CJCSM 3130.03A, *Planning and Execution Formats and Guidance*. Use only those annexes appropriate to the order. At lower echelons, annexes are typically only used when the BPLAN is limited by classification or level of detail. Following is a list of the annexes and examples of their content. **Do not change or reorder annex numbers.**

A: TASK ORGANIZATION.

- ★ Time-phased Force and Deployment List.
- ★ Shortfall identification.

B: INTELLIGENCE.

- ★ Commander's PIRs and supporting information requirements provide an overall picture of intelligence support to operations.

C: OPERATIONS.

- ★ Appendices address various aspects (e.g., personnel recovery, ROE, etc.).

D: LOGISTICS.

- ★ Broad sustainment and logistics concepts that support operations, synchronized with operations and phases for joint forces over which the commander exercises TACON (e.g., fuels management, subsistence, mortuary affairs, mobility, transportation).

E: PERSONNEL.

- ★ Personnel matters and other support (e.g., personnel processing, legal, postal).

F: PUBLIC AFFAIRS.

- ★ Broad public affairs concepts that support all operations, and the broad public affairs plan synchronized with operations phases.

G: CIVIL-MILITARY OPERATIONS.

- ★ Considerations for military interaction with governmental and non-governmental agencies, multinational forces, and other interorganizational partners.

H: METEOROLOGICAL AND OCEANOGRAPHIC OPERATIONS.

- ★ Broad weather factors affect all commander tasked operations.

I: KNOWLEDGE AND INFORMATION MANAGEMENT.

- ★ Knowledge management (KM) roles responsibilities, KM plan, and collaborative tools.
- ★ Preventive measures taken to mitigate hostile actions against DoD personnel (including family members), resources, facilities, and critical information.

J: COMMAND RELATIONSHIPS.

- ★ C2.
- ★ Command considerations.
- ★ Command relationships.
- ★ Memorandum of understanding (MOU).
- ★ Designation and location of all air-capable command HQ.
- ★ Continuity of operations (COOP) and degraded operations.
- ★ Command, control, and communications considerations.

K: COMMAND, CONTROL, COMMUNICATIONS, COMPUTERS, AND INTELLIGENCE (C4I) SYSTEMS.

- ★ General overview of C4I systems and procedures required to support air operations (e.g., cybersecurity, satellite communications).

L: ENVIRONMENTAL CONSIDERATIONS.

- ★ May contain geospatial information and services.
- ★ Broad geospatial factors affect all commander tasked operations.

N: ASSESSMENTS.

- ★ Commander-specific assessment plan and metrics.

P: HOST-NATION AGREEMENT.

- ★ HNA reliability, presumed support.

Q: HEALTH SERVICES.

- ★ Patient movement, hospitalization, etc.

S: SPECIAL TECHNICAL OPERATIONS (STO).

- ★ Air component guidance based on HHQ Annex S, “Integrated Joint Special Technical Operations” that informs COMAFFOR logistics, employment, assessment, and consequence management of Service-provided STO capabilities, as required.

T: CHEMICAL, BIOLOGICAL, RADIOLOGICAL, AND NUCLEAR (CBRN) RESPONSE.

- ★ Consequence management and CBRN response could be addressed within Annex C.

V: INTERAGENCY-INTERORGANIZATIONAL COORDINATION.

- ★ Interaction and collaboration with other government departments, and nongovernmental, private, and international entities.
- ★ Interagency synchronization matrix.

W: OPERATIONAL CONTRACT SUPPORT.

- ★ Contracted support requirements estimate and contractor management plan.

Y: COMMANDER’S COMMUNICATIONS STRATEGY.

- ★ Messages and themes to promote or avoid with the target audience.

ORDERS STEP 4: PUBLISH ANNEXES AND SUPPLEMENTAL GUIDANCE AS FRAGORDS

This step publishes and disseminates FRAGORDs for any remaining annexes or to update the base order or plan. This process occurs continually to meet evolving situations and changes in the OE. Receiving subordinate elements should actively confirm receipt of orders, plans, and annexes.

PLANS AND ORDERS DEVELOPMENT RESULTS

Plans and orders development results in a plan or order that communicates the commander's direction and intent. The plan or order should be clearly written in the five-paragraph format. The plan, order, and air component approach may require refinement as the problem, observed system, and desired system change.

MISSION-TYPE ORDER TECHNIQUE

Utilizing the MTO technique is a direct enabler of mission command. Commanders can use the MTO technique to distribute control of specified operations and activities to subordinate commanders in contested, degraded, and operationally limited environments. Alternatively, commanders can provide very detailed and specific orders to subordinates. Orders should provide subordinate commanders with clear intent, a shared understanding of an operation's purpose, and visibility of the wider operational and strategic context. MTO styled orders enable subordinate commanders to exercise flexibility and creativity during C2 activities to meet the changes in the OE and exploitation of emergent opportunities.²⁵ MTO is a technique for writing orders that provides latitude for flexibility in execution while meeting the commander's intent. Not every order utilizes the MTO technique, but the process for orders production does not change based on the technique, only the level of detailed direction contained in the order.

Operating Under MTOs

Capacity is a measure or degree to which an individual or organization is able, has the potential, or has demonstrated the ability to operate according to the principles of mission command. Units or individuals who have trained to and demonstrated an embodiment of the attributes of mission command and practice its principles consistently are able to operate with minimal guidance while still achieving the commander's intent. The MTO technique for writing orders is the USAF's preferred method. Airmen and USAF units should strive to maximize their capacity to ensure the effectiveness of the MTOs.

–AFDP 1-1, *Mission Command*

²⁵ For additional information on C2 activities, see AFDP 3-0.1, *Command and Control*.

Under the mission command philosophy, the MTO technique focuses on giving and creating orders centered on the purpose of the operation rather than details of how to perform assigned tasks. Commanders should utilize the MTO technique by writing orders that delegate decisions and empower subordinate initiative to make decisions based on the commander's guidance rather than constant communications. Subordinates' understanding of the commander's intent (spelled out in paragraph 3a of orders) at every level of command is essential to execution under the mission command philosophy.

Orders written using the MTO technique are as brief and simple as possible. MTO styled orders clearly convey the unit's mission and commander's intent. They summarize the situation (including observed system or anticipated starting conditions), describe the operation's end state, and may provide a CONOPS to accomplish the unit's mission. When assigning tasks to subordinate units, MTOs include all components of a mission statement: who, what, when, where, and why. However, commanders particularly emphasize the purpose (what and why) of the tasks to guide disciplined initiative.

MTOs contain the proper level of detail, they are neither so detailed that they stifle initiative nor so general that they provide insufficient direction. The proper level depends on each situation, and it is not easy to determine. Some phases, and types, of operations require tighter control over subordinate elements than others. A phase of an operation involving an air assault, for example, may require precise synchronization and guidance. On a similar note, nuclear operations are an example of a type of operation that often requires specific guidance for effective execution.²⁶

²⁶ As a rule, the base order contains only the specific information required to guide while allowing subordinates as much freedom of action as possible. Attachments to the plan or order contain details regarding the situation and instructions necessary for synchronization.

APPENDIX A: PLANS AND ORDERS FORMATS

PARAGRAPH FORMAT

Regardless of echelon, order writers show the main five-paragraph headings on written orders. There are several different types of orders and plans discussed in this publication. **Orders and plans should be written according to the Chairman of the Joint Chief's of Staff directive guidance to the maximum extent possible.**²⁷

The example modified five-paragraph order provided in Appendix E is aligned with the USAF modified order format in AFDP 1-1, *Mission Command*.

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

Order writers use acronyms and abbreviations to save time and space if these acronyms and abbreviations do not cause confusion. However, order writers should not sacrifice clarity for brevity. Order writers keep acronyms and abbreviations consistent throughout the order and its attachments. They avoid using acronyms and abbreviations not found in the *Air Force Glossary* or the *DoD Dictionary of Military and Associated Terms*. Before using an acronym or abbreviation, at its first use in the document, order writers spell out the acronym or abbreviation and then place the acronym or abbreviation between parentheses immediately after the term. After this first use, they use the acronym or abbreviation throughout the document.

LOCATION AND DIRECTION DESIGNATIONS

Location and direction designations are important in orders. Order writers describe locations or points on the ground by:

- ★ Providing the map datum used throughout the order.
- ★ Referring to military grid reference system coordinates.
- ★ Referring to longitude and latitude if available maps do not have the military grid reference system.
- ★ Order writers designate directions in one of two ways:
 - ★★ As a point of the compass (for example, north or northeast).
 - ★★ As a magnetic, grid, or true bearing, stating the unit of measure (for example, 85 degrees [magnetic]).

When first mentioning a place or feature on a map, order writers print the name in capital letters exactly as spelled on the map and show its complete grid coordinates (grid zone designator, 100-kilometer grid square, and four-, six-, eight-, or ten-digit grid coordinates) in parentheses after it. When first using a control measure, such as a contact point or a phase line, order writers print the name or designation of the control measure in capital

²⁷ See CJCSM 3130.03A, *Planning and Execution Formats and Guidance*, for additional information.

letters followed by its complete grid coordinates in parentheses. Thereafter, they repeat the coordinates only for clarity.

Order writers describe areas by naming the northernmost (1200) point first and the remaining points in clockwise order. They describe positions from left to right and from front to rear, facing the enemy. To avoid confusion, order writers identify flanks by compass directions, rather than right or left of the friendly force.

If the possibility of confusion exists when describing a route, order writers add a compass direction for clarity (for example, “The route is northwest along the road LAPRAIRIE-DELSON.”). If a particular route already has a planning name, such as the main supply route LION, order writers refer to the route using only that designator.

Order writers designate trails, roads, and railroads by the names of places along them or with grid coordinates. They precede place names with a trail, road, or railroad (for example, “road GRANT-CODY”). Order writers designate the route for a movement by listing a sequence of grids from the start point to the release point. Otherwise, they list the sequence of points from left to right or front to rear, facing the enemy.

Order writers identify riverbanks as north, south, east, or west. In wet gap-crossing operations, they identify riverbanks as either near or far.

NAMING CONVENTIONS

Unit SOP normally designates naming conventions for graphics (for example, assembly areas, phase lines, and objectives). Otherwise, planners select them. For clarity, order writers avoid multiword names, such as “JUNCTION CITY.” Simple names are better than complex ones. To ensure operations security, order writers avoid assigning names that could reveal unit identities, such as the commander’s name or the unit’s home station. They do not name sequential phase lines and objectives in alphabetical order. For memory aids, order writers use sets of names designated by the type of control measure or subordinate unit. For example, a division order might use colors for objective names and minerals for phase line names.

CLASSIFICATION MARKINGS

Classification marking for orders and plans follows DoDM 5200.01 Volume 2 *Marking of Information*, DoDI 5200.48, *Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI)*, and applicable security classification guides.

EXPRESSING UNNAMED DATES AND HOURS

Order writers use specific letters to designate unnamed dates and times in plans and orders. Joint doctrine lists common letters for dates and times as shown in the below table.

Term	Designates
<i>C-day</i>	The unnamed day on which a deployment operation commences or is to commence (JP 5-0).
<i>D-day</i>	The unnamed day on which a particular operation commences or is to commence (JP 3-02).
<i>H-hour</i>	The specific hour on D-day at which a particular operation commences (JP 5-0).
<i>L-hour</i>	The specific hour on C-day at which a deployment operation commences or is to commence (JP 5-0).
<i>P-hour</i>	The specific hour on D-day at which a parachute assault commences with the exit of the first Soldier from an aircraft over a designated drop zone. P-hour may or may not coincide with H-hour planning horizon.

Designated letters for dates and times

EXPRESSING TIME

USAF orders express all times in a plan or order in the ZULU time zone (universal time coordinate). Local time should not be used due to the nature of USAF operations which often span multiple time zones.

The effective time for implementing a plan or order is the same as the date-time group of the order. Order writers express the date and time as a six-digit date-time group. The first two digits indicate the day of the month, the next four digits indicate the time. The letter at the end of the time indicates the time zone. Staffs add the month and year to the date-time group to avoid confusion. For example, a complete date-time group for 6 August 2025 at 1145Z appears as “061145Z August 2025”.

If the effective time of any portion of the order differs from that of the order, staffs identify those portions at the beginning of the coordinating instructions (paragraph 3). For example, order writers may use “Effective only for planning on receipt” or “Task organization effective 261300Z May 2025.”

When using inclusive dates, staffs express them by writing both dates separated by a dash (for example, 6-9 August 2025 or 6 August-6 September 2025). They express times in the 24-hour clock system using four-digit Arabic numbers, including the ZULU time zone indicator.

IDENTIFYING PAGES

Staffs identify pages following the first page of plans and orders with a short title identification heading located two spaces under the classification marking. They include the number (or letter) designation of the plan and the issuing HQ. For example, OPLAN 00-15-9AETF-A (U) or Annex B (Intelligence) to OPLAN 00-15-23rd AD (U). (In this case, AETF-A stands for Air Expeditionary Task Force Afghanistan.)

NUMBERING PAGES

Order writers number the pages of the base order and each attachment separately beginning on the first page of each attachment. They use a combination of alphanumeric designations to identify each attachment.

Order writers use Arabic numerals only to indicate page numbers. They place page numbers after the alphanumeric designation that identifies the attachment. They use Arabic numerals without any proceeding alphanumeric designation for base order page numbers. For example, the designation of the third page of Annex C is C-3. Order writers assign each attachment either a letter or Arabic numeral that corresponds to the letter or number in the attachment's short title. They assign letters to annexes, Arabic numerals to appendices, letters to tabs, and Arabic numerals to exhibits. For example, the designation of the third page of Appendix 5 to Annex C is C-5-3.

Order writers separate elements of the alphanumeric designation with hyphens. For example, the designation of the third page of Exhibit 2 to Tab B to Appendix 5 to Annex C is C-5-B-2-3.

ATTACHMENTS

Attachments (annexes, appendices, tabs, and exhibits) are information management tools that expand on the BPLAN or order. However, even when attachments are used, an effective base order contains enough information to be executed without them.

Staffs refer to attachments by letter or number and title. They use the following naming conventions:

ANNEXES. Staffs designate annexes with capital letters, for example, Annex D (Fires) to OPOD 19-06—9AETF-A.

APPENDICES. Staffs designate appendices with Arabic numbers, for example, Appendix 1 (Intelligence Estimate) to Annex B (Intelligence) to OPOD 19-06-9AETF-A.

TABS. Staffs designate tabs with capital letters, for example, Tab B (Target Synchronization Matrix) to Appendix 3 (Targeting) to Annex D (Fires) to OPOD 19-06-9AETF-A.

EXHIBITS. Staffs designate exhibits with Arabic numbers, for example, Exhibit 1 (Traffic Circulation and Control) to Tab C (Transportation) to Appendix 1 (Logistics) to Annex F (Sustainment) to OPOD 19-06-1 9AETF-A.

If an attachment has a wider distribution than the base order or is issued separately, the attachment requires a complete heading and acknowledgment instructions. When staffs distribute attachments with the base order, these elements are not required.

APPENDIX B: CENTER OF GRAVITY ANALYSIS METHODS

COGS AND LINES OF EFFORT

A practical means of linking objectives, effects, tasks, and actions is through COG analysis and designing lines of effort. **COG identification and analysis is often completed at an operational level HQs.** A COG is the “source of power that provides moral or physical strength, freedom of action, or a will to act.”²⁸ COG analysis should reveal what is critical and relate what is critical to what is vulnerable. Critical vulnerabilities may be attacked, exploited, or protected to decisively affect the enemy and enable friendly action. Analysis of a COG’s critical factors generally yields DPs, which are key terrain, key events, critical factors, or functions that, when acted upon, enable a commander to gain a marked advantage over an enemy. A COG analysis may reveal vulnerabilities for countering an enemy kill chain.

Counter Kill Chain

Advancements in adversary anti-access, area denial capabilities greatly expand the range and lethality of adversary kill chains. These enhanced lethal kill chains limit friendly freedom of action and raise the risk to mission while making achievement of the JFC’s objectives more difficult. Minimizing adversary enhanced denial capabilities and achieving intended friendly effects in the OE has elevated the need to counter adversary kill chains.

To attack friendly forces, an adversary must complete a sequence of actions to implement their kill chain. They must detect friendly forces, communicate via command-and-control networks, decide on engagement options, and then employ fires. Exploiting vulnerabilities in every step of this sequence through joint all domain operations can counter these kill chains. Electromagnetic attacks can disrupt and degrade adversary detection systems. Offensive cyberspace operations can disable communication networks. Long-range fires can destroy C2 nodes. Agile combat employment can defeat adversary targeting and fires employment.

BL: Joint operations leveraging all domains can counter adversary kill chains to generate desired effects, achieve the joint force commander’s objectives, and attain the desired end state.

During design and planning, it is helpful to have a tool that depicts the relationship of effects to COGs, DPs, objectives, and other events and concepts, using the logic of purpose- cause and effect. Such a tool is usually arranged in proper time sequence to

²⁸ See JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*, for additional information.

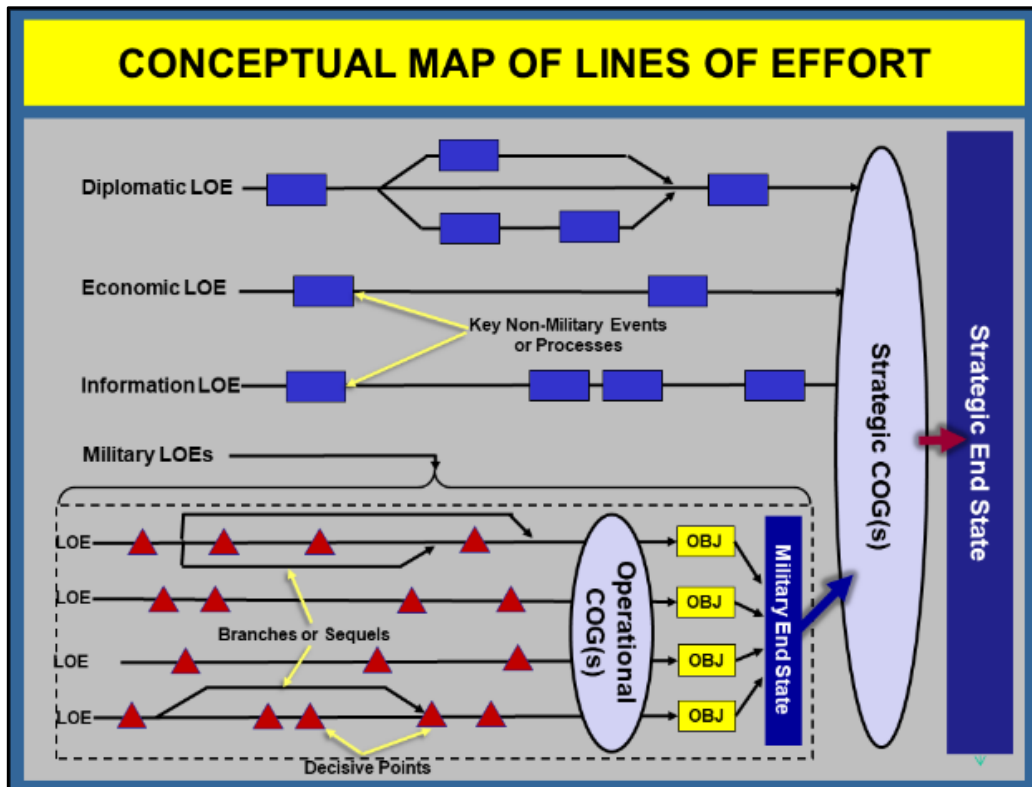
help commanders and strategists visualize how operations evolve and interact over time. LOEs provide just such a tool.

LOEs help visualize COAs, laying them out in time sequence and helping identify where certain effects should be created and where DPs are located in time relative to other events. LOEs are useful when working with interagency and multinational partners, helping commanders and strategists visualize how military means can support all instruments of national and multinational power. The aggregate of the effects of all instruments of power acting together forms a series of LOEs leading directly to the strategic end state. Each LOE can be broken down into constituent objectives, DPs, effects, and actions or tasks. LOEs contribute to accomplishing objectives in other LOEs and may define DPs.

Each LOE can be refined further by including tactical-level objectives, effects, and individual tactical tasks. Given sufficiently sophisticated planning tools, each organization's tasks could be shown as LOEs. Regardless of whether each task is so depicted, it can be useful for each tasked organization to understand how its assigned task contributes to the overall end state. This can aid in understanding the cross-domain effects of given actions. See the figure, "Conceptual Map of Lines of Effort" to visualize LOEs.²⁹

Analyzing COGs provides a means of focusing friendly efforts, both offensively and defensively. There are several tools and techniques available to identify and analyze COGs. Joint doctrine (JP 5-0, Chapter IV) presents one model, but there are others, each with its assumptions, strengths, and weaknesses. All, however, attempt to relate what is critical to what is vulnerable in some helpful way-to identify and prioritize critical, targetable vulnerabilities. Each of the common methods is examined below, with a summary discussing the strengths and weaknesses of each.

²⁹ For additional information on COG analysis and LOEs, see JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*.



Caution: In the same sentence in which he first described a “center of gravity,” Clausewitz made it clear that it was only a metaphor, a picture to help understand the “main thing.”³⁰ The COG analysis techniques—even using COG as an acronym—highlight the extent to which military planning can uncritically employ shortcuts. The process of COG analysis may also lead to a mental image of a static adversary or enemy. The best correction for this oversimplification is to study the opponent thoroughly. Respect that the opponent is capable and willing to fight wherever possible. Accept that the opponent could be employing a strategy that we may find hard to understand. Addressing these challenges can be aided by using red teams.

All models have in common that any COG a commander chooses to affect should always be linked to one or more objectives. If the objective changes, the COG may also change. At the strategic level, a COG could be one or a set of leaders (political or military), an alliance, a military force, critical functions, or national will. A COG is often associated with an adversary’s or enemy’s military capabilities at the operational level, such as a powerful element of the armed forces. Still, it could also include other capabilities in the OE. COGs can emerge or change over time due to the interplay of friendly, hostile, and other forces in the OE. They may be based on the end state, mission, objectives, and the opponent’s strategy.

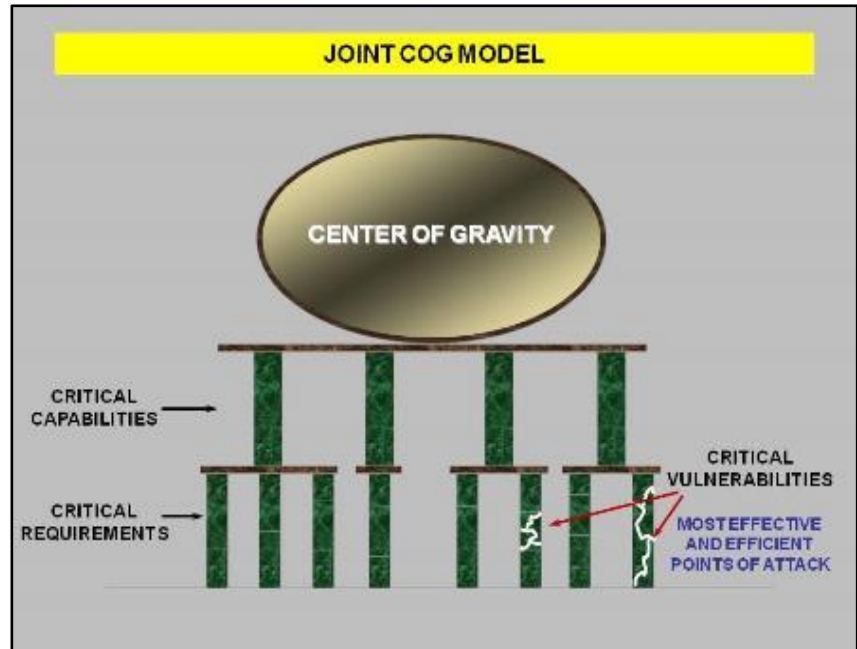
COG analysis occurs as part of JIPOE, mission analysis, or both. Commanders should consider the opponent’s COGs and identify and protect their COGs. Effects-based

³⁰ See Clausewitz, *On War*, for additional information.

approach to operations should orient on creating effects in time and space that decisively affect a COG.

THE JOINT MODEL

The model endorsed in joint doctrine is also known as the Marine Corps model, the “CG-CC-CR-CV Model,” and the “Strange Model,” for its developer, Dr. Joe Strange of the Marine Corps War College. This model uses the abbreviation “CG” for the center of gravity. For all purposes, “CG” and “COG” should be considered synonymous.³¹ This model is depicted in the figure “Joint COG Model,” and an example of its application is given in the figure “Joint COG Model Example (World War II).”



Description. This model starts with the joint definition of a COG as a source of strength, freedom of action, or the will to act. It then analyzes the COG to determine (in order) its:

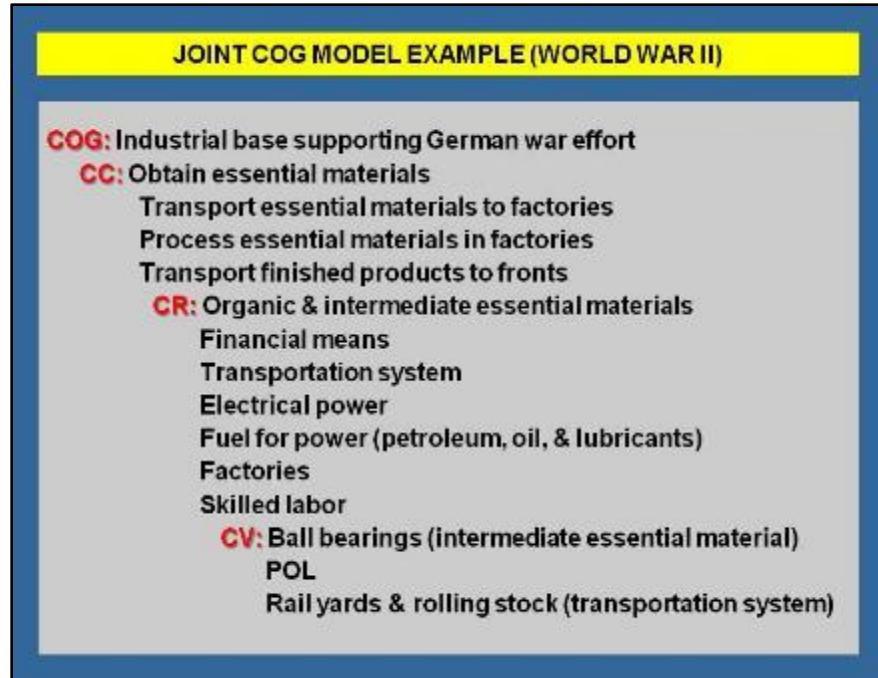
- ★ **Critical capabilities (CCs):** those means that are considered crucial enablers for a COG to function as such (and are essential to the accomplishment of the specified or implied objectives).
- ★ **Critical requirements (CRs):** essential conditions, resources, or means for a CC to be fully operational.
- ★ **Critical vulnerabilities** CRs, or components thereof, are deficient or vulnerable to attack (or other effects) that create decisive or significant effects on the COG.

COGs are nouns-tangible or intangible sources of power. CC can be thought of as verbs-things a COG *does*. CRs are nouns-those *things* a critical capability needs to function as such. CVs are those CR that are vulnerable.

Advantages. This is an intellectually thorough manner of analyzing COGs. It relates critical elements to vulnerabilities via a logical causal chain. It has been endorsed in joint doctrine and is taught in some form in most if not all, Service schools.

³¹ See Dr Joseph Strange, *Centers of Gravity and Critical Vulnerabilities: Building on the Clausewitzian Foundation So That We Can All Speak the Same Language*, for additional information.

Disadvantages. This method can be difficult to “operationalize”-to work through intellectually so that it yields actionable tasks and targets. Effective application of this approach requires a comprehensive and detailed understanding of a competitor’s systems. Doing it properly thus takes time. This model has significant power, but analysts may sometimes find it challenging to derive valid CC or properly determine



vulnerabilities from requirements. Experience has shown that these are the most common points when the model breaks down. As a result, analysts should use care and understand the system they are analyzing. This method also tends to be more labor-and information-intensive than other models.

THE STRATEGIC RING MODEL

This model is also known as the “five-rings model” and as “Warden’s Rings,” after its developer, Col (Ret) John A. Warden III.³²

Description. The basic structure of this model is not of COGs, per se, but of characteristics common to all living organisms. This is depicted in “The Strategic Ring COG Model.” It posits that there are one or more COGs within each ring of the systems, it is thus a straightforward systems analysis tool as much as it is a tool for COG analysis.

The model maintains that there are certain functions necessary for every system to function:

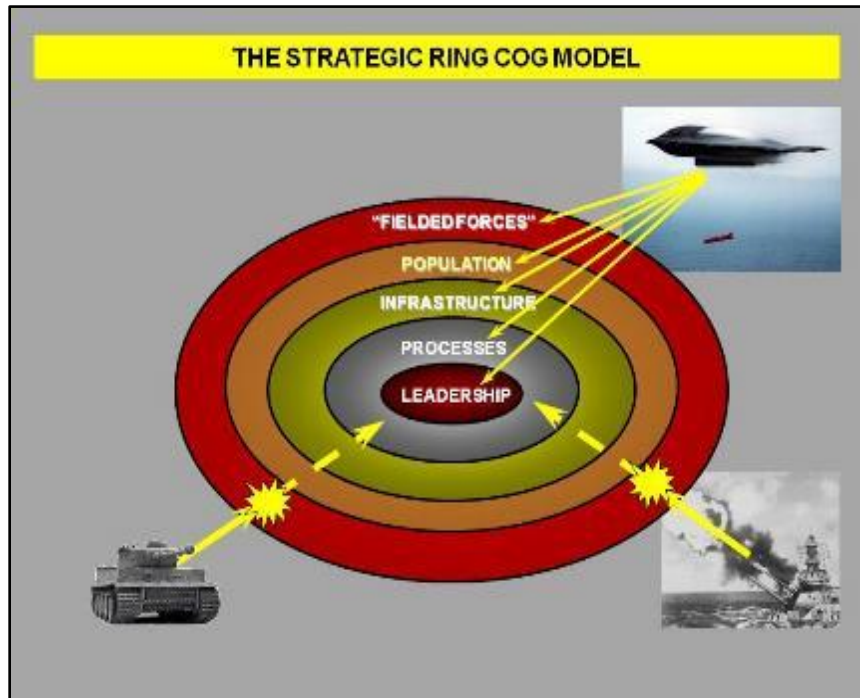
- ★ A C2 and information processing system, such as the leadership and C2 apparatus within a military or the central nervous system of a human body.
- ★ The processes necessary for the system's survival, such as communications, food production and distribution, financing, and manufacturing in a state, or respiration and blood circulation in a living body.
- ★ A system of infrastructure, like the electrical power distribution or transportation

³² See John Warden, *Warden’s Five-Ring System Theory*, for additional information.

systems of a nation or the bone and vascular systems of a body.

- ★ A population, such as the aggregate of individuals within a nation or armed force or the cells within a body.
- ★ A fighting or defense mechanism, such as the fielded armed forces of a nation or the immune system of a body (*NOTE: Col [Ret] Warden chooses to call this ring “fielded forces”*).

Advantages. This model shows the central value of leadership as a COG—it helps demonstrate the value of shock and dislocation on all rings through effects on leadership. It also shows that airpower does not have to fight through enemy fighting mechanisms (fielded forces) to affect the critical opponent systems defended by them, as other forms of military power often do. If used according to Warden’s original logic, one of the more powerful aspects of



the model is that the five-rings are “fractal”—they recapitulate at lower levels. They can be used to describe system behavior at successively lower levels. One can easily analyze any component or subcomponent of a system using the same five rings model.

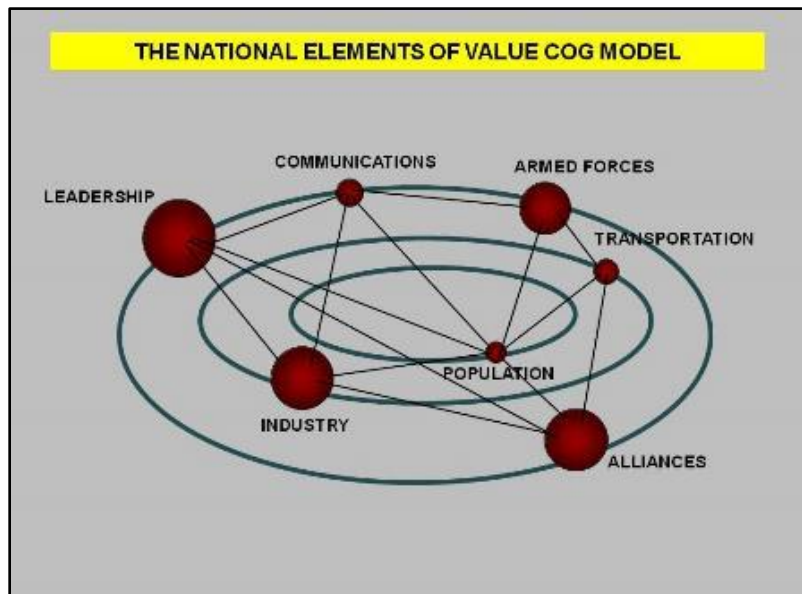
Disadvantages. This model makes no distinction between what is critical and vulnerable, in fact, it confuses the two. Applying blindly (“we’ve drawn our five-rings, and those are our COGs”) can encourage mirror imaging of the opponent’s system and lead to a mechanistic and reductionist inputs-based approach to targeting. Experience has shown that some teams using only this method list the five categories as *the* COGs and immediately begin listing “customary” target sets below them. This is the antithesis of effects-based targeting. Finally, this model considers the subject system in isolation, ignoring its connectivity to external systems and other aspects of the OE. This is the antithesis of a systems approach to COG analysis.

THE NATIONAL ELEMENTS OF VALUE (NEV) MODEL

This is also known as the NEV model and Barlow's Model, after its originator, Col (Ret) Jason Barlow.³³

Description. This model is generically like the strategic rings model but seeks to show a greater degree of interconnectivity and connectivity to external systems. The national elements of value include:

- ★ **Leadership**-The political and military decision-makers within the government.
- ★ **Industry**-All of a country's manufacturing, agriculture, research, technical enterprises, and parts necessary to support them, such as power production, water supply, and raw materials.
- ★ **Population**-A country's ubiquitous features that are important but hard to categorize and quantify, e.g., nationalism, morale, the will of the people, esprit de corps, ethnocentrism, ability to endure hardship, and religious conviction or fervor.
- ★ **Transportation**-All modes.
- ★ **Communications**-The physical means thereof.
- ★ **Alliances**-The friends, trading partners, and neighbors from which a country receives support for continuing the conflict. NEVs are interdependent and self-compensating. They are a critical means of system adaptation, redistribution, and recuperation. The lines connecting NEVs (depicted in the figure, "The National Elements of Value COG Model") are constantly varying in size and texture, as they represent the strength and direction of influence, both formal and informal, and the various lines of command, control, and authority inherent among the elements. Although the NEVs are the same for every country, they vary in importance from country to country and from day to day within a given country. Therefore, it can be assumed that commanders make rational decisions concerning their NEVs.



³³ See Jason Barlow, *Strategic Paralysis: An Airpower Theory for the Present*, for additional information.

Advantages. This model provides a somewhat more sophisticated analysis of the elements of a nation-state than does the strategic ring model. It also accounts for connectivity between elements and entities external to the system.

Disadvantages. The NEV model is designed to evaluate national systems and thus may be of limited value in analyzing non-state actors. Further, like the strategic ring model, it does not provide a means of analyzing individual elements as systems. It thus may have the exact disadvantages the strategic ring model does: oversimplification, a cookie-cutter approach, and a tendency to fit preconceived targeting information to the model rather than letting the model drive targeting decisions.

THE “CARVER” METHOD

This model is used in the special forces community and elements of the Federal government to assess Centers of Gravity and may have some validity for USAF elements (at echelon) to assess localized threats as well as friendly critical assets or capabilities.

Description. “CARVER” stands for “criticality, accessibility, recoverability, vulnerability, effect, and recognizability.” Its elements are used to conduct a comparative assessment of previously identified critical elements, according to the following criteria:

- ★ **Criticality**-How essential is this element to the successful functioning of its parent component, complex, or system?
- ★ **Accessibility**-How susceptible is this element to attack, given its defenses and friendly offensive capabilities?
- ★ **Recoverability**-How quickly and easily can this element recover from inflicted damage or destruction?
- ★ **Vulnerability**-How susceptible is this element to neutralization, damage, or destruction given friendly offensive capabilities?
- ★ **Effect**-What is the confidence that successfully prosecuting this element as planned creates the overall desired effect of the mission?
- ★ **Recognizability**-How easily recognizable is this element (i.e., differentiated from surrounding nodes) considering sensor capabilities, employment conditions (weather, etc.), and time available to analyze the situation and act?

The CARVER method is a means to help analyze which COGs are susceptible to effects, whether friendly, neutral, or enemy, given determination by other methods. At the tactical level, Commanders and planners should rate prospective COGs (or the associated critical vulnerabilities) as objectively as possible according to the six criteria above and then total the scores to indicate which element might be the most susceptible to effects. This may be applied to friendly force assessment (force protection, survivability) or hostile systems lucrative for multidomain attack. CARVER can be an excellent tool for tactical commanders to develop COOP Plans as well as in-depth force protection schema.

Advantages. This method can offer valuable insights, more on which CR is vulnerable or which CV to attack than on what constitutes a COG and its relation to the rest of the opponent's system.

Disadvantages. This is only a partial COG analysis tool and should be used in conjunction with other methods to determine the most lucrative elements for targeting.

SYNTHESIS

Time and staffing permitting, one of the best methods of analyzing COGs is to synthesize the methods described above. One notional means of doing so is to:

- ★ Identify opponent COGs.
 - ★★ Begin with the strategic rings model because of its simplicity.
 - ★★ Apply Barlow's NEV model for greater detail and functional nuance.
 - ★ Identify critical vulnerabilities.
 - ★★ Employ the joint (Strange) model (CG-CC-CR-CV) to determine CVs.
 - ★ Validate and prioritize the identified CVs.
 - ★★ Apply the CARVER method to rank CVs as subjects for action.
 - ★ Re-accomplish the first three steps for friendly COGs. Reassess periodically through COA wargaming and during each iteration of design and planning.
-

APPENDIX C: ACTIONS AND EFFECTS

There are two broad categories of actions relevant at the tactical and operational levels: **kinetic** and **non-kinetic**. Examples of kinetic actions include the use of explosive munitions and directed energy weapons. Examples of non-kinetic actions include using cyberspace weapons, radio broadcasts through operations in the information environment to encourage enemy surrender, and the employment of electromagnetic warfare capabilities.

Notes on the Terms “Lethal,” “Nonlethal,” “Kinetic,” and “Non-kinetic”

The terms “lethal” and “nonlethal” are currently recognized, although not formally defined, in joint doctrine. The existing dictionary definitions of these words describe them adequately. Joint doctrine refers to “lethal or nonlethal effects” (JP 3-0 and JP 3-09, *Joint Fire Support*), as well as “lethal and nonlethal fires.” This volume refers to the effects that both lethal and nonlethal weapons and fires have on targets exactly as joint doctrine does.

Two other terms are in widespread, if informal, use as well: “kinetic” and “non-kinetic,” intended to mean weapons or actions that create effects by releasing physical, kinetic energy, and those that do not. Joint doctrine, however, does not recognize these terms. Since they show no signs of disappearing from common use (including in much tactical doctrine), this publication uses definitions that convey distinct military meaning while keeping them as close as possible to the technical meaning of the terms in physics:

Kinetic: Relating to actions, capabilities, or weapons designed to produce effects using the forces and energy of moving bodies and directed energy. Kinetic actions can have lethal or nonlethal effects. **Non-kinetic:** Relating to actions, capabilities, or weapons designed to produce effects without the direct use of the force or energy of moving objects and directed energy sources. Non-kinetic actions can have lethal or nonlethal effects. **Neither term is used to describe an effect.**

TYPES OF EFFECTS

Four broad effects categories often overlap: *direct*, *indirect*, *intended*, and *unintended*. In addition, there are many subcategories within these categories, especially concerning indirect effects. A few of these subcategories are highlighted in the following sections because of their doctrinal implications. Understanding these types of effects is important to an effects-based approach.

- ★ **Direct Effects** are the results of action with no intervening effect or mechanism between act and outcome. They are also known as first-order effects. They are often immediate and easy to recognize. In most cases, they can be assessed empirically and meaningfully quantified.

- ★ **Indirect Effects.** Direct effects trigger additional outcomes-intermediate effects or causal mechanisms that produce additional outcomes or results. These are indirect effects, sometimes known as second-, third-, or higher-order effects. Indirect effects may be intended or unintended and may be categorized in many other ways (see discussion below). They are usually displaced from direct effects in time and space and often can be hard to quantify or measure empirically. As a result, they are often assessed or evaluated in qualitative terms. Generally, the less direct the effect (the further removed it is in the causal chain or in time from the initial action), the harder it is to predict its results and measure after. Historically, it has proven extremely difficult to anticipate beyond third-order effects with certainty.
- ★ **Intended Effects.** Intended effects are the desired, planned, and anticipated outcomes of an action or set of actions. They can be direct or indirect. Intended effects should always represent a net gain in accomplishing objectives or the end state
- ★ **Unintended Effects.** Unintended effects are outcomes of an action that are not part of the original intent. These effects may be undesired or desired, presenting opportunities for exploitation. Almost all actions produce some unintended effects. These can be direct but are usually indirect. If unplanned, they can also be desirable or undesirable from the friendly point of view, leading to outcomes that help or hinder the achievement of friendly objectives.

There is another aspect of unintended effects that is easy to overlook in planning. Even successful operations carry a cost in terms of lost opportunities. For example, destroying certain C2 or communications nodes to degrade enemy cohesion can remove valuable sources of friendly intelligence or prevent the transmission of surrender guidance by the enemy government. Likewise, destroying transportation nodes like bridges to impede enemy movement may interfere with future friendly schemes of maneuver or recovery efforts after combat has ceased. Effective planning should account for these opportunity costs.

An Airmen's perspective will often highlight alternatives to outright destruction that can create desired effects without removing future opportunities for exploitation or negatively affecting the end state. For instance, in strategic attacks against enemy electrical power, carried out to cripple conflict-sustaining resources and disrupt national leadership functions, planners can use nondestructive weapons to bring down power for a given period or can destroy only a few critical nodes to avoid wholesale destruction of infrastructure that could impede later civil stabilization efforts.

NATURE OF EFFECTS

Within the categories direct, indirect, intended, and unintended, the nature of effects may be further understood to be *physical*, *psychological*, *behavioral*, or *functional*.

- ★ **Physical effects** are the results of actions or effects that physically alter an object or system. Most physical effects are direct, but some may be indirect. Unintended or undesirable physical effects, like collateral damage, can often be major concerns in an operation.

- ★ **Psychological effects** are the results of actions or effects that influence the emotions, motives, and reasoning of individuals, groups, organizations, and governments.
- ★ Certain effects may result in changes in the outward behavior of these actors, which are then known as **behavioral effects**.
- ★ When components of a system act in concert to produce a given function (as when those manning an IADS operate that system), intended behavioral effects may lead to changes in the system's behavior. These changes are known as **functional effects**.

Operational level objectives often entail defeating enemy forces, and defeat inevitably involves a psychological component. Unless the enemy is destroyed outright, all such changes entail a change in the enemy's emotions, motivations, or reasoning. Thus, there is a psychological component to almost every set of effects and may be the most important aspect in generating desired behavioral changes. There are very few instances in history where an enemy, however thoroughly beaten in battle, was utterly denied a means of resistance. Ultimately, collapse entails a series of choices framed by emotion, motivation, and reason. In conflict or coercive operations, defeat is an event that occurs in the mind of the enemy, who chooses to end resistance or aggression and otherwise act (behave) as we desire.

While it is seldom possible to directly measure psychological effects in living systems, behavioral results (and related functional results) can be measured. Nonetheless, the psychological states leading to a particular behavior can be important to understanding causal mechanisms during planning.

TYPES OF INDIRECT EFFECTS

Cumulative and Cascading Effects. Indirect effects can be achieved in a cumulative or cascading manner. Effects that result from the combination of many other effects are *cumulative*. The effects of synergy function the same as elsewhere, the combined, cumulative effect of such actions designed and coordinated in concert should be greater than the sum of each individual action added together.

Cascading effects are indirect effects that ripple through an enemy system, usually affecting other systems. Typically, they flow from higher to lower levels and typically result of attacking critical system nodes that connect systems or sub-systems.

As a practical matter, some of the most desirable effects have both cumulative and cascading aspects. The point at which a military unit "fails" and ceases to act as a coherent fighting force is a typical example. The collapse itself may be triggered by an accumulation of losses (although the precise point at which collapse occurs is often difficult to predict). In addition, however, the unit's collapse may foster significant changes that spread through its component elements, subordinate units, and other connected or related systems. These are cascading effects.

Cascading effects may accomplish desired ends more effectively than cumulative effects. For example, removing critical nodes may ensure a complete collapse or neutralization than a cumulative, attritional approach. They may also achieve ends more efficiently, requiring fewer resources to achieve equivalent effects, thus freeing those resources for other uses. Of course, some systems do not lend themselves to this approach. It may not always be possible to identify or target key nodes but targeting efforts should strive to do so whenever possible.

Cumulative and Cascading Effects

Weakening an enemy unit's combat power by destroying a command vehicle would be part of the **cumulative effects** of attack upon the unit, as would the unit's eventual collapse through attrition of many of its vehicles and personnel. To the extent the attack impacts other units and elements across the enemy system due to the degraded C2 ability, such impacts could be considered **cascading effects**.

In the case of an integrated air defense system (IADS), air superiority may be achieved through the accumulation of effects against the IADS' components and achieving it may cascade into many other desirable effects, giving the air component greater freedom of action, as well as increasing freedom of action for the joint force in other domains.

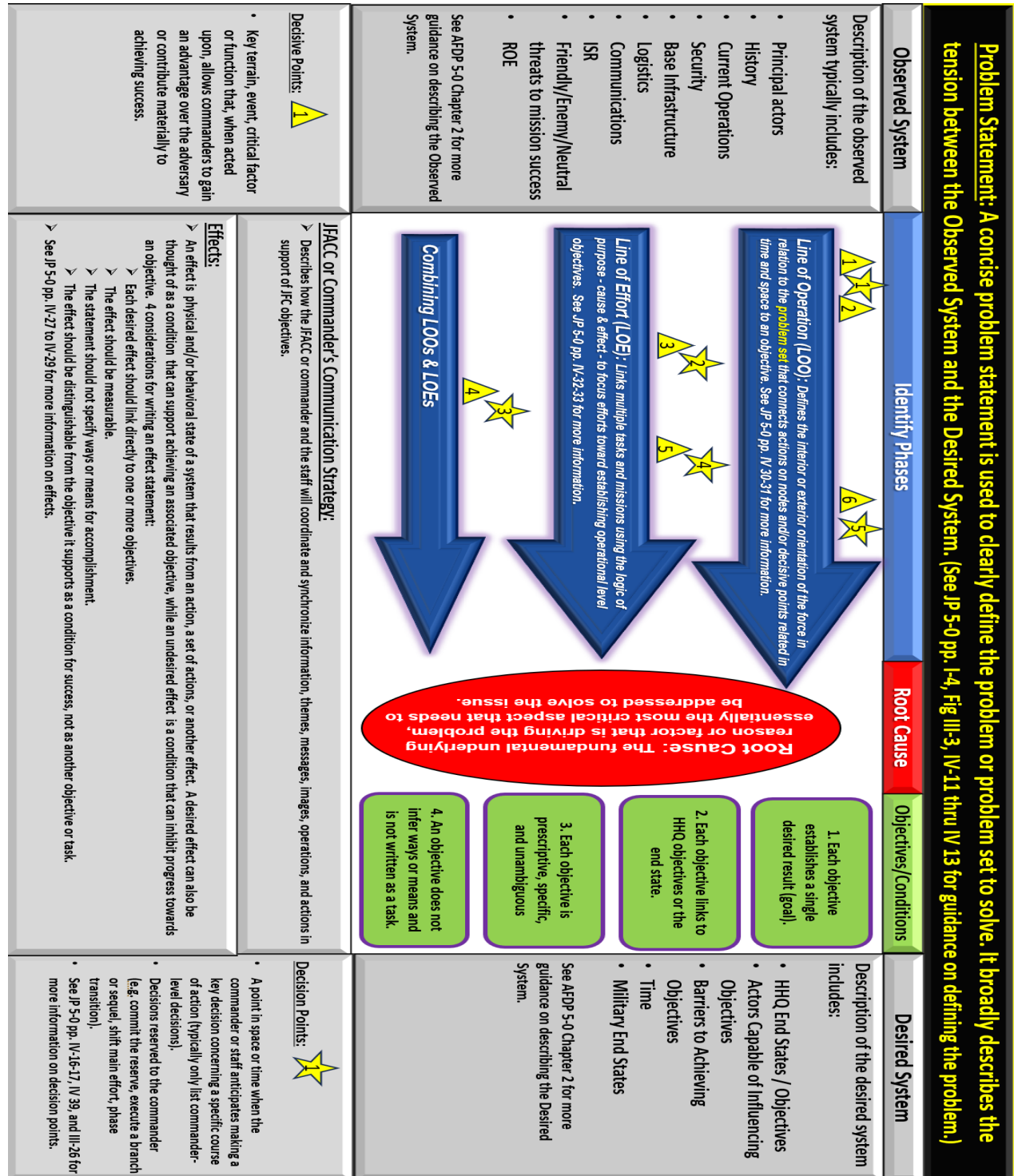
An electrical network, as an integrated complex system, demonstrates a different aspect of cascading effects. Targeting a few critical nodes within the network, then allowing internal system stress to cause successive cascading system-wide failure. Nature has inadvertently caused such effects with US power grids several times and coalition forces were able to achieve them early in Operation DESERT STORM by attacking a few key Iraqi power plants and distribution nodes. The effects of damage to critical infrastructure, such as the power grid will almost certainly cascade across other elements of the enemy system. Though effective at causing paralysis or system collapse, planners should be mindful of the potential cascading effects have for inducing unintended, second and third-order effects that may undermine achievement of objectives or the desired end state.

Effects of Sequential vs. Parallel Operations. In sequential operations, effects are imposed one after another. These operations are generally conducted when the effects generated through associated tasks and actions are required to enable follow on operations. Of the two, sequential operations are less likely to generate cumulative or cascading effects. To cause paralysis or enemy system failure, it is normally better to impose effects through parallel operations instead. Parallel operations aim to converge effects across an enemy system in a relatively short period, through various means and domains, to stress an enemy system in a manner that overwhelms its capacity to adapt. Functioning in this manner, parallel operations may take less time to achieve desired objectives.

However, parallel operations come at a cost. They require more resources (except time). Parallel operations are more complex to coordinate and should be planned more thoroughly, especially in terms of integration and synchronization of operations. Further, there may be reasons effects cannot or should not be imposed in parallel. In some cases, there may not be sufficient resources or capabilities. In other cases, a sequential approach is necessary because events need to happen in a certain order to enable other effects and ensure success. For example, in the opening minutes of Operation DESERT STORM, specific key early warning nodes were targeted to facilitate penetration of Baghdad's air defenses by other coalition aircraft. This one sequential strike helped ensure the success of the parallel efforts that followed.

APPENDIX D: AIR COMPONENT APPROACH TEMPLATE

Air component approaches are created using different templates to communicate the commander's vision. An example template is provided in this publication for reference.



APPENDIX E: EXAMPLE MODIFIED FIVE-PARAGRAPH ORDER

Subject: [Title or Serial] xxxxx

Originator: [Originator]

DTG: [date time group]

GENTEXT/SITUATION/

1. () SITUATION. <At a minimum, provide sufficient background information as to WHY the tasking is needed and timeline. Additional amplifying information, as necessary.>//

GENTEXT/MISSION/

2. () MISSION. <State the mission statement and address who, what, when, where, and why>//

GENTEXT/EXECUTION/

3. () EXECUTION.

3.A. () COMMANDER'S INTENT. <Sub-paragraphs include the purpose, end state, and risk>

3.B () CONCEPT OF OPERATIONS. <Sub-paragraphs may include a general description of type or scope of the requirement and establish times.>

3.C. () TASKS TO STAFF, ORGANIZATIONS, AND SUBORDINATE UNITS
<Sub-paragraphs provide specific tasks to staff, organizations, and subordinate units with sufficient information of task requirements>

3.D () COORDINATING INSTRUCTIONS.

3.D.1. C-DAY L-HOUR for deployments DDMMYYYY____Z.

3.D.2. Target D-DAY L-HOUR DDMMYYYY____Z.

3.D.3. <Estimated duration of the operation. Circumstance or date that automatically terminates operations.>

3.D.4. <Defense condition (DEFCON) or deployability posture.>

3.D.5. <Operational constraints, including any special ROE to include anti-terrorism and force protection issues applicable to this specific operation.>//

GENTEXT/FORCE SUSTAINMENT/

4. () FORCE SUSTAINMENT. <Sub-paragraphs may include areas such as logistics, concept of maintenance, quantities and class of supplies, resupply plan, health requirements, status protections, transportation, etc.>//

GENTEXT/COMMAND, SIGNAL, AND COMMUNICATIONS/

5. () COMMAND, SIGNAL, AND COMMUNICATIONS.

5.A () COMMAND RELATIONSHIPS: <State supported/supporting relationships>

<Sub-paragraphs provide type of control exercised by the supported commander (OPCON, TACON, direct liaison authorized [DIRLAUTH])>

5.B () COMMAND, CONTROL, COMMUNICATIONS, AND COMPUTER SYSTEMS (C4). <Sub-paragraphs may include requests for subordinate unit requirements, communications circuits to be used for reach-back, POCs, etc.> //

//SIGNED/JCD/DD Mmm YYYY//
JOHN C. DOE
Rank, USAF
Position

DECL/<source for classification>/<reason for classification>/<downgrade instructions or date>/<downgrading or declassification exemption code> //

(CLASSIFICATION)

APPENDIX F: AFPP KNEEBOARD

STEPS	INPUTS	ACTIVITIES	RESULTS/OUTPUTS
1: Planning Initiation	☐ HHQ Direction to start planning ☐ Commander's recognition of planning requirement	☐ Alert Staff ☐ Document relevant design elements ☐ Gather tools ☐ Make staff estimates ☐ Conduct initial assessment ☐ Issue Commander's guidance	☐ Planning timeline ☐ Planning team ☐ Planning Guidance ☐ Identification of necessary design elements ☐ Issue of preparatory order
2: Mission Analysis	☐ Strategic Guidance ☐ HHQ Planning directive ☐ Commander's initial planning guidance ☐ Description of the OE ☐ Definition of the Problem ☐ Operational or Air Component Guidance ☐ Commander's Intent	☐ Review HHQ Planning Activities, Strategic Guidance and identify Chain of Command ☐ Review Commander's initial planning guidance ☐ Identify design elements ☐ Determine Facts ☐ Analyze Most Likely and Most Dangerous threat to mission success (Enemy COAs for JPP & JPPA) ☐ Develop Initial assumptions ☐ Determine Constraints and Restraints ☐ Determine necessary elements of design to develop an operational approach or air component approach ☐ Analyze Friendly/Adversary COGs and Critical Factors (JPP/JPPA) ☐ Determine Root Cause of Problem that requires further planning ☐ Identify Specified, Implied and Essential tasks ☐ Determine Decision points ☐ Develop a Proposed Mission Statement ☐ Conduct Initial Resource Review ☐ Develop Mission success Criteria ☐ Develop Risk Assessment ☐ Determine Initial CCIRs ☐ Determine the problem, problem's route cause, and subordinate problem sets ☐ Develop Commander's Intent Statement ☐ Prepare/Update Staff Estimates ☐ Present a Commander's Mission Analysis Brief	☐ Publish an air component approach (JPP/JPPA) ☐ Publish Commander's Refined Planning Guidance ☐ Identified Specified, Implied and Essential Tasks ☐ Component(s) of the problem that need to be addressed ☐ Staff estimates ☐ Mission Statement ☐ Updated Commander's intent statement ☐ List of initial CCIRs
3: COA Development	☐ HHQ Guidance ☐ Operational Approaches ☐ Air Component Approaches ☐ Mission Analysis Results	☐ Brainstorm COAs ☐ Chart/Visualize COAs ☐ Prepare COA concept of operations statement, sketch, and task organization ☐ Brief Commander on COAs under consideration – COA Selection Brief ☐ Continue Staff Estimate process to enhance COAs ☐ Continue vertical and horizontal parallel planning	☐ CONOPS ☐ COMREL ☐ Required capabilities ☐ Deployment and Sustainment Concept ☐ COA statement (narrative description) ☐ Valid COAs
4: COA Analysis and Wargaming	☐ Valid COAs ☐ Mission Analysis results ☐ Operations approaches ☐ Air component approaches ☐ COA evaluation criteria ☐ Selected wargaming method ☐ Planning guidance	☐ Prepare for COA Analysis and Wargaming ☐ Conduct Analysis/Wargaming and record results ☐ Refine/Modify each COA ☐ Report results	☐ Analysis and Wargaming results Inform COA Comparison ☐ Advantages/disadvantages for each COA
5: COA Comparison	☐ Commander's evaluation criteria and definitions ☐ Weight considerations (if used) ☐ COA Analysis and Wargaming results ☐ Selected COA comparison method ☐ Associated guidance to the staff	☐ Compare COAs using selected COA comparison method	☐ Individual COA advantages and disadvantages ☐ COA discussion notes ☐ COA recommendation
6: COA Approval	☐ Individual COA Advantages and disadvantages ☐ COA Discussion Notes ☐ COA recommendation	☐ Prepare COA Decision Briefing ☐ Present COA Decision Briefing ☐ Commander selects and/or Modifies COA ☐ Refine Selected COA (as required) ☐ Prepare briefing, message, or Commander's Estimate for HHQ Approval	☐ Selected COA
7: Plans and Orders Development	☐ COA Approval Decision ☐ Valid COA ☐ COA Analysis and wargaming results ☐ Mission analysis results ☐ Air component design ☐ Air component approach ☐ Operational approach ☐ HHQ guidance	☐ Develop base paragraphs ☐ Publish base order/plan ☐ Develop appropriate annexes ☐ Publish annexes and supplemental guidance as FRAAGORDS	☐ An order or plan to disseminate to subordinate forces

REFERENCES

All websites accessed 15 January 2025.

Doctrine can be accessed through links provided at: <https://www.doctrine.af.mil/>

US AIR FORCE DOCTRINE: <https://www.doctrine.af.mil/>

- ★ AFDP 1, [The Air Force](#)
- ★ AFDP 1-1, [Mission Command](#)
- ★ AFDP 3-0, [Operations](#)
- ★ AFDP 3-0.1, [Command and Control](#)

JOINT DOCTRINE

Joint Electronic Library (JEL): <https://www.jcs.mil/Doctrine/>

JEL+: <https://jdeis.js.mil/jdeis/index.jsp?pindex=2>

- ★ JP 2-0, [Joint Intelligence](#)
- ★ JP 3-0, [Joint Campaigns and Operations](#)
- ★ JP 3-02, [Amphibious Operations](#)
- ★ JP 3-30, [Joint Air Operations](#)
- ★ JP 5-0, [Joint Planning](#)

MISCELLANEOUS PUBLICATIONS

DoDM 5200.01 Volume 2, [Marking of Information](#)

DoDI 5200.48, [Controlled Unclassified Information \(CUI\)](#)

[DoD Dictionary of Military and Associated Terms](#)

CJCSM 3130.03A, [Planning and Execution Formats and Guidance](#)

CJCSM 3105.01B, [Joint Risk Analysis Methodology](#)

[Air Force Glossary](#)

Dr Joseph Strange, [Centers of Gravity and Critical Vulnerabilities: Building on the Clausewitzian Foundation So That We Can All Speak the Same Language](#)

Maj (Ret) Jason B. Barlow, [Strategic Paralysis: An Airpower Theory for the Present](#)

Col (Ret) John A. Warden III., [Warden's Five-Ring System Theory](#)

Carl von Clausewitz, *On War*
